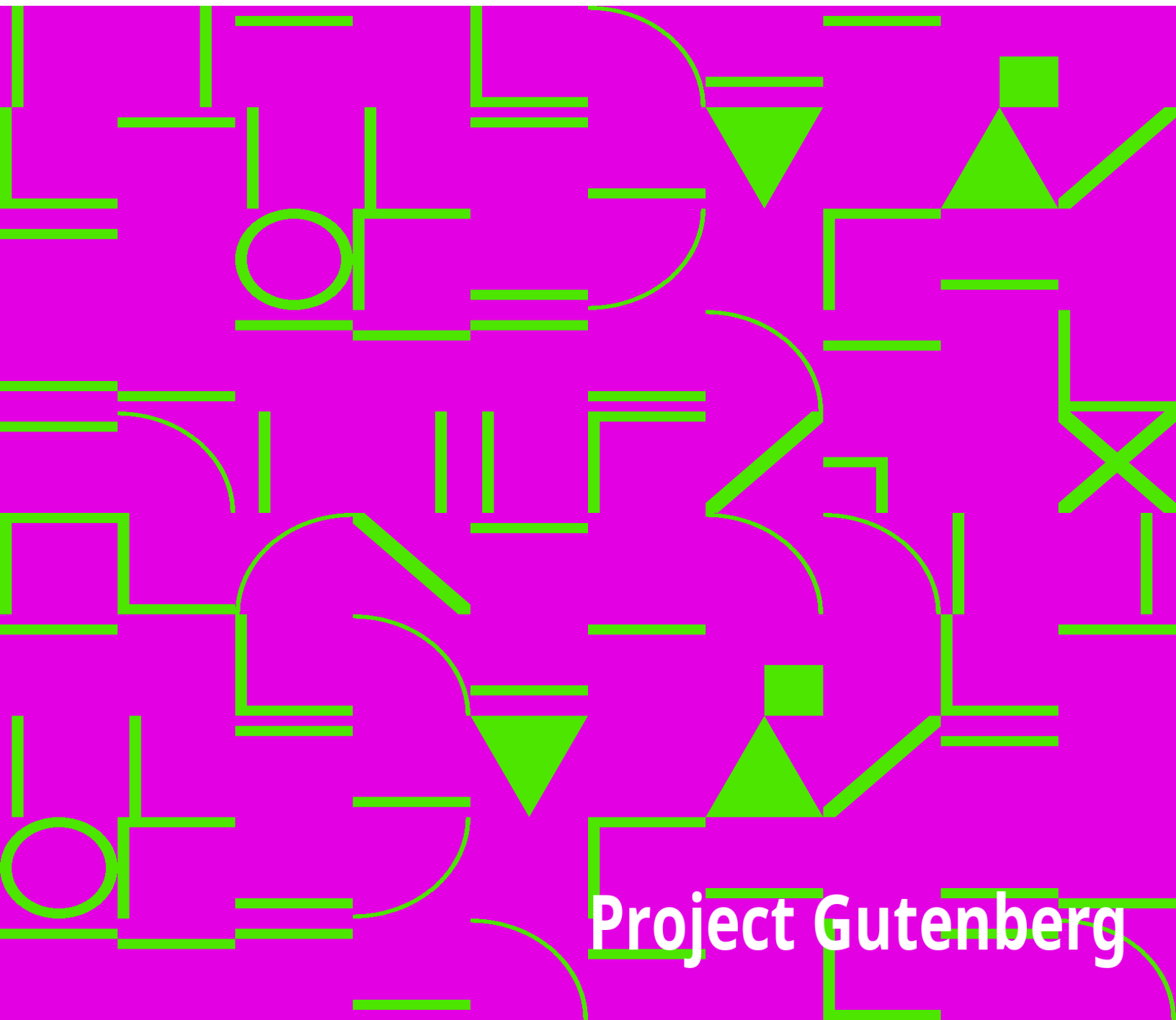


The life, letters and work of Frederic Leighton. Volume II

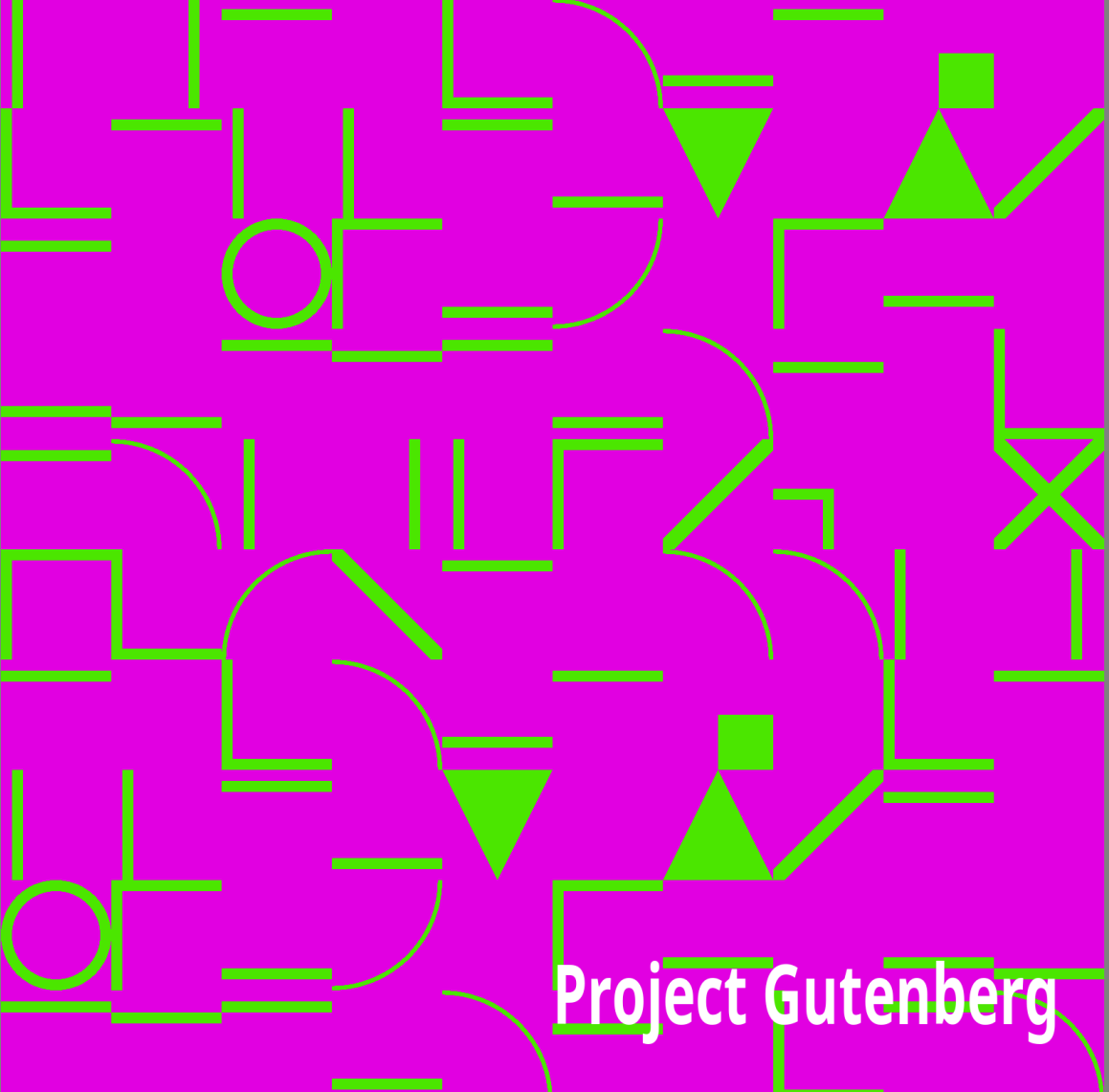
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**The life, letters and work of Frederic
Leighton. Volume II**

Mrs. Russell Barrington



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Obvious typographical errors have been corrected. For a complete list, please see the [end of this document](#).

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The Life, Letters and Work of Frederic Baron Leighton

Of Stretton

VOL. II

*"I am a workman first, and an
official after."*—FRED. LEIGHTON,
1888.

*"Es bildet ein Talent
sich in der
Stille,
Doch ein Character in
dem Strom der
Welt."*

—
G
O
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The Life, Letters and Work of Frederic Leighton

BY

MRS. RUSSELL BARRINGTON

AUTHOR OF "REMINISCENCES OF G.F. WATTS," ETC. ETC.

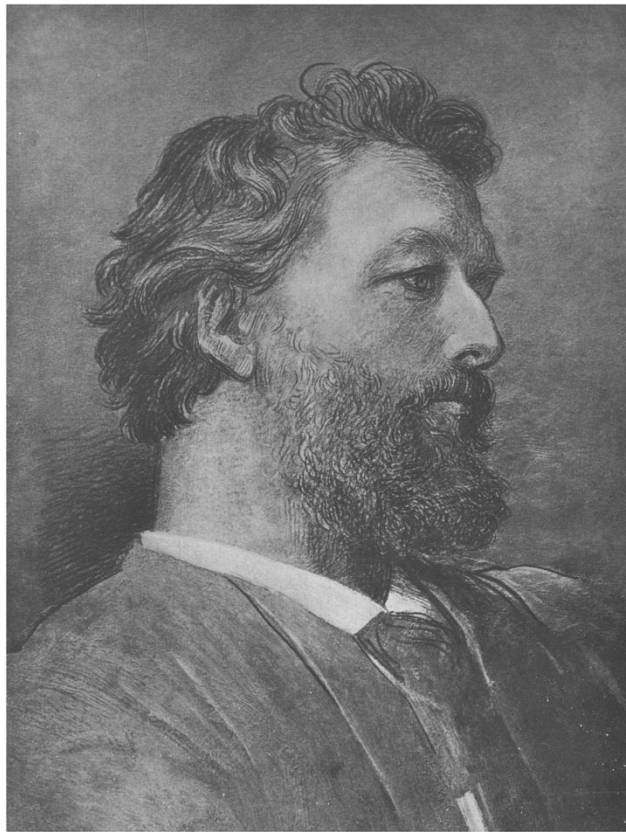
IN TWO VOLUMES

VOL. II

**LONDON
GEORGE ALLEN, RUSKIN HOUSE
1906**

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LORD LEIGHTON
From the portrait by G.F. Watts [ToList](#)

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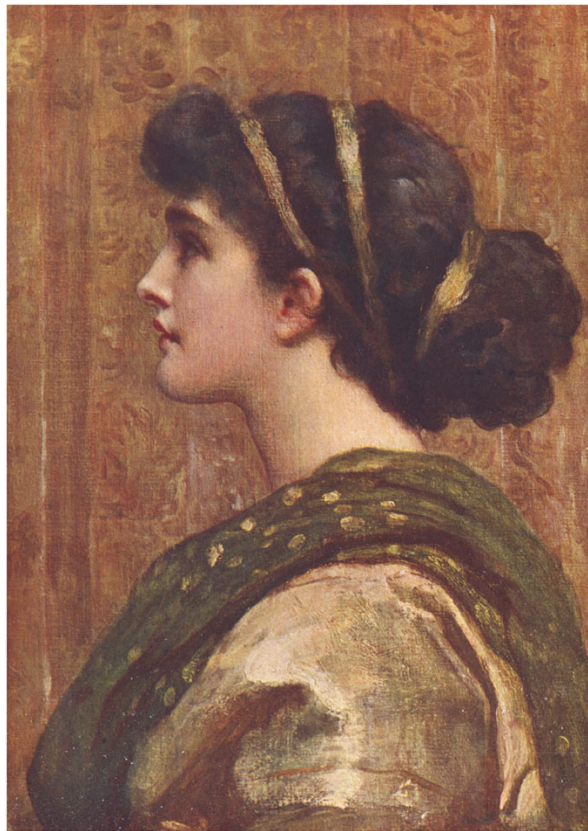
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HARRIS STONE.



HEAD OF YOUNG GIRL

Wedding present from Lord Leighton to H.R.H. the Prince of Wales,
who has graciously allowed the painting to be reproduced in this
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THE LIFE OF LORD LEIGHTON

INTRODUCTION [ToC](#)

SIR WILLIAM RICHMOND, R.A., and Mr. Walter Crane have kindly contributed the following notes:—

It was in 1860 that I first knew Leighton. We met over affairs connected with the Artist Rifle Corps at Burlington House, and afterwards at the studios of various artists, where discussions took place regarding the formation and means of conduct of the Corps. On several occasions I walked home with Leighton to his house in Orme Square.

I don't think I have ever known a man who grew more steadily than Leighton did. The effort of his artistic life was to remove the effects of a certain mannerism and over-education in his early artistic life. His knowledge was wonderful, his powers of design without immediate consultation with Nature were phenomenal; he feared the facility in himself and went always to Nature, that out of her manifold gifts he should be inspired directly by them. And this constant study had its drawbacks as well as its merits, because in one sense it stood in the way of the development of an abstract power of invention. If ever an artist made the most of his conscious abilities, Leighton did. His character was so curiously simple on the one hand, and so complicated on the other, that a balance between a very emotional and extremely accurate temperament had to be found, and it was found. How far a certain charm of spontaneity was

obscured a little, perhaps by erudition and a sort of Aristotelian preciseness, it is not for me to say. There is in all things a balance which, when once obtained, reduces the weight in both scales. But we must take a life as it has been made by circumstances, by early training and after influences; and probably most men who are in earnest,—and Leighton was pre-eminently in earnest,—find their proper issue finally. That the best of Leighton's work will live, I am convinced; that it will hold its own when a great deal of other work praised, admired, even worshipped during the life of his contemporaries shall be dead, I feel quite assured; and one may very justly be asked—Why? The simple answer is that it was thorough, definite, sincere, accomplished. Leighton never put out his hand towards the limbo of vulgarity or fashion. Like Virgil, like Mendelssohn, Leighton was a stylist, and his life's work showed a perfection of attainment upon the lines which he drew out for his progress almost to my thinking unrivalled in the work of any of his contemporaries. Here and there he struck a deep note of poetry, here and there he was like a Greek for his simplicity, here and there his work shows the luxury of the Venetians, the restraint of the Florentines, but never perhaps the majesty of M. Angelo or the strong charm of Raphael. His art was eclectic; still it was Leighton, and could have been done only as the result of great natural gifts, assiduous study, force of character, and, withal, independence of vision. His love of beauty was his own personal love, not learnt, hardly perhaps inherited, but spontaneous and lasting. This devotion to beauty may have sometimes led his emotions away from character, which sometimes is very nearly ugly as well as very nearly allied to the highest beauty, which Bacon says has always something of strangeness in it. The pursuit of beauty, *per se*, may be purchased at the expense of character.

But Leighton was always pulling himself up; and when he found himself too facile, too ornate, he resolutely set his mind to correct any tendency in that direction by fidelity to Nature, sometimes even to her ugly movements. Excess was not in his nature, which was curiously logical; his mind was swift, far-seeing; in debate he was admirable, always seeing the weak point of an argument at once, and "partie pris" was his abomination. A man so gifted in the

essence and laws of form, so learned in the construction of the human frame, so deeply sensitive to line and movement as well as to structure, surely would have given to the world great works of sculpture. Indeed he did, but not enough! One regrets that—still one must accept the fact that form is but little cared for in this country, and Leighton sinned by reason of his love of form; by many he was called not a painter because he did not smear, did not trust to accidents, did not leave works half done—because he was sincere to his conviction that a work of art must be, to last, complete "*ad unguem*." The present craze for incompleteness, for sketches instead of pictures, for unripe instead of ripe fruit, must die as all false notions die; the best, the rightest will live; and when the present ephemeral fashion has worked itself out, the nobility of Leighton's works, his best, are certain to take their place in the estimation of those that know as surely as that they are good.

How many out of the multitude really, if we could test them, care one jot for the Elgin Marbles, for the Demeter of Knidos, for the vault of the Sistine Chapel?—very few. Really great things never can be accepted by the commonplace. How should they be? for to understand the highest in music, in architecture, sculpture, or painting, the observer or listener must have a spark in his constitution which is a portion of the flame that burned white heat in the soul of the conceiver. How can such an attitude of intimate sympathy belong to the many? It never has, and probably never will. Great men are rare, and those who are mentally or organically made to comprehend them are rare also. The great can afford to wait because they are immortal. In all one's dealings with Leighton what did one find? a noble nature, restrained, charitable, in earnest; and if in many discussions as to the desirability of certain events, certain compromises, certain acts of conformity, one did not agree with Leighton, one knew "*au fond*" that the attitude was quite logical, not hastily arrived at, and the position taken up was to be strenuously held: and it was that power of consistency which made Leighton so trustworthy. He was fearless when his principles were touched, he was loyal to his associates in the Academy even if he did not see eye to eye with them, and he was loyal to his art and to his friends. If Leighton had chosen politics for his career he would probably have

been Prime Minister, just as Burne-Jones might have been Archbishop of Canterbury had he continued his early and very remarkable theological studies. All really great men have endless possibilities. It is more or less chance which decides the direction of ability, which, once discovered, forcibly, dominantly present, must find opportunities for its highest development and achievement in the tenure of the goal. It was ability and natural gifts that made Leighton great, industry that nourished his greatness, and stability to principle which made it lasting in his lifetime, and must for all time stamp his work. The thing that really engages one's interest about a great man is not so much his "technique" as his general disposition and character, which forms for itself a suitable "technique" by which his achievements have been manifested. Should any one by-and-by describe the "technique" of Joachim, the supreme violinist, he would probably interest a few, but in reality he would say nothing really valuable, excepting inasmuch as he touched upon first principles. The "modus operandi" of an artist's life is moulded by his personal aims, the means are those by which he found his own way of stating them; and one doubts very much if, after all, the points which differentiate one man's work from another's are not those which have obliterated the conscious efforts, preserving just the touches which genius gives beyond and above all laws that may be learnt. Verse no doubt is much dependent for its beauty on the system of the arrangement of syllables, and the music they make when harmoniously handled upon the final perfection which they reach, and so become rule-making instead of being the result of rule-following. Hence lies that unaccountable beauty which is the inexplicable result of the ego—that taste, that selection, that special word which creates an impression immediately, and which seems inimitable even, and obviously the only one which could have been used; that is style—the very essence of the ego which cannot be copied, or indeed again brought into relation with the idea. And isn't that the reason why the copy of a picture can never be really like an original? even if the "technique" is identical, it lacks that last touch, that last word which transcends tradition, almost transcends thought, for it is just the thought which has been summed up in a moment of inspiration, uncalculated, spontaneous. Leighton was far too wise a

man to believe in the constant recurrence of inspirations: he knew that the moment when the whole spirit is ready to act is involuntary; he knew that to reach the supremacy of that moment, labour was necessary; that in labour is the foundation of the building for that moment of inspiration. One may question if the first vision in Leighton was very strong—strong as Blake's, strong as many artists whose powers of attainment were much less than Leighton's, but whose vision was clearer at the outset. Rougher minds than Leighton's have produced more epic effects, and a ruder, less accomplished "technique" has borne with it more original, more trenchant ideas. Leighton was not a mystic; he dealt with thoughts which he embodied in forms that he saw, but which he also made his own in their application; that was his genius of originality. The rugged verse of Æschylus had no place in his temperament, much as he admired it; the polished diction of Virgil bore more similitude to Leighton's inspiration. Sometimes one missed in his work just the touch of the rugged which would have given more grace by comparison, by contrast. His grace of diction, his oratory, his writing, was sometimes over-refined, and missed its mark by over-elaboration. The very speciality of Leighton was completeness. One has seen pictures in his study only half finished, which had a charm of freshness that vanished as each portion became worked into equal value. But that fastidiousness was his characteristic, it was part of him; and therefore we must not deplore it. His originality was exemplified by his power of taking pains, his power of will to do his very best according to his guiding spirit of thoroughness. Temperaments are so different. Whistler could not be Leighton. Because we admire the one, it is not necessary to decry the other; that is weak criticism, or rather none at all. The spirit which inspires the impressionist is not the spirit of design, but a limited observation in a very restricted area. We can have the Academic as well as the Impressionist: both are useful as foils to each other, and it is just as narrow of the Impressionists to want all men to see nature and art as they see them, as it has been for the Academics to see "nothing" in the newer if more limited system. I believe that Leighton's real love was early Italian art; all that came to him after was the result of growth. His enthusiasm for Mino da Fiesole, for the earlier

Raphaels, for Duccio of Siena, for Lorenzetti, was evident and absorbing; other enthusiasms were more branches from the stem than its roots. He loved line; he found it there: he loved restraint of action, pure sensuous beauty; he found it in early Italian Art. The reserve of emotions touched him in Greek Art—its suavity, its almost geometrical precision, the tunefulness and melody of its rhythmical concords. His love of music was on the same lines: Wagner never appealed to him as Mozart did; it was too strenuous, too busy in changes of key, too incomplete in the finish and development of phrases. It was not that he liked dulness—not a bit; he was emotional, often gay, often depressed—excitable even; but to him Art was an intellectual more than a purely emotional system, and he liked it to be finished, consistent, perfect—and those qualities he strove for, without a doubt he obtained in a high measure. It will be long before we see again the like of Frederic Leighton, a man complete in himself.

W.B. RICHMOND.

June 1906.

I first met Leighton about 1869 or '70, I think. I went to one of his receptions at the Studio in Holland Park Road, at the time he was showing his pictures for the Academy. I think his principal work of that year was "Alcestis," or "Heracles Wrestling with Death." About the same time Browning's poem of "Balaustion's Adventure" appeared, in which he alludes to Leighton and this very picture in the lines beginning:

"I know a great Kaunian painter"

(if I remember rightly).

I availed myself of a friend's introduction, and presented myself. One recalls the courteous and princely way in which he received his guests on these occasions, and the crushes he had at his studio—Holland Park Road blocked with carriages, and all the great ones of the London world flocking to see the artist's work.

About this time, or shortly before, he had done me the honour to purchase two landscape studies I had made in Wales from among a number in a book, which was shown him by my early friend George Howard (now Earl of Carlisle), and I remember his kind words in sending me what he deemed "the very modest price" I had asked for them.

His kindness to students and young artists was well known. He would take trouble to go and see their work, and he was always an admirable and helpful critic.

I remember, on my first visit to Rome in the autumn of 1871 (on our marriage tour), going into Piali's Library one evening to look at the English papers. No one was there, but presently Leighton came in. He did not remember me at first, but I recalled myself to him. He was very kind, in his princely way, and gave me introductions to W.W. Storey, the sculptor, and his great friend, Giov. Costa, and he called at our rooms to see my work, in which he showed much interest. In a letter I had, dated March 1st, 1872, written from the Athenæum Club, he speaks of some drawings I had sent to the Dudley Gallery, one he had seen on my easel in Rome, and he says: "I have seen your drawings, all three—one was an old friend; of the other two, the 'Grotto of Egeria,' with its 'sacrum numes,' most attracted me through its refined and sober harmony. *The quality of your light* is always particularly agreeable to me, and not less than usual in these drawings"; he goes on to say he is glad to hear I have "made friends with my excellent Costa, who as an artist is one in hundreds, and as a man one in thousands"; he adds, "Have you sketched in the 'Valley of Poussin'? It strikes me that old castle would take you by storm."

I saw Leighton again in Rome in 1873, meeting him on the Palatine, among the ruins of the Palace of the Cæsars. He was with a

lady who, I believe, was the author of the story published in *The Cornhill*, "A Week in a French Country House," for which Leighton made an illustration. (His black and white work was always very fine, and I recall seeing some of his drawings on the wood for Dalziel's Bible and "Romola.")

Later, he came to see us when we settled in London, in Wood Lane.

I had further relations with him about the time he was building the Arab Hall, when (through George Aitcheson, his architect) I designed the mosaic frieze. On some sketches I made for this he writes: "Cleave to the Sphinx and Eagle, they are *delightful*—I don't like the duck-women." With regard to these Arab Hall mosaics, he said that he hoped to have more, and eventually "to let us loose (Burne-Jones and myself) on the dome."

After this, I saw something of Leighton on the committee of the South London Fine Art Gallery, Peckham, in its earlier days, when he was chairman, and helped to pilot the institution from the somewhat exacting proprietorship of its founder towards its ultimate position as a public institution.

From the aristocratic point of view, he certainly had a keen sense of public duty, and probably laid the motto "Noblesse oblige" to heart.

I met him again at the Art Conference at Liverpool, when a trainful of artists of all ranks went down together, and some notable attacks were made on the Royal Academy. Leighton was tremendously loyal to that institution, which I notice is always stoutly defended by its members, whatever opinions they may have expressed while outsiders.

I suppose we differed profoundly on most questions, but he was always most courteous, and, whatever our public opinions, we always maintained friendly personal relations; and I may say I always entertained the highest admiration for Leighton's qualities, both as an artist and as a man.

At the time when the election for the presidency of the Academy was in view (after the death of Sir Francis Grant), it was said that Leighton was the *only* man, and that if they did not elect him the institution would go to pieces; but probably as president he had less power of initiative than before.

I remember, after one of our committees at his studio, he drove me home to Holland Street in his victoria; and as he set me down at my door, he pointed to a little copper lantern I had put up over the steps, and said, "Is that Arts and Crafts?"

His fondness for Italy was well known, and I think he went every autumn. I recall meeting him at Florence in 1890, while staying at the delightful villa of Mrs. Ross (Poggio Gherardo), when he came to luncheon.

In death he was as princely as in life; and on the day of his burial at St. Paul's I was moved to write the following as a tribute to his memory, which will always be vivid in the hearts of those who had the privilege of his friendship:—

Beneath great London's dome to his last
rest
The princely painter have ye borne
away,
Who still in death upholds his
sumptuous sway;
Who strove in life with learned skill to
wrest
Art's priceless secret hid in Beauty's
breast
With alchemy of colour and of clay,
To recreate a fairer human day,
Touched by no shadow of our time
distrest.

What rank or privilege needs art
supreme—

Immortal child of buried states and
powers—
Who can for us the golden age
renew?
Let worth and work bear witness when
life's hours
Are numbered: honour due, when, as
we deem,
To his ideal was the artist true.

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"EUCCHARIS." 1863

By permission of Mrs. Stephenson Clarke [To List](#)

Having settled in England in 1860, Leighton found that there, contrary to his expectations, his sense of colour became developed; and with this his individuality as a *painter* asserted itself. Between the years 1863 and 1866 he painted pictures which proved that, as a distinct artificer in painting, he had found himself, and was no longer under the controlling influences of German or Italian Art, though, unfortunately, hints of German methods in the actual manipulation of his brush clung more or less to his painting to the end. From boyhood Leighton's power of designing, his sense of beauty in line and form and of dramatic feeling, his extraordinary facility in drawing

with the point, proved his genius as an artist; but it was not till the early sixties that his pictures proved him to be possessed of individual distinction as a painter, probably because the method of handling the brush associated with the teaching which, in other respects, commanded his reverence and admiration, were alien to his finest artistic sense. No later works are to be found more notable in luminous quality of painting than "Eucharis," 1863, and "Golden Hours," 1864; none in strength and solidity of texture, or in beauty of distinguished handling, than "A Noble Lady of Venice," about 1865; none in richness of arrangement combined with the fair aerial atmosphere appropriate to a Grecian scene, for which Leighton had so native a sympathy, than "A Syracusan Bride Leading Wild Beasts in Procession to the Altar of Diana," 1866.^[1] Later works may claim a greater public prominence among his achievements, but for actual individuality and feeling for the beauty which appealed most strongly to Leighton in colour as in form, none he painted after evinced any fresh departure.



"A NOBLE LADY OF VENICE." 1866

By permission of Lord Armstrong [To List](#)

As early as 1852, at the age of twenty-one, Leighton wrote to Steinle from Venice: "I must candidly confess that great as my admiration for Titian (& Co.) was, yet the well-known art treasures here have seized me and entranced me anew. You, dear master, are so familiar with all these things that there is nothing I can write you about them; but on one point I am fairly clear, namely, that the admirers and imitators of Titian (particularly the latest) seek his charms quite in the wrong place, and I am convinced that the impressiveness of his painting lies far less in the ardour of his colouring than in the stupendous accuracy and execution of the modelling." In another letter to Steinle he refers to the necessity of mastering the capacities of the brush in order to render form in a complete manner independently of the function of the brush to render colour.

"Those who place the brush behind the pencil, under the pretence that *form* is before all things, make a very great mistake. Form is *certainly all important*; one cannot study it enough; *but* the greater part of *form* falls within the province of the tabooed *brush*. The everlasting hobby of *contour* (which belongs to the drawing material) is first the *place* where the *form* comes in; what, however, reveals true knowledge of form, is a powerful, organic, refined finish of modelling, full of feeling and knowledge—and that is the affair of the brush (*Pinsel*)."

In January 1860 Leighton wrote to Steinle: "You will perhaps be surprised, but, in spite of my fanatic preference for colour I promised myself to be a draughtsman before I became a colourist," and in fact Leighton was fighting, throughout his whole career, against allowing the sensuous qualities in his art to override those which the teaching of Steinle had proved to his nature to be the most truly elevating and ennobling. Up to the age of thirty he had been overshadowed by the influence of others in the matter of actual technique in painting. From the time he settled in London he freed himself from the tutelage of all masters. As we have read in his letters, his intention was to do so in 1856 when he painted "The Triumph of

Music;" but at that time he failed in finding his real self in his painting of that picture, and fully realised that he must *reculer pour mieux sauter*, returning in the autumn of that year to Rome to be fed by the greatest art of the past, and to study again, "face to face with Nature—to follow it, to watch it, and to copy, closely, faithfully, ingenuously—as Ruskin suggests, choosing nothing and rejecting nothing." The studies of a Pumpkin Flower (Meran), Branch of Vine (Bellosquardo), Cyclamen (Tivoli), reproduced in Chapter III., and others, were made during this autumn of 1856.

In a letter written to Mr. M. Spielmann, a few years before his death, Leighton describes the procedure he pursued in accomplishing a serious work.

"In my pictures,—which are above all decorations in the real sense of the word,—the design is a pattern in which every line has its place and its proper relation to other lines, so that the disturbing of one of them, outside certain limits, would throw the whole out of gear. Having thus determined my picture in my mind's eye, in the majority of cases I make a sketch in black and white chalk upon brown paper to fix it. In the first sketch the care with which the folds have been broadly arranged will be evident, and if it be compared with the finished picture, the very slight degree in which the general scheme has been departed from will convince the spectator of the almost scientific precision of my line of action. But there is a good reason for this determining of the draperies before the model is called in; and it is this. The nude model, no matter how practised he or she may be never moves or stands or sits, in these degenerate days, with exactly the same freedom as when draped; action or pose is always different—not so much from a sense of mental constraint as from the unusual liberty experienced by the limbs to which the muscular action invariably responds when the body is released from the discipline and confinement of clothing.

"The picture having been thus determined, the model is called in, and is posed as nearly as possible in the attitude desired. As nearly as possible, I say; for, as no two faces are exactly alike, so no two models ever entirely resemble one another in body or muscular action, and cannot, therefore, pose in such a manner as exactly to

correspond with either another model or another figure—no matter how correctly the latter may be drawn. From the model make the careful outline on brown paper, a true transcript from life, which may entail some slight corrections of the original design in the direction of modifying the attitude and general appearance of the figure. This would be rendered necessary probably by the bulk and material of the drapery. So far, of course, my attention is engaged exclusively by 'form,' colour being always treated more or less ideally. The figure is now placed in its surroundings, and established in exact relation to the canvas. The result is the first true sketch of the entire design, figure, and background, and is built up of the two previous ones. It must be absolutely accurate in the distribution of spaces, for it has subsequently to be 'squared off' on to the canvas, which is ordered to the exact scale of the sketch. At this moment, the design being finally determined, the sketch in oil colours is made. It has been deferred till now, because the placing of the colours is, of course, of as much importance as the harmony. This done, the canvas is for the first time produced, and thereon I enlarge the design, re-draw the outline—and never departing a hair's-breadth from the outlines and forms already obtained—and then highly finishing the whole figure in warm monochrome from the life. Every muscle, every joint, every crease is there, although all this careful painting is shortly to be hidden with the draperies; such, however, is the only method of insuring absolute correctness of drawing. The fourth stage completed, I return once more to my brown paper, re-copy the outline accurately from the picture, on a larger scale than before, and resume my studies of draperies in greater detail and with still greater precision, dealing with them in sections, as parts of a homogeneous whole. The draperies are now laid with infinite care on to the living model, and are made to approximate as closely as possible to the arrangement given in the first sketch, which, as it was not haphazard, but most carefully worked out, must of necessity be adhered to. They have often to be drawn piecemeal, as a model cannot by any means always retain the attitude sufficiently long for the design to be wholly carried out at one cast.^[2] This arrangement, is effected with special reference to painting—that is to say, giving not only form and light and shade,

but also the relation and 'values' of tones. The draperies are drawn over, and made to conform exactly to the forms copied from the nudes of the underpainted picture. This is a cardinal point, because in carrying out the picture the folds are found fitting mathematically on to the nude, or nudes, first established on the canvas. The next step then is to transfer the draperies to the canvas on which the design has been squared off, and this is done with flowing colour in the same monochrome as before over the nudes, to which they are intelligently applied, and which nudes must never—mentally at least—be lost sight of. The canvas has been prepared with a grey tone, lighter or darker, according to the subject in hand, and the effect to be produced. The background and accessories being now added, the whole picture presents a more or less completed aspect—resembling that, say, of a print of any warm tone. In the case of draperies of very vigorous tone, a rich flat local colour is probably rubbed over them, the modelling underneath being, though thin, so sharp and definite as to assert itself through this wash. Certain portions of the picture might probably be prepared with a wash of flat tinting of a colour the opposite of that which it is eventually to receive. A blue sky, for instance, would possibly have a soft, ruddy tone spread over the canvas—the sky, which is a very definite and important part of my compositions, being as completely drawn in monochrome as any other of the design; or, for rich blue mountains a strong orange wash or tint might be used as a bed. The structure of the picture being thus absolutely complete, and the effect distinctly determined by a sketch which it is my aim to equal in the big work, I have nothing to think of but colour, and with that I now proceed deliberately, but rapidly."

So far Leighton explained the conscious processes he went through in creating his pictures; but does this explanation record truly the real agencies which brought about the result we see in his finest achievements? I should say no,—most emphatically no. Where we can trace the sign of these processes, there the picture fails in the power of convincing. No such process produced "Eucharis" nor the "Syracusan Bride." The process may have been gone through in painting the procession, but it is obliterated by touches instinct with a true painter's inspiration. All *teachable* qualities

Leighton could *teach* on the lines of soundest principles. His extreme modesty left others to find out that where his preaching left off the real work began in his own pictures. No one knew better than Leighton that no theoretic knowledge ever made an artist; no teachable processes ever made a beautiful picture; no one knew better that head without heart never produced any work that was truly cared for.

"God forgive me if I am intolerant," he wrote to Steinle, "but according to my view an artist must produce his art out of his own heart; or he is none."

"The chord that wakes in kindred hearts a
tone,
Must first be tuned and vibrate in your own"

were the words with which he ended his first address to the students of the Royal Academy.

In the world's estimate of things and people, classification plays at times a pernicious part. Classification in art matters may be tolerated as useful only in the education of the non-artistic. Invariably the most convincing touches escape the possibility of being reduced to so dull a process of reckoning. Art marked by individual spontaneity, emanating from the ego of the artificer, refuses to be levelled down into a class. Critics seem at times to be strongly tempted to fit an artist's achievements into certain classes, because they have previously made up their minds as to the class the work belongs to. Hence the perversion often of even an intelligent critic's estimate: certain squarenesses exist which will not fit into round holes, so, for the sake of classification, the corners must be shaved off. Surely no artist ever existed who evaded being comfortably fitted into either a square or a round hole more completely than did Leighton. Every serious work he undertook was an entirely separate performance from any previous invention—a new venture throughout—and, once decided on, carried through with absolute conformity to the original conception. Therefore any classification, beyond his mere method of working, is more sterile in producing a just estimate of Leighton's art than of those workers who are in the habit of painting pictures in which the same motive recurs. Essentially original in his conceptions as in his aims, and vibrating with receptiveness,

he sounded nevertheless every impression he received by unchanging principles adhered to as implicit guides. He had within him at once the steadiest rock as a foundation, and the most fertile of serial growths on the surface. Abiding rock and surface flora alike had had their earliest nurture, it must be remembered, in foreign parts, under other skies than that of our veiled English light—under other influences of nature and of art than that of our English climate and schooling—and it is partly owing to this fact that it is not realised by those who have never seen nature under the aspects which most delighted him, that Leighton's conceptions were directly and invariably inspired by nature. Those who are conversant with Italy and other Southern countries will possess the key to much that is misjudged by others in Leighton's work. Scenes which entranced his sensibilities as a boy, and, lingering ever in his fancy, gave subjects for his paintings when his art was mature, may appear to one without special knowledge of the South as mere echoes of classic art. When he was thirty-one Leighton exhibited the picture "Lieder ohne Worte."^[3] It is no record, probably, of any particular place, nor of any particular fountain; but when strolling on a road in or near a southern town or village in Italy, a view which might originally have inspired the motive may be seen at any moment. Encased in a wall near Albano is a fountain which certainly recalled to me the picture as, in the bright light of a May morning, the song of nightingales in the grand foliage of overhanging magnolia trees echoed the sound of the water springing from the glistening lip, and flowing over the clean curve of the marble basin into the trough below. There was the same lion's head which served as spout, the same arrangement of ornament encircling it; also a finely shaped pitcher placed below to catch the water, and—more recalling than any detail—was the echo of the real motive of the picture—the dream-like poetry of the sunlit scene, with the musical accompaniment of trickling water. Had Leighton painted a Discobolus, it would probably never have occurred to most English critics that nature and living action had inspired the work. Above the lake of Albano is a road—"the Upper Gallery"—where every day are to be met men playing the game. Any one watching it may see repeated over and over again the action in the well-known statue. Nature inspired the creations of the great ancients, and it was also invariably first-hand impressions from nature that inspired Leighton's creations, whatever superstructure of learning he added in the course of their development. Living in Italy when his feelings were most sensitive to impressions, the

origin of the suggestions he imbibed is to be found in her atmosphere, colouring, and the scenes which surrounded him when his imagination was most free and fertile. Later, when he lived in England, his travels in Italy and Greece supplied him with the subjects for the most beautiful sketches he made direct from nature. No one, I believe, has ever painted the luminous quality of white, as it is seen under heated sunlight in the South, with the same charm as Leighton. The sketches he made of buildings in Capri^[4] are quite marvellously true in their rendering of such effects. He made equally beautiful studies of mountains and sea, under the rarefied atmosphere of Greece. He seemed always happiest, I think, when the key of his pictures and sketches was light and sunlit; in such pictures, for instance, as "Winding the Skein," "Greek Girls Picking up Shells by the Seashore," "Bath of Psyche," "Invocation," and others remarkable for their fairness and their light, pure tone.

Leighton's sympathies were adverse to the more sensuous qualities in painting. Often, in discussing the works by Watts, he would strongly discourage those who were, he considered, unduly influenced by the charm of the great painter's quality and texture, from endeavouring to aim at it in their own work. Such a treatment, Leighton maintained, might be legitimate as the natural expression of the intuitive genius of one gifted individual, but was not the treatment to copy by the student on account of any intrinsic merit. He had almost an aversion to any process which obtained effects through roughness and inequality of surface. His genuine youthful predilection, which he retained consistently throughout his life, was for the early Italian art and Italian method of painting *al fresco*. "To see the old Florentine school again is a thing which always enchants me anew, for one can never be sated with seeing the noble sweetness, the child-like simplicity, allied with high manly feeling, which breathes in it. But I speak to you of plain things which you know far better than I."—(Letter to Steinle from Florence, 1857.)



GREEK GIRLS PICKING UP SHELLS BY THE SEASHORE. 1871

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After Leighton became President of the Royal Academy he made Perugia his halting-place for some weeks during his autumn travels, while he wrote his biennial discourses for the students. He invariably stayed at the well-known Brufani Hotel,—Mrs. Brufani, with whom he made great friends, always reserving the same two rooms for him, from the windows of which he could watch the sun set behind the glorious piles of Umbrian mountains to the west of Perugia. From these windows he also made sketches in silver point of the distant ranges, each form modelled with exquisite delicacy and perfection, though in faintest tones. Other inmates of the Brufani supposed he lived in his two rooms, as he was seldom seen elsewhere in the hotel; but Leighton had found a restaurant which, like his old quarters in Rome—the *Café Greco*—was the resort of the artists living in Perugia. There he would lunch, and then repair to the Sala del Cambio. Sitting on the raised seat near the window, he would, day after day, spend an hour or more revelling in the beauty of the frescoes by Perugino. Then he would mount to the Pinacoteca and take a deep draught of enjoyment from the tempera paintings of Perugino's master, Benedetto Bonfiglio, Leighton's favourite of favourites ("They are all my *Bonfigli*!" he would exclaim), whose angels' aureoles rest on wreaths of roses, and whose lovely work Perugia seems to have

monopolised. The old paintings of Martino, Gentile da Fabriano, Pietro da Foligno, and their followers Leighton also loved, likewise the later work of Bernardino Pinturicchio and Lo Spagna, pupils with Raphael of Perugino. Among his greatest favourites were the painted banners—the *Gonfalone*—which are peculiar to the Umbrian cities. He loved the freshness of their quality—the result of a first painting never retouched—the masterly ease of the workmanship, full of tender, gracious beauty. These days were Leighton's real holidays, where, in rapturous admiration of the art he loved so profoundly, he put behind him for the time the weight of official responsibility, and the no less exhausting social duties of his life.

Had Leighton been able to devote himself to the method of painting in fresco, and to work in a warm, dry climate, which admits of painting into the wet surface of plaster without danger of the wall retaining the moisture, he would, undoubtedly, have felt a freer impulse to work rapidly and more spontaneously than when his touch was controlled by the complicated procedures in oil painting. In the process of painting *al fresco*, colour, in a sense, models itself—its absorption into the wet plaster softening the edges of one touch into another; hence, over a first painting no half obliteration is necessary, and any elaborate finish is avoided. Being obliged to complete before the plaster was dry, Leighton could not have yielded to the temptation to over-refine his surface; and his splendid power as a draughtsman, allied to his sense of beauty, would have found a perfectly spontaneous, happy utterance. As a boy he had imbibed one great principle, and from this principle he never deviated. He wrote, "The thoroughness of all the great masters is so pervading a quality that I look upon them all as forming one aristocracy." In his sketches alone did Leighton relax from the strain which absolute thoroughness involves; and then, in all the fervour of æsthetic inspiration, colour would fly on canvas, chalk or paper, with a charm of quality and exquisite grace of line and form which, as Mr. Briton Rivière remarks, is the very best that can be obtained from a great artist thoroughly trained, but which condition Leighton would never admit into what he considered his serious work. He writes to his father from Rome, January 1853: "I was deeply impressed with the glorious works of art I saw in Venice and Florence, and was particularly struck with the exquisitely *elaborate* finish of most of the leading works by *whatever* master; the highest possible finish combined with the greatest possible breadth and grandeur of disposition in the principal masses. Art with the old masters

was full of love, refined,—sterling." Leighton formed his standard from these old masters, and never for a moment allowed his standard to be replaced by another. In certain types of Englishmen chivalric loyalty develops at times into obstinacy. Leighton, with all his passion for Italy, his artistic sensitiveness, his excitability, his finely wrought nervous temperament, and his intense power of sympathy, had also in his blood something of the old English Tory, which made him adhere and remain loyal to the strongest impressions of his youth. Catholic and generous as he always proved himself to be when it was a question of considering the work of others, when he was considering his own he ever maintained absolute consistency with the tenets of his early illuminations. Speaking of his extraordinary sense of duty and the consequent tension involved, Mr. Briton Rivière writes:—

"No doubt the constant wear and tear occasioned by the perpetual strain of mental and physical watchfulness did much to shorten his life; I think it sometimes injured his own work as an artist, because, though a great artist can never be evolved except by years of patient work and strenuous effort to do his very best always, yet, on the other hand, it is often the happy, easy work and absolutely spontaneous effort of the moment by such a hand which is his very best. Such happy, easy work probably Leighton would seldom allow himself to do, and never would leave at the right moment, but would still strive to make better and more complete. He must still elaborate it and try to make it more perfect; and this it was that made his enthusiastic admirer Watts sometimes say, 'How much finer Leighton's work would be if he would admit the accidental into it.'"

A fact, little suspected by the public, certainly affected the element of strength in some of Leighton's works. Besides often suffering from a positive want of health, his normal physical condition was far from robust; and, as appears in his letters, he suffered much through weakness and irritation in the eyes from the time he was a boy. He did not wear his physical (or any other) distress on his sleeve, and experienced many hindrances in his work never dreamt of, even by his intimate acquaintances. These might not have been so serious had he been willing to sacrifice all

other duties in life to his own special vocation; but though he realised that Art, the language of beauty, was his main passion, his conscience would not allow him to make this passion an excuse for avoiding help to his generation on other lines, if he distinctly felt he could do so. In the happiest of surroundings, with his life unburdened by public responsibilities, he painted "Cimabue's Madonna"; and, for pure vigour in the manipulation, this painting has a robust quality which is scarcely to be found in any other of the larger works which followed, though these may possess many other virtues, and evince a more definite individuality, than does the early work.

Leighton's art appeals to the artists (comparatively few in England) possessed of cosmopolitan culture—also to many who love beauty, a sense of refined distinction in feeling and in form and in the arrangement of line. Beyond these it appeals also to the great public outside the radius of specialists, a public which is impressed by a sense of beauty and achievement without possessing the knowledge of experts. It is not much cared for by the disciples of either of the latest schools in England, and in France, which have governed fashion in the matter of taste for the last twenty years. In the first place, it appeals but little to those to whom the highest province of art appears to consist in conveying didactic sentiments and poetic ideas through a language of form and colour—to suggest thought to the brain rather than beauty to the eye. Respecting this theory of the province of art, Leighton expresses himself clearly in his second address to the Royal Academy students in December 1881:—

"Now the language of Art is not the appointed vehicle of ethic truths; of these, as of all knowledge as distinct from emotion, though not necessarily separated from it, the obvious and only fitted vehicle is speech, written or spoken—words, the symbols of ideas. The simplest spoken homily, if sincere in spirit and lofty in tone, will have more direct didactic efficacy than all the works of all the most pious painters and sculptors from Giotto to Michael Angelo; more than the Passion music of Bach, more than a Requiem by Cherubini, more than an Oratorio of Handel.

"It is not, then, it cannot be the foremost duty of Art to seek to embody that which it cannot adequately present, and to enter into a competition in which it is doomed to inevitable defeat."

That so great a painter as Watts should have taken a contrary view, and preached this contrary view as that which inspired his own *conscious* aims, was quite sufficient to secure to it many adherents. He preached his doctrine, moreover, with a most convincing argument, but one which cannot logically be used in favour of it, namely, his own great genius as a *painter*. Watts was essentially a *painter*—one who at his best ranks with the best painters of all times.

Mr. Arthur Symons, writing on "The Psychology of Watts,"^[5] quotes a popular preacher who affirmed that "Critics who approach his (Watts') work from the side of technical excellence do not interest him at all. His endeavour has been to make his pictures as good as works of art as was possible to him, for fear that they should fail altogether in their appeal; but, beyond that, their excellence as mere pictures is nothing to him." "Now," writes Mr. Symons, "it is quite possible that Watts may have really said or written something of the kind; he may even, when he set himself down to think, have thought it. The conscious mental processes of an artist have often little enough relation with his work as art; by no means is every artist a critic as well as an artist. But to take a great painter at his word, if he assures you that the excellence of his pictures 'as mere pictures' is nothing to him; to suppose seriously that at the root of his painting was not the desire to paint; to believe for a moment that great pictorial work has ever been done except by those who were painters first, and everything else afterwards, is to confuse the elementary notions of things, hopelessly and finally. And so, when we are told that the technical excellence of Watts' pictures is of little consequence, we can but answer that to the 'painter of earnest truths,' as to all painters, nothing can be of more consequence; for it is only through this technical excellence that 'Hope,' or 'The Happy Warrior,' or 'Love and Life,' is to be preferred to the picture leaflet which the district missionary distributes on his way through the streets."

All who knew Watts intimately and watched him working day by day can testify that he spared no labour, time, or patience, in working over and over

on a picture in order to attain the finest quality in the actual surface which his material—paint—could possibly produce.

Neither the disciples of the original brotherhood of the pre-Raphaelites nor those of Burne-Jones care, as a rule, for Leighton's art. Though starting as one with the pre-Raphaelites, Burne-Jones, possessing a remarkably fine intellect, a subtle fancy, a rich inventiveness in the detail of design, an exquisite sense of grace, and great genius as a colourist, developed so distinct an individuality that his followers cannot be precisely identified with those of the pre-Raphaelites. Leighton fully appreciated the genius of Burne-Jones, and did all in his power to secure his adherence to the Academy; but he had no sympathy for that feeling in art evinced by Burne-Jones' followers, which is so essentially rooted in purely personal moods that even distortion of the human frame is condoned, so long as prominence is given to the suggestion of such moods.

Imbued with a rare, peculiar refinement all its own, a kind of æsthetic creed sprang up in the later days of the nineteenth century apart from the arid soil of commonplace respectability and tasteless materialism. Burne-Jones painted it, Kate Vaughan danced it, Maeterlinck wrote it, the "Souls" (rather unsuccessfully) attempted to live it, the humourists caricatured it, the Philistines denounced it as morbid and unwholesome. Leighton was tolerant and amused, but could not be very solemn over it. And, assuredly, already this creed has been whisked away into the past by fashions diametrically opposed to it in character. Its text may be found in Melisande's reiterated refrain, "I am not happy"—though the unhappiness does not seem ever to have been of the nature of the iron which entered into the soul, but rather the shadow of sadness, adopted with the idea that such a condition betokens a more rare and tender grace than the radiance of joy can give. Every mood of the subjective has been lately in fashion in æsthetic circles, and is still rampant in much of the up-to-date (or down-to-date, as it may be) conditions of the present taste. This is probably consequent on the leadership of those artists who possessed not only genius and sense of beauty, but a peculiar charm of texture in their work which seems a native adjunct to certain temperaments. It is a purely personal manner, and crops up without reference apparently to any special school of art. In Sodoma we find it allied to a development of the splendid completeness of Italian Art; again in the Celt, Watts, to a lofty imagination

and to a Pheidian sensibility for noble form; it appears in the work of the Jew, Simeon Solomon; and is an element in Burne-Jones' lovely quality of painting especially noticeable in his water-colour drawings—and, on a smaller scale of workmanship, in the pictures by Pinwell. It is more a matter of quality than of colour, and yet it is only colourists who have possessed it—most obviously, however, where the key of colour is restrained almost to monochrome. A hint of it can be found in Tintoretto's paintings, where few positive tints are prominent, as in some of the ceiling paintings in the Ducal Palace at Venice. There is a something which this special handling suggests which possesses a very subtle charm, the charm of dreamland,—less tangible, less real than direct appeals from nature. A slight mystery seems to veil the vision like a reflection swayed by the surface of the water. It is less explicit than any real object, and only suggests completion without quite achieving it; there is something left out from the aspect of nature, something added from the ego of the artist. There are those to whom such a treatment suggests a deeper truth than can any wholly explicit expression, because they feel forcibly that mystery is the soul of all earthly conditions—"we see through a glass darkly." There are others—and Leighton was among these—who are so strongly imbued with a sense of the wonderful and marvellous in actual creation that they need no art, no veiled suggestion of the hidden, in order to realise that our lives are wrapped in mystery from the cradle to the grave. This quality in painting alluded to, fits in with that taste in literature which prefers hints to assertions—that insistency on the value of what is, after all, but a *fugitive* phase in special temperaments—that setting most value on the principle of suggestion rather than of definition, of which we hear so much. The devotees of Maeterlinck delight in the shadow of a thought rather than the thought *arrêté*; they feel that a further stage of refined culture is reached in worshipping a style you have to get somehow behind, rather than one in which thoughts are fully and frankly expressed. Doubtless it requires a more subtle weapon to catch the fleeting aroma, the hint of a thought trembling in the brain and giving it permanent existence in Art, than to carve the expression of a complete idea explicitly with cameo-like precision, be it in the form of words or a visual impression—the wise sayings of a Solomon or a Bacon, the sculpture of a Pheidias or the painting of a Leonardo da Vinci. The actual visible facts in the aspects of nature, which were of such entrancing interest to Leighton, become of less and less interest to the wide public as the human intelligence

is trained more and more through books, less and less through the eye; our modern conditions making the world we live in, more and more ugly and uninspiring to the echoing tune of nature within us. Even if we recede into the depths of the country, we find the signs all round us of the sense of beauty being deadened, the revulsion against ugliness having ceased—corrugated iron supplanting thatched roofing, and the loveliest, most rural spots in England year after year newly deprived of some special charm they have possessed for centuries. Those who seek for beauty have been led to find it in the unreal—the things which might be, but are not. We cannot help it, but we certainly become more artificial as our civilisation becomes more complicated, and everything we see around us grows uglier. It is because the general public has so little genuine interest in Art or love of beauty, however great may be its professions, that the tendency has developed to care for the art which appeals rather to the mind and the æsthetic sensibilities generally, than to the actual vision.

This reign of the subjective has brought in its train the undue monopolising of the world's most ardent interest in one passion. French novels of great literary power secured to it the monopoly in France, and magnates in æsthetic culture have grafted it on to our English taste. This strongest and most beautiful feeling in human nature has been so monotonously forced upon us in literature *à tort et à travers*—the assumption that this is the only feeling worth serious consideration has been dwelt on with such a tiresome pertinacity—it has been so often caricatured, so often debased in books and pictures, that even the real thing itself runs a danger of palling. This human passion may be the greatest, but it is not the only great feeling with which the lives of men and women are enriched; and surely the absorbing prominence which has been given to it latterly in literature is out of proportion with its real position in healthy lives. Little sympathy seems left for other deep and stirring emotions. In Leighton's art we find no monopoly of this kind either recorded or suggested. He painted the passion of lovers in the "Paolo and Francesca," but with no more sincere interest than he did other feelings; than, for instance, his fervent and reverent worship of art in "Cimabue's Madonna," or in the ecstasy of joy in the child flying into the embrace of her mother in "The Return of Persephone," or in the exquisite tender feeling of Elisha breathing renewed life into the Shunammite's son, or in that sense of rest and peace after struggle in the lovely figure of "Ariadne" when Death releases her from her

pain; or in the yearning for that peace in the "King David": "Oh that I had wings like a dove! for then would I fly away and be at rest."

As the climax of nature's loveliest creations Leighton treated the human form with a courageous purity. In his undraped figures there is the same total absence of the mark of the degenerate as there is in everything he did and was; no remote hint of any *double-entendre* veiled by æsthetic refinement, any more than there is in the Bible, the *Iliad*, or in the sculpture of Pheidias.

To quote lines that were written about Leighton very shortly before his death:—

"There is truly to be traced in the feeling of his art that 'seal on a man's work of what is most inward and peculiar in his moods'; the sign of individual intimate preferences and of the moving power which certain aspects of beauty have had upon the artist's innermost susceptibilities, though these may be somewhat veiled and distanced by being translated through the reserved form of a classic garb. Perhaps it is this reserve which invests Sir Frederic Leighton's art with the special aroma of poetry which Robert Browning found in it to a greater extent than in any other work of his time.^[6] Whether in his larger compositions, in the complicated grouping of many figures, such as the Cimabue picture being led in procession through the streets of Florence, the 'Daphnephoria,' 'Heracles struggling with Death,' the 'Andromache,' the 'Cymon and Iphigenia,' and others; or those simpler compositions, such as the 'Summer Moon,' 'Wedded,' 'The Mountain Summit,' 'The Music Lesson,' 'Sister's Kiss,' in all can be traced the sentiment of a poet inspiring the touch; not overriding by any assertiveness of sentiment the complete scheme of the picture, but lingering here and there with a wistful loveliness which has to be sought for within the barriers of the formal classic design. And it is this reticence in the expression of individual sentiment, this subduing it to the larger conditions of a more abstract style of art which, though it will never make Sir Frederic Leighton's work directly popular, gives to it a quality of distinction. In such reticence is an element of greatness which probably will only be duly appreciated when the more transient moods of thought in the

present generation have passed. His work lacks altogether the sentimental, brooding-over-self quality, which, when allied to genius, is contagious, and gives an interest of a subtle, but perhaps not altogether wholesome kind to some of the best work of this era."

And again after his death:—

"Beauty of every kind played on a very sensitive instrument, when it made an appeal to his nature, giving him very positive joy: no complication of subtle interest beyond the actual influence being required before a responding echo was sounded, because so pure and innocent was this joy he had in the charm of beauty;—so also attendant on his personal influence, there was no power of mesmerism, nor of the black arts. In every direction it was healthy and bracing. Even a Nordau could have discovered no remotest taint of the degenerate!"

It is the emotions which art suggests outside itself which have been viewed by one school as more interesting than art itself, and it is the sensuous qualities in painting—colour and texture—which are the visible agents, and convey more readily these suggestions of emotions in our northern temperaments than do beautiful lines and forms. Our northern temperaments also love symbolism and mysticism, therefore are apt to favour the art that meets a veiled condition of things; and the perfection of complete finish in nature's form is no longer held up as a standard for the student to aim at. Leighton had no sympathy with the artificial, neither had he any with the shadow put in the place of the substance. The actual was ever sufficient for him, for in nature herself he never failed to find sufficient inspiration. The mind of the Creator in matter is what the ingenuous artist temperament searches for and is inspired to record; whereas it is, on the one hand, phases of human moods, selections from human passions, good, bad, and indifferent, which are made to saturate the feeling in much of our modern art, or, on the other hand, aspects of nature's moods given without the framework of her structure, and without the detail of her perfection.

It may be argued, however, that there are among the most beautiful effects in nature those which are not fully distinct to the sight—the

shimmering iridescence on a shell, where one colour is seen sparkling against another through a film, or the waving branches of a willow, the liquid shifting of a flowing stream, or the endless effects of cloud and mist in a northern sky. To express this in paint requires an appropriate treatment in the manipulation of the pigment itself. Watts' theory was that you have to unfinish the record of certain facts in order to render the truth of the whole fact (see also Steinle's criticism on Leighton's head of "Vincenzo," 1854). He would, therefore, film his painting over with a scumble of white, and only partially repaint the surface, in order to get at that whole truth which includes the bloom of atmosphere and the veil of northern mists. Leighton is thought at times to have erred on the side of explicitness, and the texture of his surface is apt undoubtedly to lack the vibrating quality which carries with it a beauty of its own. This is partly accounted for by the fact that he had imbibed the rudiments of his teaching in a school whose followers were not sensitive to the finest qualities in oil painting, but also probably from his extreme desire to give expression to his sense of the intense finish in nature.

Doctrinaires of the very latest fashion in art insist that nothing comes legitimately within the province of the pictorial, except the impression of nature transmitted to the physical organ detached from memory, experience, and mind. By this faction the eye is treated solely as a machine. Sound as may be the doctrine that art has nothing to do with what the eye cannot see, or with those facts which experience alone teaches us are there, it is also no less true that the human eye sees, according to its intuitive power of transmitting to the brain, the different component parts of the actual object of its vision. It was no knowledge of anatomy which enabled Pheidias to see every subtilty of form in the human figure with consummate insight—any more than it was a knowledge of the laws of the flow and ebb of the tides, which enabled Whistler to give an actual sense of the swaying surface of the waves in "Valparaiso Bay"; again, it was no knowledge of botany which enabled Leighton and Millais to reproduce the structure of plants so perfectly, that they evoked unmitigated admiration as botanical studies from so high an authority on botany as Sir W.C. Thistleton Dyer. We may be told that what we really see is only the relation of tone, of light and shadow; but the fact that the architecture of the whole visible world, the meaning-full construction of all things that nature builds, is being constantly realised by our sight, makes the truth of this theory at least doubtful. That our eye

cannot discern these natural objects without light goes without saying; further, that light and shadow shape the forms to be rendered by the brush is also true: but the assertion that what we see is only light and shade playing upon form, is shutting the door on another equally obvious truth. The eye, gifted with a natural sense of form, records ingenuously to the brain the sense of projecting and receding planes, the foreshortening of masses, the straightness, slant, or curve in a surface or in a line. A complete and exhaustive result may be achieved in a painting through this sense of form, as in the work of Van Eycke and of Leonardo da Vinci; or a shorthand record may be made, as in that of Phil May's sketches. But we feel that in both the sense of the whole form has been felt. However, volumes would not exhaust the arguments for and against the so-called impressionist's view of art; so-called—but surely a term unfortunate and misleading, and in nowise explanatory. Every touch a true artist ever puts upon canvas is a record of an impression—whether that impression comprises the structure, light and shade, true colour and tone, all combined,—or only certain surface qualities extracted from its entirety and enforced so that the most obvious appearances start into relief, giving doubtless a sense of vitality to a work, but remaining nevertheless only a partial record of the object. Needless to say, Leighton sought to record his impressions of nature in their entirety, and this necessitated a balancing of their component attributes. The startling element is never found in his art.

He viewed the influence of art as one which should perfect the life of every class; should purify in all directions the debasing elements of materialism and self-interest; should put zest and gratitude into the hearts of all men and women who can see and feel, by awakening a sense of the perfection and beauty of nature, art forming an explanatory and illuminating link between her and mankind—a translation of her perfection transmitted with all reverence by the artificer;—a perfecting beautiful pinnacle in the erection and development of a noble human being.

No words could better describe Leighton's high endeavour in training his own mind and those whom he tried to influence, than the following, written by Lord Acton and quoted by his friend, Sir M. Grant Duff.^[7] "If I had the power," writes Sir M. Grant Duff, "I would place upon his monument the words which he wrote as a preface to a list of ninety-eight books he drew up, and about which he still hoped to read a paper at Cambridge when he

wrote to me on the subject last autumn. 'This list is submitted with a view to assisting an English youth, whose education is finished, who knows common things, and is not training for a profession, to perfect his mind and open windows in every direction; to raise him to the level of his age, so that he may know the forces that have made the world what it is, and still reign over it; to guard against surprises and against the constant sources of errors within; to supply him both with the strongest stimulants and the surest guides; to give force and fulness, and clearness and sincerity, independence and elevation, generosity and serenity to his mind, that he may know the method and lay of the process by which error is conquered and truth is won, discerning knowledge from probability and prejudice from belief; that he may learn to master what he rejects as fully as what he adopts; that he may understand the origin as well as the strength and vitality of systems, and the better motives of men who are wrong; to steel him against the charm of literary beauty and talent, so that each book, thoroughly taken in, shall be the beginning of a new life, and shall make a new man of him.'" In a like spirit Leighton sought to arrive at viewing art; and what Lord Acton sought to effect by the general culture of men's minds and natures through reading, Leighton sought to effect in his special vocation by inducing other artists to study all that was greatest in Art from a wide and unprejudiced point of view—making it their own, so to speak, by thoroughly realising and appreciating the qualities in it which make it great. Each true masterpiece in Art, he urged, should be thoroughly taken in, and should be the beginning of a new effort. On the other hand, he sought to make the student "learn to master what he rejects as fully as what he adopts, that he may understand the origin as well as the strength and vitality of systems, and the better motives of men who are wrong." His desire was to guide art into the current of the world's best interests—the current in which good literature is so forcible an agent—on the highest, broadest, most catholic lines. He endeavoured to do so by his example as a working artist, by his Discourses, by his labours for the public in every direction where the Art of his country was concerned, and more directly by his influence on those with whom he personally came in contact.

FOOTNOTES:

[1] This picture has, I believe, unfortunately left the country. It was suggested by a passage in the second Idyll of Theocritus: "And for her, then many other wild beasts were going in procession round about, and among them a lioness." Sketches for portions of the picture and the squared tracing for the complete design can be seen in the Leighton House Collection. The full-length portrait of Mrs. James Guthrie was exhibited the same year as this second processional picture, which appeared on the walls of the Academy eleven years after the "Cimabue's Madonna." The head of the central figure, the Bride, Leighton painted from Mrs. Guthrie. The following charming letter from Mrs. Norton, the most notable of Sheridan's three beautiful daughters, refers to this picture:—

3 CHESTERFIELD STREET,
April 9.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I was so amused by the little grandson's observation on the picture that I cannot help writing about him. I asked him "what he thought of it"? He said, "Oh! it was *beautiful!* but you told me it would be beautiful—*Mr. Leighton* was like a *man in a story!* you did not look so much at him as Carlotta and I did, but I suppose you have seen him before, and you did not seem to *pity the little panther!* There was, in the picture, a little young *puppy* panther, and one of the young brides was coaxing it so tenderly, and looking down at its head; and she was one of the prettiest and kindest looking of all the brides (it was the side of the picture furthest from the screen); and I could not help thinking, 'Ah, my poor little panther! you little know when the brides get into that temple, and she gets married, how she'll forget all about you, and get coaxing other things, her husband and her children'; and I felt quite sorry for the panther." So spoke my grandson (just as I felt sorry for the cripple beggar).

Now, as I am quite sure no one else will take this view of what is the principal interest in your glorious procession of youth and hope, I thought it as well to let you know, that you might give that little panther his due importance (a little leopard, I think he is), and not suppose him a subordinate accessory! That whole procession was tinged with mournfulness in Richard Norton's eyes for that little leopard's sake. I shall see that "Dream of Fair Women" again in the Exhibition, and admire it, as I did to-day, in a crowd of other admirers, I know. I do not mind the crowd. I see over them and under them, and through them, when there is anything so worth being eager about.—Believe me meanwhile, yours very truly,

CAROLINE NORTON.

[2] In a letter from Leighton to his mother, the following sentence occurs:—"Will you please explain to him" (his father) "that I am not going to model the *drapery* of my figures, but the *figures themselves* to lay the drapery on, as my models could not fly sufficiently long for me to draw them in the act; it is of

course a very great delay, but the result will amply make up for the extra trouble, I hope."

[3] The picture has left the country, but sketches of the complete design are among those in the Leighton House Collection.

[4] Lent by Lady Wantage to the Exhibition, in Leighton House, of the smaller works and sketches in 1903.

[5] *Outlook*, July 15th, 1905.

[6] When standing with me before Leighton's picture "Wedded" in the studio Robert Browning exclaimed, "I find a poetry in that man's work I can find in no other."

[7] "The Late Lord Acton." *The Spectator*, July 5, 1902.

CHAPTER I [ToC](#)

FIRST STUDIO IN LONDON

1859-1863

In 1858 Leighton was represented on the Royal Academy walls by two pictures, "The Fisherman and the Syren"—a subject from Goethe's ballad,

"Half drew she him,
Half sunk he in,
And never more was seen"—

and by a scene from "Romeo and Juliet," both small canvases painted in Rome and in Paris. [\[8\]](#)

Leighton at this time received an encouraging letter from Robert Fleury, from whom he had learned much:—

Que parlez vous de reconnaissance, mon cher Monsieur Leighton? de l'amitié je le veux bien, et je reçois, à ce titre seulement, le dessin que vous m'avez envoyé. Ne me suis je pas fait plaisir en vous reconnaissant du talent et en vous rendant la justice qui vous est due? si vous m'avez donné l'occasion de vous faire part de ma vieille espérance n'est ce pas une preuve de l'estime que vous faites de mes conseils? Puisque vous m'offrez généreusement votre amitié, je l'accepte de bien bon cœur, et votre petit dessin me restera comme un gracieux souvenir de vous.

ROBERT FLEURY.

PARIS, *le 18 Mars 1858.*

In the autumn of 1858 Leighton was back in Rome, and it was at that time the King, then Prince of Wales, first visited his studio. "I myself had the advantage of knowing him (Leighton) for a great number of years—ever since I was a boy—and I need hardly say how deeply I deplore the fact that he can be no more in our midst," were the words spoken by the King—thirty-nine years after this first meeting—at the Royal Academy banquet, which took place after Leighton's death, 1st May 1897.

He worked in Rome till his pictures were finished for exhibition in the spring, 1859.

He wrote to his mother:—

It is my particular object and study to go to no parties, in the which I have succeeded admirably. I go often to Cartwright's in the evening, that don't count; now and then to Browning, now and then to the play, see a good deal of Lady Hoare; and that reminds me that Hoare sent you some game the other day, which, however, was returned, as you were not forthcoming. By-the-bye, when I say I have made no acquaintances of interest, that is not true; Odo Russell, son and brother of my friends, Lady William and Arthur Russell, and our diplomatic agent here, is a great friend of mine, and particularly sympathetic. I see him often at Cartwright's, who is his *alter ego*; also I know and like Miss Ogle, who wrote that (I hear)

exceedingly remarkable novel, "A Lost Love." She is a country clergyman's daughter in a remote corner of Yorkshire, and wrote this book when she had, I believe, never lived out of a circle of "kettles." She is not young, but agreeable and quaint.

I am just finishing the largish studies of a very handsome model here, and am about to send them off for exhibition. They seem very popular with all who see them, and are, I think, my best things.

1859.

DEAREST MAMMY,—I find to my annoyance that I have mislaid your kind letter, so that I must answer as best I can from memory.

That the French and Austrians have been formally requested by the Pope to withdraw their troops from the States of the Church is, I have ascertained from good authority, true, though how on earth you can have known in Florence so long ago a thing which has only just happened, and which is still in great measure a secret here, is what I can't make out; but, dear Mamma, I trust this won't prevent your coming to Rome in April, as there is no chance of the evacuation being carried into effect by that time. There will be particularly (indeed exclusively) on the side of Austria a great demur and *pourparler*, inasmuch as the consequences of this step will probably be most serious to her; so that for the next few months we need fear nothing. I trust you will come; however, of course I dread the responsibility of insisting too much. You will see how matters look in a few weeks. I am just about to despatch to the Royal Academy some studies from a very handsome model, "La Nanna." I have shown them to a good many people, artists and "Philistines," and they seem to be universally admired. Let us hope they will be well hung in the Exhibition. Talking of exhibitions, you will be rather amused to hear that my "Samson" has been *refused* at the British Institution, which this year is particularly weak and insignificant. It is gone in to the Suffolk Street now, unless too late. Neither I nor anybody else has the least idea what is the cause of this strongish measure. I have sent my "Negroes" to Paris, and if it is not too late the "Juliet" and "Paris" will go there also. I think they will be well

hung, as they are godfathered by Mr. Montfort, my kind and valuable friend. This afternoon the Prince of Wales came to my studio, with Colonel and Mrs. Bruce, Gibson, &c. &c. Gibson spoke in the very highest terms of my pictures, so of course all the others were delighted!

Tuesday Morning.

I have not been able to answer your letter till now, and indeed even now I am interrupting my work to do it; I will answer all your questions categorically. First, about the brigands—I have made inquiries, and have heard of nothing new since these two cases about five weeks back, and am told that now the roads may be considered safe; indeed, no time is generally so good for travelling as just after an accident of that kind, as the authorities are on the look out: if you go by *vetturino*, there will in all probability be other *vetturini* on the road, and you will start together and arrive together from and to the different stations on the road. You quite misunderstood the sense of my letter, dear Mamma, if you imagined that I knew nothing of rumours of war, &c. &c.—so far from not knowing what is going on, I live in a hot-bed of politics, what with Cartwright and what with Odo Russell. I expressed my surprise that you should speak with confidence of the withdrawal of the French troops when the official news of the Pope's *formal request* to that effect could not yet have reached Florence, for the reason that it had not taken place; with the Florentine politicians the wish must have been father to the thought. What really will happen is impossible to say; they won't withdraw till the Austrians do—that is pretty certain; the French, I think, like to mislead people about it. A French general told a friend of mine that in *six weeks* they would all be gone, but *Antonelli*, who ought to be the best authority, told Odo Russell they would not go for *six months*, though the occupation has already ceased (as the *Moniteur* expresses it) "*en principe*." You see, dear Mamma, that it is entirely impossible for me to give you any *definite* information at a moment when nobody seems to know what is coming next. I should be very much disappointed if you could not come; if you settle to come, let me know in time to look for rooms

at an Hôtel, and tell me what you expect to give. My work would not allow me to go to Florence. My pictures for the R.A. this year are three portraits in different sizes and attitudes from the same model, all *dressed*—one a small half-length, the other a kit-cat, the third a small head the size of my hand—this I have sold to Lady Hoare for forty guineas. It has been much coveted—Lady Stratford de Redcliffe wanted a repetition (I never do repetitions), and Mrs. Phipps seemed quite distressed it was sold. The Prince and his party told O. Russell they liked my studio better than any they had seen in Rome. My "Pan" and "Venus" are stowed away in London.

Besides the three portraits of a model mentioned in his letter, exhibited at the Royal Academy, 1859, Leighton sent "Samson and Delilah" to Suffolk Street. For studies of this picture, see Leighton House Collection.

Later, from Naples, he wrote:—

Wednesday Morning, 1859.

I scribble two lines in haste before starting to Capri to announce my safe arrival here in the middle of the day on Monday. I found here several letters from England; but, as I had presumed, that report about the sale of all my pictures was a *canard*. Lord Lansdowne wishes very much for a repetition of my small profile of Nanna, but as I refused to make one for Lady Stratford, I of course can't for him. George de Monbrison has very kindly consented to give up his Nanna to the Prince,^[9] but is evidently sadly disappointed—so much so, that I have written to offer to do what I could not under any other circumstances, *i.e.* copy it for him.

This place is in great beauty. I have been received with the greatest hospitality by the Hollands, with whom I have dined and supped both days.

Yesterday I breakfasted with Augustus Craven,^[10] who photographed me. He is a great adept at this art, and devotes much time to it. He has a most lovely house here, looking out on to the sea.

I have nothing to add for the present, and I will write again from Capri.

This visit to Capri produced the famous drawing of the Lemon Tree.^[11] Mr. Ruskin wrote: "Two perfect early drawings are of 'A Lemon Tree' and of a 'Byzantine Well'" (see [List of Illustrations](#)), "which determine for you without appeal the question respecting necessity of delineation as the first skill of a painter. Of all our present masters, Sir Frederic Leighton delights most in softly-blended colours, and his ideal of beauty is more nearly that of Correggio than any since Correggio's time. But you see by what precision of terminal outline he at first restrained and exalted his gift of beautiful *vaghezza*." In letters to Leighton, Ruskin refers to these drawings:
—

1860.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—Unless I write again I shall hope to breakfast with you on Friday, and see and know evermore how a lemon differs from an orange leaf. In cases of doubtful temper, might the former more gracefully and appropriately be used for bridal chaplet?
—Most truly yours,

J. RUSKIN.

15th December 1882.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—Of course I want the lemon-tree! but surely you didn't offer it me before? May I come on Tuesday afternoon for both? and I hope to bring "Golden Water," but I hear there's some confusion between the Academy and the Burlington Club. "Golden Water" is perhaps too small a drawing for the Academy—but you'll see.

I wish the lecture on sculpture you gave that jury the other day had been to a larger audience, and I one of them.—Ever affectionately yours,

J. RUSKIN.

17th November.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I brought up the "Byzantine Well,"^[12] but was forced to trust my friend, John Simon, to bring it across the Park to you, and then forbid him till I wrote you this note, asking you to spare a moment to show him the "Damascus Glass and Arab Fountain." He is, as you know, a man of great eminence, with a weakness for *painting*, which greatly hinders him in his science.—
Ever your loving,

J.R.

I can't get lectures printed yet.

With reference to differences of opinion which had arisen between them on certain art questions, Ruskin wrote in 1879: "I expected so much help from you after those orange (lemon) trees of yours!" Later (1883) he wrote: "The Pre-Raphaelite schism, and most of all, Turner's death, broke my relations with the Royal Academy. I hope they may in future be kinder; its President (Leighton) has just sent me two lovely drawings (the 'Lemon Tree' and the 'Byzantine Well') for the Oxford Schools, and, I think, feels with me as to all the main principles of Art education."

After his visit to Capri Leighton returned to London. He stayed with Mr. Henry Greville, and while there wrote to his mother the following letters:—

19 QUEEN STREET,
Wednesday Morning, 1859.

I have so far altered my plans that I stay on until Saturday morning instead of going to-morrow with Mrs. Sartoris as I had intended. I have still a call or two to make, and, besides, am going to dine to-morrow with Mario and spend the evening of Friday at Lord Lansdowne's, whose invitation I got though I had not called on him. I suppose that a card was sent me because my name was on the old list. I have since met him (at Henry's party), and he made himself very amiable, renewing the invitation by word of mouth. I have just been spending two or three days at Old Windsor with Miss

Thackeray, who has been kindness itself as usual; the weather was divine, and we took exquisite drives. Chorley^[13] also has been a kind friend to me; he took me twice to the Handel Festival, seating me, conveying me, breakfasting me, and, but that I was engaged, would have dined me. The Festival was, as you have no doubt read in the papers, most successful, the choruses, considering the enormous difficulty of training such masses of people (2000!) were excellent; the quantity of sound produced was, of course, enormous, still there was no *din*, nothing stunning, only an exceedingly dense and close-textured quality of sound. The solo singers varied in excellence. Clara Novello shone by the quality of her voice, which carries any distance, and by the correctness of her singing, but to me she is entirely without charm, and left me as cold after the great song of the Nativity in the "Messiah" as if she had not sung at all. Miss Dolby sang well throughout; she was remarkable for the excessive decorum and simplicity of her singing. She finishes a phrase with great breadth; her voice, to some people disagreeable, is to me very *simpatica*, and she gave me altogether the greatest pleasure. Sims Reeves, whom but a few days back I heard sing so badly at Liverpool, astounded me here by the remarkable care and study he brought to bear on his solos. He sang in the "Messiah," beginning with "Behold and see if there be any sorrow," &c. He sang exquisitely; and in the "Israel" he sang "The enemy said" (a very ungrateful song) as well as possible. He was vociferously encored, and well deserved it. — was simply abominable, without a redeeming point. —, though less aggressively bad, was too insignificant to say much about at all. Of course, altogether, the solos, especially the more vigorous ones, were too weak for the choruses; that could not be otherwise short of having four pair of Lablache lungs. Costa led to perfection; it was a sight to see him.

Friday, PARIS.

DEAREST MAMMA,—I write you a few lines just to announce my safe return to Paris. You have no doubt by this time got the box back again. Henry was, as always, very kind to me, and I spent three days very simply at his house. I had intended, when I left this, to stay

only two days in London, but those days being Saturday and Sunday, I remembered that all the Galleries were shut, and therefore, being most anxious to see the new Veronese, I stayed over Monday. I was delighted with the pictures in the National Gallery and also at Marlborough House, but the annual exhibition at the British Institution is *deplorable*. I have decided, on the advice of Buckner, Colnaghi, and others, to send my "Niggers" ("A Negro Dance"—water-colour—from sketch made in Algiers) to the Suffolk Street Exhibition (where I shall be well hung through Buckner's intervention) *if* I get done in time: it will be a hard race, as the Exhibition opens a month sooner than the R.A.

I reached home Tuesday evening at 10½ o'clock, after a good passage; I was, however, suffering from a shocking indigestion, and, to crown all, was kept awake till four in the morning by a ball immediately under my bed. Next morning I had to paint away at Gallatti (my model) willy nilly (particularly nilly), feeling seedy and frightfully cross. However, my "Gehazi" is now as near as possible finished, and to-morrow I go in for the "Niggers." I hope, dear Mamma, you will let me hear at once what Lina or Suth. write; I am most anxious to hear more.

Good-bye, dear Mamma. Best love to all from your most affectionate

FRED.

Friday, 26th.

I am happy to say I have just done my "Niggers," and though too late for the ordinary mode of conveyance on account of an accident in the papers, I am saved by the exceeding kindness of a secretary of the Sardinian Embassy, a great friend of mine; it will be taken over on Monday night by a messenger under the seals of the Embassy, and will just arrive in time. On Sunday I hope to show it to Monfort, Fleury, and Scheffer. I will let you know their verdict.

From America I have good and bad news. The bad is that my "Pan" and "Venus" are *not being exhibited at all* on account of their

nudity, and are stowed away in a cupboard where F. Kemble with the most friendly and untiring perseverance contrived to discover them. This is a great nuisance. I have sent for them back at once; they know best whether or no it is advisable to exhibit such pictures in America, but they certainly should have let me know. I have written to Rossetti about it to-day, expressing my regret and desires, and have added "my pictures have been exposed to the wear and tear of several long journeys *not only* entirely for no purpose, but, being shut out from the light, they are even suffering an injury; meanwhile I am neglecting the opportunity of showing and disposing of them in England, a possibility which I might willingly forego for the sake of supporting an enterprise in which I am interested, but not to adorn a hidden closet in the United States." Fanny Kemble was charmed with the pictures, went often and pluckily to the forbidden cupboard, and said she only wished she could afford to buy them.

Friday.

Since I last wrote I have had a note from Rossetti, the Secretary of the American Exhibition, giving me a piece of information about my "Romeo" which can't fail to gratify you. He said that, had my picture not been bought by Mr. Harrison, a public subscription would have been opened to procure it for the Academy of Arts at Philadelphia. Rossetti answers me (as indeed I did not doubt) that he had not the remotest notion of the fate of "Pan" and "Venus." He has written on my request to beg they may be sent back at once to Europe. By Henry Greville's urgent advice I have given notice that I shall send the "Orpheus," as they have applied for more pictures; things were selling so satisfactorily that there was scarcely anything left to exhibit in Boston. I am glad to be able to reassure you about the "Niggers." Sartoris *did* like them exceedingly even before they were anything like as good as they are now. Cartwright, who is not *géné* to dislike, is enchanted with them, and says if they are not sold at once people are fools, for he has not for some time seen anything he likes so much. Puliza Ricardo and other "publics" like it extremely. Robert Fleury considered it highly original, and said that

if he only saw one little head in it he would say, "c'est d'un coloriste." R. Fleury, you know, blames very roundly what he does not like. Montfort, my most candid adviser, was delighted, and said of a particular bit "je vous assure c'est tout à fait comme Decamps." This is unconditional praise. Again I consulted him about its chances of success in the gallery of water-colours. He said, "*Comme aquarelle* je vous promets qu'il n'y en a pas beaucoup qui font comme cela;"—about water colour being *infra. dig.*, showing myself competent in *two* materials can only raise me. Poor Scheffer was unwell and could not come. You see, dear Mammy, you need not be so uneasy. I fully appreciate your and Papa's anxiety about my pictures; but it has too great a hold on you when it makes you think that I am entirely reckless and foolish, and that rather than give in I should tell a lie and say it was too late to withdraw a picture when it might still be done. Many thanks for the extract about Sutherland which, however, I had already seen, Henry Grev. having sent it me a week ago. My "Niggers" arrived in time by great luck. Buckner godfathers them.

In haste with very best love, your affectionate boy,

FRED.

19 QUEEN STREET, 1859.

I have got, through the kindness of Elmore (R.A.), a sort of studio at the other end of the world; I believe I told you this in my last note; I suppose my things will come over in a week or less. I am in great doubt about being able to paint in that studio, and about its having been any use to come over to London without the possibility of a really good *locale*: however, here I am. I shall brush up my acquaintances and see a good deal of my friends. Don't reckon on my *selling* anything—I don't at all. My picture is hung so that it is virtually *impossible* to see it. I went to look at my "Niggers" in Suffolk Street, and am confirmed in the idea (that also of my friends) that it is my best work. I have as yet nothing worth writing about, so good-bye, dearest Mamma, best love to all.

2 ORME SQUARE, *Sunday*, 1859.

Having got on Monday last into my studio and been very busy ever since, this is absolutely the first moment I have found to sit down and write to you.

You will wish to know some particulars about my studio. Of course after Paris and Rome it is a sad falling off—narrow and dark, though I believe, for London, very fair; when I *live* here I must have a much larger light or I shall go blind—however, I must not look a gift horse in the mouth. I have had to furnish—this costs me about nine or ten shillings a week; I keep a servant (a stupid, pompous, verbose, dirty, willing, honest scrub) to run my errands and clean my brushes, &c. &c., at half-a-crown a day; models are five shillings a sitting here—ruination!—men with good heads there are none—women, tol-lol!—a lay figure, twenty-five shillings a month; in short, historical painting here is not for nothing; I am working at my "Samson" picture; God knows how I shall finish it in so short a time! Dearest Mammy, I shall have but a very short peep at you this year, I am very sorry to say—I lost a full month waiting for this wretched studio. I don't see my way through my work before the middle or even end of the second week in August, and I cannot well

give up going to Scotland though only for a very few days, as I have accepted so long ago. I am to go there on the 20th; after that I must rush back post-haste to Stourhead to finish Lady Hoare; all this will make me very late for Italy, as I am anxious to revisit the north of that country and study the Correggios a little at Parma before going south. I shall be obliged to scamper across the country. I *must* be in Rome or the neighbourhood in October; I am going to finish my Cervara landscape on the spot.

I am in very fair health, London decidedly agrees with me, and I don't suffer as much as I expected from the obligato spleen of blue devildom. I need not say this is a source of immense congratulation to me.

When the picture "Nanna" returned from the Royal Academy, where it was exhibited in 1859, Leighton sent it to Bath, writing to his mother to announce its arrival.

LONDON, 1859.

DEAREST MAMMY,—I scribble a word in haste to announce to you that I have sent "Nanna" off to Bath for you to see, she wants varnish very badly as you see, but is not dry enough for that yet. You must mind and put her in the right light, the window must be on the left of the spectator—the more to the *left* of the picture you stand yourself the less you will see the want of varnish. If you stand to the *right* of the painting you won't see it at all. Please send "Nanna" back when you have shown to whom you wish, as she is overdue at Paris.

Saturday Morning, 1859.

I returned yesterday from the Highlands, and have at last time to write you a little word. My stay in the North has been most satisfactory, I have enjoyed myself thoroughly, and have felt particularly well in the keen bracing air of the mountains. My time has been spent exclusively in walks, rides, and drives, for the

weather was great part of the time too uncertain to allow of sitting out to paint (even had there been time), whereas no amount of showers prevented our going out, and indeed to those showers I owe seeing some of the most superb effects of colour, light and shade, that I ever beheld. We used sometimes to have three or four duckings in one ride, drying again in the sun, or not as the case might be, and never catching even the phantom of a cold, so healthy and invigorating is the breath of those healthy hills. I said I painted nothing and bring home an empty portfolio (all but a flower I drew one *very* wet morning), but I have studied a great deal with my eyes and memory, and come back a better landscape painter than I went. On my road home, at Dunkeld, where I lingered a day (exquisite spot), I jotted down in oils two reminiscences of effects observed at Kinrara with which I am rather well pleased—one is a stormy Scandinavian bit of cloud and hill, the other a hot sunny expanse of golden corn and purple heather, which looks for all the world like a bit of Italy. Mind, they are the merest little sketches, but accurate in the *impression of the effect*.

I go on Monday morning to Stourhead, where I stay till Saturday, and start Monday week for the Continent. Please send me a line to Stourhead. How are you, darling? and Lina and Gus? and Papa? Have you had any more drives?—Your loving boy,

FRED.

On returning to England Leighton took up his abode in his first studio in England. Hitherto he had paid visits to London,—Rome, and subsequently Paris, being his real home, for an artist's true home is in his studio. In the autumn of 1859 he settled in 2 Orme Square, and from that time to his death London became his headquarters.

After having settled into his studio in Orme Square in the winter of 1859, he wrote to Steinle and to Robert Browning the following letters:—

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER, LONDON,
December 5, 1859.

MY DEAR FRIEND AND MASTER,—What a long time it is since I heard from you! my last letter, despatched from Rome, has had no answer.

I enclose a photograph of a memorial tablet which I executed in Rome last winter for my poor widowed sister. The monument is of white marble with black mosaic decoration; the four dark circles are bronze nails, which secure the marble tablet to the wall.

When I had finished work in Rome, I went south and spent five weeks in Capri. You would hardly believe, dear Friend, how this wonderful island delighted me. I made vigorous use of my visit and executed a fairly large number of conscientious studies. I also took the opportunity to visit Paestum for the first time. I may say that the *Temple of Neptune* gave me the most exalted architectonic impression that I have ever received; I shall never forget that morning. The two neighbouring temples, however, are not worth looking at, except from a painter's point of view.

Meanwhile, the season being advanced, I was obliged, with real regret, to give up my plan of going to Frankfurt, and to hurry back to England. Here I am now permanently established. I confess that I did not pitch my tent here without some anxiety; I had not spent *a single winter* in England since my earliest childhood, and I had good reason to fear that to me, with my love of sunshine, it would prove a little harsh. I also feared the climate for my bodily health. However, "native air" appears to be not altogether an empty phrase, but I find myself, notwithstanding the fog, well and in good spirits. Man must indeed carry the sun in his heart—if he is to have it. Of work in particular, I have nothing much to say. Later, in the course of the winter, I will report more at length.

Meanwhile, dear Master, write to me very soon. Tell me whether you still think of your pupil, and especially tell me about your certainly numerous works.—Your grateful pupil,

LEIGHTON.

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER,
LONDON, *January 12, 1860.*

I spoke little in my last letter of my present work, partly perhaps because of the feeling I have already described, but partly also because I intend to send you a photograph directly the picture is finished, which will not be till spring. It is a commission, and the subject is religious. There is only a single figure, and I would describe it to you now, but that I fear you would imagine the picture much more beautiful than I can paint it, and you would consequently suffer a disappointment later on in my work which would be painful to me. For the rest, I am striving as hard as I can to make it fine and simple. You will perhaps be surprised, but, in spite of my fanatic preference for colour, I promised myself to be a draughtsman before I became a colourist.

And now adieu, my dear Friend. Directly I can show you anything in "black and white" you shall hear from me again, and I shall expect from you, as my old master, the most unsparing criticism; that is the greatest proof of love you can give me.

FRED LEIGHTON.

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER,
January 29, '60.

DEAR BROWNING,—It is not till the other day that I at last received from Cartwright your Rome address, or I should have written to you some time ago; before it was too late to wish you a merry Xmas and health, happiness, and all prosperity for yourself and Mrs. Browning in the present year. I don't know that I have anything worth telling you to write about, for all the little incidents which have their importance for the space of a day, all appear too trivial to write about after a lapse of a week or two. Still I write to assure you I keep up my most affectionate remembrance of you, and to beg that you won't entirely forget me. I received your kind letter at the beginning of the winter, and was truly concerned to hear that Mrs. Browning had been so alarmingly unwell; I trust that the air of Rome, which once before was so beneficial to her, will have

strengthened and recruited her again this time. Dear old Rome! how I wish I could fly over and spend a week or so with you all in my old haunts. I suppose I shall never be entirely weaned of that yearning affection I entertain for Italy, and particularly for Rome and the "Comarea." You must have it all to yourselves this year. What a delight it must be to see neither Brown, Jones, nor Robinson.

I suppose Cartwright, Pantaleone, and Odo Russell are the staple of your convivial circle; and, by-the-bye, how much more freely Mrs. Browning must breathe this winter without certain daily visitations which I remember last year. I wonder whether you will write to me and tell me what you are doing, socially and artistically; everything about you will interest me.

As for myself, you would not believe it, in spite of my old habits of continental life and sunshine, I take very kindly to England; *it agrees* with me capitally, really better than Rome. I am fattening *vue d'œil*. The light is certainly not irreproachable, still I can work, and don't find that my ideas get particularly rusty. On the contrary, for colour, certainly my sense seems to be sharpened in this atmosphere.

I am soldiering too. I drill three times a week, and make as bad a soldier as anybody else. The Sartoris, you know, are no longer in London—a great loss to all their friends—but I go pretty often to see them in the country, and have spent many a happy day there in the course of the winter. By-the-bye, do you hear or know anything of those two drawings I did of you and Mrs. Browning? If so, will you give the one of you to Hookes that he may send with some other things he has? And now, dear Browning, "*vi leverò l'incomodo*," and will bring this very tedious epistle to a close. Remember me most kindly to Mrs. Browning, to Cartwright and his wife, to Odo Russell, B——, Pantaleone with better half, Storeys, and last, but not least, dear little Hatty! Love to Cerinni; tell me about him. Good-bye.—Believe me, very affectionately yours,

FRED LEIGHTON.

I am hand-and-glove with all my enemies the pre-Raphaelites. Woolner sends his affectionate remembrances.

Leighton writes to his sister in Italy:—

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER,
March 12.

MY DEAR GUSSYKINS,—You may have heard from Mamma that I went to Paris to hear Madame Viardot in "Orphée." What wonderful singing! what style! what breadth! what pathos! You would have been enchanted, I am sure. Do you know the music? It is wonderfully fine and pathetic, the first chorus particularly is quite harrowing for the accent of grief about it. Madame Viardot's *acting*, too, is superb—so perfectly simple and grand, it is really antique. And when you consider all she has to overcome—a bad, harsh voice, an ugly face, an ungainly person; and yet she contrives to look almost handsome. She enters heart and soul into her work; she said it was the only thing she ever did that (after fifty performances) had not given her a moment's *ennui*. I am afraid there is no chance of her singing it in England this year, if at all; I don't believe the Covent Garden audience would sit through it.^[14]

I also saw Gounod's new opera, "Philémon et Baucis," and was disappointed. Nothing but the care and distinction of the workmanship redeems it from being a bore; the subject is ill adapted for the stage, and is dragged through three acts with portentous efforts. Striking melodies there are few, charming accompaniments many; all the pretty music (or nearly) is in the orchestra—*c'est la sauce qui fait avaler le poisson*. The introductions to the first and second acts, but particularly the latter (a little *motif* on the oboë), are charming; there is also a capital chorus. All this, however, is an impression after one hearing; I might alter my mind on hearing it oftener, but I think not.

In the Royal Academy Exhibition of 1860 Leighton sent one picture only, "Sunrise—Capri."

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, *September 15, 1860.*

MY VERY DEAR FRIEND,—I was almost afraid that you would think that I had entirely forgotten you, but this would be a very undeserved interpretation of my long silence. No, my dear Master, you still live in my constant memory, in my most grateful recollection.

When I last wrote, I promised to send you a photograph of my large picture. This work has taken up my time far beyond my expectations, and I always put off writing in order not to send you an empty letter. At last it is thus far, and I enclose both the large photograph and some little ones, in the hope that you, dear Master, will be interested also in the unimportant works of your old pupil.

Have I already told you the subject of my religious picture? I think not. At the turning-point of a very critical illness, the lady who commissioned my picture dreamt that she, as a disembodied spirit, soared up heavenwards in the night.^[15] Suddenly she was aware of a point of light in the far vault of heaven. This light grew, developed, and soon she saw coming forth from the night the shining form of the Saviour. Full of confidence she approached the holy apparition. Jesus, however, raised His hands and, gently repulsing her, enjoined her to return to earth, and during her life to make herself worthier to enter the company of the blessed. She awoke, recovered, and ordered the picture.

You will be able to imagine, my dear Friend, how little contented I am with my work; however, I am accustomed to show you my weaknesses, and I therefore send you also this unsatisfactory work. As regards the photograph, it is in certain respects successful, although it makes the whole picture *four times too dark*.

I send also a portrait of my sister; a head of an English soldier, who lost an arm at Balaclava, and recently died of consumption; and finally a photograph after a drawing on wood, which I drew for a book, but which has been *incredibly* disfigured by the engraver.

Fortunately I had the drawing (although bad) photographed before I sent it to be engraved.

But enough of me and my affairs.

And you, dear Master, what are you working at? Are your cartoons all finished? Shall you soon begin your frescoes? What other beautiful things have you composed?

Do not punish my long silence, but send me a couple of lines to tell me what interests me so deeply. So soon as I have finished anything new (and I have many pictures in prospect) I will send you another specimen of my handiwork.

Meantime I beg you will remember me most cordially to your wife and daughters, and to my other friends in Frankfurt. And yourself do not altogether forget, your loving pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

It was in 1860 Leighton joined the Artist Rifle Corps. It was also then he first made the acquaintance of Sir William B. Richmond (now Chairman of the Leighton House Committee).

December 12, 1860.

DEAREST MAMMY,—I have deferred until now answering your kind letter that I might be able to announce to you a little circumstance which took place yesterday, and which, though not of any real importance, may give you and Papa pleasure. I was yesterday raised to the rank of Captain; I command the 3rd Company—Lewis was at the same time made Captain of the 2nd—his election of course came before mine; he has done three times more for the Corps than I have or could have done—he lives very near and goes *every day*—as a man of business, and a very clever one, he has entirely organised the bookkeeping department, and in fact has been altogether the vital principle of the Corps. I was chosen next for having shown some zeal in this service and some little capability for teaching. The vacant lieutenancies go to Nicholson (the musician) and Talfourd. One of the ensigncies has

been given to Perugini, contingent on its being lawful for him to hold such commission; another to old Palmer. So much for our volunteering. I wish we had a commander. The next question in your letter I thought I had answered in my last—however, though Ruskin stayed about three hours and was altogether very pleasant, he did not say anything that I could quote about my paintings. He was *immensely* struck by my drawing of a lemon-tree, and was generally complimentary, or rather, *respectful*, that is more his *genre*. I don't think, however, that he cared for Sandbach's picture—which leads me to the third point in your letter. Neither of the S.'s have seen their picture; last time they were in London, having made no definite appointment, I missed them. He wrote to say that when he came up to town again, he would fix a day to call on me. Gibson, the old traitor, never turned up at all. By-the-bye, I see you ask whether I shoot much—no, not often; I am an ordinary, average shot—my unsteady hand prevents my shooting well. My general health is pretty fair. Many thanks, dearest Mammy, for your kind wishes and congratulations on that melancholy occasion, my birthday—it is a day I always hate—fancy my being *thirty!!!* About marrying, dear Mamma, you must not forget it requires two to play at that game. I would not insult a girl I did not love by asking her to tie her existence to mine, and I have not yet found one that I felt the slightest wish to marry; it is no doubt ludicrous to place this ideal so high, but it is not my fault—theoretically I should like to be married very well.

In another letter to his mother Leighton writes on the subject of marriage: "If I don't marry, the reason has been that I have never seen a girl to whom I felt the least desire to be united for life. I should certainly never marry for the sake of doing so." The same subject is again alluded to in a letter written in 1863, from Leighton's mother to her younger daughter who was in Italy. The letter begins by referring to a servant who was dismissed by Leighton.

"He has such an effect on him by his profound stupidity and intense conceit he can't keep him, for if he did, the irritation would render him wicked if he indulged it, and ill if he repressed the same

—at least that's Fred's feeling just now. He means to take an Italian servant if he can find one.

"Fred has received an invitation to Sandringham (the Prince of Wales). If he has not found a suitable servant we are to lend him ours—Ellen's husband, a very superior person. I must not forget to tell you that we saw ——'s new baby, a very dear little thing. Freddy was enchanted with it. He noticed him more than ——, who is a delightful little chap, and after caressing it several times with exceeding tenderness, he suddenly grew red in the face, and said, 'I must nurse him,' which he did for a long time, to the wonder and admiration of Miss —— and the nurse. For my part, it gave me actual pain to see that proof of his strong love for children, believing that he will never have any of his own. He declares he has never seen a girl he could marry. Of course this shows he is unreasonably fastidious; more's the pity!"



PORTRAIT OF MRS. SUTHERLAND ORR. 1861[ToList](#)

2 ORME SQUARE, *April 10, 1861.*

DEAREST MAMMY,—I have deferred writing until now that I might be able to tell you the result of my little "private view," now over. I am happy to say I have a great success. The "Vision" pleased many people much, but was altogether, as I expected, the least popular; the subject, though very interesting, was less attractive to the many, and besides I have progressed in painting since the date of that picture. My little girl at the fountain, christened for me by one of my visitors, "Lieder ohne Worte," has perhaps had the greatest number of votes.[\[16\]](#) The "Francesca,"[\[17\]](#) on the other hand, has had, I think, the advantage in the *quality* of its admirers. Watts, for instance, and Mrs. Sartoris think it by far my best daub.

By-the-bye, you will be particularly pleased to hear that Lina's portrait has had an immense success, and indeed, on second thoughts, perhaps it was more admired than anything else. The "Capri" and the "Aslett" were also much liked. Mind, dear Mamma, this letter is "strictly confidential," because although, of course, you want to know what people say of my pictures, anybody else seeing this letter would (or might) suppose I was devoured with vanity.

I have just made an unexpected acquaintance in the Gladstones, who sent me, I don't know why, a card for two parties. It was very polite of them, and of course I went. This is a very egotistical letter, dear Mamma, but I know that is what you want.

I am very sufficiently well, not strong, but never ill. I marched to Wimbledon with the Volunteers last Monday, and got wet several times but did not catch cold.[\[18\]](#)

LONDON. 1861.

DEAR PAPA,—If the *Public* receives my pictures as favourably as the *Private* has done, I shall have no cause to complain; as far, at least, as the maintenance and increase of my reputation is

concerned. I should, however, have liked the "market" to be a little more "brisk."

Tom Taylor and Rossetti (Wm.), the only critics that came (as far as I know) besides Stephens, were, as far as I can judge, both of them much pleased with what they saw. I know at least that both spoke well of my pictures behind my back.

As for Ruskin, he was in one of his queer moods when he came to breakfast with me—he spent his time looking at my portfolio and praised my drawings most lavishly—*he did not even look at the pictures*. However, nothing could be more cordial than he is to me.

I bolted out into the passage after you when you left the other day to tell you that one of the gentlemen you saw come in was Sir Edwin Landseer, but you had disappeared.

PARIS. *Monday.*

DEAREST MOTHER,—I must wind up with bad news, which I hope you will bear well: my pictures are badly hung, ill lighted, and almost entirely ignored by the press.^[19] Of course this is *au fond*, a bitter disappointment to a man of my temperament, especially after all the praise my work got before the Exhibition. However, I shall wear a brave face, and who knows but that some good may arise to me out of this? My little energies will be sharpened up and my tenacity roused. I trust in some future day, as long as hope lives. God bless you, Mammy; best love to dear Gussy. From your affectionate son,

FRED.

May 1, 1861.

DEAREST MAMMY,—Life being a pump handle, first up then down, you won't be too much surprised to hear that after the real success my pictures had on "private view" they are with one exception (the landscape) badly hung, "The Vision" over a door, the others above the line, which will make it impossible to see the finish or delicacy

of execution which is an important feature in them. I have not seen them myself, but am told this by those who have. Don't take on, dear Mammy, nor let Papa worry himself about it. Things come right in the end, and I know that many people will be much annoyed at this treatment of me. *Millais*, like a good fellow that he is, spoke up for me like a man, though he himself feels so differently on art from what I do. My good friend *Aïdé* is furious. After all perhaps, though badly hung, the pictures may still be seen well enough to be judged, that is all I really want, then perhaps some of the papers will speak up for me. I am glad I let so many people see them at the studio, those at least know what the pictures are like. Of one thing be sure: if my works have real value, public opinion will in the *long run* force the Academy to hang me—but enough of this subject.

The Prince of Wales saw a photo-portrait of me in Valletort's book the other day and begged him to ask me for one. I have had some new ones done, and mean at the same time to send H.R.H. a photograph of each of my larger pictures, "The Vision," the "Francesca," and "The Listener," which, by-the-bye, I have christened on the suggestion of a lady friend of mine (a sister of Cockerell's) "Lieder ohne Worte."

Landseer said nothing that was worth repeating, though he gave me one or two useful practical hints. He is eminently a practical man, and I suspect in his heart sneers at style. He was, however, I believe, pleased with my things.

9 PARK PLACE, ST. JAMES'S,
Sunday, May 5, 1861.

DEAR MRS. LEIGHTON,—I know that the news of the bad hanging of your son's pictures has reached you (unpleasant tidings generally travel fast) and I hasten to tell you, what I hope may a little mitigate the annoyance you must have felt about it, that they are spoken of in terms of great eulogium by both the *Times* and *Athenæum*. I was afraid that their unfortunate placing might have prevented the possibility of any justice being done them by the public critics, but after all the *Times* and *Athenæum* are the most influential and

leading of all our public journals. Mrs. Orr's portrait is consistently praised by all the papers, even by those which review the others less favourably. Fortunately, the pictures were well seen in the studio by numbers of people of all classes before they went to the Academy, and excited very general admiration in those who felt no particular interest either in art or in your son; while his friends, and those who *know*, were delighted not only with the works themselves, but at the visible indications in them of increased power in all ways. They have been thought by all whose opinion is of value a great advance upon what he has hitherto done. All this will, I hope, be pleasant to you; what will be so most of all will be to know that he took the exceeding trial and vexation of the abominable hanging of his pictures with the most perfect temper, and an admirable desire to be just about those who were doing him this ill turn. You will care for this, as I do, more than for any worldly success his talent could have brought him. I think he is looking well, although he complains a little of feeling tired. I daresay it is nothing but the weariness that must make itself a little felt after a great and all-engrossing exertion. His volunteering occupation is quite invaluable to him, giving him the exercise he never would otherwise get. I think he seems to like his life in London, where he has many friends, so many that if you were here you would no longer feel as jealous about me as you once owned to feeling—do you remember? I do not apologise for writing all this to you, for although excess of zeal may be a sin in the eyes of others, and even indeed of those whom one would die to serve, a mother will hardly count it as such when her child is in question. With best remembrances to Mr. Leighton and your daughters, I am, ever faithfully yours,

ADELAIDE SARTORIS.

To his father Leighton wrote:—

1861.

As to the article in *Macmillan*, I don't in the least deny its value as far as it goes and *quo ad* the public; it is in that sense very gratifying to be spoken of in such flattering terms in a periodical of some

standing, but I can't individually feel much elated at the praise of a critic who in other parts of his article shows he is not *au fond* a judge; as for what he says in *interpretation* (I am not now alluding to the *praise*), it is so verbatim what I said myself to those who visited my studio, that I suspect he must have been of that number. I remember, it is true, telling you *before* I began to paint "Lieder ohne Worte" that I intended to make it *realistic*, but from the first moment I began I felt the mistake, and made it professedly and pointedly the reverse. I don't think, however, that we understand the word realistic alike; the Fisherman and Syren which you quote was as little naturalistic as anything could be, and, while you urge me to take up some subject possessing that quality, I would point out that the Michael Angelo and the Peacock Girl both fulfil that condition—to my mind *to a fault*. I have sent in (or am about to) a formula which I received to fill up, stating what I would contribute to the Great Exhibition of 1862 (International). I have offered the Cimabue, four "Nannas," the "Lieder ohne Worte," "Francesca," and the "Syren." I have obtained permission for all.

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER,
30th April 1861.

MY DEAR FRIEND AND MASTER,—When I last wrote you I promised in the spring to send you photographs of my pictures for the exhibition. I have just received some prints and hasten to enclose them.

One of them (the girl by the fountain) gives, as is so often the case, an entirely false impression of the picture, in that the drapery of the principal figure should be much darker, and that of the retreating figure much lighter. I have called this picture "Lieder ohne Worte." It represents a girl, who is resting by a fountain, and listening to the ripple of the water and the song of a bird. This subject is, of course, quite incomplete without colour, as I have endeavoured, both by colour and by flowing delicate forms, to translate to the eye of the spectator something of the pleasure which

the child receives through her ears. This idea lies at the base of the whole thing, and is conveyed to the best of my ability in every detail, so that in the dead photograph one loses exactly half, also the dulling of the eyes, which are dark blue in the picture, gives a look of weakness in the photograph that is not quite pleasant.

The second subject is, as you will know well, the old, ever-new motive of Paolo and Francesca. I endeavoured to put in as much glow and passion as possible without causing the least offence; this picture also would, perhaps, have pleased you in colour. How I should like to show it to you, my dear master! However, you will no doubt send me your candid opinion of the photographs in a few lines, and not spare criticism.

I am exceedingly curious to know how *your* work is getting on. What are you working at just now? When is the fresco to be begun? What easel pictures have you undertaken? I want to know all that. I also hope with all my heart, my dear master, that your health keeps good, that your wife and children are all well. Please remember me most kindly to your family and all in Frankfurt who remember me. And yourself, my dear friend, keep in remembrance.—Your grateful pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER, LONDON,
June 30, 1861.

MY DEAR FRIEND,—Forgive my not having thanked you sooner for your kind note. The same thing has happened to me as to you: work has left me but little leisure for writing. Now, however, my hearty thanks for the open sincerity with which you have spoken of my latest work, I am only sorry that you have not gone into it even more closely. I shall endeavour in my present works to diminish the excessive mannerism of the lines, which will be all the easier for me as I am now painting principally from nature; in my last picture the subject permitted that but little. In any case I hope, dear master, that

you will always speak to me with the same candour; it is the best proof to me that I still possess your friendship.

I am extremely eager to see how far your works have got on. Amongst them, however, my dear friend, keep in remembrance your grateful pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

P.S.—I notice with regret that already I do not write a German letter with my former fluency.

In a letter to his sister, Mrs. Matthews, January 24, 1860, Leighton wrote: "I am horrified to hear the account you give of Mrs. Browning. I knew she was a confirmed invalid, but had no idea that one of her lungs was already gone! What will poor Browning do if she dies? He adores her, you know."

LONDON, *July 1861.*

DEAREST MAMMY,—Thanks for your kind letter, which I have been unable to answer till now. I had heard of poor Browning's bereavement; we were all very much shocked at it, knowing, as we do, how entirely irreparable his loss is. I wrote a few lines to him that he might know how sincerely I grieved with him; I don't at all know what were the circumstances of her death, we have no particulars.

Leighton undertook to design the monument over Mrs. Browning's grave in the English Cemetery at Florence. The work appealed to him in every sense, and remains as a permanent memorial of those friendships which made the years spent in Italy so full, so rich, so entrancing. With reference to the monument Browning writes:—

CHEZ M. LARAISON,
STE. MARIE, PRÈS PORNIC, LOIRE INFÉRIEURE,
August 30, 1863.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—Don't fret; you will do everything like yourself in the end, I know; wait till the end of October, as you

propose. I cannot return before the beginning of it, though I would do so were it necessary, but it is not, for I have only this morning received the notification of which I told you, that "the marble is in the sculptor's studio." We shall therefore be in full time.

The portrait you saw was the autotype which I lent to Mr. Richmond, and concerning which I wrote to him before leaving London, directing that it should be sent to you. He engaged to let you have it whenever you desired. I therefore enclose (oh, fresh attack on your envelopes and postage stamps!) a note which I presume he will attend to, and which you will of course burn should he have sent the portraits meanwhile. I have also two others nearly like that portrait, taken the same day with it, which I was unable to find, but which shall be found on my return.

Dear Leighton, I can only repeat, with entire truth, that you will satisfy me wholly. I don't think, however, you can make me more than I am now—Yours gratefully and lovingly,

ROBERT BROWNING.

Continuation of letter to his mother:—

I am glad to hear Papa reported favourably of my work, and that you like the photographs of my pictures now in the Exhibition. I am very glad also that Gussy liked the *receding figure* in the "Lieder ohne Worte," as it was a favourite also with me, the *tallness* of said figure was inseparable from the sentiment of it in my mind. I have a photograph of that picture still remaining; I will give it to Gus when she comes through, I can get myself another some future day. I am getting on tol-lol with my pictures, but am rather anxious just now about the extreme difficulty of getting a peacock. I want to *buy* one to have the skin prepared, and if I don't get one soon they will all lose their tails; and there I shall be—in a fix! A friend of mine has written to Norfolk, and hopes to get me one. The season, even in the extremely moderate form in which I take it, is a fatiguing affair. I get up late and never feel fresh and vigorous. I have serious thoughts of entirely giving it up next year. I will go now and then to

stay at people's houses, but not to their parties—*le jeu ne vaut pas la chandelle*. A *propos* of country houses, I am going to spend a few days with Lady Cowper at Wrest Park towards the end of this month; there are to be theatricals and great hilarity. And now about Bath, I hope, dearest Mammy, you won't be hurt if I propose to come at the end of the *first* week in September instead of the *last* week in August. The fact is I have a great "giro" I want to make, and if I could take Bath in the regular progress it would be both a great convenience and a saving of expense. I mean to stay three weeks in Bath and have thoughts of painting a *pot-boiler* of little Walker if he is still handsome. I wish Papa would look after him, and let me know what he is doing and how he is looking. These are my plans: I want, whilst the summer is still hot and green, to visit South Hampshire, New Forest, Isle of Wight, South Devon, North Devon, and so work my way round to Bath, whence to Stourhead for a few days; then to Mason in Staffordshire, and then back to London. My pictures will be done long before the Exhibition next opening, so I can manage all this. I shall visit the following people: Sartoris, Aïdés, perhaps Morants, I hope *Tennyson*, Lady E. Bulteel, and look in at Mount Edgcombe—the rest of the journey will be purely artistic.

CLOVELLY, *Sunday*.

DEAREST MAMMY,—I could not find time to answer your note (for which best thanks) before I left Ventnor. I am now in one of the most picturesque spots on the north coast of Devon—the *rendezvous* of painters and tourists, the *pays de cocagne* of Hook and one of the chief lions of my trip.

The places I have visited so far are Salisbury, Exeter, and Bideford; with the latter I was much disappointed, and think it far below its reputation; not so Salisbury, which is a most interesting town, full of quaintness and character beyond my expectations; it has, however, a look of decay and depopulation about it which makes me feel awfully low-spirited. The Cathedral, perhaps, *altogether* rather disappointed me—though of course much about it

is very beautiful; then, too, its general (internal) aspect is entirely marred by a brutal coat of whitewash laid on in the last century, covering up the marble columns and killing out all life and colour. Unfortunately, it would cost very many thousands to restore the church and its ancient glories.

To-morrow I start for Ilfracombe—the next day for Lynton.

Again, later:—

Many thanks for your letter just received and for all the kind wishes therein contained, which I most warmly return for you all—a double portion to dear Taily in honour of her birthday.

I will come on the 8th if I possibly can, and bring some little sketches to show you.

I shall exhibit this year IF I get done in time, but I can't hurry—it is entirely immaterial whether I exhibit or not—I would rather, of course.

We have begun drilling, but it will be many weeks before we get to rifle-shooting—this is the sort of thing we are doing now. Our uniform is plainness itself, all grey, and the cheapest in London.

I weather the cold so-so—I have a gas-stove beside my fireplace, but am still tolerably cold when it comes very sharp.

My dinner with Millais was put off till Monday next—I think Millais *charming* and so handsome.

I am exceedingly sorry, dear Mamma, you have reckoned on me for cotillon figures—with the exception of the one I led at Bath once, *I have not seen one for years*, and have not the faintest notion what is done—I will, however, *back* anybody else with great zeal.

I was indeed truly sorry to hear of Lord Holland's death—I had expected it for some time; nothing could exceed their kindness to me, and the House is an irreparable loss to me.

I hope to have a very merry Christmas Day. I am running down to Westbury (the Sartoris); there is to be a tree; I come up again of

course Monday morning.

I am never *ill*. I take my human frailty out in never being very well—never equal to much fatigue.

LONDON 1861.

My dinner at Millais' yesterday was very pleasant. I like him extremely, and his wife appears an agreeable person. I met there John Leech, the man who does all those admirable caricatures in *Punch*—he is a very pleasant and gentleman-like person.

I don't feel sure whether I told you that I am about shortly to send my "Paris and Juliet" with the "Samson" to America on spec. Mrs. Kemble will do all she can to godmother them; I got a very kind letter from her from Boston the other day—she has asked me to send her a little sketch of Westbury with the pictures—of course I shall.

The following letters from Mrs. Fanny Kemble reveal the interest which this friend took in Leighton and his pictures, also the genius of the writer in penning delightful epistles:—

REVERE HOUSE, BOSTON,
Friday, December 9, 1861.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—It was very kind and amiable of you to write to me of Westbury and my sister; you cannot imagine the forlornness one feels when, to the loss of the sight of those one loves, is added that bitter silence which leaves one almost ignorant, as death does, of all the conditions in which our friends remain. God knows, written words are a poor substitute for the sound of a voice and the look of living eyes; still, when they are all that can reach us of those towards whom our hearts yearn, it is miserable not to be able to obtain them. The friends with whom I constantly correspond see and know little or nothing of her, and so no one of them can in any degree supply me with the news that I most desire from across the sea—how it is faring with my sister; so I am very grateful to you

for your intelligence, which was just what I would give anything for (though not in itself, perhaps, very satisfactory) out here, where I think you have none of you an idea how *banished* I feel. Now, my dear Mr. Leighton, to your business, about which I began my inquiries almost immediately after my return to this country, but only received the last of these communications last night, and you perceive the other was incomplete without it. You must command me entirely in any and every thing that I can do to forward your aims, and I will promise to be *severe* in my obedience to any instructions you may like to give me. New York is undoubtedly a better market for pictures, and therefore a better place to exhibit them than this, but I do not know anybody whom I trust there. Mr. Ordway, however, seems inclined to take charge of your pictures if they are exhibited there.

Good-bye. Do not fail to employ me in this matter to the fullest extent that I can be of the least use to you; it will be a great pleasure to me to help you in any way that I possibly can.—Yours very truly,

FANNY KEMBLE.

I wish you would send me out some sketch of Westbury with your pictures, if they come. I wish for one very much. I wish you could see the world here just now—a sky as pure and brilliant as it is possible to conceive, and every bough, branch, blade of grass and withered leaf coated with clear crystal and *blazing* with prismatic colours. There are, every now and then, *sentiments* in this sky that I have seen in none other. There are certain points of view in which Boston, rising beyond broad sheets of water that repeat them still more tenderly, seems to me worthy of a great painter. But do not come out and try unless you are quite sure of going back, or you will break your heart.

REVERE HOUSE, BOSTON,
Friday, February 7.

I feel terrified, when you speak of my determining what is to be done with your pictures when they arrive in Boston, for assuredly I am utterly incompetent to any such decision, and can only refer

myself to the judgment of my friend Mr. Cabot, who will certainly advise for the best in the matter, but who, nevertheless, is not infallible. I should think it rather late in the season for exhibiting them here, but again would not take upon myself to say. I do not know what the percentage on sale here is, but presume it is not higher than in London. But here people exhibit their pictures at a shilling a head, *i.e.* put them in a room hung round with black calico, light up a flare of gas above them, and take a quarter of a dollar from every sinner who sees them. Two of Church's pictures (he is a great American artist, though you may never have heard of him) have been, or rather are, at this moment so exhibiting—his "Falls of Niagara," and a very beautiful landscape called the "Heart of the Andes." Both these pictures were exhibited in London, I know not with what success; they have both considerable merit, but the latter I admire extremely. Page had a "Venus" here the other day, exhibited by gas-light in a black room; but indeed, dear Mr. Leighton, it sometimes seems to me as if you never could imagine or would consent to the gross charlatanry which is practised—how necessarily I do not know—here about all such matters. Certainly your gold medal should be trumpeted—and your profession of art and your confession of faith, and anything most private and particular that you would not wish known, had better be published in several versions in all the newspapers of the United States. Your pictures must be placarded over all the walls in all the sizes of type conceivable, and all the colours of the rainbow. If you will write me your personal history, and rampant puffs of your own performances, I will copy them and send them to those sources of public instruction, the enlightened public press. Moreover, I will go and sit before them daily and utter exclamations of admiration on every note in my voice, and if anything else remains to be done I will do it; but you must not make me in any way responsible for the result, because it is not in the least likely that you will write yourself up to the mark of puffing as practised here. Basta—I will take the very best advice and do the very best I can about the pictures, and rejoice in my heart to see them myself, that I can assuredly promise you. By-the-bye, I gave your address only a few days ago, to be sent to a person now in Europe negotiating with French and English artists

for pictures to exhibit. I wonder if he will find you and enlighten your mind about art in America. Thank you for the account of Westbury and its Christmas festivities, and thank you, thank you for the sketch of the home you are so very kind as to promise me; it will be a blessed treasure to see, for you cannot conceive the dreary heart-sickness that utterly overcomes me here sometimes. To-day I was singing the quartette in "Faust" that we used to sing, and was obliged to stop for crying. I wished extremely to have a photograph of the house, and, if I could only have afforded it, should have asked you to sell me every sketch you took about the place. The skies here are beautiful, wonderful in their transparent purity. They seem to me of a different *texture* from any other I ever saw, more diaphanous, and there is a colour in them when they are quite free from clouds that surpasses in delicacy all other skies I have seen. It is like the complexion of the young girls here, a miracle of evanescent brilliant softness. My winter is wearing along pretty tolerably. My Christmas was passed entirely alone, but I am quite used to that. I am beginning to be much occupied about the plans and drawings for a house, which I am thinking of building on some land I own in Massachusetts. It is a great undertaking, and really at fifty years old seems hardly worth while, and yet, till I am ready for my coffin, I must have some place in which to rest my head. Perhaps some fine day—who knows?—you will come to see me there. That would be a very pretty plot, and I think I need not say how welcome you would be, dear Mr. Leighton, to yours very truly,

FANNY KEMBLE.

LENOX, *Tuesday*.

A thousand thanks, my dear Mr. Leighton, for the minute account of Westbury—as I cannot know anything about my sister, it is something to know how her house is settled and decorated, and how the place where she lives looks. The red velvet drawing-room sounds gorgeous, and it must be very becoming to the pictures. Of your pictures that have "wandered west" you may be sure I should have written you, if I had had the good news to give you that either

of them was sold, but I am sorry to say this is not the case. The New York Exhibition is now closed, and the pictures have been sent back to Boston, where they are at present hanging in the Athenæum under the care of Mr. Ordway, who wishes, but does not much hope, to be able to sell them. It seems that one or two people asked the price of the pictures in New York, but considered it, when they received the information, "rather a tall price." I am a little consoled at the ill success of this venture of yours, by Henry Greville's writing me that your hands are full of orders, for which you are to be well paid. Your small acquaintance, Fanny, who left me this morning after a visit of a month, propounded to me the expediency of desiring the purchaser of the reconciliation of old Capulet and Montague to buy as its pendant the "Paris and Juliet"; and though she has no personal acquaintance with the lover of art in question, she said, when she got to Philadelphia she should set about intriguing to that effect; and she had my full permission to try and to succeed. I wish I could tell you anything pleasant in return for your description of the rooms at Westbury, but I have nothing very cheerful to impart. I have been quite unwell, and am still very far from flourishing; my spirits are much depressed, and the life I lead, of incessant worry and discomfort with servants and all one's domestic arrangements, is something quite too tedious to relate—and that indeed it would be impossible to *realise*, as the Yankees say, unless you witnessed it. I saw Hetty Hosmer three days after her arrival in Boston. Her father is a hopeless invalid, and she will certainly not leave him while he lives; but I suspect that he is likely to die before this year ends, and then she will return to live in Italy. The State of Missouri has voted two thousand pounds for a statue of Colonel Benton, one of its "great men," to be erected by her, which, of course, is a whole plume of feathers in her cap.

Good-bye, dear Mr. Leighton; believe me always yours most truly,

FANNY KEMBLE.

You must not fail to write to me any directions that you wish observed about your pictures, while they remain here. I am only too glad to try to serve you.

LENOX, BERKSHIRE, MASSACHUSETTS,
Monday, March 12.

Pictures of very high pretensions are exhibited, like the scenes in a theatre, by gas-light, and advertised in coloured *posters* all over the streets like theatrical exhibitions. However, it is no use vexing your soul with what neither of us can help. I cannot and will not accept the responsibility of disposing of your pictures; but I will get the best advice I can about them and follow it, and spare no personal pains to have them advantageously dealt with; only, I hope it will not be very long before they arrive, because my own stay in Boston is now drawing to a close, and after the end of the present month I shall be at Lenox, a remote village in a lonely hill district one hundred miles from Boston, or rather I should say seven hours distant from the nearest railroad station, which is six miles away again from Lenox. When once I come here—for I write at this moment from this snowy wilderness—it will be to remain for the next nine or ten months, so you see I must make all arrangements about your pictures before taking my leave of civilised communities. I came up to this place from Boston yesterday to look at a house that I think of hiring for a year, and shall return to the city next week. I have left your pictures (should they arrive during my absence) to the charge of a friend of mine who is one of the directors of the Athenæum, and will see that they are properly received. Thank you a thousand times for the promised likeness of Westbury, which will be a treasure to me. What a contrast is my recollection of that charming place, to the abomination of desolation of the dreary savage winter landscape of low black hills, bristling with wintry woods and wide, bare, snow-covered valleys, that stretch before me here at this moment. I am well, but much worn out with my last course of public readings, which I had just ended in Boston. My daughters are well, and write to me tolerably frequently; the eldest seems happy and contented in her marriage;

your small acquaintance, Fanny, writes to me from Savannah of sitting with the doors and windows wide open, and wiping the perspiration from her face in the meantime; and here everything is buried in snow. I shall wait till I return to Boston to finish this, as I shall hope to send you then news of the arrival of your pictures.

Wednesday, March 14.

Your pictures are arrived, my dear Mr. Leighton; they reached Boston last week while I was absent at Lenox. I only returned yesterday evening, and found a letter from Mr. Cabot announcing that they were at the Athenæum; thither I went this morning, and spent a most delightful half-hour in looking at them. I like the "Samson" very much indeed; I think it is beautiful, and am charmed with the treatment of the subject, though you have chosen a different moment for illustration from the one I had imagined. This evening I have been having a long conversation with Mr. Ordway about the future destinations of the pictures. I am little sanguine, I regret to say, about their being bought here, for the only rich picture purchaser that I know here has a predilection for French works of art, small *tableaux de genre*, and Troyon's landscapes. However, it must be tried. Mr. Ordway says he will exhibit your pictures in the Athenæum, which (should they be sold while there) will save you your commission, because, being an artist himself, he will not charge you any. If after due experiment they do not seem likely to sell here, we will send them to New York, and then to Philadelphia; in short, the best that can be done for them shall, as far as my agency is concerned, you may be sure.

BOSTON, Thursday, March 15.

I have this moment received your letter of the 25th February, for which I thank you very much. It does not require any further answer with regard to your pictures, of the safe arrival of which I wrote you word last night. I did not tell you, by-the-bye, that they are both slightly *streaked* across from side to side with what Mr. Ordway thinks must have been small infiltrations of sea-water; he says the

pictures are not injured by them, nor do they indeed appear to be so in the least, and that he can wipe off the stains with no damage whatever to them. Thank you for all you tell me of my sister; it is not much, indeed, nor very cheerful, but it is more than reaches me through any other channel, and far better than the miserable conjectures of absolute ignorance. Dear Mr. Leighton, thank you a thousand times for the *portrait* of Westbury—it is exactly what I wished for—but, oh, why could there not be the lovely upland beyond, and the sheep slowly rolling up and down the slopes, and the tinkle of the bell, and you and she and they and all of us. Oh dear, if you could conceive what it is to me to be *here*, you would know a thousand times better than I can tell you how precious such a memento of *there* is to me. Thank you, too, for the good inspiration of telling me about the change of place of the pictures at Westbury; it is wonderful how much one small particular has power to bring the whole of what surrounds it, back to the mind, and what vividness it gives to the picture that, in spite of the distinctness with which it was stamped upon the memory, becomes so soon, and yet so unconsciously, obliterated in the minor parts that give it charm and vitality. I spent a long hour to-day again looking at your pictures and wishing most heartily that I could afford to buy them both. Good-bye, dear Mr. Leighton; I shall leave this open till to-morrow, in case I should hear anything more about them before I go. I enclose the receipts for what I have paid. I suppose it is all right, but it seems a most monstrous price for mere conveyance, and indeed reminds us that our humorous forefathers called *stealing conveying*.

LENOX, BERKSHIRE, MASSACHUSETTS,
Friday, April 27.

Your pictures are at present in the New York Exhibition. Mr. Ordway tells me that it is extremely rare for pictures to sell without the intervention of dealers. In this country they cry down and undervalue all pictures that are not expressly committed to them, and the ignorance of the rich shopkeepers who purchase works of Art, is so excessive that they do not feel safe in making any acquisition without the advice and permission of some charlatan of

a dealer, to whom these wiseacres come saying (verbatim, so Mr. Ordway informed me), "I want some pictures; can't you recommend any to me?" and then, of course, the picture-dealer recommends what brings him the highest percentage; and the man who buys pictures exactly like looking-glasses, window-curtains, or any other *furniture* for a new house, departs satisfied that he possesses a work of Art. The things that are bought and sold here in the shape of pictures, and the things that are said about them, *vous feraient pouffer de rire*, if you did not live in this country. If you did, they would be like many other proofs of the semi-civilisation of the people, that would be rather doleful than otherwise to you. Thank you for all you tell about my sister and her children. I feel very much both for my sister and Anne in their separation. I have just parted with my maid Marie, who has lived with me fifteen years, and who leaves me now because her health is so much broken down that her physician tells her, she must go to some other climate or she will die. So she is gone, and here I remain absolutely alone, looking, not for the "wrath to come," but what may be supposed no bad instalment of it—the advent of four new servants with whom I am to begin housekeeping in my small cottage next week. Just before leaving Boston I saw Hetty Hosmer. She has come home to her poor old paralytic father, who, I suppose, is not likely to live very long. Whenever the event of his death happens, Hetty will gather up her substance, and depart hence for the rest of her natural or artistic life. She is very little changed in appearance, and only a little in manner. She seemed very glad to see me, and so was I to see her, for she represented to my memory a whole world of things and places and people that I am fond of. I have not seen Lord Lyon, and do not expect to do so, as I understand he does not mean to stir from Washington all the summer, and thither I shall assuredly not go, though I would go a good way to see him. I'm told he lives in dread of being married by some fair American, and it is not always a thing that a man can escape; but he is too good for that, and I trust will not succumb to these intrepid little flirts. Good-bye, dear Mr. Leighton; I have a settled nostalgia, which is the saddest thing in the world. Your sketch of Westbury is always before me, and your letters are the most kindly return you could possibly make, for any service that

you could require of me. I wish with all my heart I might have the great pleasure of writing you, now that one of your pictures was sold.

Addio.

LENOX, *Friday, June 7.*

Thank you, dear Frederic Leighton, for your letter and the photographs, by means of which, and your description, I have a sort of vision (not quite what the Yankees call a "realising sense") of your pictures. The girl at the fountain is charming,^[20] the other beautiful and terrible, as it should be.^[21] I can well imagine the beautiful effect the sentiment of the picture must receive from that regretful return, as it were, of the daylight that has set upon the poor people for ever. In the English newspapers that are sent to me I looked eagerly among the notices of the Exhibition for your name, and read the meagre little bit allotted to each picture. I was especially delighted with the critic who thinks your "Paolo and Francesca" too *earthly* in the intensity of their passions. The gentleman apparently forgets that it was not in Heaven that Dante met these poor things. With regard to your other pictures, dear Mr. Leighton, I think you are right to withdraw them from America. I wish with all my heart that I could have presented myself with one of those pictures; however, that is one of the vainest of all human desires. My income is already docked of two hundred pounds this year by the disastrous state of public affairs; but, of course, if one is in the midst of a falling house, one can hardly hope to avoid bruises and broken bones. The attitude of England is highly unsatisfactory to the North, who now choose to consider the whole action of the Government a crusade against slavery—which it is not, and was not, and will not be except in the New England state where the Abolitionist party has always been strongest, and where the character of the people is more of the nature to make fighters for abstract principles. The Southerners hate the Yankees, and *vice versâ*, for this very reason; and if the crisis comes really to anything like fighting, the New England, especially the Massachusetts men,

will probably fight very maliciously as against slaveholders, and the slaveholders against them as Abolitionists, which *they* now are, pretty much to a man. A huge volunteer force is levying and being prepared for action; but in spite of the very unanimous feeling of the North and North-West, and the warlike attitude of the South, I shall not believe in anything deserving the name of war till I see it. The South is without resources that can avail for a six months' struggle. The North has a huge, unarmed, undisciplined force of men at its command; but the Southerners do not want to fight, and neither do the Northerners; *but* if any combination of circumstances (and of course matters cannot stand still, especially with the border states all *au pied en l'air*) should occasion any collision accompanied with considerable effusions of blood, I believe the North would pour itself upon the Southern States and annihilate the secessionist party. It is extremely difficult to foresee the probable course of events, but I believe eventually the Southern States will be obliged to return to their allegiance, and *then* I believe the North will, once for all, legislate for the future limiting of the curse of slavery to those states where it *now* exists, and where, of course, under such circumstances, it would very soon cease to exist, as if it cannot extend itself it must die. In one sense slavery is undoubtedly the cause of the present disastrous crisis—and in the profoundest sense, for the character of the Southerners is the immediate result of these infernal "institutions"; and but for Southern slavery Southern "Chivalry," that arrogant, insolent, ignorant, ferocious and lawless race of men, would never have existed.

Oh, how thankful I shall be to be at home once more! Farewell, dear Mr. Leighton; pray, if there is anything special to be done about your pictures, write to me and let me have the pleasure of doing something for you. Oh, I am so enraged that I could not get them sold; and yet though you may not think it, I should have thought it a pity for them to have to live the rest of their lives here. Thank you again for the photographs; I look at them constantly. All *such things* are like being lifted into another atmosphere from that which surrounds and stifles one here. Believe me always your obliged and sincere friend,

FANNY KEMBLE.

Emil Devrient's was the best Hamlet I ever saw. It would not have been if my father's had not been too smooth and harmonious. I hope I shall see Fechter's.

LENEX, *Thursday, October 11.*

How good an inspiration it was that made you send that beautiful photograph to me! It came to me really like a special providence, on the day when I had parted from my children for an indefinite time, and with more than usual sadness and anxiety; for my eldest child's health has failed completely since her confinement, and she came to me for a visit of ten days only, looking like the doomed, wan image of some woman whose enemies were wasting her by witchcraft. My small comfortless home was intolerably lonely to me, and towards sunset I went out to find some fortitude under the open sky. I wandered into a copse of beech trees that clothe the steep sides of a miniature ravine with a brook at the bottom, and here gathered a handful of the beautiful blue fringed gentian (do you know that exquisite flower that grows wild in the woods here?). The little glen with its clusters of mysterious blue blossoms was all but dark, but, emerging from it, I stood where I saw a wide valley flooded with the evening light, and hills beyond rising in waves of amber and smoke colour and dark purple; it was so beautiful that it cannot be imagined. The autumn has turned all the trees into gold and jewels, like the enchanted growth of fairy-land, and the whole world, as I saw it from the entrance of that shadowy dell, looked as if it was made of precious metals and precious stones. I was very sad, and stood thinking of our Saviour and the widow of Nain, and how pitiful He was to sorrowful human creatures, and with some sparks of comfort in my heart I returned home, where I found your letter waiting for me. I have told you all this of my previous state of mind and feeling, because—without knowing that—you could not conceive how like an express message of consolation your work appeared to me. May it be blessed to many hearts for admonition and for consolation as it was to mine, dear Mr. Leighton. It is no

wonder that it seemed to me beautiful, and I do not think I shall ever sufficiently disconnect it with this first impression, to be able to judge of its merit as a work of art; it was, as I said before, a special Providence to me. I long to have it framed and hung where I can see it constantly. I have within the last few days moved into a house which I have hired for the next two years. It is all but in the village of Lenox, and yet so situated that it commands from the windows of every room a most beautiful prospect. The whole landscape is a harmonious confusion of small valleys and hills, rolling and falling within and around and beyond each other, like folds of rich and majestic drapery. Oh, what lights and shadows roam and rest over these hill-sides and in the hollows between them! The country is very thickly wooded, and the woods are literally of every colour in the rainbow, all mixed together under a sky, the peculiar characteristic of which is not so much softness or brightness, as a transparent purity that seems as if there was *no* atmosphere betwixt oneself and the various objects one sees. I expect this would make it difficult to paint these beautiful aspects of nature here; but, oh, how I *do* wish you could see it, for, in the matter of American autumnal colouring, seeing alone is believing. The house itself is very tolerably comfortable, but hideous to behold both within and without; and I have begun my residence in it under rather depressing circumstances, *i.e.* without *being able* to obtain the necessary servants for the decent comfort of my daily existence. Ever since the beginning of May I have been endeavouring, in vain, to procure and keep together a decent household. Not for one *single week* have I had my proper complement of people in the house, and I have done every species of house-work myself, from cleaning the cellar and kitchen to washing the tea-cups; it is a state of things as incredible as the colour of the autumn woods, and as peculiar, thank God, to America. I am now making my last experiment by trying coloured servants. Their manners and deportment are generally much better than those of either the Irish or American, and they seem capable of personal attachment to their employers, which neither of the other races are. The incessant worry, discomfort, and positive fatigue that I have undergone during the whole summer has completely shaken my nerves, so that I have been in a sort of hysterical condition of

constant weeping for some time past. I trust, however, it will not be so wretched now, for I am at any rate close to the village inn, and if I am left without servants, can go there and get some food; it is a state of existence *qu'on ne s' imagine pas*. You will not wonder, after all this, to hear that I declined a ticket to the Prince's ball at New York, to which the whole population of the United States are struggling to get admittance; but at the best of times "I am not gamesome," and feel as if I had swept my own rooms quite too recently to be fit company for my Queen's son. Thank you, dear Mr. Leighton, for all you tell me about my sister and the children; she never writes, you know, and so I am thirsty all the time for some tidings of her. It is very sad to be so far away and hear so seldom from those one loves. Good-bye, God bless you; and thank you once more for the "Vision." I am sorry I cannot tell you of the sale of either of your pictures; they are in the Boston Athenæum, very safe, and highly ornamental to it, but not, I regret to say, sold. If you wish me to do anything more about them, you must write me your directions, which I will fulfil with every attention and accuracy of which I am capable.

LENOX, *Sunday, November 11.*

I trust before long you will receive your children safe and sound. I wish the two hundred pounds I have lost this year had been invested in one of those pictures instead of in St. Louis. Thank you for your account of Adelaide and her children; it is not much, but it is all that much better than nothing. The state of the country is very sad, and any probable termination of the war quite out of calculable distance. England, no doubt, will maintain her absolute neutrality in spite of secession, cotton, and anti-slavery sympathies; it is her only part. Good-bye, dear Mr. Leighton.

I beg you will not scruple to write me now if there is anything more that I can do, either in the matter of the pictures or any other by which I can be of use to you here.

NEW YORK,
Sunday, March 10.

I am sure you have not forgotten the charming farmhouse at West Mion, to which you and your sketch-book were the means of introducing us, — farm: well, his brother is one of the richest shopkeepers in New York—and, upon the strength of my visit to the paternal acres in Hampshire, his wife, a funny little specimen of vivacious vulgarity, called upon me, and I, of course, upon her. I was shown into a drawing-room at least thirty feet long, with two massive white marble chimney-pieces, green silk brocade curtains and furniture to match, magnificent carpets, mirrors, gildings, hideous *works* in marble on scagliola pillars—in short, the most marvellous palace of shopkeepers' *beaux ideaux* that you can conceive; through this to a beautifully fitted-up library; through this to a picture gallery, noble *seigneur, pensez y bien!* Oh, my dear Frederic Leighton, it was enough to make one fall down and foam at the mouth, to see such a hideous collection of daubs and to think of the money hanging on those walls; and then I thought of your pictures, and why the wretched man couldn't have procured them for some of his foolish money; and then I begged your pardon internally for the desecration of imagining your pictures in such company; and then I gazed amusedly about me, and at length gave tongue: "Mr. —," said I, "this is a vastly different residence from the old homestead in Hampshire." The worthy man could not see in my heart which way the balance of preference inclined, and answered with benignant self-satisfaction: "Ah, well, you see, ma'am, they've been going on there for the last I don't know how many hundred years, just about in the same social position; they haven't a notion of the rapidity of our progress here." I hate to advise you to have your pictures back, for there really does seem to me to be a *greedy desire for pictures* (I cannot qualify in any other way the taste which covets and buys such things) here; but I suppose pictures, at any rate, must be what these people want, and will not buy dear and good ones, when cheap and nasty do as well. I think, while I am here in New York, I shall take the liberty of making some further inquiry as to whether the great print and picture seller here does not

think they could be seen to selling advantage in his shop; in short, it throws me into a melancholy rage to think what pictures are bought while yours are not. The state of this country is curious—strange and deplorable beyond precedent in history, it seems to me; and it is absolutely *impossible* to foresee to what issue things are tending. The opinions one hears are all coloured by the particular bias of the speaker, and the confusion is so great in the general excitement of sectional partisanship that even one of the members—and a very influential one—of the peace convention sent to Washington for the purpose of proposing terms of conciliation—which should not, however, compromise the Northern principles—said that nothing had been done, that all was "sound and fury, and signifying nothing"—or if anything at present, the confirmed secession of the Southern, the disruption from the North of the Northern slave States, and, not impossibly, civil war. Of course, the more time elapses in palavering before the first fatal blow is struck, the less probability there is of its being struck at all; but, on the other hand, the longer the present state of things continues, the more accustomed people become to the idea of the dismemberment of the Union, and therefore, though the clangour of an appeal to arms diminishes, so I think does the prospect of anything like "making up" the family quarrel—indeed, if it were patched, and soldered to the very best, I do not believe that it will ever "hold water again"; but it is impossible to foresee from day to day what may be the turn of events.

If I live till a year from this summer I will be in England in July, and if I live till the November after that I will be in Rome, and you and Edward and Adelaide have my full permission to come too.

Good-bye, dear Mr. Leighton. Your letters are a great comfort as well as pleasure to me; I am extremely obliged to you for them.

I showed my daughter the photograph of your "Vision," and she was enchanted with it. She has not a cultivated or educated taste in matters of art—this country affords no means for such a thing—but she is a person of very fine natural perceptions and great imagination and sensibility, and she was so charmed with it that I

hope you will not think it foolish or impertinent in me to tell you of it.

The last political news I have is that the border or Northern slave States will probably not join the cotton states, in which case the latter will, of hard necessity, very soon be compelled to abandon their absurd and infinitely perilous position; but one does not see the end of it all, for if they *do* come back into the Union, it will be under a burning sense of humiliation which will hardly facilitate their future intercourse with the North, for humiliation and humility are difficult things, and the cotton Lucifer under coercion will not be a pleasant devil to deal with.

LENOX, *Saturday, September 7.*

You owe me nothing, and you will owe me nothing, dear Mr. Leighton, for expediting your pictures to England. When I wrote to Mr. Ordway about them desiring him to send them back to you, and to let me know the amount of any expenses he incurred in doing so, his reply was that the mere cost of packing and putting them on board ship would not be worth charging you with, and that the possession of your pictures in his gallery was well worth the small outlay of merely despatching them to you. I hope they will reach you safely. I am sorry, *sorry* they have not remained here; but latterly, as you will easily believe, people's minds have been little inclined to the peaceful arts or any influences of beauty and grace; moreover, the pockets of the wealthiest amateurs are affected, as those of their poorer neighbours are, by the public disasters. My own loss this year is two hundred pounds of my income. What it may be next year, or how far my capital itself is safe, is more than anybody can tell. We are to be taxed moreover beyond all precedent in this country hitherto, and as it is already nearly the dearest place in the world to live in, what with onerous imports and the failure of interest from one's investments it will be simply ruinous. Thank you for all you tell me of my sister and her children. I am beginning to *see them again*, as the time when I may really hope to do so draws nearer. I am sorry for what you and all my friends tell me about

Harry's strong dramatic propensities. Of course, if he is fit for nothing else, or fitter for that than anything else, he had better become an actor, and his being so in England need not prevent his being a worthy fellow and respectable and respected member of society. I am, however, much reconciled to what at first disappointed me extremely—my not being able to bring him out to this country; for if he should eventually take to the stage, here that is simply in most instances equivalent to taking to the gutter. My daughters are both with me just now, and Fanny desires me to remember her very kindly to you. The incidents of the war which reach the other side of the water no doubt strike you as amazing enough; but anything more grotesque than the daily details in the midst of which we live, you cannot conceive. A young gentleman, a friend of ours who has just returned from his share in the campaign in a three months' volunteer regiment (he has entered the regular army, as a very large proportion of the volunteers did as soon as their three months' amateur service expired), described to us a volunteer corps which happened to be encamped in the neighbourhood of his company. He said they were one of the finest bodies of men he ever saw. Lumberers, that is, wood-fellers from the forests of Maine and New Hampshire, perfectly brave and reckless and daring—perfectly undisciplined too, to the tune of replying to their officers when ordered to turn out on guard, "No, I'll be damned if I do," with the most cheerful good humour. Thereupon the discomfited "superior" simply turns to some one else and says, "Oh, well—you're so and so—go." Good-bye; I shall rejoice to see you again, and be once more at home among people who know how to behave themselves.—Believe me, always yours most sincerely,

FANNY KEMBLE.

After the Prince Consort's death in 1861 Leighton wrote the following letter to his younger sister, who was in Italy:

I have just returned from a fortnight in Bath, where I have at last finished the Johnnies,^[22] I believe, and hope you will like them; they are at all events much improved. I am glad for the poor lad that

the *corvée* of settling is over; he was dying to get back to his work. If zeal and enthusiasm can make an artist, he ought to become one.

I don't attempt to give you home news, as you are amply supplied with that article by Mamma. Everybody here is in great sorrow for the poor Queen. She bears up under her overwhelming grief with admirable fortitude, and expresses her anxious desire to do *her duty as he* would have wished it, but she speaks of all earthly happiness as at an end. The tender sympathy manifested by the whole nation is touching, but deserved.

Whether there will be war or not, the beginning of the year will show; it is, I think, more than probable; there is no probability of the Americans giving up Mason and Slidell. If we do fight, it will be agreeable to feel that we are supported by the sympathy and approval of *all Europe*; that we are entirely in the right is *universally* recognised, even by those who have no love for us. Sooner or later, a war with America was, I fear, unavoidable. There is a limit to what even we can overlook. All this need not prevent your coming to England that I can see; it won't stop the Exhibition, nor make any perceptible difference in anybody's doings, except perhaps the picture buyers.—Your very affect. brother,

FRED.

Sunday, 1862.

Arrived here safe and sound on Thursday night, and began my work on Friday. I am making studies^[23] for the "Eastern King" which I shall begin to paint shortly after New Year. I found the frame for the large "Johnny" on my return. It improves the picture very much, and looks very handsome. I also found a letter from Henry Greville waiting for me. He says the Queen bears up admirably, because, she says, *he* would have wished it, but that she always talks of her earthly career as at an end. The equerries, &c., will remain attached to the court.

In 1862 Leighton sent eight pictures to the Royal Academy, and six were accepted. Before the sending in he writes to his father:—

1862.

DEAR PAPA,—I am afraid I don't take exercise *very* regularly, still, I walk a *little* nearly every day.

With regard to the volunteering, the zeal for the matter is necessarily not what it was when every third man really expected to be called to defend the country. Nevertheless, the movement is not dead, but has found a level on which I fancy it will remain; the *shooting* will keep it together a good deal. We (the artists) shall join the great business at Brighton on Easter Monday.

Had I thought you would have taken my remark about the M. Angelo and the Johnnies so much to heart, I should have thought twice before I made it. Against what I said you must set the paragraph in the *Athenæum* two or three weeks back—my doubt is not whether they will be admired—I think they will be *that*—my only question is whether they will be *cared* for. Mrs. Austin admires and likes the M.A. beyond anything, and if she could afford it would, I believe, buy it at once.

You will perhaps be surprised to hear that the pictures from which I expect most are the three which you have not seen—the "Eastern King" and the two others I mentioned in my last. One of them is Pocock's smaller order, a girl with a *swan* (not with *peacocks* as the *Athen.* says)—the other is a kitcat of a girl listening to a shell. Both these are very luminous, and are in that respect the best things I have done.

And later:—

LONDON, 1862.

DEAR PAPA,—I think I may confirm the report made to you of the success of my pictures, particularly the "Odalisque" and "Echoes" (by-the-bye, I have just received a letter from somebody who wants

to know if they are sold). What the papers say, you have seen. You will be glad to hear that I have received congratulations on all sides, which gives me the idea of being tolerably secure; at all events, I got no such last year, nor indeed at all since the "Cimabue." That two of my pictures should not have been accepted does not indeed surprise me, and least of all would it do so if they were rejected on the score of *number*, but I have reason to suspect that they were *not* liked; in fact I *know* it. I have put my name down as a candidate for associateship.

I don't think I have anything of interest to communicate; nobody has as yet asked the price of the "Eastern King" or the "Michael Angelo." There is no mistake now about what people in this country like to buying point; whether I shall conform to their taste is another question.

Pocock liked the "Michael Ang." much, but did not seem to wish to have it. The same remark applies to the Johnnies.

Millais has been, and liked the yellow woman^[24] extremely. I think he liked them all *of their kind*, but the yellow woman was his favourite by far. Stephens has also seen my pictures. He seemed altogether much pleased, but most especially with the design for the "Eastern King," which is also Fred Cockerell's favourite.

To his mother he wrote:—

1862.

I have deferred answering your letter till now, that I might be able to inform you definitely of my fate as regards the Royal Academy. I have just been there; I must tell you at once the least pleasant part of my news—they have rejected the large "Johnny" and "Lord Cowper." On the other hand, the other pictures are well hung; two (the "Odalisque" and the yellow woman), *very* well, being on *the line* in the *East Room*. The "Michael Angelo," the "E. King," and the shell girl are just above the line and well seen—the small "Johnny" just below the line. I think the pictures all look well, though not so luminous as in the studio. I am confirmed in my opinion that the

Academy Exhibition is a false test of colour; what looks sufficiently *silvery* there is *chalky* out of it. The "Odalisque" looks best from general aspects. Lady Cowper wrote me a very nice note about the rejection of her son's portrait, and said she was delighted to get it so soon. I am sorry about the large "Johnny," because my chance of selling it is much diminished.

That Leighton received great encouragement from personal friends there can be no doubt. The following is one of very many letters he received which expressed warm appreciation.

64 RUTLAND GATE.

MY DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I do not know how to express my thanks to you. I have this moment come home and found your beautiful drawing, and can hardly hold my pen, I am in such a state of delight at possessing such a reminiscence of my favourite picture. You really *do* not know what pleasure you have given me, and I think it *too kind* of you to have parted with this to give to me. One thing you may be quite sure of, that the "Eastern King" will receive the greatest homage to the end of days from his devoted admirer and your sincere friend,

MARY SARTORIS.[\[25\]](#)

Past Midnight, Tuesday.

Among Leighton's friends was Charles Dickens. The following notes, written in 1863, have turned up in a packet of miscellaneous correspondence:—

OFFICE OF "ALL THE YEAR ROUND,"
NO. 26 WELLINGTON STREET, STRAND, LONDON, W.C.,
Thursday, April 9, 1863.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I owe you many thanks for your kind reminder. It would have given me real pleasure to have profited by it had such profit been possible, but a hasty summons to attend upon a

sick friend at a distance so threw me out on Friday and Saturday in obliging me to prepare for a rush across the Channel, that I saw no pictures and had no holiday. I was blown back here only last night, and believe that I shall deliver your message to Mrs. Collins to-day; that is to say, I am going home this afternoon and expect to find her there.

When the summer weather comes on, I shall try to persuade you to come and see us on the top of Falstaff's Hill. A hop country is not to be despised by an artist's eyes.—Faithfully yours always,

CHARLES DICKENS.

GAD'S HILL PLACE,
HIGHAM BY ROCHESTER, KENT,
Saturday, July 18, 1863.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—Shall I confess it? I never went out to breakfast in my life, except once to Rogers'. But what I might have done under this temptation is a question forestalled by my having engaged to go down to Bulwer Lytton's in Hertfordshire on Monday, to stay a few days.—Cordially yours,

CHARLES DICKENS.

It was in 1863 that Leighton paid the notable visit to his friend of the Roman days, George Mason, to whom the world's Art owes so much. Assuredly, without Leighton's encouragement and help, those lovely idylls which stand with the most precious treasures of the English school of painting would never have been created. Mason had returned to England in 1856; he married and settled in his own manor-house, Wetley Abbey. Children were born and expenses increased, and little or nothing was there with which to meet them. After Rome England seemed a hopeless place to work in, and Mason's surroundings were quite dumb to his artistic sense. Leighton, when he heard of his depression and poverty, sought him out in his rural retreat, beamed mental sunshine on his spirits, made him walk with him, pointing out the pictorial beauties of Mason's own native country, and ended by taking him a tour through the Black Country. Mason's poetic sense

was again awakened; an artistic purpose was again inspired; and, feeling the despair of hopeless poverty removed (Leighton was ever ready with substantial aid), he painted the pictures for which the world has so much reason to be grateful. When in 1872—nine years after this visit—George Mason died, Leighton arranged for a sale of his pictures and property, from the proceeds of which his wife and children obtained an income of £600 a year. Leighton wrote to Mrs. Matthews at the time of Mason's death: "Poor Mason's death has been a great shock to me, though indeed I should have been prepared for it at any time. His loss is quite irreparable for English Art, for he stood entirely alone in his especial charm, and he was one of the most lovable of men besides."

FOOTNOTES:

[8] The critics, judging from the following extracts, were amiably inclined towards him that year:—"Among the pictures familiar to London loungers of 1858, is Mr. F. Leighton's scene from 'Romeo and Juliet,' a work lost and, it may be submitted, undervalued, owing to the disadvantageous place given it in Trafalgar Square. The depth and richness of its colour, the picturesque manner in which the story is told, the contrast in some of the heads, that, for instance, of Friar Lawrence, hopeful in the consciousness of knowledge of Juliet's secret, with that of the entrancing maiden of Verona, or again with that of the weeping nurse, whose grief is a trifle too *accentué*. The truthful conception and careful labour of this picture have now a chance of being appreciated, and but that Pre-Raphaelitism is resolute not to give in, might fairly have entitled it to the prize bestowed elsewhere."—*Athenæum*, 1858.

"We will take the second-named gentleman first, and come at once to his 'Fisherman and Syren.' The picture is not of any commanding size, nor does it relate any very exciting legend. The story is of the mystic Undine tinge, and with a shadowy semblance in it to that strange legend, current among the peasants of Southern Russia, of the 'White Lady' with the long hair, who, with loving and languishing gestures, decoys the unwary into her fantastic skiff, then, pressing her baleful lips to theirs, folds them to her fell embrace, and drags them shrieking beneath the engulfing waves. The 'Fisherman and Syren' of Mr. Leighton has something of this unreal, legendary fatality pervading it throughout. There is irresistible seductiveness on the one side, pusillanimous fondness on the other. That it is all over with the fisherman, and that the syren will have her wicked will of him to his destruction, is palpable. But it is not alone for the admirable manner in which the story is told that we commend this

picture; the drawing is eruditely correct, most graceful, and most symmetrical. The syren is a model of form in its most charming undulations. The fisherman is a type of manly elegance. That Mr. Leighton understands, to its remotest substructure, the vital principle of the line of beauty, is pleurably manifest. But there is evidence here even more pleasing that the painter, in the gift of a glowing imagination, and a refined ideality, in his mastery of the nobler parts of pictorial manipulation, is worthy to be reckoned among the glorious brotherhood of disciples of the Italian masters—of the grand old men whose pictures, faded and time-worn as they are, in the National Gallery hard by, laugh to scorn the futile fripperies that depend for half their sheen on gilt frames and copal varnish. This young artist is one of Langis' and Nasasi's men. He has plainly drunk long and eagerly at the painter's Castaly. The fount of beauty and of grace that assuaged the thirst of those who painted the 'Monna Lisa' and the 'Belle Jardinière'; who modelled the 'Horned Moses' and the 'Slave'; who designed Peter's great Basilica, and the Ghiberti Gates at Florence."—*Daily Telegraph*, 3rd May 1858.

[9] The Prince of Wales, who lent the picture to the exhibition of Leighton's works at Burlington House, 1897.

[10] Mr. Augustus Craven's wife, *née* Pauline la Ferronnay, was the authoress of the famous book, *Le Récit d'une sœur*, in which several of the most charming scenes took place at Naples.

[11] Mr. George Aitchison wrote: "In 1859, while at Capri, he drew the celebrated Lemon Tree, working from daylight to dusk for a week or two, and giving large details in the margin of the snails on the tree."

[12] The drawing had been lent to Ruskin at the time he was lecturing at Oxford.

[13] Leighton knew Mr. Chorley through Mrs. Sartoris. He accompanied the great *cantatrice* when she made a tour abroad. "Mrs. Kemble's children and their nurse are with them, and Mary Anne Thackeray, a life-long friend, and Mr. Chorley, and the great Liszt, who subsequently joined them in Germany."—Preface by Mrs. R. Ritchie to "A Week in a French Country House," by Mrs. Adelaide Sartoris.

[14] Leighton was perfectly right. "Orphée" was produced at Covent Garden, and the great artist, Madame Viardot, sang in it superbly. The opera was given after one or two acts of a well-known work, and I can vouch for the fact, having been one of the audience, that the house was very nearly empty at the close of "Orphée," Lord Dudley and a very few true lovers of music only remaining in the stalls to the end.

[15] The lady was Mrs. Sandbach, a *Hollandaise*, who was Maid of Honour to the Queen of Holland. In after years, on an occasion when she and I paid a visit together to Leighton's studio in Holland Park Road, she recounted the incident above related by Leighton, which happened in the palace at the Hague when she was in waiting. She also added that from her description Leighton painted what she had seen in her dream to perfection; but that he subsequently added two *amorini*, which in her opinion did much to mar the otherwise true feeling of the picture.

[16] See sketches in the Leighton House Collection. The picture itself is, I believe, in America.

[17] *Ibid.*

[18] A visitor to Leighton's "private view" wrote him the following suggestions:

—

13 CHESTER TERRACE, N.W., *Easter Monday*.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Pardon intrusion. I thought much of your beautiful pictures after my yesterday's visit, and I anticipated a struggle with the difficulty you mentioned of worthily naming them.

Don't think me impertinent for volunteering the result. It seemed impossible without verbal description to explain the sacred subject to the profane imagination, while a prose translation of its sentiment must be heavy and subversive of romance.

I think, were I fortunate enough to own the picture, I would call it "Not Yet," and I would put some little lines in the catalogue, which, for aught any one knows, might have come from some volume of rhyme, and which should explain that it is a story of a dream, and that the rejection is not final: something in this spirit, only better:—

"Not yet—not yet—
Still there is trial for thee, still the lot
To bear (the Father wills it) strife and care,
With this sweet consciousness in balance set
Against the world, to soothe thy suffering there.
Thy Lord rejects thee not."
Such tender words awoke me, hopeful, shriven,
To life on earth again from dream of heaven.

For the beauty at the fountain I once thought the best title might be some couplet like the following:—

"So tranced and still half-dreamed she, and half-
heard
The splash of fountain and the song of bird."

But my wife, from my description of the picture, suggested a name better suited to the "suggestiveness" of the work:—

"Lieder ohne Worte": don't you think it rather pretty?

In the multitude of counsellors some one says there's wisdom, and this liberty we take with you may beget some thought that had not struck you.

I have Mr. Cockerell's commands to express to you the gratification his visit afforded him and his sense of your kindness and attentions.—I am, faithfully yours,

RALPH A. BENSON.

Another friend wrote of "Lieder ohne Worte," adding a poem suggested by the "Francesca":—

TRINITY HOUSE, E.C., *8th April 1861*.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—If you did not paint better than I write you would not be the man of abounding promise that you are.

What I meant to say was that Law and Restraint are healthy life and the infraction of them ghostly death and dissolution, and that meaning is in your picture, whether you know it or not. Your "dæmon" may have put it there, but then you can trust *your* dæmon.

Still, best love to the little girl at the fountain, who knows that though Speech may be silver, Silence is Golden.—Ever yours, with many thanks,

ROBIN ALLEN.

FRED. LEIGHTON, Esq.

LEIGHTON'S "FRANCESCA DI RIMINI."

"That day they read no more." Virtue grows
faint,
One hand lies powerless, the wife's sweet face
Is half-convulsed by loss of self-restraint.
Outstretched to resist, remaining to embrace,
The extended arm will clasp her guilty lover,
And all the bright, pure world beyond for her be
over.

Their very forms grow blurred and change their
colour
Into dim snaky wreaths of purple pallor,
Fading away with Honour's fading Law
Into the pale sad ghosts that Dante saw;
Which we too see, crowned with departing
glory,
When Leighton's genius deepens Dante's Story.

R.A.

6th April 1861.

[19] D.G. Rossetti, in a letter to William Allingham, May 10, 1861, writes: "Leighton might, as you say, have made a burst had not his pictures been ill-placed mostly—indeed one of them (the only very good one, *Lieder ohne Worte*) is the only instance of very striking unfairness in the place."

[20] "*Lieder ohne Worte*."

[21] "Paolo and Francesca."

[22] These two pictures were painted from John Hanson Walker. Leighton sent both to the Royal Academy Exhibition of 1862 with the titles "Duet" and "Rustic Music." The first only was accepted.

[23] See water-colour and chalk drawings: Leighton House Collection.

[24] "Sea Echoes."

[25] The Hon. Mrs. Alfred Sartoris, sister-in-law of Leighton's friend, Mr. Edward Sartoris.

CHAPTER II [ToC](#)

ILLUSTRATIONS FOR *CORNHILL MAGAZINE*—FRESCO FOR LYNDHURST CHURCH—ASSOCIATE OF THE ROYAL ACADEMY—MRS. LEIGHTON'S DEATH

1863-1865

In 1860 Leighton drew his first illustration for the *Cornhill Magazine*:—

Translation.]

Friday, 30th November 1860.

MY DEAR FRIEND AND MASTER,—Best thanks for your dear letter of the 7th, thanks also especially, because in your kind praise you do not spare criticism also; you could give me no better proof that you still esteem and love your old pupil. I feel the justice of your remarks about the drapery of the Saviour very much, and can only say in my excuse that I have treated this kind of subject very little, for I am only really a profane fellow; but should I at some future time again treat such a theme, I should endeavour to avoid similar faults. I send you this time, for fun, a proof impression of a woodcut after a drawing I made for one of our good monthly periodicals (*The Cornhill Magazine*). It seems to me to be not bad for wood. It illustrates a poem, and represents Ariadne kneeling on an eminence,

looking out for Theseus. This as a preliminary; I hope to send you something in April.

DEAREST MAMMY,—My wretched picture is causing more delays! I am very sorry to say I shan't be able to get to Bath before Wednesday evening. I am due at Stourhead the 27th; this I cannot defer any more, as I must be on duty with the Rifle Corps at the beginning of September, and can't do all I have to do in less than a week—this will, however, still leave me three weeks, all but two days, at Bath.

I enjoyed myself at Panshanger very much—did I write to tell you who our party was? In case I did not, it was as follows: Henry Greville, Lord and Lady Katherine Valletort, Lord and Lady Spencer, Mrs. Leslie, Lord Listowel, Mr. Clare Vyner, and Mr. E. Lascelles—all young people; so that it was very pleasant.

There are, as you know, most beautiful pictures at Panshanger—a magnificent Vandyke, a splendid Rembrandt, Correggio, Andrea del Sarto, and two beautiful Raphaels.

G. Smith sent me a kind note and a cheque to fill up for drawing in the *Cornhill* ("Ariadne"). I put ten guineas, telling him that I could not, as a general rule, interrupt my work for that sum, but that I would not take more because the cut had turned out so extremely bad.

I am going to expend the money, adding a few pounds, on a cup, to be shot for in the spring by our Rifle Corps. Arthur Lewis has already given one, and another of our men has promised a second prize to go with my cup. My picture will be *finished* by the time I go to Bath. My eye is too accustomed to it to know whether it is successful; I shall know better when I return from the country.

I have no news, so good-bye, dear Mammy. Best love to all.—
From your very affectionate boy,

FRED.

I go to Windsor (to Miss Thackeray) for two days next week; that also is an old invitation; I have no time for it, but must go. I keep my parties going tolerably, but shall give that up with a few exceptions when I settle here; it makes work impossible from unavoidably late hours, and produces a general deterioration of mind and body, mostly the former; the Hollands I shall always keep up—they are most kind; I dine there frequently and meet interesting and remarkable people.

Very remarkable drawings in pencil on other lines followed the celebrated "Lemon Tree"—surpassing in dramatic truth of expression any Leighton had executed since the early design he drew of the "Plague in Florence in 1850."[\[26\]](#)



SKETCH FOR "MICHAEL ANGELO NURSING HIS DYING
SERVANT." 1862

Leighton House Collection[ToList](#)

The group of drawings for "Michael Angelo Nursing his Dying Servant" are among those preserved in the Leighton House collection, but were not seen by the public before Leighton's death. Though slight, they are among the most admirable he ever achieved in subtle tenderness of feeling and expressive truth of drawing. The feeble twitching clutch of the hands of the old man—announcing the speedy approach of Death—is a convincing proof of imaginative realism of a high order. This group of sketches, however, exemplify the curious artistic discrepancy which at times existed, especially before and about the time when the Michael Angelo was painted, between Leighton's pictures and the studies he made for them—a discrepancy which had no reference to his feeling for colour, but simply arose from an absence of sensitiveness for texture. In turning from the drawings to the painting, we find the noble feeling and conception, the lines and forms of the design much the same in all; but the heavy and yet insufficient texture of the actual surface mars the full conveying, even in the completed painting, of the feeling of the motive—so imperative is a simultaneous union of the idea with a happy echo of it in the touch of the human hand, if a work of art is fully to convey its message. Leighton's genius for using the point is referred to in a letter from Mrs. Browning, on the subject of a drawing he had made of her husband:—

Copy.]

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—The portrait is beautiful, and would satisfy me entirely except for a want of strength about the brow, which I must write of, because I can't trust Robert himself with the message. I think the brow is feeble, less massive than his, with less fulness about the temples. In fact, your temple is *hollow*, instead of full. Will you look at it by the original? The eyes and mouth are exquisite. *Your pencil has the expressiveness of another's brush.*

How much I thank you for having put so much of my husband on paper is proved by the very insolence of my criticisms.—Most truly yours,

ELIZABETH BARRETT BROWNING.

April 1.

In the same category as the Michael Angelo studies may be placed the first sketch of "Samson Wrestling with the Lion," designed as an illustration for Dalziel's Bible. This drawing is also in the Leighton House Collection, also the original drawings for "The Spies' Escape" and "Samson at the Mill." The following was written with regard to it: "An animal model never 'sits.' The artist must catch the action he wants from fleeting suggestions. His imagination alone can guide his pencil when he depicts such action with realistic power. It is in a pencil drawing of a lion that we find the work that evinces, more distinctly perhaps than does any other of Leighton's utterances in art, the highest kind of imagination in the drawing of form in action, namely in the sketch of 'Samson Wrestling with the Lion' for the illustrations in Dalziel's Bible. Where, indeed, for vigour of invention, can we find a drawing to surpass these few pencil lines? The sinews in the legs and claws of the animal are drawn up, clenching the vacant air with a quivering grip; the tail straightened stiffly through the strain of the wrestling; the whole animal convulsed with the force of the struggle. This is treatment of form no model could suggest, no knowledge evolve, no labour or industry produce. A true imagination alone can inspire such vivid realism." The other subjects Leighton illustrated were "Death of Abel," "Moses Viewing the Promised Land," "Samson Carrying the Gates," "Abraham and the Angel," "Eliezer and Rebecca at the Well," "The Slaying of the First-born."



ORIGINAL DRAWING FOR "SAMSON AND THE LION" IN
DALZIEL'S BIBLE
Leighton House Collection [ToList](#)

In 1862 Leighton illustrated George Eliot's great novel "Romola." He writes to his father:—

Tuesday.

DEAR PAPA,—Though I am not able, I am sorry to say, to report the sale of any more of my pictures, you will be glad to hear of a commission just given me by G. Smith of the *Cornhill* which is very acceptable to me. I am to illustrate (by-the-bye this is "*strictly confidential*") a novel about to appear in the *Cornhill* from the hand of *Adam Bede*. It is an Italian story, the scene and period are Florence and the fifteenth century, nothing could "*ganter*" me better. It is to continue through *twelve* numbers, in each of which are to be two illustrations.

I am to have for each *number* £40; for the whole novel, therefore, £480. I have conferred with the authoress to-day, and am to get the first-proof sheets this week. The first number will be published in July. Miss Evans (or Mrs. Lewes) has a very striking countenance. Her face is large, her eyes deep set, her nose aquiline, her mouth large, the under jaw projecting, rather like Charles Quint; her voice and manner are grave, simple, and gentle. There is a curious mixture in her look; she either is or seems very short-sighted. Lewes is clever. Both were extremely polite to me; her I shall like much.

I have no other news; no one asks about my pictures, though their success is decidedly great; hard times! Are you writing to Gussy? if so will you tell her that I mean to give her some lessons with Hallé when she comes to London? she shall have *three* a week for a month. Tell Lina with my love not to be jealous, it will be her turn

next. How is she? and how is Mamma? Give them my best love, and believe me, your affectionate boy,

FRED.

That George Eliot should write a Florentine story at a time when Leighton was available to illustrate it, was certainly a most fortunate coincidence. Each scene which he represents is impregnated with a feeling which records the strong hold Italy had on his artistic resources. With a few exceptions, these illustrations for "Romola" are the last examples of his art, when a dramatic or a humorous treatment was a prominent feature of the designs. The last picture exhibited at the Royal Academy in 1897—the passionate, despairing figure of "Clytie"—was notably one of these exceptions. Unfortunately Leighton's letters to George Eliot respecting the "Romola" drawings cannot be found, and were probably destroyed before the author's death. The following were preserved by Leighton:—

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Friday.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Thanks for the sight of the Vignettes. They are satisfactory.

Your delicious drawing was with me all day yesterday and made the opera more delightful to me in the evening. I never saw anything comparable to the scene in Nello's shop as an illustration. There could not be a better beginning.

I should very much like to have a little conversation with you, and will arrange to see you at any hour that will best suit you, in the evening if you like, any time after the morning working hours, which last till two o'clock. I know your time is very precious to you just now, but I think we shall both benefit by a little talk together after you have read the second proof.—Yours very truly,

M.E. LEWES.

F. LEIGHTON, Esq.

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Wednesday.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I feel for you as well as myself in this inevitable difficulty—nay, impossibility of producing perfect correspondence between my intention and the illustrations.

I think your sketch is charming, considered in itself, and I feel now with regret that if we had seen each other and talked a little together after you had read the proof, the only important discrepancy might have been prevented. It is too late for alterations now. If it had not been, I should have wished Bardo's head to be raised with the chin thrust forward a little—the usual attitude of the blind head, I think—and turned a little towards Romola, "as if he were looking at her."

Romola's attitude is perfect, and the composition is altogether such as gives me a very cheering prospect for the future, when we have more time for preparation. Her face and hair, though deliciously beautiful, are not just the thing—how could they be? Do not make yourself uneasy if alteration is impossible, but I meant the hair to fall forward from behind the ears over the neck, and the dress to be without ornament.

I shall inevitably be detestable to you, but believe that I am
(Unfinished)

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Thursday.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Unmitigated delight! Nello is better than my Nello. I see the love and care with which the drawings are done.

After I had sent away my yesterday's note, written in such haste that I was afterwards uncomfortable lest I had misrepresented my feelings, the very considerations you suggest had occurred to me and I had talked them over with Mr. Lewes—namely, that the exigencies of your art must forbid perfect correspondence between

the text and the illustration; and I came to the conclusion that it was these exigencies which had determined you as to the position of Bardo's head and the fall of Romola's hair. You have given her attitude transcendently well, and the attitude is more important than the mere head-dress. I am glad you chose Nello's shop; it makes so good a variety with Bardo and Romola. In a day or two you will have the second part, and I think you will find there a scene for Tessa "under the Plane Tree." But perhaps we shall see each other before you begin the next drawings.—Ever yours truly,

M.E. LEWES.

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Monday.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Your letter comforts me particularly. I am so glad to think you find subjects to your mind. I have no especial desire for the view from S. Miniato, and indeed a plan we started in conversation with Mr. Smith this morning, namely, to have moderately sized initial letters—the opening one being an old Florentine in his *Lucco* and generally the subjects being bits of landscape or Florentine building—seems to do away with any reason for having the landscape to begin with. The idea of having Tessa and the mules, or Nello's sanctum, smiles upon me, so pray feel free to choose the impression that urges itself most strongly. Your observation about the "che, che" is just the aid I besought from you. With that exception, I have confined myself, I believe, to such interjections as I find in the writers of the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, and in them, curiously enough, this exclamation now said to be so constant and "to mean everything" (according to our authority) does not seem to occur.

Thank you. Pray let me have as many criticisms of that kind as you can. I am more gratified, I think, by your liking these opening chapters than I have yet been by anything in these nervous anxious weeks of decision about publication.—Very truly yours,

M.E. LEWES.

F. LEIGHTON, Esq.

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Tuesday Evening.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I am enchanted! purely delighted! which shall I begin with, to tell you that I delight in Baby's toes or that exquisite poetry in the scene where Romola is standing? Is it not a pleasant change to have that opening made through the walls of the city, so as to see the sky and the mountains? In the scene with Baldassarre and Tessa, also, the distant view is charming. Tessa and her Babkin are perfect—Baldassarre's is, as you say, an impossible face to draw, but you have seized the framework of the face well, both in this illustration and the previous one.

I want to tell you that a man of some eminence in art was speaking of your drawings to a third person the other day as "remarkable" in a tone of genuine admiration. I don't know whether you care about that, but it is good to know that there is any genuine admiration in one's neighbours.

I am glad to have the drawings left. I shall go now and have a long look at them. The February number will soon be out of my hands, but you will have it when it pleases the pigs—or printers.—
Ever yours truly,

M.E. LEWES.

PARK HOTEL, LITTLE HAMPTON,
SUSSEX, *September 10, '62.*

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Thanks for your letter, which I have received this morning.

My copy of Vasari has a profile of Piero di Cosimo, but it is of no value, a man with a short beard and eyes nearly closed. The old felt hat on his head has more character in it than the features, but the hat you can't use.

Of Niccolo Caparra it is not likely that any portrait exists, so that you may feel easy in letting your imagination interpret my suggestions in the First and the Fifth Parts of Romola. There is probably a portrait of Piero di Cosimo in the portrait room of Uffizi, but in the absence of any decent catalogue of that collection it was a bewildering and headachy business to assure oneself of the presence or absence of any particular personage.

If you feel any doubt about the *new* Romola, I think it will be better for you to keep to the original representation, the type given in the first illustration, which some accomplished people told me they thought very charming. It will be much better to continue what is intrinsically pretty than to fail in an effort after something indistinctly seen. If you prefer the action of *taking out* the crucifix, instead of the merely contemplative attitude, you can choose that with safety. In the scene with Piero di Cosimo, I thought you might make the figures subordinate to those other details which you render so charmingly, and I chose it for that reason.

But I am quite convinced that illustrations can only form a sort of overture to the text. The artist who uses the pencil must otherwise be tormented to misery by the deficiencies or requirements of the one who uses the pen, and the writer, on the other hand, must die of impossible expectations. *Apropos* of all that, I want to assure you again of what I had said in that letter, which your naughty servant sent down the wind, that I appreciate very highly the advantage of having your hand and mind to work with me rather than those of any other artist of whom I know. Please do not take that as an impertinent expression of opinion, but rather as an honest expression of feeling by which you must interpret any apparent criticism.

The initial letter of the December part will be W. I forgot to tell you how pleased I was with the initial letter of Part V.

I am very much obliged to you for your critical doubts. I will put out the questionable "Ecco!" in deference to your knowledge. I have a tremulous sense of my liability to error in such things.

I don't wonder at your difficulty about the modification of *com* into *ciom*. The writers of the fifteenth century, speaking of the insurrection of the *Ciompi* which occurred in the previous century, say that the word was a corruption of the French *compère*, the same word of course as *compare*, constantly on the lips of the numerous French who were present in Florence during the dictatorship of the Duke of Athens. The likelihood of the derivation lies in the analysis of transition in the meaning of words *compère* and *compare*, like the English "gossip," beginning with the meaning of godfather and ending with, or rather proceeding to that of companion. Our "gossip" has at least parted with its secondary meaning as well as its primary one.

The unlikelihood of the derivation lies in the modification of the sounds, and I felt that unlikelihood as you have done. But in the absence of a Max Müller to assure me of a law to the contrary, I thought the statement of Tuscan writers a better authority than inferences. I ought to have written "is stated by the old historians."

I am really comforted by the thought that you will mention doubts to me when they occur to you. My misery is the certainty that I must be often in error.

Mr. Lewes shares my admiration of the two last illustrations.—
Ever yours truly,

MARIAN E. LEWES.

F. LEIGHTON, Esq.

16 BLANDFORD SQUARE, N.W.,
Tuesday.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—Since I saw you I have confirmed by renewed reference my conclusion that *gamurra* was the equivalent of our *gown*, *i.e.* the constant outer garb of femininity, varying in length and cut according to rank and age. The poets and novelists give it alike to the peasant and the "city woman," and speak of the *girdle* around it. Perhaps it would have been better to call Tessa's gown a *gamurrina*, the word sometimes used and indicating, I

imagine, just that abbreviation of petticoat that active work demands.

If you are going to see Ghirlandajo's frescoes—the engravings of them I mean—in the choir of Santa Maria Novella, I wish you would especially notice if the women in his groups have not that plain piece of opaque drapery over the head which haunts my memory. We were only allowed to see those frescoes once, because of repairs going on; but I am strongly impressed with a belief—which, *au reste*, may be quite false—in the presence of my "white hood" there. As to the garb of the luxurious classes at that time, a point which may turn up in our progress, I think the painters can hardly be believed to have represented it fully, since we know, on strong evidence, that it ran into extravagances, which are even in contrast with the general impression conveyed not only by the large fresco compositions but by the portraits. You must have had sufficient experience of the *eclecticism* in costume which the artist's feeling forces upon him in the presence of hideous or extreme fashion. We have in Varchi a sufficiently fit and clear description of the ordinary male costume of dignified Florentines in my time; but for the corresponding feminine costume the best authority I have seen is the very incomplete one of a certain Ginevra's *trousseau* in the Ricordi of the Rinuccini family of rather an earlier period, but marking even there the rage for embroidery and pearls which grew instead of diminishing.

I imagine that the woman's *berretta*, frequently of velvet embroidered with pearls, and apparently almost as prevalent as our bonnet, must have been that close-fitting cap, square at the ears, of which we spoke yesterday. I trouble you with this note—which pray do not think it necessary to answer—in order to indicate to you the very slight satisfaction my anxiety on this subject can meet with, and the obligation I shall be under to you if you will ever give me a positive or negative hint or correction.

Approximative truth is the only truth attainable, but at least one must strive for that, and not wade off into arbitrary falsehood.—
Ever, dear Mr. Leighton, yours very truly,

MARIAN E. LEWES.

Leighton preserved the records of a friendship with Mr. Robin Allen,^[27] established and for most part continued through a correspondence which lasted for many years from the early 'sixties. The letter sent with the following poem refers to Leighton's illustration to Mrs. Browning's poem, "Musical Instrument," of which the original drawing is reproduced. (See [List of Illustrations](#).)

TRINITY HOUSE, E.C.

MY DEAR SIR,—If I send this to the author of a lovely illustration to a lovely poem, it is not for its worth, but to give me an excuse for saying that I go out of town for a month next Wednesday, and hope that I may call on you on my return, perhaps get leave to show you over Loughton Woods in the autumn.—Believe me, my dear sir, yours truly,

ROBIN ALLEN.

F. LEIGHTON, Esq.

SEQUITUR TO MRS. BROWNING'S "MUSICAL INSTRUMENT" IN THE
"CORNHILL MAGAZINE" OF JULY 1860.

A greater God than the great god Pan
Planted the reed in the river,
And he is the only God who can
Break through its heart without killing the
reed,
And make of its very life indeed
An organ, to utter His psalm as the
Giver.

This greater God than the beast-god Pan,
As He watches the reeds in Time's river,
Counts for best poet that perfect Man

Who holds lightly his song, at its loftiest
strain,
So he live a man's life!—and at all cost and
pain
Is a reed among reeds in the river.

R.A.



"THE GREAT GOD PAN"

Original Sketch for Illustration to Mrs. Browning's Poem in the
Cornhill Magazine, 1861 [To List](#)



"AN EVENING IN A FRENCH COUNTRY HOUSE"

Illustration for Mrs. Adelaide Sartoris's story, "A Week in a French Country House," published in the *Cornhill Magazine*, 1867

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In a letter to his mother Leighton expresses a warm admiration for these lines by Mr. Robin Allen.

In the autumn of 1863 the following letter to his mother mentions a notable visit to Compiègne. The charming story Mrs. Edward Sartoris wrote, which appeared some years later in the *Cornhill Magazine*, "A Week in a French Country House," owes its local colour to this home at Compiègne to which Leighton refers. It belonged to Mr. Edward Sartoris' brother-in-law, the Marquis de l'Aigle. For this story Leighton made two admirable illustrations—"An Evening in a French Country House" and "Drifting." Leighton is supposed to have suggested the character of Monsieur Kiowski, the Polish artist in the story; and the figure in the boat holding the rudder in "Drifting" he certainly meant to represent himself, while the figure singing is Adelaide Sartoris—drawn, as shown by the head-dress, from the sketch Leighton made in 1856. (See [List of Illustrations](#).)

Commencement of letter missing.]

1862.

I have a fit of the blues instead.

I hope for the sake of my pictures that I shall soon get over them (the blues, not the pictures). I believe if I could find models I should recover at once; but I foresee that I shall have no such luck.

I had a delightful time at Compiègne—the place is charming, the house comfortable in the extreme, and the life the perfection of unconstraint (if that is English); I have told you already how hospitable and kind my host and hostess were. I have, of course, no news to give you yet, except, by-the-bye, that the bailiffs were in the house the other day because Mr. and Mrs. Gedy had not paid £3, 5s. 6d. taxes; they stayed two days in the house, and if the money had not come, would have walked off with some of *my* furniture. I wish I had a house; they are beginning a house on Campden Hill, and would build it for an artist after his own designs.

Mr. and Mrs. Alfred Sartoris, the admirer of "Eastern King," were also among the visitors during this week in a French country house, and write the following anecdote:—

"Those who knew Lord Leighton require no record of his kindness and unselfishness. For those who had not that privilege the following little anecdote may be interesting. In the late autumn of 1863 we were all staying with my sister-in-law, the Marquise de l'Aigle, at Francport, near Compiègne. Mrs. Sartoris was also there and Mr. Leighton. There was to be a service on the Sunday in a little neighbouring village church for some children who had made their first communion, and it occurred to Mme. de l'Aigle to have some special music on the occasion, and profit by the glorious voice of Mrs. Sartoris, who kindly offered to sing. Mr. Leighton also volunteered to take the tenor part in various sacred pieces. We were all to help in the concerted music, and the old curé was in the seventh heaven of delight at the prospect of such a grand service.

Our dismay can be imagined when three days before the service Mr. Leighton announced that he must leave us as business required his presence in London. 'Oh!' we all exclaimed, 'what shall we do? the tenor pieces must be given up; the curé will die of grief,' &c. ... 'No, no,' said Mr. L., in his cheery way, 'don't change anything; I shall be back all right on Sunday morning in time to sing;' and so, sure enough, he did return, having travelled two nights to London and back. He never would tell us why he had gone; and it was not till long afterwards that it transpired that he had made the hurried double journey to help a struggling artist, whose work he wished to bring forward and introduce to some influential person. He attained his object, and thought nothing of the time and trouble involved, only glad to have been a help to one who needed assistance, and also to keep his promise by singing in the little village church."



"DRIFTING"

Illustration for Mrs. Adelaide Sartoris's story, "A Week in a French Country House," published in the *Cornhill Magazine*, 1867
By permission of Messrs. Smith, Elder, & Co. [ToList](#)

In 1863 Leighton began painting the fresco of "The Wise and Foolish Virgins," which he presented to the Church at Lyndhurst. It was painted on the plaster wall above the altar at the east end. While at work on it, he stayed with his old friend Mr. Hamilton Aïdé, who formed one of the happy company of *intimes* of the Roman and Lucca days. Several visits to this charming home in the New Forest were made before the work was finished.

In the following letter to Steinle he mentions his first experiment in Mr. Gambier Parry's medium for painting in fresco.

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER.

MY VERY DEAR FRIEND,—When I last wrote I asked you when the German exhibition of which you spoke was to take place, and whether it was to be held in Cologne itself; but as I received no answer I supposed that this exhibition either had not come to anything (as I have seen nothing about it in the newspapers), or that it did not seem sufficiently important to you for me to go specially to Germany for it. Nevertheless, I would have gone to Cologne, if it had been in any way feasible, exclusively on account of you and your works, which I am very anxious to see; unfortunately, however, I could not arrange it, and must content myself with learning from a letter (if you will write me one) how your work succeeds, and how far you have got with it. Two walls are already finished, are they not?

As for myself, I am fairly industrious. Amongst other things, I am painting at present the composition which you have already seen, of Michael Angelo and his old servant Urbino. I have endeavoured to keep the action of the figures simpler and smoother than in the first sketch; and, in fact, I think the picture will please you better than the drawing. For the rest, I am sick of painting small pictures, and would like to undertake something large; but it is not very agreeable to paint pictures which will probably remain always hanging round one's neck.

I think I shall very soon test the public again in this respect—but *what* I shall paint I do not know. A friend of mine (Mr. Gambier

Parry), a great art devotee and first-rate amateur, has discovered a medium to replace fresco painting in our damp climate. I have seen his experiments, and have myself painted a head under his rules,^[28] and to my complete satisfaction. The result is scarcely to be distinguished from fresco, and is quite as easy, indeed even easier to achieve. At the same time this method has advantages which *buon fresco* does not possess; it dries exactly as one lays it on (and is then flat), it has no deposit (*Ansätze*), and one can go over it as often as one likes. The wall (a granular lime wall) is saturated with the same preparation as you paint with. This preparation, which is *stone hard* against water, can always dissolve *itself* with moisture, so that one can retouch it perpetually, at the same time the *whole* of one's palette is available. My friend is going to publish his system; I will then, if you like, tell you exactly about it.

And now, farewell, dear Master. Remember me most kindly to your wife and children, and keep in remembrance your friend and pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

He wrote to Steinle in 1862 that he was making studies for the Lyndhurst fresco, and expected to finish it that summer; but it was apparently only begun in August 1863.

Translation.]

2 ORME SQUARE, BAYSWATER,
April 22, 1862.

MY VERY DEAR FRIEND,—When I last wrote to you, I promised and hoped that this time I should be able to send you some photographs of my latest works, but unfortunately at the last moment time ran short. My pictures are only just ready for exhibition, and I must send them off unphotographed. In order that you may not think I have been idle, I write these lines; also because I am unwilling, my dear Master, to fade entirely from your memory. I am exhibiting *eight* pictures this year, an unusually large number. But the case is not so bad as it looks at the first glance. Two only of these pictures

are important in size and subject. One of them you already know from a former composition. It represents Michael Angelo with his dying servant Urbino. In the principal idea I have not deviated much from the first sketch, but have endeavoured to treat the whole with more unity and the details with more simplicity than in the drawing which you saw, and the faults of which you pointed out to me. This picture is life-size, and extends down to the knees.

The other is of a somewhat fanciful description. I have imagined one of the three holy kings, when he sees the Star in the East from the battlements of his palace. The picture is curious and open to much fault-finding, but I think it will please you by a certain poetry in the conception. The shape is long and narrow. The king, half life-size, almost turns his back upon the spectator, and is, in the midst of the dark night, only lit by the mystic rays of the Star. In contrast to this pure light one sees, quite at the bottom, through an arch, into the hot lamp-light, which illuminates a gay orgy. I have allowed myself a certain amount of pictorial licence, which may well surprise the general spectator at first glance, but which to me heightens the poetical impression of the whole.

Five other pictures are smaller, and three of the subjects are idyllic or fanciful (*e.g.* a shepherd playing on a flute, an Oriental girl with a swan, &c. &c.), all carried out with great love, and certainly my best works.

At present I am busy making studies for a large wall painting (the "Wise and Foolish Virgins"), which I am giving to a church. I shall execute it this summer, and tell you more about it.

Now, my dear Friend, I have given you a long and full report of myself; I hope you also will tell me what you are doing. I am very anxious to know how the Cologne frescoes get on. How I should like to see them! PERHAPS I may manage it this autumn. In the meantime, however, write to me, and believe me to be, your devoted pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.



PORTRAIT FROM A PHOTOGRAPH OF LORD LEIGHTON
TAKEN IN 1863[ToList](#)

April 1863, Saturday.

DEAREST MAMMA,—You have seen in the papers that the Review at Brighton went off capitally. I enjoyed my day very much, and though I was a *little* tired and *very* sleepy for two days after, was altogether the better for it. It was a stiff day's work too—nine or ten hours without sitting down, and with the additional responsibility of having the command of the Artists' Company. I was sure you would be pleased at the reception of my "Fruit Girl"[\[29\]](#) by my brother artists—you must understand, though, that this applies chiefly to the younger men (and not to *all* of *them*), for there are several of the older painters who strongly object to my style of painting and are bent on suppressing it.

Will you thank Papa for his hint about the *Athenæum*—I am pretty sure he is mistaken about it, but I shall take measures about it—indeed I *have*.

I spoke to *Charles* Greville (Henry's brother) and told him I thought I should be coming on before very long; he very kindly overhauled the lists and said he thought I might be up by the end of the summer, and, what was still more kind, seeing me unseconded, he put his name down as seconder.

FOREST BANK, LYNDHURST,
Thursday, August 6, 1863.

If I was not more explicit about being with Aïdé, it was because I made sure you knew it. You will be pleased to hear that when after many *péripéties* I did begin my fresco I got on capitally; I have now finished the task for this year, having painted *three* life-size figures, with a good bit of background, in *four* days. I worked hard for it, and am rather tired—head and eyes; otherwise flourishing.

I am delighted with my new fresco material (Parry's)—the effect is excellent—nearly as fine as real fresco. Everybody seems much pleased with what I have done, particularly the parson. I like it myself; I enjoy working at it immensely; it is my real element. I find it (for mere *manipulation bien entendu*) absurdly easy.

The following letter from Mr. Gambier Parry explains the "fresco material" Leighton used.

HIGHNAM, GLOUCESTER,
August 3, 1863.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—In reply to your last note about the use of the wall itself rather than of canvas, there can be no doubt on the subject, if only the plaster is *good* and *well put on*. You speak of two or three months to get it dry. I assure you that that is *not near enough*. When the surface feels dry to your hand you must not suppose that it is all dry inside, and if the *wall* is new, I doubt a year

being enough to dry it. The water must evaporate somewhere—it is drawn *to the* surface of *interiors* because they are the warmest.

You ask whether the rough cast on the wall must be scraped off before you wash the wall for painting. If by the *rough cast* you mean rough plaster, which is a totally different thing to rough cast, certainly use it as it is. The coarser the plaster the better, because it is all the more porous, so long only that it is of the best materials (viz. perfectly *washed* sand, and good lime), and well put on a good wall. *Nothing in the world could equal it for painting upon*, except a surface of *coarse clean* Bath stone, with *all its pores open*. If you have such plaster as I have just described, and both it and the wall thoroughly dry, nothing could be better. The smooth surface, with what granulated texture you please, can be got according to the directions in my paper—viz. after two or three washes of pure diluted medium, give another or two more of the same, with dry whiting and a little white-lead, then go ahead *while it is all fresh*, viz. *two or three days* after the process of preparation has been completed.

Take care in painting not to rub it up too much, for fear of *drawing up the glossy resins to the surface* away from the wax. Paint right *into* your prepared surface *solidly* and with *decision* in the way of fresco painting, not as oil. Keep the brush clean, and the volatile oil in the dipper clean, and then, oh! how shall I envy you your power to use them all!^[30]

At the *Ely ceiling*, which is of hard wood *not* porous, but prepared with three coats of oil white-lead, I am painting with

	Liquid Measure.
Pale drying oil	2
Japan gold size	2
Turpentine	2
Artist copal	1

well shaken up every time it is used. The colours are all ground up in it, and then painting is done as in water-colour, using *pure spirits of turpentine* as a vehicle. Colours dry extremely rapidly and with a dead surface. The stuff looks horribly black, but the colours are not materially affected by it. Of course it is not to be compared with my former medium, because there is that bane of the palette oil in it, but I used it because of its great facility (used transparent like *water-colour on a white ground*), and because the surface was hard, so that wax might (in great heat) shrink or play tricks on it, as it has done in Murillo's pictures and many others.—Ever most sincerely yours,

T. GAMBIER PARRY.

If I can do anything for you, command me; we go to Scotland on the 14th.

LONDON, *April 26, 1863.*

DEAREST MAMMA,—You were no doubt surprised to see a sock arrive in Bath in solitary grandeur, unaccompanied by any sort of note. The fact is, for some days past I have been working at a rate which made me altogether unfit for correspondence. I have just returned from Lyndhurst, where I have been doing a bit more fresco—and very stiff work it was—up and at work at seven, and at its best part of the day, perched generally on an uncomfortably narrow ladder, and with my head almost blown off by the agreeable but overpowering smell of the vehicle with which I painted. The result is as far as it goes tolerably satisfactory—everybody there is delighted, and though that, of course, does not prove much, it is at all events agreeable to me that they derive so much pleasure from my work. The stained-glass window, too, which has been executed at my desire from Jones' designs, gives great satisfaction—is a lovely piece of colour, and (which was, to me, of paramount importance) does not hurt my fresco, though, of course, in the nature of things, it outshines tenfold in point of brilliancy; hence the folly, to my mind, of ever putting glass and wall painting in immediate juxtaposition. I shall go and paint another slice in June,

after which Aïdé leaves, so I may not be able to finish my work till he returns in autumn. On my road to Lyndhurst, I paid a visit to Lady Dorothy Neville (Lady Pollington's sister) at Dangstein—a very beautiful place near Petersfield.

On Monday week the Royal Academy opens—I shall be curious to see what pictures they have taken; my work at present will be a woodcut for Dalziel—then that for the *Cornhill*—then a drawing for Cundall's Bible—Mrs. Magniac's portrait—the cartoon for the remainder of the Lyndhurst fresco—then perhaps a new picture. I wish some one would buy the old ones!

Have you read "Sylvia's Lovers"? Don't read "Salamambo"—it is hideous.

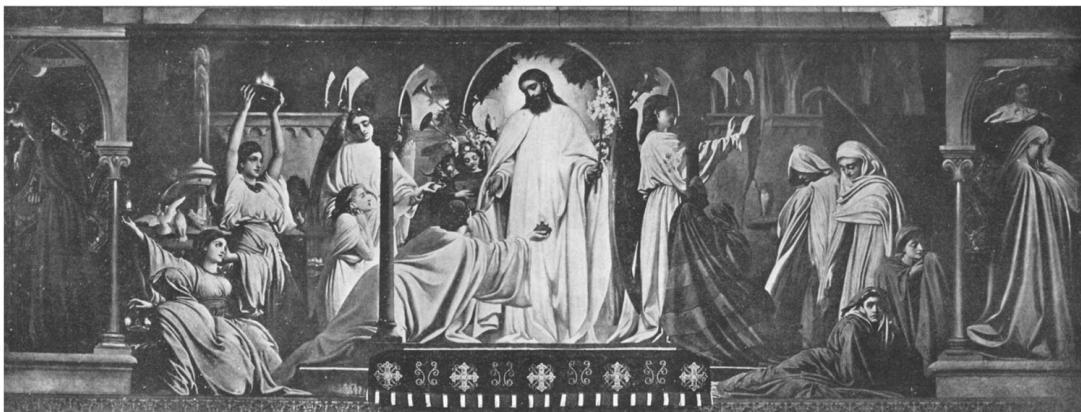
DEAREST MAMMA,—My chair has arrived safe and sound; once more, my very best thanks for it.

Aïdé is one of the most *excellent* men that ever lived—I like him extremely.

By-the-bye, I am made one of the ensigns in our Rifle Corps, so that when you come to town you have a chance of seeing me strutting about with a sword.

I write in haste. Good-bye, best love to all.—From your very affectionate boy,

FRED.



THE FRESCO PRESENTED BY LORD LEIGHTON TO
LYNDHURST CHURCH—"THE WISE AND FOOLISH VIRGINS."
Completed 1864 [ToList](#)

In a letter to his father dated 1864 Leighton announced the completion of the fresco, "The Wise and Foolish Virgins." The design of the whole and the lines of the draperies in each figure are all admirable, and the work is one which proves Leighton's powers of achieving rapidly, and under great difficulties, a complete work and one in which his great sense of beauty is very salient. There is also sufficient dramatic feeling in the gestures and expressions of the faces. Perhaps the most interesting (because the most spontaneous) attitude in the figures of the wise virgins is that which is kneeling, profile-wise, under the figure of the angel, who is indicating to her the presence of her Saviour. She seems dazed with awe and rapture. Her arm is caught up with a sudden unstudied angularity of movement which, though not so beautiful intrinsically as are most of those in Leighton's work, is very expressive, and produces a happy effect amid the more obviously arranged lines in the rest of the design. Among the many drawings preserved in the Leighton House Collection made for this fresco there is a slight but very sensitive sketch for this figure, also a finished pencil drawing for the head of Christ. The model who sat for this head was the Italian whom Leighton painted in "Golden Hours," and whom Watts used for the picture he (many years after its execution) entitled "A Prodigal." The type of this model may be felt by some to have been an unfortunate one to choose for the central imposing figure in the design of the fresco. It is, perhaps, weak—too good-looking in a commonplace style for such a subject.

Ruskin, on seeing the photograph of this work, wrote to Leighton (a postscript to a letter): "I was much struck—seriously—by the photograph from your fresco; it is wonderfully fine in action."

Leighton wrote to Steinle on receipt of his criticisms on the Lyndhurst fresco:—

Translation.]

3rd December.

MY DEAR FRIEND,—Just now returned from a long journey (to Constantinople and Athens), I find two very welcome letters from you, by which I see with great pleasure that your old pupil may still reckon upon your invaluable friendship and sympathy, and I see it all the more certainly because you enclose a kind but pertinent criticism of the photographs I sent you.^[31] I agree entirely, and can only pretend in my defence that it was difficult, with the long space (all having to be filled) and the altar standing in the middle of it, not to fall into rather a panic. That, after all, is but a lame excuse, and I hope that you will always rap me over the knuckles with the same friendly sincerity.

My dear Friend, the idea of appearing as a collaborator beside you, my master, would be in the very highest degree delightful and flattering to me. It is therefore only after mature deliberation, and in the firm confidence that you will at least appreciate the sincerity of your Leighton, that I have to decline with real regret Herr Bruckmann's flattering invitation. *You*, more than any one else, will agree with me that an artist can execute no first-rate work, indeed dare undertake no work, that is not a genuine expression alike of his feelings and his convictions. I must candidly confess I cannot agree about a complete illustration of the Shakespearian plays, those masterpieces already in existence as *exhaustively finished* works of art; it seems to me that in literature only those subjects lend themselves to pictorial representation which stand in the written word more as *suggestion*. Subjects perhaps which are provided in the Bible or in mythology and tradition in great variety, or are not already generally in possession of the minds of the spectators of living plays (*e.g.* the Greek Tragedies). It is for the most part a struggle with the incomparable, already existing *complete*—which is quite intimidating to my capabilities. Do not take this ill, my dear Friend, and do not consider it too great a presumption that I, your pupil, declare so plainly against you where you think so differently. To go back over one detail, I must also confess that *to me* a *coloured cartoon* is not a natural mode of expression; a *drawn*, or a *grey in grey* (grau in grau) painted cartoon—well enough. A size five feet high is to me, for a *suggestion* of colour, at least five times too large; just as little could I give a suggestion of form in this size.

Colour is not necessary; but if one should use it in half life-size, it is too noble and poetic, I think, for one to venture, so to speak, to clarify it. Will you forgive me for all this, dear master? However, I shall see with deep interest the progress of the beautiful work which you will certainly execute.

I have heard with some sorrow of the burning of the venerable Dome, and am just writing to Otto Cornhill in respect to a lottery which is to be arranged for the re-erection of the tower.

I have read what you tell me of your dear family with great pleasure; please remember me most kindly to your wife and children; also to my old comrades V. Müller, Wecker, and the rest. I am very glad to hear that G. Wecker, the apostate, has returned to art. He was, undoubtedly still is, a very gifted man, but had to guard somewhat, had he not? against the *ornamental*.

But my letter is becoming too long.

Farewell, my dear Master; take nothing amiss from your grateful, devoted pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Friday 10, 1864.

DEAR PAPA,—You will be disappointed, after waiting so long, to receive no paper after all, and a skimpy note instead. I am amused at the studied ill-nature of the *Spectator*; I wonder who V. is. The author of an article on sensation pictures in the *Realm*, in which I am flatteringly quoted, is by Mrs. Norton. *En somme* I think my "*Golden Hours*" is the most successful of my pictures (perhaps more than anything since "*Cimabue*") and the "*Orpheus*" (deservedly) the least. I am about to begin two new pictures. Mrs. Guthrie's portrait—a full length—is postponed for her health till the winter.

1864.

I should not leave the place I am in except to build; a mended house would be most unsatisfactory and *temporary*. I feel sure I

shall nowhere get standing room for a house for less than £28, still less room for a house and *large garden*. If I find the terms exactly as I expect and my lawyer (Nettleship) satisfied with the title I shall, I think, close the bargain, the more so that another painter (I don't know who) is after it.^[32] I am staying for a day or two at Dangstein (Lady Dorothy Neville's). I met here last night Mr. Henry Woolfe, who very kindly offered me introductions to one or two charming Venetian families (Mocenigo) which will be very pleasant for me, as I want to see a Venetian interior. Gambart has paid the £1050 for "Dante." The "Honeymoon" was bought by a Cornhill dealer yclept Moreby.

I will let you know how all goes off on Saturday at the Council, meanwhile best love to Mamma.—From your affectionate son,

FRED.

August 23, 1864.

I found your letter on returning from Lyndhurst this morning. I may as well tell you at once that I have finished my fresco, retouching a great deal of what was already painted, and I think I may add, greatly improving it—so much for that.

With regard to the draft, my assent was only general and preliminary (besides being subject to the approval in the details of my solicitor) and bound me to nothing. My surveyor and solicitor have conferred together and with Lady H.'s agent, and though the agreement is not yet signed, the matter is virtually settled. I have several minor clauses altered which had been inserted originally in the general draft to meet cases different from my own. With regard to the title, I was surprised and vexed to hear that it was stipulated that *no title should* be called for. My lawyer told me that this was frequently the case—that he would go to Doctors' Commons to see the Will to ascertain the truth of the statement that the property was Lady H.'s in fee simple (as it is). Even this he said did not *legally* exhaust the matter, as there might be encumbrances not alluded to in the Will. He said, however, that many other leases had been granted on that property on precisely the same terms, that the matter turned

on the character of the landlord, and that, *en somme*, I ran but little risk. *Since then* I have seen him, and he tells me that he has fortunately been able to ascertain through a very respectable firm of solicitors, who *have* seen the titles, that *it is all right*; he has therefore not thought it desirable to put me to the expense of investigating the Will—so far so good. As to the possible expense of the house, my dear Papa, you have taken, I assure you, false alarm. I shall indeed devote more to the architectural part of the building than *you* would care to do; but in the first place architecture and much *ornament* are not inseparable, and besides, whatever I do I shall undertake *nothing without an estimate*.

You need never fear that I shall take otherwise than it is meant the advice that your experience and interest in me suggest to you. You will also, I am sure, allow for the difference of feeling between yourself and an artist who lives by his eyes.

A line will find me at Venice, *poste restante*, all September. I am just off.

Best love to Mammy.—From your affectionate son,

FRED.

I knew neither *Poole* nor *Jones*. Grant said he thought it probable I should be an R.A. before long.

VENICE, *September 20, '64.*

MY DEAR PAPA,—Many thanks for your letter, which reached me safely a few days ago. I do indeed contemplate building my house so as to be enlarged at a future day. I find, however, that I shall probably be obliged to build at once rather more than I absolutely require for practical building reasons, but I need not therefore furnish more than I require. About the well I am now entirely in the dark. It would never have occurred to me to ask myself the question, Are there not *pipes* or something? With regard to the Will, if the perusal of it only cost a guinea, it might have been worth while to look at it, though Palmer and Nettleship thought it superfluous; but then P. and N. tell me it would cost £20! to have it gone over, and as

my expenses with Browne (Lady H.'s agent) are already very great—he makes a preposterous charge, *which I can't dispute*, for the agreement—I don't think I shall care to add to them.

My architect is Aitchison, an old friend.

I wrote to the Academicians (Poole, Grant, and Jones) almost immediately on hearing from them, and expressed a hope, vague but polite, that we might meet on my return. *Poole* I should like to know; he is a man of poetic mind. I need scarcely tell you that the idea of my being elected President (!!!) for many years to come is simply *ludicrous*, even if there is a chance of my ever having the offer of that dignity.

I am quite aware that people do talk of it *laughingly*, but I don't think it goes beyond "chaff" yet. No doubt many other young artists are chaffed in the same way with imaginary dignities. I am delighted that Mamma is better; I should have said this before but that I have answered your letter systematically. I trust the improvement will be lasting.

I congratulate you on Colenso's visit, and shall be very anxious to hear from you how it went off.

As for myself, I am very snugly ensconced in a little mezzanino on the Grand Canal, with a sort of passage which I use as a studio and a bath-room, inasmuch as it opens straight on the water, and enables me to take a very jolly swim every day. I am not attempting a picture, but am making a sketch for one which I shall probably paint on the spot next autumn, staying here a couple of months or so. Meanwhile I have got several heads in hand—*studies*, *not* for *sale*, for use—and a few sketches in Saint Mark's, which I think promise well. *Et voilà*.

I stay here a fortnight longer, so that a letter written on receipt of this would still catch me; after that *Rome* is the safest address. I shall be there from the 20th to the 28th of October.

Best love to Mamma, and believe me, your affectionate son,

FRED.

In the preceding letters mention is made of the final arrangements for the building of Leighton's house in Holland Park Road. Mr. George Aitchison, R.A., his old friend, undertook to be the architect. It was begun in 1865, and first occupied by Leighton in 1866.

Referring to opinions expressed regarding Florentine Art, past and present, Leighton wrote to his younger sister: "——'s remark about ——, if I remember it, was utter bosh and pedantry. The Florentines of the end of the fifteenth century were *emphatically* realists, though their realism was animated by a higher genius and a deeper humanity than the modern Italians exhibit, though *they*, by-the-bye, are mostly not *realists* but mannerists. The chief characteristic of English Art is (I speak of course of the better men) originality and humanity on the one hand, and on the other, absence of acquired knowledge and guiding taste. Some day I will write you a lot more about it."

Fully launched into the English art world, deeply interested in every phase of sincere work produced by contemporary brother artists, Leighton nevertheless adhered in his own practice to the views and principles which he held from the time he became Steinle's devoted pupil. To a question which referred to his art development, asked by Mrs. Mark Pattison when she was about to write an account of his life in 1879, Leighton answered, "I can only speak of what is not a *change* but virtually a growth, the passage from Gothicism to Classicism (for want of better words) *i.e.* a growth from multiplicity to simplicity. Artists' manners are not changed by books!" "As regards English artists," he writes in the same letter, "I can only of course speak with great reserve. Elmore treated me with marked kindness, lending me a studio. Millais, Rossetti, Hunt were most cordial and friendly, though I openly told them I was wholly opposed to their views; but, indeed, few men have more cause to speak well of their brethren."

The artistic events of the years 1862, 1863, and 1864 culminated in Leighton being elected an Associate of the Royal Academy. His old friend, Mr. George Aitchison, wrote at the time of Leighton's death: "In 1860 he took a studio at Orme Square, Bayswater. It was during this time that his conversation was so brilliant and so free from restraint. I remember a summer afternoon I spent with him, Mason, and Murch on the terrace at the Crystal Palace, when he gave vent to the freest criticism on books, artists, philosophy, science, and the methods of teaching, and deplored the waste of

time to students of making large chalk studies, when everything that was wanted could be shown on a sheet of smooth paper, seven inches high, with a hard pencil. He was a great admirer of Boxall and his delicate painting, of Mr. Watts' and Sir E. Burne-Jones' work, and persuaded the last two to join the Royal Academy. In 1864 he was made an A.R.A., and after this he became very cautious of expressing any but the most general opinions on contemporary English art, as his remarks generally got into the papers."

"Eucharis," 1863; "Dante at Verona," and "Golden Hours," 1864, are three works which might be placed in the first rank of Leighton's achievements. In the following letters references are made to the pictures:—

April 29, 1863.

DEAR MAMMY,—I have just been to the R.A., having been invited to the "Varnishing Day." *Four* pictures are hung—"Elijah," *high*, of course, but in a centre place; it looks well, but *much* darker than in the studio. "Peacock Girl,"^[33] very well hung, exactly where "The Vision" was a few years ago; it looks well. "The Crossbowman" and "The Girl with the Fruit"^[34] are fairly hung, but look, to me, less well than in the studio. The "Salome"^[35] is the one not taken. Altogether I am well treated.

In the following letters from Ruskin his interest is expressed in the pictures exhibited in the Academy of 1863, and for the "Romola" illustrations:—

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I've only just had time to look in, yesterday, at R. Ac., and your pictures are the only ones that interest me in it; and the two pretty ones, peacocks and basket, interest me much. Ahab I don't much like. You know you, like all people good for anything in this age and country (as far as Palmerston), are still a boy—and a boy can't paint Elijah. But the pretty girls are very nice—very *nearly* beautiful. I can't say more, can I? If once they *were* beautiful, they would be immortal too. But if I don't pitch into you when I get hold of you again for not drawing your Canephora's basket as well as her head and hair! You got out of the scrape about

the circle of it by saying you wanted it hung out of sight (which *I* don't). But the meshes are all wrong—*inelegantly* wrong—which is unpardonable. I believe a Japanese would have done it better. Thanks for nice book on Japan with my name Japanned. *It* is very nice too. I wish the woodcuts were bigger. I should like it so much better in a little octavo with big woodcuts on every other page. But I never do anything but grumble.—Faithfully yours,

J. RUSKIN.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—The public voice respecting the lecture you are calumniously charged with, is as wise as usual. The lecture is an excellent and most interesting one, and I am very sorry it is not yours.

I am also very sorry the basket is yours, in spite of the very pretty theory of accessories. It is proper that an accessory be slightly—sometimes even, in a measure, badly—painted, but not that it should be out of perspective; and in the greatest men, their enjoyment and power animated the very dust under the feet of their figures—much more the baskets on their heads: above all things, what comes near a head should be studied in every line.

There is nothing more notable to my mind in the minor tricks of the great Venetians than the exquisite perspective of bandeaux, braids, garlands, jewels, flowers, or anything else which aids the *roundings* of their heads.

It is my turn to claim Browning for you, though I know what your morning time is to you. I must have you over here one of these summer mornings, if it be but to look at some dashes in sepia by Reynolds, and a couple of mackerel by Turner—which, being principals instead of accessories, I hope you will permit to be well done, though they're not as pretty as peacocks.

I have been watching the "Romola" plates with interest. The one of the mad old man with dagger seemed to me a marvellous study (of its kind), and I feel the advancing power in all.

Will you tell me any day you could come—any hour—and I'll try for Browning.—Ever faithfully yours,

J. RUSKIN.

I'm always wickeder in the morning than at night, because I'm fresh; so I'll try, this morning, to relieve your mind about the peacocks. To my sorrow, I know more of peacocks than girls, as you know more of girls than peacocks—and I assure you solemnly the fowls are quite as unsatisfactory to me as the girl can possibly be to you; so unsatisfactory, that if I could have painted them as well as you could, and *had* painted them as ill, I should have painted them out.[\[36\]](#)

Monday.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I saw Browning last night; and he said he couldn't come till Thursday week: but do you think it would put you quite off your work if you came out here early on Friday and I drove you into Kensington as soon as you liked? We have enough to say and look at, surely, for two mornings—one by ourselves?

I want, seriously, for one thing to quit you of one impression respecting me. You are quite right—"ten times right"—in saying I never focus criticism. Was there ever criticism worth adjustment? The light is so ugly, it deserves no lens, and I never use one. But you never, on the other hand, have observed sufficiently that in such rough focussing as I give it, I measure faults not by their greatness, but their avoidableness. A man's great faults are natural to him—inevitable; if *very* great—undemonstrable, deep in the innermost of things. I never or rarely speak of them. They must be forgiven, or the picture left. But a common fault in perspective is not to be so passed by. You may not tell your friend, but with deepest reserve, your thoughts of the conduct of his life, but you tell him, if he has an ugly coat, to change his tailor, without fear of his answering that you don't focus your criticism. Now it so happens that I am in deep puzzlement and thought about some conditions of your work and its way, which, owing to my ignorance of many things in figure painting, are not likely to come to any good or speakable

conclusion. But it would be partly presumptuous and partly vain to talk of these; hence that silence you spoke of when I saw you last. I wish I had kept it all my life, and learned, in place, to do the little I could have done, and enjoy the much I might have enjoyed.—Ever faithfully yours,

J. RUSKIN.

Send me a line saying if you will give me the Friday morning, and fix your own hour for breakfast to be ready; and never mind if you are late, for I can't give you pretty things that spoil for waiting, anyhow.

Leighton writes to his mother:—

I had a kind note this morning from Ruskin, in which, after criticising two or three things, he speaks very warmly of other points in my work and of the development of what he calls "enormous power and sense of beauty." I quote this for what it is worth, because I know it will give you pleasure, but I have NOT and *never shall have* "enormous power," though I have some "sense of beauty." The "Orpheus" and "Golden Hours" are not in the *great* room but in the next to it. I have not seen Gambart lately, and do not, therefore, know whether he has got rid of any more of my pictures (by-the-bye, I have sent the "duet"—"Johnny"—to America to an Exhibition for the Sanitary Commission, on the request of Mrs. Kemble's daughter). He will, *I think*, engrave the "Honeymoon," but probably only photograph the others; by-the-bye (again), Mammy, tell Gussy with my love that I shall present her with a copy of each and shall not "*think her greedy*," having no thoughts for her but affectionate ones. With regard to the money paid me by Gambart, I invested as soon as I got it £1000 in Eastern Counties Railway *debentures*, at par, 4½ per cent., this on the advance of Coutts' stock clerk. Lord Ashburton's portrait was scarcely begun.^[37] I have offered to try to finish *tant bien que mal* from photographs, and to *give* it to Lady A. She is very grateful. The child's picture also goes to the wall, as she won't be able to sit for some time, and would then be *changed*. Lady A. wanted to pay the

price of the sketch as it stood; this I of course refused. She has commissioned me to paint her a fancy picture for £300.

Leighton was for five years an Associate before being elected a full member of the Royal Academy in 1869. During these years the number of important pictures he exhibited each season notably increased. In at least twelve of these works the many-sided Leighton is worthily represented—"Dante at Verona,"^[38] "Golden Hours," "David," "Syracusan Bride" (exhibited at the Royal Academy in 1866 and in the Paris International Exhibition in 1868), "Helen of Troy,"^[39] "Greek Girl Dancing," "Venus Disrobing from the Bath," "Ariadne Abandoned by Theseus, Ariadne Watches for his Return, Artemis Releases Her by Death," "Actæa, the Nymph of the Shore," "Dædalus and Icarus," "Electra at the Tomb of Agamemnon," "Helios and Rhodos." The extreme variety from every point of view which exists in this group of twelve pictures, chosen from the twenty-six paintings and the numerous sketches executed in these five years, would be a proof in itself, if one were needed, of Leighton's extraordinary versatility as regards the *motives* of his pictures.



"GREEK GIRL DANCING." 1867
By permission of Mr. Phillipson[ToList](#)



DRAWING FOR THE PAINTING "A PASTORAL." 1866
Leighton House Collection[ToList](#)

In the spring of 1865, after years of delicate health, Mrs. Leighton at the last died suddenly, at her home in Bath. At the time Leighton was staying at Sandringham where he received a telegram announcing her death, and on the same day he joined his family at Bath. It has been said that, as long as a man is blessed by possessing a mother, he still retains the blessing of being—in the eyes of one person at least—a child. To Leighton's tender-hearted nature this blessing was a very real one, as is testified by his correspondence with his mother.^[40] The first chapter of Leighton's life seems, in a sense, only to end with this great sorrow.

Translation.]

FRANKFURT AM MAIN,
April 30, 1865.

DEAREST FRIEND,—As your last friendly lines of 14th March did not bring your address, I grasp the opportunity offered me by Mr. Tobie André to express to you my heartfelt sympathy on the loss of your dear mother. I remember that you often spoke to me of this mother with true filial affection, and I have secretly blessed you for it; I know now also that you will treasure her memory!—Always, your truly devoted,

STEINLE.

FOOTNOTES:

[26] See [Appendix](#), "Lord Leighton's Sketches."

[27] See [page 59, vol. ii.](#), poem, Leighton's "Francesca di Rimini," by R.A.

[28] Head painted on the wall of the Vestry of Highnam Church—since destroyed.

[29] "Eucharis."

[30] Sir Hubert Parry writes: "I remember Leighton made a practical test of my father's medium by painting a fine dashing sketch of a head on the wall of the Vestry at Highnam Church. I used to admire it greatly. Unfortunately that Vestry was pulled down; and though efforts were made to preserve the sketch by cutting a great piece of plaster out of the wall, I understand that during the many years when I was hardly ever at Highnam, the plaster crumbled and collapsed." See letter to Steinle.

[31] Photographs of the Lyndhurst fresco.

[32] The ground on which Leighton built his house, 2 Holland Park Road, now preserved for the public.

[33] "Girl feeding Peacocks" (see sketches in Leighton House Collection). Leighton painted a small and exquisite water-colour on ivory of the picture, which was sold at Christie's after his death.

[34] "Eucharis."

[35] See [List of Illustrations](#): reproduction from sketch in Leighton House.

Mr. Frith, R.A., wrote the following respecting the rejection of "Salome":—

10 PEMBRIDGE VILLAS, BAYSWATER, W.,
April 29, 1863.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—We have been unable to hang one of your best pictures—not because it was an excellent work, as the profane world would say—but because we had already placed so many of your pictures that the space due to Leighton was more than exhausted. M.C. Mortlake called us over the coals dreadfully on your behalf, but I, for one, resisted his arguments, and I believe you have to blame me for your picture being returned to you. I should have said nothing about the matter, but for the fear that I might be thought so stupid as not to see the merit of your work. Pray believe that my motive was a good one, and that I have tried to do what is right to you and to the rest.—Ever, dear Leighton, faithfully yours,

W.P. FRITH.

[36] Ruskin would not, I believe, have spoken thus of the peacocks in the exquisite water-colour on ivory—presumably a sketch in colour for the picture.

[37] Refers to Lord Ashburton's death.

[38] This picture illustrates the verses in the *Paradiso*:—

"Thou shalt prove
How salt the savour is of others' bread;
How hard the passage, to descend and climb
By others' stairs. But that shall gall thee most
Will be the worthless and vile company
With whom thou must be thrown into the straits,
For all ungrateful, impious all and mad
Shall turn against thee."

"Dante, in fulfilment of this prophecy, is seen descending the palace stairs of the Can Grande, at Verona, during his exile. He is dressed in sober grey and drab clothes, and contrasts strongly in his ascetic and suffering aspect with the gay revellers about him. The people are preparing for a festival, and splendidly and fantastically robed, some bringing wreaths of flowers. Bowing with mock reverence, a jester gibes at Dante. An indolent sentinel is seated at the porch, and looks on unconcernedly, his spear lying across his breast. A young man, probably acquainted with the writings of Dante, sympathises with him. In the centre and just before the feet of Dante, is a beautiful child, brilliantly dressed and crowned with flowers, and dragging along the floor a garland of bay leaves and flowers, while looking earnestly and innocently in the poet's face. Next come a pair of lovers, the lady looking at Dante with attention, the man heedless. The last wears a vest embroidered with eyes like those in a peacock's tail. A priest and a noble descend the stairs behind, jeering at Dante."—*Athenæum*, April 1864.

The following expresses the admiration of a brother artist, Richard Doyle, for the exiled "Dante":—

54 CLIFTON GARDENS, MAIDA HILL,
April 5, 1864.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I feel so awkward whenever I attempt to praise a man's works to his face, and I felt that you, yesterday, were so likely to be bored with the repetition of similar speeches from your large influx of visitors, that at the moment of my going I could not bring myself to say what I wished to say—how much I liked your pictures. To-day, however, when "Dante" and "Orpheus," and the music and drawing parties are before my mind as vividly as they were yesterday before my eyes in your studio, I cannot resist sending you a few lines to say what pleasure my visit gave me, although I was "without words."

The "Dante" seemed to me a very impressive picture, and I think one of the most important as well as most successful of your works, historical in a higher sense than the mere representation of an event—an illustration of the man and the time. I could mention many of the figures that especially pleased me, but, for beauty, can only single out that most delightful little child in the foreground, toddling at the feet of Dante, laden with flowers, the childhood and innocence of whose whole figure and face, although we do not see the face, contrasts so beautifully with the worn, ascetic, melancholy Poet. I think these two are a poem in themselves.

The lady in the "drawing lesson" struck me as a charming figure, so graceful, and the painting of her dress as a perfect piece of work. The lady leaning over the instrument in the "music" ("Golden Hours") subject is also a great favourite of mine.

The "Orpheus," although there is a great deal to admire in it, I don't think I liked so well as the others. Perhaps it is that the classic subject does not come home to me, but I say this doubtingly, feeling that it is a picture that would very likely grow upon me.

Anyhow, I end by offering you my most hearty congratulations.—
Most sincerely yours,

RICHARD DOYLE.

[39] Referring to Leighton's painting of "Helen of Troy," exhibited in 1865, Mr. Martin Tupper wrote:—

ALBURY HOUSE, NR. GUILFORD,
May 23, 1865.

DEAR SIR,—It is just possible that the following few words of comment upon your wonderfully spiritualised "Helen of Troy" may be acceptable to you from the undersigned.

The "Helen" of Euripides is very little read amongst us, and yet it is as strangely sensational as "The Woman in White": there being two Helens

in the play, the real substantial wife remaining faithful to Menelaus in the island of Pharos, while Juno gives to Paris—out of jealous rage at him for his "judgment" in favour of Venus—"an image composed of ether" in the likeness of Helen.

This Ethereal Presence you have so exquisitely portrayed that it is probable you know the play! only that I think you would then have quoted from it in the R.A. catalogue, in explanation of what confuses some of your ignorant reviewers as to this embodied spirit.

The counterfeit Helen was of "unsubstantial air," a figure marvellously rendered in your picture, and which I can fully appreciate: and you quote a very apposite passage from Lord Derby's "Homer," as that which you illustrate; but if there are reprints of the catalogue, I would suggest the addition of a line from Euripides, as thus:—

"Juno to Paris gave me—yet not me,
But in my semblance formed a living image
Composed of ether."

Wodhall's
Eur.
Hel.

If haply you do not know the book, inquire at Longman's for the fifth volume of the Greek Tragic Theatre (in English); or, should you prefer it, of course it is extant in the Greek. If not easily attainable in London, I shall be happy to lend you the volume by post. Congratulating you on your difficult and exquisite achievement—I am, dear sir, truly yours,

MARTIN F. TUPPER.

F. LEIGHTON, Esq.

[40]

WARNFORD COTTAGE,
BISHOP'S WALTHAM.

MY DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I was very sorry indeed when I returned to Park Place on Sunday evening and found that you had been so kind as to call upon me.

I have not ventured to intrude upon you in your late affliction with the expression of a sympathy which cannot have much value for you, but had I seen you when you called I should hardly have refrained from telling you how sincerely I feel for your sorrow.—Pray believe me, yours always most truly,

FANNY KEMBLE.

WARNFORD, *Thursday, 2nd.*

FOREST BANK,
LYNDHURST.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I cannot let the post go out without offering you my sincere sympathy on your loss. I know how deeply attached you were to your mother, and am very sure the bereavement is a heavy grief to you. You are right in saying that to me your sorrow comes especially home. My mother sends you her affectionate love, and we both beg you to remember that, whenever you have a few spare days and want quiet, you must consider this home as a temporary home.—Believe me always, in all affection, yours,

HAMILTON AÏDÉ.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I must write to you to express the grief both myself and my wife felt on hearing of the loss which has befallen you. I am well aware that no words can afford consolation against such afflictions, but I should be sorry if you had construed silence into want of sympathy. If you have time I should be glad to hear from you, and to know how may be your father, from whom I have received on every occasion so much kindness. You have much distress to go through, for death has recently touched you in many ways by striking your own family, your friends, and imperilling others to a degree that must have inspired every pain it can produce.

Good-bye, my dear Leighton; remember me to your father, and express to him my deep sympathy with him in his misfortune.—Yours ever affectionately,

W.C. CARTWRIGHT.

PALAZZI GIORGI, ROME,
January 31.

13 EATON PLACE (WEST),
Tuesday, January 17, 1865.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I heard at the Marqs', on Sunday, of your late bereavement; and, as perhaps the one of all your many friends whose mind the most habitually dwells among thoughts of loss and deprivation, I can assure you of thought of it with sincere concern and sympathy, and just write a line to say so. There is nothing to be said, I well know, which is of any immediate good or alleviation, and time only strengthens affectionate recollection: but after a time, among gentler thoughts which will come, I hope you will, as you may justly, find comfort in thinking that your mother's life was spared so as to permit her to be cheered by the certainty of your success. This is much—especially to a woman's heart.—Faithfully and sincerely yours,

HENRY J. CHORLEY.

CHAPTER III [ToC](#)

JOURNEYS TO THE EAST—CONSTANTINOPLE—SMYRNA— ATHENS—DIARY "UP THE NILE TO PHYLÆ"

1866-1869

Leighton visited Spain in 1866. There exists apparently no letters or written record of this journey, but he made many sketches remarkable for strong and characteristic colouring.

The letter written to Mrs. Mark Pattison in 1879, already quoted, contains an amusing endeavour on Leighton's part to date the various journeys he had made in answer to questions she had asked.

"I am sorely perplexed to answer this; I can only approach an answer by a sort of *memoria technica*. I made studies in Algiers for 'Samson Agonistes'; that will give you roughly the period. This visit made a deep impression on me; I have loved 'the East,' as it is called, ever since. By-the-bye, I drew here my (almost) only large water-colour drawing, 'A Negro Festival' [the picture Leighton alluded to as 'The Niggers'], which was thought very well of by my friends. To Spain (into which I had made a raid of a few days on a previous occasion when visiting the South of France for architecture, to which I am much devoted) I went the year of the cholera. I remember this because I was going to Constantinople, but was dissuaded by a friend there because of the ravages of that epidemic. The following year I *did* go: Vienna, Danube, Varna, Constantinople, Broussa, Smyrna, Rhodes, Athens (the greatest

architectural emotion of my life, by far), &c. This was the year *before* those poor young Englishmen were murdered on Pentelicus, up which I had been with *the same* guide. My visit to Egypt, and up the Nile on a steamer, given me by the Khedive, was a year before the opening of the Suez Canal; I rode over the Salt Lakes with Mons. de Lesseps and a party of his friends. Damascus a year before I exhibited the 'Jew's House,' I *think*. Spain, revisited, and Morocco, the year before last. This is a roundabout way of getting about dates, but, contrary to my expectation, I think I have contrived to fix all the chief journeys approximately."

In 1867 Leighton wrote to his father:—

LLOYD STEAMER "ADRIATIC,"
November 28, 1867.

MY DEAR PAPA,—As I am likely to be busy during my very short stay in Venice, where I hope to find a letter from you, I take advantage of the leisure which I find in excess on board this steamer to begin an epistle which, however, I shall not close till I have seen yours, in case anything in the latter should require an answer. Of course my getting to the end of even this first page depends upon the state of my feelings—physical, not moral, for I am a poor sailor at best. I told you, I believe, in my last how much I had enjoyed and, as I hope, profited by my stay in Rhodes and Lindos. I am uncertain whether I added that I had received great kindness and attention from our consul and his brothers, and also from one or two other gentlemen with whom I became acquainted. Through the assistance of Mr. Biliotti (our consul) I had an opportunity, which could never present itself again, of buying a number of beautiful specimens of old Persian *faience* (Lindos ware), chiefly plates, which will make a delightful addition to my collection of Eastern china and pottery. I know that you, personally, care little for such things, and have small sympathy with purchases of that nature; you will, therefore, be glad to hear that though I spent a considerable sum, knowing that such a chance would never again be given me, I could, *any day*, part with the whole lot for at least double—probably treble—what I gave.

The weather, which was very beautiful at the beginning—indeed during the greater part of my stay in the Island—was not faithful to me to the end; it broke up a few days before my departure, and, to my very great regret, prevented my painting certain studies which I was very anxious to take home: on the other hand, I had opportunities of studying effects of a different nature, so that I can hardly call myself much the loser as far as my work in Rhodes was concerned. In Athens, however, the effect of the absolute instability of the weather (an instability of which I have never seen the like anywhere) was that I left that place almost empty-handed, although I stayed there a week longer than I had originally intended. If, however, I got through little or no work, I had infinite enjoyment in the frequent and unvaried study and contemplation of the ruins on the Acropolis. Familiar as I was, from casts and photographs, with the sculptures and some part of the architecture which I found there, my expectations were very highly wrought, but it is impossible to anticipate, nor shall I attempt to describe, the impression which these magnificent works produce when seen together and under their own sky. Indeed, it is quite strange how one seems to read with new eyes things which one conceived oneself to have understood thoroughly before. The scenery about Athens, depending a good deal on effects of light, only rarely displayed its full beauty during my stay; sufficiently often, however, for me to see that it is of exquisite beauty, and that that part of it described by Byron in certain favourite lines of yours does not receive full justice at his hands. I had letters, as you probably knew, to Mr. Erskine, our Minister, and to Mr. Finlay, the historian; both of them received me with the greatest cordiality and kindness, as did also two or three other persons with whom I became acquainted, so that my stay was socially agreeable as well as artistically delightful; but herewith ends my journey, for heavy weather, rain, sleet, fog and the rest prevented my seeing any of the scenery of the Gulf of Lepanto, which I might as well not have visited, and although I passed Zante, Cephalonia, and Corfu under rather more favourable skies, I did not see them to advantage—*ce sera pour une autrefois*. Your letter, which I have found on my arrival, and for which thanks, does not call for any particular reply beyond that I have painted *no* figures,

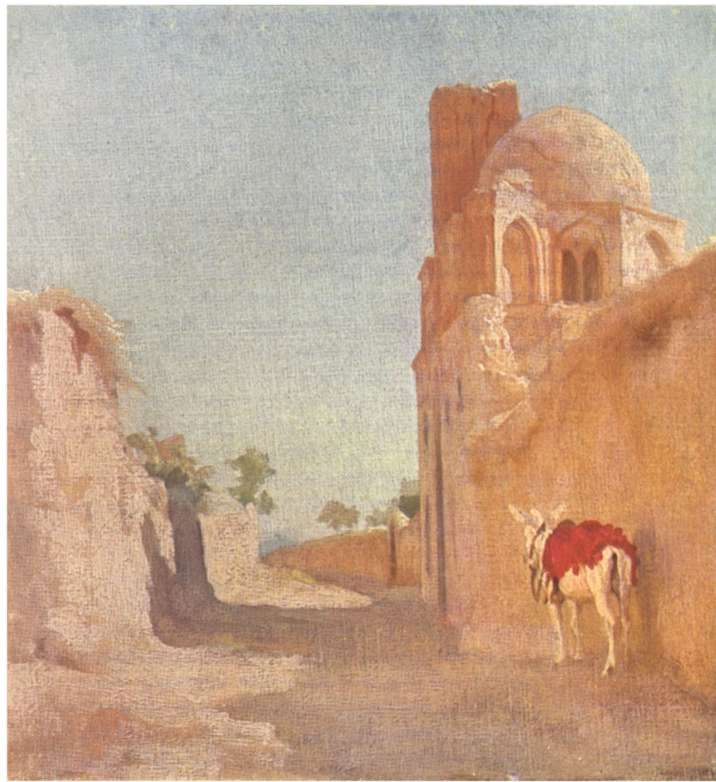
though I might have been tempted by several fine heads I saw, but time only sufficed for my landscape studies, which in this journey were my chief care. The extract from the *Saturday Review*, which is highly flattering, was shown me by Mr. Finlay in Athens.

Of Venice I have nothing to say, except that my first impression of the Gallery, coming as I did straight from the Parthenon, was that everything but the very *finest* pictures was wanting in dignity and beauty, and was *artificial*. I was much surprised myself, as the Venetian school always exercises a great fascination over me. You may infer from that what an impression of beauty Athenian Art has left on me. I was incessantly reminded, in looking both at the sculpture and architecture of the Acropolis, of the admirable words which Thucydides puts into the mouth of Pericles: those are the beginning and the end of the Greek artistic nature.

I shall be in London by the 10th, and right glad to get home again—meanwhile, with best love to Taily.—I remain, your affectionate son,

FRED.

VENICE, HOTEL DE L'EUROPE.



SKETCH WITH DONKEY. EGYPT. 1868[ToList](#)

Respecting the knowledge Leighton possessed of the Greek language, he wrote in a letter to a friend, "In Greek I never got beyond Homer and Anacreon. I have just retained this, that, having read a passage in a translation (I generally read Homer in *German* or *Latin*), I am able to feel, on referring to the original, its superiority to the foreign rendering."

In 1868 the great desire which Leighton for many years had felt to see Egypt was gratified. In October of that year he wrote to his father from Cairo:—

Beginning of letter missing.]

I find that the Prince (the Prince of Wales) asked him in the said letter to introduce me as a personal friend of his to the Viceroy, adding that he would be obliged by anything he (Col. Stanton) could do for me. This was more than I had expected from what Col. Tait also had written me. Well, to make a long story short, I

communicated to Col. S. the ambitious desires that Smart had stirred up in me, assuring him, however, that I should never have dreamt of entertaining them of my own accord. He took my case in hand at once, by asking for an audience, which the Viceroy granted as soon as he should have returned to Cairo; he was too busy to see me at Alexandria. Meanwhile Col. Stanton hinted to the secretary of H.H. what my wish was, but nothing was said to the Viceroy himself. Wednesday being fixed for my reception, I went to his palace of Abbassia with Col. S., and was there received in a pavilion in the open air, which overlooked a tract of country covered with tents in which some 5000 men were quartered. Round His Highness' pavilion were the tents of his chief ministers in attendance. It was rather a picturesque sight. The Viceroy was alone, and, having received us very courteously, and asked after the health of the P. and Pcess. of Wales, made us sit down. He then clapped his hands, and on a word from him long *tchibouques* were brought, of which the amber mouthpieces were enriched with enormous diamonds and emeralds. A little conversation on general matters then followed between him and Col. S., after which he questioned me about my projects; and after asking whether he could assist me, and Col. S. throwing out a little hint about a steam tug to get me on quicker, he said, "Would you not rather have a steamer to go in? it is the same to me, and you will be more comfortable." Here Col. Stanton, very judiciously and promptly, said he was sure the P. of Wales would be much gratified by this mark of favour to me; so that I have only to name the day, and the vessel will be at my orders, and I shall do all I wish in *half the time*, or less, it would otherwise have taken me. I bowed myself out with my best thanks, and went home much pleased at my good fortune and at everybody's kindness. I should not forget to say also that Mr. Ross (Lady Duff Gordon's son-in-law, you know) was full of *empressement* and kindness to me, and Lady D.G. lent me a gun for the Nile. I start in ten days or thereabouts, and hope before that to hear from you, for no letters will follow me and I shall lose sight of everybody for nearly two months. I will write again before I start; meanwhile, when you write which it will be no use your doing till *November*, address, please New Hotel, Cairo, Egypt.

And believe me, meanwhile, with best love to Taily, your affte. son,

FRED.

Happily, while Leighton lost sight "of everybody for nearly two months," he kept the following diary:—

Wednesday, October 14, 1868.—Went on board, dined and slept.

Thursday, 15th.—Started at about 7 A.M. There had been a storm in the night, and the east was still heavy with clouds; but the western sky was pure and soft.

At about ten caught up the Sterlings, becalmed in their dahabyeh; their crew was making a futile attempt to tow them against the current. I let out a rope and tugged them as far as Benisoëf, which, owing to the additional weight, I did not reach till Friday morning (16th).

The first day's journey up the Nile is enchanting, and I enjoyed it thoroughly. The sky was bright, but tempered by a glimmering haze which produced the loveliest effects; those of the early morning were the most striking. The course of the river being nearly due north, the western bank was glowing in varied sunny lights; the other seemed made up of shadowy veils of gauze fainting gradually towards the horizon. The boats that passed on the left, dark in the blaze of light, looked, with their outspread wings, like large moths of dusky brown; those on the right shone against the violet sky like gilded ivory. The keynote of this landscape is a soft, variant, fawn-coloured brown, than which nothing could take more gratefully the warm glow of sunlight or the cool purple mystery of shadow; the latter perhaps especially, deep and powerful near the eye (the local brown slightly overruling the violet), but fading as it receded into tints exquisitely vague, and so faint that they seem rather to belong to the sky than to the earth. At this time of year the broad coffee-coloured sweep of the river is bordered on either side by a fillet of green of the most extraordinary vivacity, but redeemed from any hint of crudity by the golden light which inundates it. The brightest

green is that of the Indian corn—the softest and most luminous that of an exquisite grass, tall as pampas (perhaps it *is* a kind of pampas, I have not seen it close yet), and like it crowned with a beautiful plume-like blossom of the most delicate hue; seen against a dark shady bank, and with the sun shining through it, it shimmers with the sheen of gossamer.

Frequent villages animate the river's edge; they are built of unbaked bricks coated with mud, and have a most striking effect. The simplicity and variety of the shapes of the houses, with their slightly sloping sides and flat roofs, give them a certain dignity in their picturesqueness which delights me; the colour, too, is particularly agreeable, and is the most beautiful foil to the bronze-brown of the naked, or nearly naked, fellaheen and the indigo of the robes of their wives; to the sparkling white of the doves that swarm in the gardens, and to the cinder-colour of the buffaloes that wink and snoot along the bank. Every village nestles in a dense grove of date-palms, and one cannot conceive a lovelier harmony than that which is made by the combination of the browns below with the sea-green of the sweeping branches and the flame-like orange of the fruit. The acacia (here a large, massive tree, with a vigorous dark green foliage) is frequent in the villages.

The shape of the hills and mountains is very peculiar and striking. It gives the idea of a choppy sea of sand thrown up into abrupt peaks and then uniformly truncated by a sweep of a vast scythe, sweeping everything from horizon to horizon. Here and there a little peak, too low to be embraced in the general decapitation, raises its head amongst innumerable table-lands and gives great value and relief to the general outline.

Meanwhile an occasional train and not infrequent lines of telegraph poles don't add to the poetry of the scene.

Nor the flies to one's comfort! What a curse they are! they *infest* one's face. I wonder what the epiderm of Egyptian children is made of; you see babies with a dozen flies settled, no, stuck, embedded in and round each of their eyes, and as many in and about their noses

and mouths; and they make no attempt to remove them—seem absolutely unconscious of them.

Scenery this afternoon less interesting—river wider—banks more monotonous.

Opposite a place called Magaga, some fine mountains on the east bank, scored with innumerable horizontal lines marking the monotonous parallel strata of which they are composed; a characteristic peculiarity in all the Egyptian hills I have seen as yet. (The finest in outline are the Quarries opposite Sakkara, on the right bank, and like those behind the Citadel at Cairo.)

Spent the night at a village called Kolosana, not having made Minyeh owing to delay at Benisoëf, where we coaled, and took leave of the Sterlings, with whom I breakfasted. The sunset before reaching Kolosana was magnificent, like a sunset at sea; almost as grand in its simplicity. Between the broad flaming sky and the broad flaming river there was only a long narrow strip of dark bronze-green bank, that seemed to burst into flame where the almost white hot sun sank scowling behind it. The after-glow was also very fine, though less grand than I should have expected. The sky was of a deep violet, and the distant rolling sand-tracks wore the most mysterious tints, faint, glimmering, uncanny, vague fawn colours, pale dun browns, and ghostly pinks.

Saturday, 17th.—Started at dawn, and arrived at Minyeh about eight o'clock.

Stayed two hours and coaled.

Obeying the custom of the country, I have presented the crew with a sheep—great satisfaction.

Took a stroll in the Bazaars, which are rather picturesque. Minyeh is a largish place (*chef lieu*), and, like every second village on the Nile, disfigured by the tall chimneys of sugar factories.

There is a striking line of hills opposite Minyeh, quaintly jagged in outline and curiously regular in the marking of its strata.

Passed Beni Hassan, where I shall stop on my return.

It is curious to see the incessant toiling of the natives at irrigation. The poor people literally *make* their country every year, and it is marvellous to see how a narrow fillet of water will, as by enchantment, conjure up in a few weeks an oasis out of an arid desert. The land of Egypt is born afresh out of the Nile every returning year.

I observe, with pleasure, in this part of the country those little white-domed tombs of Sheykhs which make such a pretty feature in the landscape of Algeria.

At Minyeh there is one, close to the riverside, in which rests the "Sheikh of the Crocodiles" whose holy dust prevents those man-eating ornaments of the Upper Nile from going any further towards Cairo—below this tomb they never venture.

Not having reached Manfalût by sunset, we have drawn up for the night by the bank of the river, nowhere in particular. This entire freedom in our movements (I should say *mine*, for the steamer stops exactly where, when, and as often as I choose) is very agreeable. Less pleasant is the storm of flies and insects of every kind, that rush in literally by myriads as soon as candles are lighted within reach of shore; my tablecloth is darkened with thousands of little flies no larger, wings and all, than a moderate flea; the nuisance is intolerable.

A wonderful sunset again this evening. The western bank like yesterday was low and brown and green, but, unlike yesterday, it was alive with the sweet clamour of many birds. On the eastern side the long wall of rock which seems to enclose the whole length of the valley of the Nile came flush, or almost flush, to the water's edge; and with what an intense glory it glowed! The great hills seemed clad in burnished armour of gold fringed and girt below with green and dark purple; but the smooth face of the water was like copper, burnished and inlaid with sapphire.

I sat in the long gloaming enjoying the soft, warm, supple air, and watching the tints gradually change and die round the sweep of the horizon, and across the immense mirror of the Nile as broad as a lake. It was enchanting to watch the subtle gradations by which the

tawny orange trees that glowed like embers in the west, passed through strange golden browns to uncertain gloomy violet, and finally to the hot indigo of the eastern sky where some lingering after-glow still flushed the dusky hills; and still more enchanting to watch the same tones on the unruffled expanse of the water, slightly tempered by its colour and subdued to greater mystery. A solemn peace was over everything. Occasionally a boat drifted slowly past with outspread wings, in colour like an opal or lapis lazuli, and then vanished. It was a thing to remember.

I hear an altercation between Ottilio (my Italian waiter) and a stoker who has put down his grease can on one of the Pasha's smartest plates. "O—(adjective)—Madonna! se si può vedere una carogua simile! e se me la rompi pas? costa più di te—sa!"

My young dragoman having fastened a hook to a bit of string, and the bit of string to the stern of the steamer, has been waiting some hours for a fish. After the first hour he reasoned with himself, and said: "Brabs (perhaps?) he know!"—then, dolefully, "He come touch the 'ook, and then he go run away!"—*cela c'est vu*. Tomorrow to Asyoot. 10½ P.M. Just been on deck again. Dragoman still fishing! He says, "I tink he *won't*." I incline to agree with him.

Sunday, 18th.—Started about six. Reached Syoot, or rather El Hamza for Syoot, which is a mile inland, at eleven. Between Manfalût and Syoot the Nile takes an immense sweep west, and assumes altogether a tortuous course; the plain opens out, the eastern mountains recede, and for the first time an important chain closes in on the west. Game is already beginning to be abundant. I saw a sandbank full of pelicans and geese just below this place. I wish I could get at the names of the small birds I see here, which are mostly new to me; an Arab invariably answers your questions on this subject by the word "asfoor," *i.e.* a bird—thankee! The peasants here all wear a loose dark brown robe like that of a Franciscan monk; and as they squat fishing on the brown bank of the river with their skull-caps and black beards, I fancy I see the monks of the Thebaïd coming, as in old days, to get their daily meat out of the Nile.

Irrigation seems to go on more actively even than lower down; I saw to-day no less than twenty-four shadoofs all in a row, and in full play. The men that worked them, mostly naked, were of every colour between a new halfpenny and an old shoe, and the effect of them all toiling away and surrounded by groups of squatting onlookers was very striking.

Hossey, my servant, the angler, is having his head shaved on deck; when he has done I shall visit the town.

Meanwhile I have had a visit from the government doctor, a rather intelligent man who made his studies in Pisa.

Pipes and coffee as usual.

Here comes Hossey clean-shaven. He is a nice boy, eager and willing—but wants varnish; he can never address me without scratching his spine at its lowest extremity; Audrey herself could not have done it in a manner more naïvely unconventional. Though only twenty, he has had two wives; not liking the first, who snubbed his relations, he gave her three months' wages and dismissed her. To avoid further unpleasantness he then married his cousin: "She good woman—very quiet—good tongue."

The village at which we have landed is very picturesque. The mud and brick architecture is here carried out with some care and is entirely delightful. The walls are mostly crowned with an openwork finish made by a simple arrangement of the bricks which is most effective. Sometimes, as, for instance, in the cemetery, they are surmounted by crenulations like those we see in the old Assyrian monuments; the heads of the doorways are decorated with a charming sort of diapered ornament, capable of great variety and produced entirely by the arrangement in patterns of the bricks; the patterns being painted black and the ground filled in with white. The woodwork in the windows is also very pretty, and altogether the general aspect of the houses most novel and striking.

Beyond the village I wandered into a delightful garden; a half cultivated wilderness of palm and gum trees in which one came on unexpected pergolas, and lovely garden trees all pouring out their

most intoxicating scents under the fiercest sun I ever walked beneath. I saw oleanders, the flowers of which were as thick as roses and smelt like a quintessence of nectarines; there were also some beautiful olive trees with weeping branches—a thing I had never seen before—and with berries as large as plums. Overhead, amongst the yellow dates, sat doves the colour of pale violets.

Syoot itself is beautifully situated amongst groves and gardens; except in that it is brown and not white, it reminded me much of an Algerine town; it is very unlike Cairo. The rock-cut tombs in the mountain above the town are so mutilated and disfigured that little can be made of them; but they have that stamp of vastness which is so characteristic of all the ancient monuments of this country.

The view from the height is very fine. The river has barely begun to fall yet, so that everything is reflected in the great sheets of water that cover the land. At evening I saw the sunset through the tall palm trees, with the domes of Syoot dark against its flaming light.

For a fine showy assertion that looks very original and striking, but is not calculated for pedantic verification, commend me to a Frenchman. The other day, at Boulay, Mariette Bey, the creator and the curator of the Museum of that ilk, and a man of high standing as an Egyptologist, told me that the Nile was turned into its actual course by a great chain of hills at Syoot which, serving as a rampart, alone prevented it from following its obvious tendency to flow into the Red Sea. "Il allait *évidemment* se jeter dans la Mer Rouge;" in fact, but for this hill, there would have been no Lower Egypt, that country being literally the child of the Nile which alone prevents the sands of the central deserts from ruling over the whole breadth of the land. Here was a dramatic revelation of coincidences! Here was a startling suggestion of contingencies!

It fairly took your breath away! without that hill no Nile north of Syoot! half Egypt would not have been! No Memphis! Memphis with its wisdom! No Alexandria with its schools! No Cairo with its four thousand mosques! No Pharaohs! No Moses! (The poor devil of a sculptor who drowned himself in his own fountain because he found he had made *his* Moses too short might have died in his bed.)

No Cleopatra! (turn in your grave, noble dust of Antony!)—"forty centuries" would have had no Pyramids from which to look down on the conquering arms of Buonaparte. Mr. Albert Smith's popular entertainment would have been shorn of half its glories! Let me breathe! To what fantastic proportions did that hill grow as one thought of it!

Alas! then, for prosaic fact; and oh! for unimaginative maps! On consulting the latter I observed that, by the time it reached Syoot, the Nile had been flowing for nearly two hundred miles in a *north-westerly* direction, away from the Red Sea rather than towards it; and on visiting the spot I saw, oh confusion! that the hills which bore the responsibility (according to Mariette) of making the history of the world what it is, were on the *western* bank of the river!—there, at least, or nowhere, for a vast plain closes in on the east.

This evening more visitors on board—lemonade and cigars—*pour changer*; Consuls, &c. &c.—tedious.

Monday, 19th.—Left Syoot at six, and arrived at Sohag before three. Suffered a good deal in the morning from spasms of some sort, and was not in a frame of mind to appreciate the scenery. Was, moreover, driven near the verge of exasperation by the steersman (Reis Ali), who droned select passages from the Koran, *sotto voce*, within two yards of my ears from 8 A.M. till 2 P. ditto; the same four bars over and over, for ever and for ever in one unceasing guttural strain. I trust the pious exercise did more for his soul than for my temper. Hosseyn informs me that he is about to buy a lamb, and "make him big sheep." It appears that, during a serious illness three years ago, he vowed a votive sheep to Sitteh Zehneb—the granddaughter of the Prophet—on condition that he should recover. Since then he has put her off (oh, humanity!) with candles and occasional prayer; now, at last, he is going to fulfil his vow. Admire thrift combined with piety, and observe the economy on the *lamb*.

Habit is a strange thing! Hosseyn, whose manners have been corrupted by evil communication with Europeans, occasionally attempts to use a *fork* in the bosom of his family—particularly when salad is put before him. On these occasions his elder brother

invariably asks him with grim sarcasm whether he has no fingers. Hosseyn desists at once—"Brabs he beat me!—he big!"

This evening I went out shooting amongst the palms and gum trees. It was very delightful, though ferociously hot. The village is charmingly situated; the ground prettily tumbled about, and trees and houses group themselves in the most picturesque manner. (I noticed some new mouldings over the doorways that had a very artistic effect.) I can't shoot at all; but the birds are so plentiful that something is sure to cross your gun if you only fire. I got a hawk, some doves, a dozen little birds nameless for me, and two little green birds of a kind that I have not seen before; they are quite lovely; must ascertain what they are called. The sun had set when I reached the boat, and all the dark plumes of the palm trees stood clear over the black outlines of the village; above, the new moon, a keen, golden sickle.

Hosseyn has given up fishing. "Oh, oh! nasty fish! he to laugh me!"

Was much amused this morning by the device and trade-mark on a tin of jam. (Jam, if you please, of Messrs. Barnes & Co. of Little Bush Lane *and* Tooley Street.) The device was "Non sine labore"—and the trade-mark?—a beehive?—no!—the Pyramid of Cheops! *Excusez.*

Some twenty miles above Syoot, or, say, fifteen, the eastern chain of mountains makes a bend towards the river, and for some distance ranges near it; the stream, in its usual tortuous course, sometimes flowing for a few hundred yards towards them and then for a few hundred yards in the opposite direction. I wonder whether one of these bends served as a foundation, or rather as a blind, for Mariette's astounding assertion that the Nile "allait évidemment se jeter dans la Mer Rouge." Did he "to laugh me," as the fish did by Hosseyn? Or did he merely mean to say that, if the Valley of the Nile had not turned north-west between Keneh and Manfaloot, it might have turned north-east? If so, joke for joke, I prefer the great Pyramid on the jam-pot of Mr. Barnes of Little Bush Lane and Tooley Street.

Tuesday, 20th.—Started at about half-past five, and reached Disneh in the evening. There was a dead calm in the morning, and I congratulated myself, not for the first time, on my steamer; in a dahabieh I might have taken a week, and more, over the stretch of river I have just covered in a day; and the scenery just here, though fine, is monotonous. I am sorry for the Sterlings, who will, I fear, be unusually long getting up. This afternoon I saw Sheykh Selim, a sort of St. Simeon Stylites without the column. This holy man's peculiar form of piety consists in sitting stark naked on the bank of the river and exacting presents in money and kind from all passers-by.

Hosseyn had spoken to me at great length of his wisdom and piety, and assured me that when the crocodiles, which are numerous about here, presented themselves before the eyes of the Sheykh, he merely waved his hand and said "Biz, biz!" whereat they fled, rebuked. He informed me also that no boat refusing him tribute could expect to get on—it would infallibly be becalmed until his holiness was propitiated. To my surprise I found that my captain, a sensible old gentleman in other respects, believed this just as firmly, though he expressed his faith more vaguely. When I asked him whether the Sheykh's power extended also to steamers, which did not wait on the wind, he said: "Well, Allah was great, and though, certainly, a *steamer* might, no doubt—so well appointed a steamer particularly—might, no doubt, get past—yet who should say? Allah was great!" In fact he believed with the best; so, of course, I said, by all means let the Sheykh be propitiated. Accordingly when we hove in sight of the little mound where he sits, and has sat for God knows how many years, we turned the steamer (a vessel of seventy-five horse-power) and ran straight in for the bank at considerable risk, it struck me, of not getting off again. The whole crew then went ashore in great excitement, headed by the captain, and surrounded the Saint, kissing his hand and salaaming. As I did not wish to hurt the old gentleman's feelings by not kissing his hand, I stayed on board and looked on. Sheykh Selim is a very vigorous-looking old fellow of the colour of a very dusky mahogany table; his hair and beard are woolly and of a dirty white; his countenance, as far as I could judge from a little distance, good-humoured and sagacious. He squats on the ground with his knees up and his arms folded

across them. He inspects his presents, and asks for more. After the levée was over, and when our crew were about to come on board, he called after them and asked for roast meat, and then again a second time for oil wherewith to anoint himself. "There," said Hosseyn triumphantly, "he know everything! he know we have roast meat—how he know that?"

I was amused at the intellectual superiority of Ottilio, the Italian waiter. "Quanto sono stupidi questi Arabi!" For my part I don't see much more difficulty in swallowing Sheykh Selim than a stigmatised nun or a winking picture—I told him so.

We should have reached Keneh to-day, but the coals were bad, and we had to stop at Dishulh, three hours this side of that place. Where was thy favouring grace, O Sheykh? It appears that, like the gods of ancient Greece, the Sheykhs of Egypt have their little misunderstandings; I am told that on one occasion Selim, having a few words with another holy man thirty-five miles up the river, by name Sheykh Fadl, and waxing wroth, threw a stone at him (what are thirty or forty miles to a saint?) and blinded him of one eye; whereon Sheykh Fadl returned the amenity by throwing "some fire" at Sheykh Selim, thereby sorely burning him. "I have seen the scar," my coxswain informs me.

Killed another fatted sheep for the crew.

Wednesday, 21st.—Arrived at Lougsor (El Uker) about three. It was too hot for sightseeing, so I waited till evening and went out shooting in a boat; at least I went out with the idea of shooting—if possible a pelican or a crane—but the birds were too shy—I could not get within fair shooting distance; wounded a pelican, but could not get after him in the deep mud. Got belated on the river, and the crew had to pull hard for an hour and a half to reach the steamer; fortunately there was a moon. Anything more good-humoured or more ineffective than the way in which the sailors pulled and shoved, I never saw; they hopped in and out of the boat in the shallows, up to their hips in the water—pushed, tugged, rowed and sang *die era im piacus*; they can do nothing without the accompaniment of some rhythmic, droning refrain, which they can

keep up for an indefinite time. Anything will do; my fellows pulled on this occasion to the following words—

"Min Minyeh
fi Benisoef,"

which is as who should say—

"From Henlee
to Cookham *Reach*,"

giving the stroke and the emphasis on the last syllable.

In the evening was visited by Mustafa Aga, H.B.M. Consular Agent, one of his sons, the Turkish Governor (Hassan Effendi), and the local doctor. Mustafa is a very courteous old gentleman, with half a nose, and much respected by all who know him; I observed that Saïd, his son, would not smoke in his father's presence, in accordance with an Arab custom, which did not much remind me of the manner in which "the gov'nor" is treated in England.

On Thursday morning, 22nd, I started to see the tombs of the kings, leaving the eastern bank and Karnak for my return. It was a lovely morning, and I crossed the Nile before the air had had time to get thoroughly heated. On the other side I found horses, kindly lent me by Mustafa (whose son accompanied me), and donkeys for the rest of the party. There were a good many of us, and we made a very absurd-looking procession—*en tête*, a couple of fine brawny Arabs, one of whom has been the guide to these ruins since Champollion; then Saïd and I on our horses—mine a good-looking chestnut, caparisoned with scarlet finery; behind us, on their respective donkeys, the captain in full uniform holding a large umbrella over his head, Hosseyn in his Arab dress, the French cook in his official white jacket and cap, the Italian waiter with a large handkerchief over his head, and the engineer; further behind, lesser menials and the hamper. I forgot the Turkish Cawass in uniform and armed to the teeth. Hovering round, brandishing water-bottles, was a swarm of Arab boys and girls, in sizes, and of various qualities of chocolate; they were dressed in the most fantastically tattered remnants of dark

brown shirts that I ever saw; there was one little monkey of a dull ebony colour turned up with pale blue, whose form was revealed rather than covered by a few incoherent brown shreds of garment, and who was inexpressibly droll from the way in which he cocked his little head demurely on one side with a half-consciousness of insufficient drapery.

The ride to the tombs, which takes about an hour, and the latter half of which lies through an arid valley, is very striking from the form and colour of the mountains. Nothing announces that one is approaching the city of the dead, and it is not till you stand before them that you become aware of the plain square openings which lead down to these magnificent last resting-places of the kings. It was a right royal idea this, of the old rulers of Egypt, to plunge these shafts into the bowels of the rock, and give themselves a mountain for a tombstone over the palace which was their grave. The design of these houses of the dead is simple and apparently always much the same: a long corridor, sometimes with lateral galleries, sometimes with recesses or small chambers on each side, leads downwards by a not very rapid incline to a great hall, in the centre of which is the sarcophagus which contained the mummy of the king in its magnificent case; these cases have of course been all removed. All these lateral chambers were also originally filled with mummies—those, I believe, of the relations of the sovereign. The walls of these subterranean palaces and the ceilings are adorned throughout with coloured hieroglyphs and flat sculptured "graven images" representing mostly sacred and mystical scenes, but often, also, illustrating the different trades and crafts practised by the Egyptians. These paintings are of high interest from an ethnographic point of view—Poynter would have a fit over them. In the innermost places scores of bats dart about in intense alarm. The effect of the scanty light from the candles on these painted walls and on the dark bony forms of the Arabs is extremely fine—what your literary tourist would call "worthy of the pencil of Rembrandt."

After lunching in a shady spot we took an anything but shady ride to the temple-palace of Koorneh, and from thence to the Memnonium. Both are very interesting, but the latter by far the

finest; there is about it a breadth and a vastness, together with much elegance and variety, that are very impressive. Nothing that I have seen is comparable to the monuments of Egypt, for the expression of gigantic thoughts and limitless command of material and labour; withal there is about them something stolid and oppressive that is unsatisfactory; and as I looked at these vast ruins, vivid memories of Athens and its Acropolis invaded me, and the Parthenon in all its serene splendour rose before my mind; mighty, too, in its measured sobriety, stately in the noble rhythm of its forms; infinitely precious in the added glory of its sculptures; lovable as a living thing; and then more, perhaps, than ever before, I felt what a divine breath informed that marvellous Attic people, and what an ineffaceable debt of gratitude is due to them from us, blind fumblers in their footsteps.

I was less struck than I had expected to be by the two colossal statues, of one of which it was poetically fabled by the ancients that a mysterious clang rose from it as the first rays of the rising sun smote its forehead. The myth is more striking than the statues, though their size and isolation give them something impressive. I had expected them, too, I don't know why, to be in a desert, and they are in a field. How infinitely grander is the great Sphinx, with its strange, far-gazing, haunting eyes, fixed, for ever, on the East, as if expecting the dawn of a day that never comes; immovable, unchanging, without shadow of sorrow, or light of gladness, whilst the gladness of men has turned to sorrow and their thoughts to ashes before them, through three times a thousand years! Century by century the desert has been gathering and growing round it—the feet are buried, the body, the breast are hidden. How soon will the sealing sands give rest at last to those steadfast, expectant eyes?

In the evening Hosseyn had a great "fantasia" and fulfilled his vow—and spent all his money. He killed his sheep and roasted it, bought some rice and boiled it, some flour and had it made into bread; then mixing the whole, he distributed it in six very large trays; three were put before the crew, one he had placed on the wayside for all comers (and they all came); the other two were sent to the nearest mosque for the same purpose, and with similar results;

then, being unable to read himself, he paid five men to recite from the Koran at night, in the mosque, and invited thereto the captain, Mustafa Aga, and his son and several others; he, the while, sitting outside and offering coffee to whoever passed by. When it was all over he came to me radiant: "El Hamdul illah," he said, throwing up his hands, "this is good! I am happy, everybody to be satisfied! this is rich day! El Hamdul illah! my money is all gone! why shall I mind? I spend it for God! brabs something good happen for me, el Hamdul illah!" His delight at the performance of his vow and his absolute faith were the prettiest thing one could see. Talking of faith, I am much struck by the dignified simplicity with which Mahometans practise the observances of their religion; praying at the appointed times without concealment, wherever they happen to be, and as a matter of course.

Friday, 23rd.—Started early and coaled, first at Erment and then again at Esne, after which, being stopped by the night and shallow water, we anchored off a bank nowhere in particular. Heavens, what a hot day! this is indeed "the fire that quickens Nilus' slime," but has a vastly different effect on me. Sketching will be quite out of the question unless it gets rapidly cooler.

At Esne I was visited by the chief magistrate, and by the governor of the province; the former a jolly old *bonhomme* who offered me snuff, the other a very refined old gentleman with most charming manners. Both were Turks; and as they spoke no Christian tongue our conversation was carried on entirely through a dragoman; I was, however, pleased to find that I recognised several words that I learnt last year at Constantinople; I was glad, too, to hear again that fine vigorous language, the sound of which is extremely agreeable to me. Eastern manners are certainly very pleasing, and the frequent salutations, which consist in laying the hand first on the breast and then on the forehead, making at the same time a slight inclination, are graceful without servility. When an Egyptian wishes to express great respect he first lowers his hands to the level of his knees, exactly as in the days of Herodotus.

Talking of Herodotus, here is a first-rate subject for Gérôme suggested by that author; it is ethnographical and ghastly. The scene

is laid in the establishment of an ancient Egyptian embalmer and undertaker, fitted up with all the implements and appliances of the trade; in the background, but not so far as to exclude detail, groups of assistants should be shown busied over a number of corpses and illustrating all the different stages of preparation, embalsamation, swathing, &c. &c. In the centre a bereaved family have brought their lamented relative, and are selecting, from specimens submitted to them by the master undertaker, a style of treatment suited to their taste and means, and expressive of their particular shade of grief. A large assortment of mummy-cases would form appropriate accessories and give great scope for the display of knowledge and the use of a fine brush. It seems to me that so pleasing a mixture of corpses and archæology, impartially treated by that polite and accomplished hand, could not fail to create considerable sensation.

Took a stroll through Esne whilst the ship was coaling. The darker tints of skin are beginning to preponderate more and more; mummy colour is in the ascendant here, together with a fine Brunswick black. The *men*, I observe, spin in this country. The children are quite fascinating; they have nothing on but a little tuft of hair on the top of their shaven heads; those dazzling little teeth of theirs are wonderful to see, and funny—like a handful of rice in a coal-scuttle. Fine sunset again; the hills, ranged in an amphitheatre from east to west, showed a most wonderful gradation from extreme dark on one side to glowing light on the other. I make the profound reflection that no two sunsets are alike; this remark, however, does not extend to *descriptions* of sunsets—*verb. sap.*

When I saw Holman Hunt's "Isabel," his pot of basil puzzled me sorely; I had seen a great deal of basil, and have an especial love for it; but I had never seen it except with a very small leaf. I was sure, however, knowing his great accuracy, that Hunt had sufficient foundation for the large leaf he gave the plant in his picture; the very fellow of it is now before me in a nosegay of flowers, very kindly sent me by the old governor of Esne. As I smell it I am assailed by pleasant memories of Lindos—"Lindos the beautiful"—and Rhodes, and that marvellous blue coast across the seas, that looks as if it could enclose nothing behind its crested rocks but the

Gardens of the Hesperides; and I remember those gentle, courteous Greeks of the island (so unlike their swaggering kinsfolk—if they are their kinsfolk—of the mainland), and the little nosegay, a red carnation and a fragrant sprig of basil, with which they always dismiss a guest.

As we lay anchored by the shore in the evening, the dahabiehs came sweeping past in the moonlight; and the faint glimmering of the shell-like sails, and the flutter of the water against the swift, cutting keels, and the silence of the huddled groups, and the dark watchful figure of the helmsman at the helm, were strangely fantastic and beautiful.

Saturday, 24th.—Started at half-past five—passed Edfou (which I leave for my return) at half-past seven. Shall we reach Assouan to-day? Hosseyn's pious orgies have, I fear, turned his head, for I observed yesterday that he has taken to fishing again. "Brabs!—Insha Allah!" His interpretation of dreams is worthy of the ancient oracle-mongers; on the night before his sacrifice he dreamt that he had bought a slave, and then released it: "Wull! the slave is my sheep—is it not my slave? Wull, have I not buy it? Wull, I give it to the beebles—go!—I release it!" Whether the sheep, personally, considered itself released is problematic.

Saturday Evening.—Reached Assouan this afternoon at four, and, after the usual visit from the governor, took a stroll. I don't yet know whether I am disappointed in the place or not. At all events it is quite unlike my expectations of it. I had imagined, I suppose from descriptions, a narrower gorge and higher rocks; in point of fact there is no gorge at all, but the river is narrowed, or, rather, split by several islands and some fine granite boulders cropping up here and there to fret the river, and announcing the rapids; otherwise the country is open enough, and original and striking in aspect; I shall know better to-morrow what I think of it all. I saw during my evening stroll, and for the first time in my life, a group of slaves, mostly girls. If I had seen them subjected to any ill-treatment I should have felt very indignant; but I am bound to own that, seeing them squatting round a fire like any other children, showing no mark of slavery, and occupied in cooking their food, scratching

themselves (as well, no doubt, they might!) and looking otherwise very like monkeys, I found it difficult to realise to myself the hardship of their position, however much it may revolt one in the abstract. They were black, and uglier than young negroes generally are; their hair was arranged in an infinity of minute, highly-greased plaits all round their heads; the elder ones were draped; the youngest wore a fringe *pour tout potage*. This is a noisy night; there is a "moolid" going on on the high bank to which we have made fast, and which borders the public square. A double row of howling dervishes are squatting and rocking and howling after their kind, almost over my head. In the brief lulls during which they take breath for further efforts, I hear from the other side of the river the mournful, weary, incessant creak of the water-wheel (with its blindfold cow or camel plodding round and round and round, apparently for ever), which in this region almost entirely supersedes the hand-worked bucket. The contrast is very curious.

I have just returned the governor's visit. I found him sitting on a sofa in the piazza opposite the Government House, with half-a-dozen hand lanterns brought by the guests in front of him, and on each side a long row of benches (forming an avenue up to his seat) on which squatted and smoked numbers of picturesque folk, who looked to great advantage by the flickering glimmer of the lamps and under the soft warm light of an African moon. I sat in the place of honour, smoked my conventional *tchibouque*, drank my inevitable cup of coffee, conveyed through my dragoman the usual traveller's remarks and questions (cardboard questions, so to speak, of which I knew the answers) to my host, who, like all the Turkish officials that I have seen, has the manners of a perfect gentleman and much natural dignity.

Sunday, 25th.—Started for Phylæ at half-past seven; arrived there at nine o'clock. The road leads through a broad tract of yellow sand (where, I believe, an arm of the Nile is supposed to have flowed in remote antiquity) along which on either side crop up, in wild, irregular fashion, bumps and hillocks and hills of dark red granite, covered over with innumerable fragments of the same stone, scattered in the most incredible confusion, and having rather a

ludicrous appearance of having been *left about* and forgotten. You could get an excellent notion of the thing in miniature, by hastily spilling a coal-scuttle on a gravel walk and running away.

Above Assouan we are fairly in Nubia, and of course none but the darkest complexions are to be seen; but so large a number of negroes make their way here from the Soudan (the Nubians are not *black*, but of a beautiful dark cairngorm brown), that the whole place has an air of negro-land which is disagreeable to me. The young men, indeed, both black and brown, are sometimes extremely fine fellows (bar the legs, which are never good), but the girls, as far as one can see them, are tolerably ill-favoured, and the old women, of an ugliness which passes all belief. They are *far* worse than apes. The ladies in this part of the country gladden the hearts of their admirers by anointing their bodies with castor oil, so that the atmosphere of their villages, however full of sweet suggestion to a native, is much the reverse to a traveller with a nose not attuned to these perfumes; the smell that greets you through an open door is a mixture of the bouquet just named, and a penetrating flavour of accumulated stuffed beasts, and naturally interferes much with my enjoyment.

At Mahatter we left our donkeys and took a boat to Phylæ, a quarter of a mile, which takes half an hour owing to the rapidity of the current just above the cataract. The scenery about Phylæ has been spoken of as Paradise; I never saw anything less like my notion of Paradise, and so far, therefore, I am disappointed. Original and strange it is, in a high degree. It is in fact exactly like the valley of which I spoke a little further back, only that the hills are four times as high, and water takes the place of the sand; the same breaking up of the rocks into a myriad of fragments, putting all grandeur and massiveness of form out of the question—and, with the exception of a few palm trees and a sycamore or two, the same barrenness. Looking up in the direction of Wâdy Halfâ, the mountains appear to grow finer in outline, and a tract of very yellow sand amongst their highest crests is striking and original—gold dust in a cup of lapis lazuli. With the island itself and its beautiful group of temples it is impossible not to be delighted. Nothing could be

more fantastic or more stately than the manner in which it rises out of the bosom of the river like a vast ship, surrounded as it is on all sides by a high wall sheer from the water to the level on which the temples stand. One hall in the main temple, and one only, shows still a sufficient amount of colour to give a very good idea of what the effect must have been originally; the green and blue capitals must have been very lovely. It is needless to say that here, as elsewhere, travellers have left by hundreds lasting memorials of their brutality, in the shape of names and dates drawn, painted, scratched, and cut on every wall and column, so that the eye finds no rest from them. This strange and ineffably vulgar mania is as old as the world, and the tombs of the kings at Thebes are scrawled over with inscriptions left there by ancient Greek and Roman visitors. I shall return to Phylæ shortly to make a sketch or two—*Insha Allah*.

Here, at last, I have found that absolutely clear crystalline atmosphere of which I had so often heard; I own it is not pleasing to me; a sky of burnished steel over a land of burning granite would no doubt be grand if the outlines of the granite were fine—but they are not. Meanwhile, perspective is abolished—everything is equally and obtrusively near, and I sadly miss the soft mysterious veils and pleasant doubts of distance that enchant one in other lands. I think it very likely that in winter one has great compensation from the exhilarating purity of the air; but just now the heat, which is simply infernal, is too trying for me to do justice to these advantages; no doubt the air is light and dry, but I feel unfortunately so very heavy and wet, that I am not in a position fully to appreciate it. Returning to Assouan in the evening, saw a dahabieh that had just got through the jaws of the cataracts, always rather a nervous matter; at least so they say; "to be very dyinger" (dangerous?), according to Hosseyn; the men were chanting a monotonous strain that had little of triumph in it, but rather conveyed a feeling of an always impending calamity escaped *this* time; it was melancholy and very striking, I thought, in the silence of the gloaming; very likely pure fancy on my part, for I doubt whether more than a couple of boats are lost in a season, and the sailors of the Nile must be well accustomed to the dangers of these rapids; but the impression on me at the time was very strong.

Monday, 26th.—The dragoman of the ship having a swelling of some sort on his arm, an Arab doctor was sent for, and forthwith informed him that his arm was possessed of the devil!! Went to see the island of Elephantina opposite Assouan, but saw nothing to suggest its ancient magnificence. Gave a silver farthing to a funny little child, which (the farthing) being perforated, his mother immediately tied into one of his little oily locks—an ingenious substitute for a pocket. I observed several little boys simply attired in a piece of string tied round their loins—there, Diogenes!

Tuesday, 27th.—Began sketching, but am out of form from the heat. I am working chiefly because I am weary of idleness. I don't much care for the two sketches I have begun; they will therefore probably turn out badly. Going to try another presently.

Tuesday Evening.—Have begun a sketch which interests me more than the others; it is taken amongst the tombs and shrines on the hills south of the town towards Phylæ. As my evening's work was drawing to a close, I heard a shuffling of feet a little behind me, and, turning round, saw, in the full fire of sunset, what appeared to me at first to be a procession of golden apes with dark blue robes, light blue lips, and nose-rings; on closer inspection they turned out to be Nubian women going home to their village. Hosseyn, *qui a le mot pour rire*, apparently, engaged in conversation with them, and convulsed them with laughter; the flashes of teeth were very funny to see. At last he gave them a few halfpence, and desired them to sing; whereon they set up a series of the most uncouth howls I ever heard; one baboon in particular got up and, using a flat date basket as a tambourine, accompanied her vocal performance with hops and jumps that would have done honour to any inmate of the monkey-house in the Zoological Gardens.

The twilight, walking home, was lovely. The earth was in colour like a lion's skin; the sky of a tremulous violet, fading in the zenith to a mysterious sapphire tint. "Dolce color d'oriental zaffiro."

Slew another sheep—"Allah hou akbar!" (without which formula in the killing a good Muslim must not touch the meat): this sheep is no empty formality, for the unfortunate sailors would never see meat

without it; they live on bread and occasional beans. This is the fourth night of the moolid, which is to last the whole week! At this very moment the tambourines of the dervishes are driving me nearly wild with their diabolic din.

Wednesday, 28th.—Got on indifferently with my sketches; only one of them interests me much. The morning was almost cool and really delightful, but the heat was as great as ever in the daytime. I have always been unable to see the extraordinary difference which is said to exist between the length of the twilight in the north, and in southern countries; I could have read large print to-night three-quarters of an hour after sunset. Habit is everything, no doubt, as we are reminded by Herodotus, *à propos* of a certain people who ate their dead relatives instead of burning them; but I wonder whether I should ever get accustomed to the aching, straining, creaking complaint of the water-wheel far and near, morning, noon and night, morning, noon and night; I can *just* fancy its becoming attaching as the clacking of a mill.

I have often wondered why, contrary to all analogy, the Spaniards call oil *azedo*, which at first sight appears to be the same word as the Italian *aceto*. I find that the word is Arabic: *zeyd*. Mem.: Look up the etymology of the English word *cough*, to which no European word that I remember has any affinity, and which rather appears to be onomatopœic. The Arabs say *kokh* (guttural ending); is this a mere coincidence, and does the word date beyond the Crusades? I find a good many words that have a curious likeness to English. My endeavours to pick up a little Arabic are almost entirely frustrated by Hosseyn's utter inability to pull a sentence to pieces for me. In an Arabic sentence of two words (*e.g.* *azekan tareed*—if you please) he could not tell me which word was the verb! literally; I had to find out as best I could. I never saw anything to approach his obtuseness in the matter, except perhaps that of Georgi, my dragoman in Turkey. As I was sketching this evening a Nubian passed me, very grandly draped and erect, and followed by two green monkeys that were fastened by leading-strings to his belt. They toddled very snugly after their stately master and made a queer group.

Sunday, November 1.—I am in a state of appreciative enjoyment of the comforts and civilised cleanliness of my steamer, having just returned from three or four days' roughing in the ruins of Phylæ. "Roughing" is a relative term, and my trials were of a very mild description, for though I slept *à la belle étoile* (or rather tried to sleep), at all events I had a bed to rest in, and the air at night was delightful; moreover, the commissariat was very satisfactorily managed, so that food and drink were abundant; nevertheless, I must maintain that living in an open ruin is not comfortable. I made two or three sketches, and should probably have enjoyed myself, but that on the second day I was entirely thrown off the rails by the heat whilst sketching; I thought I should get a *coup de soleil*; I was very indisposed in the evening, and utterly unable to work the next morning, so that I took the place *en grippe*, and could see nothing but the ugliness of the rocks and the wearing monotony of the hieroglyphs. Picked up in the evening, and liked the place better; made some original and striking reflections about the desirability of health.

Having heard much of the beauty of the full moon at Phylæ, timed my visit to see it, and was entirely delighted. The light was so brilliant that one could read with ease, but at the same time so soft, so rich, and so mellow that one seemed not to see the night, but to be dreaming of the day. The Arabs say of a fine night, "it is a night like milk," but there is more of amber than of milk in the nights of Phylæ. The rising of the moon last night was the first thing of the sort I ever saw; the disc was perfectly golden, not as in a mist, but set sharp and clear in the sky, and exactly like the sun, except that you could look at it without pain to the eyes. The effect of this effulgent light on the shoulder of the hill was magical. The last hour of the afternoon I spent in strolling about the villages, which are picturesque. The cottages are four brown, roofless walls, built of the usual unburnt brick, and coated with mud; but the doorways are always highly decorated with painted geometrical devices which, in the mass of plain, sober brown, have a very cheerful and artistic effect. The people, too, amuse me; a pleasant, gentle, grinning folk these Nubians seem; I like their jargon—after the guttural Arabic it sounds so soft and round, and the women have funny, cooing

inflections of voice (pretty voices, often) that are pleasing. Some of the girls are good-looking; chiefly through the brightness of their eyes and the milky whiteness of their teeth. The coiffure of the children is too funny; it consists in tufts of hair of various shapes and patterns left on an otherwise shaven head; often a crest all down the middle and a tuft on each side, exactly like the clown's wig in a pantomime; it is irresistibly droll.

A grand sight is to see the villagers keeping the birds from their crops; they all serve in their turn, men, women, and children; they stand each on a rude sort of scaffold which rises about two feet clear of the corn; they are armed with slings from which they hurl lumps of clay at the birds, uttering loud cries at the same time. Their movements are full of grandeur and character. I wonder G r me has never treated a subject so well suited to him. Why, too, has he never painted mine enemy the sakkea, which is even more emphatically in his way, for, besides the scope for fine and quaint forms both in the men and the animals that work it, the accessories are abundant and interesting, and there are ropes in great abundance.

Is the sakkea my friend or my enemy? Its chant is so incessant that I should have to make up my mind if I stayed longer in the country; it would either fascinate me or drive me mad. As I listen in the silence of the evening, the rise and fall, the shifting and swaying of the wind bring its complaint from across the gurgling river in such a fitful way that it has the strangest and most unexpected effects: sometimes I fancy I hear deep, drowsy tones of a distant organ, sometimes the shrill quavering of a bagpipe; sometimes it is like a snatch of a song, sometimes like a whole chorus of voices singing a solemn strain in the sad, empty night; sometimes, alas! too often, like a snarling, creaking door-post.

Phyl  being above the cataracts, my steamer stopped at Assouan, and I went there by donkey as before; returning, I chartered a dahabieh to see the said cataracts, of which for some days I had heard so much; amongst other things, that a ship was wrecked there three weeks ago (I saw it stuck on its rock to-day). The cowardice of the people here, at least in this particular matter, is very funny; too na f to inspire disgust: my captain, an old sailor, and the nicest old

gentleman possible, told Hosseyn that nothing would induce him to go down them; I thought I observed a shade of respectful interest in his reception of me on my return from an exploit which most English *women* would consider good fun. I make no doubt that when the water is much lower, and your dahabieh shoots a good six or eight feet drop, and goes half into the water besides, considerable excitement may be got out of it; but now that the drop is not or does not look more than about a yard, and that the whole affair consists in a few plunges and shipping a little water, the emotion is very mild, and I own to considerable disappointment, though as far as it went it was pleasant. Nevertheless I did not for a moment regret coming if only on account of the amusement I got out of the sailors and pilots; the latter were men of years; the former, fine, jolly-looking lads as one could wish to see; but their demeanour throughout was infinitely droll; they rested their feet (according to custom here) on inclined planks, up which they ran three steps with their arms well forward to fetch the stroke, getting back into the sitting position as they pulled through the water (and wonderfully fine the action looks in a large crew all pulling well together); but the contortions in which they indulged, the gnashing and grinding of teeth, the throwing back of agonised heads, the frowns, the setting of jaws, the straining of veins, the rolling of eyes, the groans, and, absurdest of all, the coming down on one another's laps and the cutting of crabs, were ineffably grotesque, and would have convulsed me with laughter if I had not controlled myself manfully. Meanwhile the pilots were howling at one another and them with all the vehemence of a violent altercation, and for no discernible reason. When they were not shrieking at one another, the crew took up the usual Arab boatmen's chant (I know no better word); one man gives out a short sentence, or name, or form of prayer (not exceeding four syllables) in a quavering treble, and the rest then repeat it in chorus in a graver key—the effect is very original. As we got within sight of the big cataract and the stranded ship, Hosseyn loudly exhorted the crew to pray to the Prophet, and all the saints who have their shrines on the heights of Assouan, to see them safely through the danger; the invitation was loudly responded to, and everybody who had not an oar to pull held up his hands and prayed with great fervour—which

was very pretty, and done with the dignified simplicity which always accompanies an Arab's devotions; but it was certainly disproportionate to the emergency. When we had danced up and down (or rather down and up) three or four times, I had the curiosity to look about for the *sailor* and waiter I had brought with me from the steamer; they were respectively green and yellow in their unfeigned terror. Then there was a nominal *small* cataract (the first one is called the *great* cataract), and indeed I believe there was a *third* little commotion; then Hosseyn, throwing up his arms, exclaimed, "El Hamdul illah!! finish!!" and it was, as he said, "finish." I am utterly ignorant of the mysteries of navigation, but one figure we executed between the cataracts and Assouan struck me as novel: it consisted in turning entirely round in a wide circle to take (as it were) a fresh start; this manœuvre we performed with much gravity and success two successive times. An elaborate salute from the guns of the dragoman and engineer, responded to with appropriate solemnity by Hosseyn, announced my return to my steamer—and, oh joy! my tub.

In the evening governor of course.

Monday, 2nd.—Resumed work; painted for a couple of hours—badly—in a high wind at an ugly study of a view I don't like. I consider it a sort of discipline. The wind to-day is tremendously high; the dahabiehs will come flying up now. I saw my friend the captain just now sitting on the bank in the midst of an interested circle having his fortune told. There is a blessing for them that wait. Hosseyn has caught a fish! two fishes, to-day! his glee is unlimited, he is radiant; when that boy is at the near end of his fishing rope, he is so absorbed I can't get him to attend to me or to answer a question. His brilliant piscatorial success is an opportune set-off against a chagrin the poor boy had this morning; he was taking a dip somewhere under the paddle-box, and lost, in putting away his clothes (*he* thinks by a black but improbable theft), a Koran with which he travels and to which he attributes much luck; he was greatly cut up, and after telling me how much he valued the book, proceeded to inform me that it contained a little piece of wood from Abyssinia with something written on it, "some, what you call,

scription," which, when worn round the neck, infallibly cured the bite of the scorpion; seeing that this announcement did not impress me as much as he had expected, he asked me with some warmth how I supposed, pray, that the snake-charmers prevented the snakes from biting them if it was not by saying something out of the Bible.

Another sheep to-day; there was some hitch about the manner of the killing which caused a little excitement; his throat was not turned to the sun (or the East?) whilst he was being slaughtered; an important matter. I observe that Turkish officials are not expected to be able to write; my captain can, but I remarked that when his secretary, a poor, wizened little thing, whose nose and trousers are far too short, but whose mouth and ears offer ample compensation through their length, brought him to-day the ship's accounts, he stamped his signature at the foot of the page instead of writing it, although he happened to have a pen in his hand; I was giving him his English lesson. Talking of accounts, the Arabs have a curious way of singing or rather intoning their sums, rocking all the while backwards and forwards like so many Dervishes. I have seen a large house of business (at Sohag) where *all* the clerks were doing it at once; it was like a madhouse. Oh, Lombard Street, and oh, Mark Lane! what would you have felt at the sight?

Tuesday, 3rd.—My last day at Assouan. Finished my sketches, took leave of the governor, and had a final stroll about the streets of the town, which seemed to me unusually picturesque. I remark that I invariably like a place best the day I leave it; if I am sorry to go, my regret casts a halo over it; if I am glad, my gladness makes everything brighter. How picturesque the people are! their flowing, flying draperies are wonderfully grand. I hope I may carry away with me some general impressions, but the immense multitude and rapid succession of striking things drive individual memories fatally out of the field. Sketching figures is out of the question—the effects are all too fugitive. This was also the last day of the moolid, and high time too; I met in the morning, in a narrow street, a procession of sailors carrying a boat, which they were about to deposit in the tomb of the sheykh in whose honour the moolid is held, and whose name they were loudly invoking. In front, drums and flags, and

cawasses firing guns; behind, in front, everywhere, a host of most paintable ragamuffins enjoying the fun; above, over the brown house-tops, dark blue figures of women huddled peering at the procession; over them a blue sky with a minaret standing against it, a palm tree; some doves—there was the picture, it was charming. The children as usual called out, "Baksheesh howaga;" the so-called begging of the people has been ludicrously exaggerated; in the first place, only the children ask for baksheesh (I mean, of course, without the pretext of a service rendered), and in the next, they treat the whole thing as an excellent joke, and evidently have seldom the slightest expectation that they are to get anything. When you approach a village, every child, from as far as it sees you, whether from a window, or a doorway, or half-way up a palm tree, or the middle of the road, holloas out lustily, "Baksheesh, baksheesh," generally with much laughter, and frequently with a universal scamper in every direction except towards you. What I call begging is that importunate whining that clings to you, and harasses you wherever you turn in the south of Italy or Spain, and with which this clamorous performance has nothing in common. I have remarked, with regard to grown-up Arabs, that though they wrangle vehemently with the dragoman on the subject of payment, they invariably show the master a pleasant and satisfied face. I speak, of course, only of my own experience. As strange a thing as a satisfied man is a *barking* fish; the fish that Hosseyn has caught of late—for Fortune is his handmaid now—all utter a sound which I can only describe as a faint bark; perhaps everybody knows that some fishes do this, but I did not, and my surprise was extreme. They are nasty-looking objects, all fins and teeth (a thick row of little bristle-like teeth). They are fat and shiny and most insipid eating.

Wednesday, 4th.—Started at six down stream; my face is turned towards bonny old England again, and I feel as if I had wings. At Kom Ombo (the first halt to-day) there are some ruins on a rock which crops up abruptly by the riverside in the midst of a flat country. The morning was divine, and the view from the temple, looking north, surpassingly lovely in colour. The form was nothing much; a vast sandy plain (tigered here and there with stripes of green), and in the distance a long low nest of mountain peaks; but

the colour!—the gradation from the fawn-coloured glimmering sands in the foreground to the faint horizon with its hem of amethyst and sapphire was as enchanting a thing, in the sweet morning light, as I have ever seen. The temple is fine though heavy, and less delicate in detail than Phylæ. On the under surface of the architrave, between the columns, are some most curious and interesting unfinished decorations, on squares marked out in red, and showing (slight sketch) such as for instance a figure tried two ways on the same spot. The outlines are drawn out, in red also, with extraordinary firmness and freedom. Speaking of the squares, Gardiner Wilkinson—in his, I am told, most erudite, and, I am certain, most dry and heavy, guide-book—says that they were used (in the manner in which "squaring off" is practised in the present day) for the purpose of transferring a design. In this, however, he is obviously mistaken, because the squares are adapted not to the pictures but to the space to be decorated; the hieroglyphs and the figures being adapted to the squares, not the squares to them: that these squares, once made the *basis* of the decoration and fixing its proportions and distribution, may then have been used also for enlarging a small design, or even, instead of tracing, for transferring one of the same size, is probable enough; but that was not their original function. In corroboration of this view, compare the frets and ornaments painted on the *back* of the architrave of the Parthenon, which I have examined closely; they are painted in squares marked out with a sharp instrument, and determining the space to be decorated exactly as at Kom Ombo. The case is so entirely parallel as to suggest the idea that the Greeks learnt the practice in Egypt. The great temple of Edfou, where we stopped next, far surpasses anything I have yet seen in Egypt; not so much, perhaps, for any especial beauty of detail—although the sculptures are extremely fine—as for its general aspect, which is superb, and its wonderful state of preservation; many parts of it look as if they had been finished yesterday. The gigantic Propylæa, and the no less gigantic wall which encloses the whole of this fortress-temple, are almost entirely intact, and make it unlike any other ruin I know. The great court, a giant cloister into which one first enters, discloses the temple itself, blocked out in vast masses of light and gulfs of shade,

and tunnelled through by a corridor which reaches to its extremest end; the absence of some portions of the roof, by letting the light play fantastically into the inner spaces, only adds to the mysterious grandeur of the effect. A broad, open peribolus runs round the temple, dividing it from the towering *mur d'enceinte* which encloses the whole building. The western part of the temple is as full of staircases, secret passages, and dark chambers as any Gothic castle. Every square inch of the whole immense fabric is covered with sculptures and hieroglyphs.

I forgot to say that I stopped between Kom Ombo and Edfou at the ancient quarries of Gebel Silsily, from which the material of the sandstone temples was mostly quarried. They are extremely striking, and have a grandeur of their own. It was curious to compare them mentally with the marble quarries of Pentelicus from which Ictinus carved the Parthenon and Pheidias the Fates.

In a tomb at El Kab are some most amusing and interesting sculptures (with the colour almost intact on them) representing the various occupations of Egyptian life, agricultural, &c. The reaping of the corn and durrah is pretty—a vintage and wine-treading pleased me vastly. Had they wine in this district?

Coming upon a magnificent view, stopped the steamer for the night; want to see it by sunrise. The absurd spurious importance my steamer confers on me in the eyes of the natives is too funny. At Edfou I found the whole place *en émoi*; horses handsomely caparisoned, a most polite governor, sheykhs, and a general profusion of salaams. It appears that the viceroy had the authorities in the different places telegraphed to be civil to me; and God knows they are. I was struck with the magnificence of the population here, the men at least; they are most stately fellows. I should like immensely to paint some of them, but for that there is no time; I can only hope that something will stick to me from this dazzling multitude of fine things. We are now again in the region of doves, whose presence in large numbers affects the architecture of the villages in a most curious manner. Every house has, or rather, *is*, a dovecot, the chief *corps de bâtiment* being a tower, or several towers, of which the whole upper part is exclusively affected to the

doves. Their sides are inclined like the sides of the propylæa of the temples, with which they harmonise amazingly well; they are divided horizontally by bands of colour which have an excellent effect, recalling strongly the marked parallel strata of the mountains. (There is no more curious study than the concord which constantly manifests itself between national (and notably domestic) architecture, and the nature in the midst of which it grows up.) The construction of these towers is both peculiar and ingenious; they are built up entirely with earthen jars, sometimes placed topsy-turvy, but most often on their sides, and tier above tier like bottles in a cellar. The exterior is then filled in with mud, and the interior presents the appearance of a honeycomb, the cells being formed by the hollow jars; in these jars the doves have their abode. It is easy to see that by turning a few of the jars *outwards* a very simple but pretty decoration may be obtained; a crest is added at the top by placing jars upside down at certain intervals; the bands of colour are generally divided by a string-course of bricks something after this fashion, but with much variety; and each of these string-courses is garnished with a perfect hedge of branches and twigs projecting horizontally a yard or more, and forming resting places for thousands of doves. Many houses have two towers, and the wealthier people have towers of great size subdivided again into small turrets; but in all cases the height of these edifices is the same, or nearly so, so that the villages received from them a very monumental look. The large towers are divided after the manner shown in the sketch. The natives also make to themselves curious pillar cupboards of mud (about man high), which from a distance have the oddest appearance; they look like raised pies on pedestals.

Thursday, 5th.—Made a little sketch from the paddle-box before starting. Then to Esne to return the visit of my amiable friend, the governor; him of the flowers. There is a temple here; a heavy-looking portico of the Roman period, coarsely executed, but with a grand, cavernous look, buried as it is in the ground which rises all round it to half the height of the columns, so that you have to descend a considerable flight of steps to get at it. At Arnout, or at least within three miles of it, are a few fragments of the Cæsarium. The portraits of Cleopatra and Cæsarion (he is always seated on her

lap), which occur here several times, would be of the greatest interest if they were not utterly conventional, and exactly like everybody else in every temple of the date. Got to Loug sor at sunset, and found no letters, no Sterlings, no Lady Duff Gordon. I trust the letters may still turn up before I go, for, if not, I shall probably lose them entirely, through my desire to get them a little earlier. In the evening dined with Mustafa Aga, and met there the American Consul-General, Mr. Hale, who had run up from Alexandria to show the Nile to a friend of his; both are agreeable men (Mr. Hale earned my warmest blessings by lending me a pile of English newspapers); there was also the Consul from Syoot with a friend of his. After dinner the dancing girls were asked in, and, presently, a buffoon who stripped to his waist and performed various antics; he was clever and a good mimic, but became terribly tedious after a short time. His performance was of the most Aristophanic coarseness. With the girls, of whom I had heard so much, I was decidedly disappointed; in the first place they were mostly ugly, one or two only were tolerably good-looking—*et encore!* Then they were clumsily built, and their dress was quite ludicrous: it consisted in a body fitting tight to the figure and four inches too long in the waist, tight sleeves, a petticoat, in shape exactly like a pen-wiper, and very full, loose trowsers (bags) down to the feet; the whole of printed calico. In front of their waists hung a sort of *breloque*, or chain, looped up at intervals in festoons, the object of which was to jingle as they moved, and to add to the effect of certain little brass *castagnette* cymbals which they held on the middle finger and thumb of either hand. A profusion of ornaments hung round their necks. Their dancing is very inferior to that of the Andalusian dancers of the same class, whose performance is full of a quaint grace and even dignity—inferior, too, to the Algerine dancing, to which that of the south of Spain more nearly approaches in character; it is monotonous in the extreme—very ugly for the most part, and remarkable only as a gymnastic feat; sleight of loins, so to speak. These are, however, no doubt, unfavourable specimens; I shall see the best of the kind in Keneh at the house of the Consul, who has come all the way here from that place to invite me thereto.

Friday, 6th.—Went to the palace and temples of Medinet Haboo, with which I was delighted beyond my expectation. What pleased me most, and was an entire surprise to me, was a bit of purely secular architecture—the remains of a royal residence, with its towers flanking the great entrance, its windows of various shapes, balconies, semicircular crenelations, outer wall; in fact, identically such a building as one sees occasionally in Egyptian sculptures, and, curiously enough, as if it were a portrait of it, on the walls of the very temple to which this palace leads. The temple, too (the large one), interested me extremely from the wonderful preservation of the coloured decoration in parts of it; one really gathers an excellent idea of the original effect, and a most brilliant and magnificent (though barbarous) effect it must have been. The columns in the great hall here are of what, for want of a better word, I shall call the "ninepin" pattern; and I think on the whole I prefer it to the bell-capped pattern; because, besides its character and massive strength, there is no suggestion in it (as in the other) of the Doric order, with which comparison is obviously dangerous. As far as I can observe, there is no trace of colour on any of the propylæa, but the pylon is always richly decorated and highly coloured. This decorative importance given to the door must have had a very striking effect, and reminds me of the same peculiarity in the dwellings of Upper Egypt.

Visited a private tomb near Medinet Haboo, which is full of the most curious paintings, many of them in excellent preservation, and representing every sort of domestic and professional occupation. They are very superior in execution and character to those of El Kab. In the evening had a dinner on board: Mr. Hale and friend, Mustafa Aga and the Syoot Consuls (one of whom does not speak a word of anything but Arabic). I had also invited Mustafa's younger son, but find that he may not sit down with his father. (He accompanied me this morning, and insisted on lunching with the servants; on the other hand, my servant is addressed as Hosseyn *Effendi*, if you please! and conversed with as a gentleman. Service appears to be looked upon in an entirely patriarchal light.) The entertainment went off successfully, and Ottilio, the Italian waiter, covered himself with glory by his excellent waiting. After dinner

Mr. Hale received a telegram to the effect that General Grant had been elected President of the United States, with Mr. Colfax as Vice. He was in great excitement and delight; we had a recrudescence of champagne, and gave the new President three cheers in British fashion. The news had come in *three days* from Washington to Thebes! it is marvellous.

Saturday, 7th.—Went to Karnak. Wilkinson advises the traveller to see this group of temples last; and wisely, for it is indeed the crowning glory of all, and must satisfy, if it does not surpass, the most sanguine expectations. The vast unfinished propylæa of the large temple prepare one by their colossal dimensions for the gigantic grandeur of the great central hall, in which one is at a loss what most to admire—the originality of the general design, combining, as it does in a surprising degree, freedom and variety with the gravest simplicity—the massive and reposeful breadth of the forms or the exquisite subtlety of the colour. The latter has of course gained very much from the blending hand of time, and is now of a most delightful mellowness, but, judging from the better preserved portions, it must have been at all times of singular beauty. It seems strange at first that a decoration consisting entirely of small blots of vivid colour on a white ground, like butterflies on a wall, can have a *large* architectural effect; but, in fact, the *repetition* over large surfaces of wall and column restores, through its monotony, the balance of breadth. The design of this hall is very curious: the great central nave, flanked on each side by two aisles of the same height as itself, but of less breadth (diminishing, roughly, in a proportion of 10, 7, 5), runs, as in a Gothic cathedral, perpendicular to the main entrance; beyond the second aisle, however, on either side, the lintels or architraves which connect the columns run at *right angles* to the nave; the effect of this arrangement must have been peculiar and striking. (Too little remains now, except the columns, to enable one to form a distinct idea.) The central nave, with the aisles immediately adjoining, rises in a clerestory thirty or forty feet above the rest of the building, and was lighted by massive square windows filled with slabs of stone (sketch), perforated vertically, and of a severe and very fine (sketch) effect. These windows fill the space between the entablature of the lateral

columns and of the roof of the clerestory, and must be some twenty to twenty-five feet high. I find it difficult to reconcile my eye to the far-fetched "asymetria" in the arrangement of the columns, the lesser ones standing in no definite relationship, on the plan, to the two central rows, neither immediately behind them nor half-way between them. How differently the Greeks managed these things! The inner row of columns at the east and west ends of the Parthenon differs also in size, height, and level from the outer row, and also stands back; but it is only *one row* at each end; so that variety and play of form are obtained without a repeated jar on the eye; and an otherwise uniform rectangular plan is not gratuitously distorted. In a very ancient temple beyond and behind that of the great hall are some curious polygonal columns that have a very Doric look about them, though they are very rude and undeveloped.

The walls of Karnak are of course defaced and disfigured by the usual amount of inscriptions; one commemorative tablet, however, like a similar one at Phylæ, inspires a different feeling. Both are memorials of the French Campaign in Egypt; the one at Phylæ, dated "an VIII. de la République Française," alludes with simple dignity to the victorious march of the French army to the first cataract, giving the names of the generals who were fighting "*sous les ordres de Bonaparte*"; the other, under the same date, is a simple scientific memorandum giving the latitude and longitude of the chief towns on the Nile. It is impossible to read the first of these inscriptions without emotion: how remote from us, already, seems that stern, invincible French Republic, tracing its proud name with an undoubting finger here in the grave-dust of an empire that stood more centuries than this young giant completed years! How thickly, already, does the dust lie now on the grave of this thing of yesterday!

In writing about Phylæ, I forgot to notice the henna tree, which grows in great quantities round the skirts of the temple, and has a delicious scent. In this wilderness of granite and most unsavoury haunt of bats, its perfume wafted unexpectedly on the air is infinitely delightful.

Sunday, 8th.—Sketched.

Monday, 9th.—Ditto. In the evening went out to shoot, but could not get near the pelicans and crows—they see you half a mile off. Returning, against stream, Hosseyn, anxious to be useful, took a *punting pole* and *rowed* away with an air of conviction which was worthy of the fly on the coach-wheel in the fable.

The heat, though still considerable (greater than with us at midsummer), has diminished within the last few days, and does not inconvenience me as much as it did in sketching. Towards evening, soft autumnal veils of mist rise from the smooth, swift river, and shroud everything in their mysterious folds; to-night the effect was especially striking; a pale golden sun hung in a pale golden mist, tempered so that one could look at it undazzled, and so shorn of its fires that the eastern bank, instead of burning orange, showed only a faint violet flush over its dark-brown ridges. On a dahabieh alongside me an Arab is singing endless strophes of some poem of love and war, accompanied by the thud and jingle of a tambourine; the melody, a wandering, nasal strain, full of turns and runs and triplets, appears to be entirely improvised, and is full of character and melancholy. At the end of each strophe I hear a prolonged, deep groan of approval uttered in a chorus by the audience, rising in pitch after a particularly happy effort of the rhapsodist, whose song begins again and again in mournful gusts like the song of the wind. It is dark; I only hear—don't see—the singer and his listeners.

Tuesday, 10th.—Sketched. A frequent companion in my work is my friend, little Fatma, a sweet, small child of about five, with a bright face and two rows of the whitest teeth ever seen. She squats down snugly by my side, sometimes looking at the picture, sometimes at the painter, most often at the paint-box, at which she twiddles silently; sometimes she pensively draws a pattern with a little brown finger on my dusty boots. I remember at Rhodes, last year, a knot of little girls used to watch me sketching in the Street of the Knights; but the little Turks were not so nice as Fatma, the little Arab; some used to giggle, and some used to frown at the Djiaour; but one very chatty young lady of about six with the manners and graces of sixteen would exclaim in a little fluty voice, "Mash Allah! Mash Allah! beautiful indeed! nobody here can write like you!"

(Turk., if my memory helps me: *Guzel! guzel! Bir khimse burda senci zhibi yazamas!*) I had a visit on board the other day from Mustafa Aga's youngest son, bonny and rosy as an apple. He wore a flowing robe of linen, *à ramages*, buttoned summarily and once for all at the neck, but entirely open from the neck downwards; over this an enormous embroidered jacket with anticipatory sleeves turned up at the wrists, and on, or rather about, his feet, a pair of his papa's shoes; he was irresistibly funny and pretty; an *amorino*, dressed up as the Dog Toby. He was very chatty; not so his playfellow, "Genani," the son of Abdallah, the servant of Mustafa, a putto by Raphael modelled in chocolate; a wild, black-eyed, trembling, romping, dusty, stark-naked little imp (I used to call him Afreet), and the finest child I ever saw. The nearest approach to social intercourse I could get out of him was a sudden plunge at a proffered cake; after which he would dart off with affected dismay, and frown at me through an ill-suppressed grin from behind the nearest place of safety.

Wednesday, 11th.—Got on with my sketches. Have begun two or three rough small studies of heads. Hate sketching heads rapidly; it is unavoidably and odiously free and easy, and nearly all that is worth escapes. But I have no time for more, and, I suppose, the sketches will be useful. One man, with a face like a camel, whom I drew in profile, was annoyed (though in a general way complimentary) at seeing only one eye in the picture. This struck me as quaint; for he was *blind* of the other; he had not been defrauded of much. My delight, in the evening, is to watch the processions of women and girls coming down to the Nile to fetch water. The brown figures, clad in brown, coming, in long rows, along the brown bank in all the glow and glory of sunset, look very grand; very grand, too, returning up the steep bank, along the violet sky, with their long, flowing folds and the full pitchers now erect on their heads (when empty they carry them horizontally). They are neither handsome individually nor particularly well made, but their movements are good, and the repetition of the same "motive" many times in succession makes the whole scene impressive and stately. There is no more fruitful source of effect in Nature or Art than iteration.

The suppleness of the limbs of the children here is extraordinary. I have seen little girls squatting like grasshoppers in the Nile drinking, *à même*, the water in which they were standing little more than ankle deep.

An hour after nightfall the dahabieh, my neighbour, slipped her cables and began to drift down the river; but not till the rhapsodist had chanted his ditty to the approving murmurs of his little circle as on the preceding night. His singing has a great charm for me; I shall miss it. It reminds me much of Andalusian singing and moonlight nights in the Bay of Cadiz—there is about it a strangeness and a wayward melancholy that attach and charm me. It was a love song (I am told, for I could not hear the words, and should have understood very few if I had).

"Ya leyl! ya leyl! ya leyl!"—the eternal refrain of Arab songs. "Oh night! oh night! oh night! you have left a fire in my heart, oh my beloved! Oh my beloved, do not forget me!" &c. &c. &c.

A day or two ago I heard a youth calling the faithful to noonday prayer, from the gallery of a minaret, with one of the finest voices I have ever heard; he was tearing his notes from the inmost depths of his chest with that eagerness of yet unconscious passion that I have often noticed in southern children, and which to me is singularly pathetic; he retained his last notes as long as his breath allowed it, and they vibrated in distinct waves like a sonorous metal set in motion: from a little distance the effect was *saisissant*. I could not see him, and the air seemed to throb with sound as well as with heat in the sultry noon.

The departure of the dahabieh was celebrated with the usual Arab waste of powder, and all the echoes of the valley of the tombs across the river were aroused by the popping of many guns. All the consuls fired officially, everybody else fired unofficially. Hosseyn fired officiously—chuckling and nearly tumbling over; and the dahabieh itself, having opened the ball, fired again at intervals from a long distance as if it had forgotten somebody—they are too funny.

Thursday, 12th.—More sketching. The weather, which is a little too canicular at noon, is deliciously fresh and cool for an hour after

sunrise; the Arabs, however, look much aggrieved at the severity of the cold; they sit huddled in muffled groups with a pinched look that would become a British December day.

I observe that half the men in middle life have no forefinger to their right hand. They all of them mutilated themselves to avoid conscription under Said Pasha, who, however, having found them out, enlisted them all the same. A curious equality prevails here: whilst sketching two of Mustafa Aga's servants this morning, I learnt from his son that they were both his relations. One of them appears to be a particularly nice fellow, and is a perfect gentleman in his manners.

Friday, 13th.—My last day in Thebes. When I arrived here and found neither friends nor letters, I thought, caring little for the place apart from the ruins, that I should stay four or five days; to-morrow when I leave I shall have been here *nine*, and shall go with regret. Work has exercised its usual attaching influence.

I have drawn in pencil a few heads that will be of use and interest to me. The subject of one of my studies (Mustafa's gardener) on receiving from Hosseyn two shillings for one hour's sitting, accused him, to his infinite disgust and anger, of having suppressed the *remaining* eighteen shillings out of a putative pound which he conceived to be destined for him. *Excusez!*

Saturday, 14th.—Got up early to finish a couple of sketches, and started at half-past eleven amidst salutes and salaams. To my great relief, the letters which I very rashly sent for from Cairo three weeks ago have just turned up at the last moment—fewer than I had expected, but a great delight: the first and only news I have received since leaving home—such are Egyptian posts!

Weather divine: the Nile like an opal mirror, reflecting without a break the faint, sleeping, sultry hills on the horizon: a lovely, drowsy scene. Arrived shortly after three at the village at which one lands for Keneh; a very cheery town about a mile inland. It is generally separated from the landing place on the river during the floods by a vast sheet of water; this year, however, owing to the calamitous lowness of the Nile, a narrow, shallow strip of water,

only, intercepts the road, and a large tract of country remains untilled and unfruitful from the want of the quickening flood. Keneh is a very pretty sample of an Egyptian town; it is animated and full of colour, has some pretty minarets, some charming gardens, and more than the usual allowance of ornamental doorways: the effect of the mosaic of black and white bricks is most satisfactory, and has the charm which always accompanies a considerable result produced by very sober and simple means. Great relief is frequently obtained by a band or frieze of carved wood, running across the decorated surface at the springing of the arch; this band is generally carved in circles enclosing patterns and picked out with green and red. In the jambs of the door of one of the mosques, a very beautiful effect was produced by alternate bands of brickwork and minutely carved wood, *not* coloured (three courses of brick to one band of wood).

Visited a pottery, and for the first time in my life saw a pattern-wheel and the artist at work—a most fascinating sight: the bottles and jugs flow into the most graceful forms as if by magic, and look incomparably prettier than when they are baked. I could hardly get away. A little boy scratches a pattern on them as they leave the wheel.

The Consul's white donkey, on which I ride about here, is as fleet as the wind and as oily in his movements as a two-oared gondola.

À propos of consuls, Mustafa at Thebes showed me his travellers' book—in it I saw an entry of the names of Speke and Grant, with the numbers of their regiments, and the dates of their departure from Zanzibar and their arrival at Khartoum and Thebes. A simple conventional travellers' entry, as if they had returned from an ordinary journey—nothing to hint at the great achievement which brought them such honour and lasting fame.

Sunday, 15th.—Made a sketch, a little after sunrise, of the chain of hills on the west bank of the Nile, then crossed the river to see the ruins of Denderah. Horses were waiting on the other side, and would have been most enjoyable if the weather had been cool; but, under a fierce sun, absolutely incessant prancing and waltzing ("he

make 'fantasia,'" quoth Hosseyn) was fatiguing after a bit. Was so much struck with the beauties of the mountains, as seen from the left bank, that I resolved to stay a couple of days to paint them. The temple is extremely fine, and in parts unusually well preserved—the *sculpture*, that is, for the colour is almost entirely lost. These sculptures, being of a late period (Roman), are clumsy enough; on the other hand the general scheme of decoration is more artistic, more varied in distribution and rhythm than in most of the temples. On the external wall I remarked here, as at Edfou and at Medinet Haboo, massive and very handsome gargoyles—half a lion, couchant, on a large bracket, the water flowing from a spout between the paws—a more important feature in the architectural aspect of the wall than in northern countries, and calculated for five months' rain rather than for five minutes', which is the average annual fall here, I believe. This temple boasts a portrait of Cleopatra on a large scale, but, like those of Armout and Karnak, it is absolutely conventional, and any pretence of detecting an individuality is mere humbug. One fancies at first one has discovered some peculiarity in the features, but on a candid examination one must own that the same peculiarities occur in other faces on the same wall, or that they are owing to the mutilation to which two-thirds of the figures in all Egyptian temples has been assiduously subjected. In a lateral chamber of the temple, on the ceiling, is a most striking mystical design, representing the firmament and the sun fecundating the land of Egypt. It is fantastic and poetic in the extreme; it would delight Rossetti. In the evening made another sketch, and then rode to Keneh to dine with the Consul—a most interesting glimpse into a real old-fashioned Muslim interior. Si Syed Achmet (forty-five years British Agent in this town and at Khossayr) is a very wealthy old gentleman with large property in this part of the world. He is of the blood of the Prophet, a good and pious Muslim, tolerant and full of kindness. A son, three nephews and a daughter form his immediate family circle, living with him in the house to which I was bidden—a bald, uninteresting place enough. It is entered from a narrow, irregular triangular court, ornamented on one side with some good brick and wood work, but ugly and plain on the others, and disfigured by

something between a ladder and a staircase which leads to the clean but singularly naked room in which we were to spend the evening. This room was whitewashed, but so roughly bedaubed that the plain deal cupboards, the doors of which formed the only embellishment (?) of the walls, were all besmeared with ragged edges of white. Three windows, innocent of glass, and protected by a close, plain trellis-work of ordinary white wood, lighted the room, which boasted in the way of furniture the usual ugly divans, three red muslin curtains, a small deal table, two lanterns and two candles in candlesticks. Shortly after my arrival and most kindly reception by the old gentleman, who had come up from the country expressly *ad hoc*, dinner was served. The son, as the eldest, sat at table; the nephews waited on us; we squatted, I on a cushion, they on the floor, round a very low table on which was a large, round, brass tray, containing four plates, some wooden spoons, and a great many small loaves of bread arranged round it in a circle; a soup tureen, into which, after washing of hands, everybody plunged his spoon, was the central feature. After the soup, came in rapid succession several dishes containing savoury messes which were really very good, though perhaps too rich, but which I was entirely unable to enjoy in the sight of a number of hands, shining with gravy, mopping in succession at the dishes with crusts of bread, or fetching out a coveted morsel with fingers too recently licked. It is a delicate and hospitable attention to put a bit with your own hand on to your guest's plate—an attention of which I was the frequent but unworthy recipient. After the made dishes had been done justice to, half a sheep—head and all—was put on the table and *clawed* asunder by Hosseyn. The roast being disposed of, the sweets appeared, and were eaten out of the common dish with spoons, like the soup: I was not sorry when it was over, for I had gone through all the sensations of a sea voyage. I observe that Arabs make a point of eating with as much noise and smacking of lips as possible; it is as if they were endeavouring to convey a sort of oblique expression of thanks to Providence by manifesting their relish of the blessings vouchsafed. When dinner was over, and a by no means superfluous washing of hands had been gone through, we had pipes and coffee. Hosseyn having gone to dine, I was now thrown on my own extremely

limited stock of Arabic for conversation; and as I had about exhausted that during my ride to Keneh with one of the nephews, I was hard put to it. However, I just managed to get through a few broken sentences, to the great satisfaction of Achmet, who informed me that he had been for forty years the servant of the English, of whom he thought very highly, chiefly because, as he expressed it, they have "one word"—a satisfactory character to leave behind. In the evening the governor (Mudir) came to see me with a tail of employés and, if you please, a pocket-handkerchief, of which he was not a little conscious, holding it in his hand rolled into a neat tube, which he occasionally drew with dignity across the basis of the official nose. The Consul for France and Prussia also came and made his salaam. My borrowed and temporary plumes have been of real use to somebody here, for the Mudir, hearing that an Englishman (whom he erroneously supposed to be somebody) was on board a viceroy's steamer, immediately gave the crew two months' pay—an alacrity not sufficiently often displayed in this country, if I am not much misinformed. The dancing-girls who came to entertain us in the evening were no doubt better than those of Loug sor, though, with one exception, at least as ugly; but some of them were gorgeously attired (from the dancing-dog point of view), and all were a mass of gold necklaces and coins and glittering headgear, which produced at a certain distance and in the doubtful light a prodigiously fine effect of colour. The dancing was a little more varied than that of the Loug sor women, chiefly, no doubt, because they got more to drink; but, *en somme*, I am confirmed in my first impression that it is an eminently ugly performance, though a very remarkable gymnastic feat. Of course a graceful and good-looking girl may do a good deal to redeem it by personal charm, and this was in some degree the case with Zehneb, who is a noted dancer and the *fine fleur* of the profession. She is pretty though coarse in feature, and not without grace; but has a semi-European smack about her dress and ways that spoils her in my eyes—hers, by-the-bye, are splendid. Just as the "fantasia" was at its height, a ragged, dust-soiled, old beggar came, chattering and grinning, into the room, and at once installed himself, uninvited but unhindered, on the divan, from which comfortable post he proceeded to witness

the performance and apparently thoroughly to enjoy his evening. The contrast between his beggar's garb and the scrupulously cleanly attire of his neighbours was very curious. He is a fakeer, as I am told; everybody feeds him, no doors are closed to him; he is not, I believe, exactly an idiot, but is certainly in his second childhood—"rimbambito," as the Italians say. On one side of him squatted a sweet little brown girl, Achmet's daughter, of about five or six, in a pink cotton shift and with anklets hanging about her little naked feet. On the other side, a little further off, was an umber-coloured dancing-girl, with bright bold eyes painted round with black, covered with a mass of gold coins on her head, in her hair, on her ears, and round her neck, and wearing a blue silk dress all bespangled with gold. He looked like a dust-heap between them. It was a queer picture, taken out of the "Thousand and One Nights"; from which work also, I presume, the numerous one-eyed people that I see everywhere in Egypt, are copied. (I prefer this view to that of unimaginative pedants who, attaching undue importance to facts, inform me that this blindness is self-inflicted, to avoid conscription.) My ride home was a fitting close to such an evening; a fantastic procession we made, headed by a handful of torch and lantern bearers, brandishing enormous staves; after which "Meine Wenigkeit" on a sumptuously caparisoned steed, the consul's nephew, the captain, Hosseyn, a cawass, all of them on horses, others on donkeys, and odd men bustling about amongst us and dispersing the few stragglers that were to be found at that late hour in the streets. The fitful flare of the torches, dressing in fugitive, fantastic lights the gateways and dim walls of the slumbering town, had a very fine effect. More curious still was our ride *through* a quarter of a mile of *dourah* that stood at least ten or twelve feet high all round us; the train of light and shower of sparks in the tall graceful corn was of a surprising aspect. Except that nothing took fire, it was as if Samson's foxes had been let loose in front of us.

Monday, 16th.—Sketched. In the evening, yielding, I own, with some reluctance, to a pressing invitation, returned to Keneh to dine with Si Achmet. Had, except the roast, exactly the same dinner as on the previous day, which leads me to conjecture that the *répertoire* of Arab cookery is limited. After dinner we rode out to see the moolid,

which is just beginning here. It is *the* great moolid of Central Egypt, and to it, but only towards the end, flock people from all parts of the country till the concourse is enormous. It must be an interesting sight when in full swing, but as yet there is little or nothing worth seeing except the tomb of the sheykh in whose honour the moolid is held (Sheykh Abd-er-Rahim, the "Genani") to which I was taken by my host. The building was like most others of the same class in Egypt: a square chamber with a dome, and windows through which the coffin, placed conspicuously in the centre, can be seen by the pious crowds outside. On entering, I was conducted, after taking off my boots, to a post of honour, on the ground of course, in the midst of a grave circle of worthies who were squatting in the *ruelle* between one side of the coffin and the wall. On my right was one of the civic functionaries, on my left the priest attached to the tomb. The spectacle before me was wonderful both in colour and form, though composed in great part of the simplest elements. It was like the finest Delacroix in aspect and tone, but with a gravity and stateliness of form very foreign to that brilliant but epileptic genius. To the left of me, covered with a showy embroidered cloth, stood behind a railing the sarcophagus of the saint, illuminated from above by various lanterns hung from the ceiling (the central one, and the handsomest, the gift of Lady Duff Gordon) and from the corners by gigantic candles, standing in candlesticks of proportionate dimensions; at the same corners stood great banners of sober but rich tone, which added much to the general colour. On each side of the carpet at the head of which I squatted, squatted, in far more picturesque attire, some of the notables of Keneh, half hidden in the shadow, their large turbans cast on the rich carpet they sat on. At the further end stood and stared, with the solemnity of a chorus in an opera, a motley, dazzling group of lesser folk; magnificent, too, in the flow of their draperies, the grace of the half untwisted turbans wreathed round their necks or hanging from their shoulders, the stateliness of their forms, and the fiery glow of colour in which they burnt under the clustered lanterns. Unfortunately, I could not gaze with attention as undivided as I could have wished, because the gentleman on my right insisted on making conversation, the very meagrest form of which exercise absorbed for the time my

powers of attention. Hosseyn, who is very pious, bled me of an enormous baksheesh for the shrine of the saint.

Tuesday, 17th.—Completed my sketches in the morning. In the evening, Si Achmet, his son, and three nephews, one of whom I neither knew nor had invited (this is entirely Arabic—I might, also, have taken any one with me to dine with them) came to dine on board. It was a very droll ceremony—the Arabs had, with one exception, probably never sat at a table on a chair before, but they were so entirely simple as not to be (also, by-the-bye, with one exception) at all ridiculous. Otilio had, perhaps with a little malice, arranged the napkins in a most artistic and intricate fashion; these edifices so impressed my friends that they did not sit down opposite to their plates but on one side of them. I set them at once comparatively at their ease by requesting them, through Hosseyn, to consider themselves at home and eat with their fingers, forgiving me if I followed the custom of my country; the proposal was received with great satisfaction by the old gentleman and his son, who fell to in their own way, the father muttering his appreciation of the dishes in low, sonorous ejaculations: "Allah!"—"Mash Allah!"—"Ou Allah!"—"Ameer! Ameer!" &c. &c. &c. The son, a man of about forty, with a broken nose and a very strong squint, and whose movements carried a general impression of contemplative dreaminess, always verging on surprise, ate with his usual deliberation and spent his odd moments in contemplating a shining bunch of fingers, which he periodically and slowly licked with the utmost impartiality; he did not mix in the conversation. Of the three cousins on my left, two made a very fair attempt at using the knife and fork, though it must have been a virgin effort; the third, who had been a great deal with English people when he was consul at Khossayr, ate his dinner and put down his wine like the best European; I suspect, in fact, that he was brought as a show man. Achmet, in a climax of gratification, exclaimed towards the end of dinner, "By Allah! if the Ameer comes to my house another year, he shall be served after the Frankish custom." Arabs appear to be much devoted to *limonade gazeuse*—without being the forbidden fruit of wine itself, it dwells in bottles, and has a sort of air of crime about it

which no doubt pleases them; my left-hand neighbour took off at least two bottles during dinner.

Hosseyn, whose father was a great friend of Si Achmet, proved invaluable; he hopped about like a delighted child, filling the glasses, cutting the meat of the two digitarians, and generally making conversation—a great relief to me. In the evening one of the nephews asked for some tea to take home, which I gave him; another pocketed all the tobacco that was brought them to make cigarettes. Arabs are hospitable and generous, and I like them much, but they are indiscreet in the extreme. "Arabs," says Hosseyn, "have no face; they never take shame." I have seen instances of this which I won't put down; one only, for it is very droll: my squinting friend with the pensive look asked Lady Ely last year if she would just procure for him from the Queen a title, or an order, as a mark of her regard. I am the bearer of a letter to her from him now, which I have no doubt is a reminder. Slew a sheep again.

Wednesday, 18th.—Left Keneh early, and with regret; the place, the people and the scenery have left many pleasing pictures in my memory. I little expected at starting the annoyance that awaited me! As we approached the spot where Sheykh Selim receives his devout visitors, I sent word to the captain that I did not wish to lose any time in landing, but that the bag of money which had been collected for the saint was to be delivered, and we were to go on. I had scarcely uttered this almost sacrilegious order, when the steamer, which had been judiciously steered within ten yards of a flat, shelving bank, ran hard and fast into the mud, with the apparent intention of sticking there permanently, the engine being utterly powerless to get her out. Nobody on board doubted for an instant but that Sheykh Selim had stopped us in his resentment; the captain instantly dispatched sailors with money to propitiate him, and after a few futile attempts on the part of five or six of the crew (to loud cries of "Help us, O Prophet! help us, O Sheykh Selim!") to heave out a vessel that was four or five feet in the mud, jumped himself into a boat, and hurried, of course accompanied by Hosseyn, and leaving his vessel to take care of herself, to beseech the sheykh to get us off. Their conversation was afterwards reported to me by one

who was present. "What is this, O Sheykh, that thou hast done to us? in what have we been wanting towards thee? did I not give thee a shirt when we last came by? and the tobacco, was it not good? was the roast meat not sufficient? why are we thus punished?"—to whom the sheykh: "Don't be a fool! why do you come to me about your boat? am I a sailor? how do you expect me to get her off—or on? Allah got her on the sand, not I, who am a man like yourselves." The captain: "Allah is indeed great, but if he ran us aground it was on thy instigation—thou knowest it, O Sheykh!" &c. &c. In this strain the conversation lasted at least twenty minutes, during which time and for the rest of the day I was literally sick with disgust and anger at the lot of them. Everything that ought not to be done under the circumstances, including losing the anchor (which is still at the bottom of the river), was done before evening; everything that should have been done was left undone.

Next morning (Thursday, 19th) we obtained (by force, after the fashion of this country) through the governor of the neighbouring town a gang of two hundred Arabs, magnificent fellows some of them, who, at last, by heaving and tugging, contrived to get her off—not without the most unearthly *charivari* I ever heard. In the morning I made a sketch; reached Bellianeh in the evening, appeased, at last, and rather amused at the abject condition of the captain, to whom I had conveyed my mind (he had never seen me angry before), and who swore that in future one hundred sheykhs should not take him out of his course. My misadventure will benefit my successors in the good ship *Sheberkheyt*—à *quelque chose malheur est bon*.

Friday, 20th.—Started at seven on horseback to see Abydos, and had a delightful morning. The weather was fresh and clear, and the canter of six or seven miles across a fine open plain to the foot of the mountains where the ruins lie was most enjoyable. The temples, very strikingly situated on a slope which sweeps down from a grand amphitheatre of bastion-like rocks, have a great advantage over all those that I have yet seen, viz. that their sculptures have almost entirely escaped mutilation, and are in admirable preservation. This is the more fortunate, that they are of a very fine period, and most

delicate in workmanship; the type of the faces has considerable beauty and refinement. The colours, notably in the more recently excavated temple of Osiris, are often extremely well preserved, and I am confirmed in my conjecture, that they must have been much less beautiful in their freshness than now that time has toned and tuned them. In the larger temple are some very beautiful wagon-head vaults *cut in the thickness of two layers of stone*, the upper ones laid on end to get more thickness of material. They are charmingly decorated with cartouches and stars on a blue ground, and divided by a band of hieroglyphs running like a ridge-rib along the head of the vault. The stars on Egyptian ceilings are always pentagonal, and placed very near together. At the temple I was joined by the obligato governor, a puffy Turk with a tight, shiny face that had a look of having been stung all over by a wasp; he was heavy and stupid, and I left him in the hands of Hosseyn, galloping ahead myself with the mounted cawass, a very picturesque Arnout on a very good horse. *N.B.*—Never come to the East again without an English saddle; the back-board of a Turkish saddle is in the long run an intolerable nuisance, as are also, though in a less degree, the shovel-stirrups in which one's feet are imprisoned. In the afternoon reached Sohag, a sail, or rather a steam, of three or four hours, in time for a most pleasant evening's walk.

Saturday, 21st.—Got to Syoot in the afternoon, and was very glad to catch Lady Duff Gordon on her way up the river. Was received with great hospitality by the American and Spanish consuls, wealthy Copts of this town who kindly put their carriages at my disposal and, better still, their donkeys—splendid Arabian donkeys, looking, in their trappings, like cardinals' mules. Nothing is more pleasant than the swift amble of a good donkey from the Hejaz. Dined in the evening with Mr. Wonista, the consul for Spain, quite "*à la Franca*" with knives and forks and the whole thing. A curious house, and the rooms small but of enormous height, so that they looked as if they had been set *on end* by mistake. The walls were bare whitewash, but the furniture was of the most gorgeous brocade, as were also the curtains; there was a European carpet all over the floor and as many candles on the walls (in glass bells) as in a *café chantant*. I met there a Scotch clergyman belonging to the American Mission

(Episcopalian) which is very active in Egypt. After dinner the singer from Lady Duff Gordon's boat was sent for, and in a short time arrived with some of the crew who acted as chorus; it is this chorus, I find, that gives the approving murmur after each strophe. He sang well, but his performance of course lost three-fourths of its charm by not being heard in its proper place and surroundings. I remember once in the Sabine hills hearing unexpectedly at a distance, in the silent dimness of night, the droning song of a *piffera*; nothing could be more strangely pathetic than this voice rising in the utter silence from out of the heart of the valley below—yet those same sounds heard close in the broad daylight would have seemed uncouth and strident. Arab singing has a similar quality, and is equally dependent on time and place for its full effect. Whilst the performance was at its height, and the minstrel was tuning his note to the most ambitious *fioriture*, I heard in the room overhead some European part-singing of a melancholy order, and was informed that the Scotch minister had been invited by a few proselytes to retire upstairs "to worship and explain an obscure passage in the Gospel." On the invitation of the master of the house, I went up and joined the congregation, who thought it right to favour me with another psalm. The clergyman then read in Arabic, and expounded in the same language a chapter from the Bible, and I must say did it (I speak of his manner only, for Koran and Bible Arabic is so different from the current idiom, here at all events, that I did not understand four words in the whole sermon) in a very simple and impressive way. He had, too, an admirable accent. He tells me that in spite of vehement opposition from the Coptic prelates he finds a good deal of sympathy amongst the people.

Sunday, 22nd.—Lovely day. Strolled about with a gun. This place is full of "sparrows of paradise," a little bird of an exquisite golden green. Since I was here last, the aspect of the country has changed very much and for the better. Where I saw, a few weeks back, nothing but pools and mud, is now a vast expanse of clover and grass of an intense green, sunny and brilliant to a wonderful degree. The plain looks like one immense jewel, and contrasts deliciously with the tawny sand-rock which walls it in on the west, behind the gleaming white domes of the cemetery. Dined with the other consul

in the evening. Same sort of house, but much larger. No Scotch clergyman this time, but an Anglo-Arab who teaches in the Coptic school, and, embracing Coptic views, inveighs bitterly against the converts to Protestantism. At sunset, to my agreeable surprise, the Sterlings turned up, *musique en tête*, the singer in the bows quavering a jubilant strain, and the vessel magnificent with fresh paint.

Monday, 23rd.—Killed a sheep. Sketched. Had the consuls and the Scotch missionary to dine with me. The latter brought me some newspapers, which I read greedily.

Tuesday, 24th.—Sketched. At last an evening to myself!—these festive gatherings are an ineffable bore, if the truth were told.

Wednesday, 25th.—Completed my sketches with one exception—a study of my beautiful grey (*hechtgrau*) donkey. Unless I make a study at Sakkara, which is just possible, this will be the end of my work on the Nile. In twenty-two skies which I have painted there is not a vestige of a cloud, such has been the divinely serene weather I have had all along. This evening, indeed, faint, shining flakes of vapour were drawn across the sky, breaking and tempering the last rays of the sun; but by a curious piece of luck they did not appear till I was just giving the last touches to my day's work. Saw a beautiful and original effect at sunset. Just as the sun was about to sink behind the hills, a dahabieh drifted past with its sails spread, and reaching up into the region where the light was still golden, whilst the face of the water was darkened, and the long, low banks were already shadowy and grey, the burning sail was reflected in the night of the river, and looked astonishingly beautiful. It was like the mellow splendour of the rising moon.

I delight in seeing the sailors climbing the tall, oblique yards of the Nile boats. Sometimes five or six of them perch on one yard at the same time, looking at a distance like great birds.

Thursday, 26th.—Finished my donkey and started; as I get further north, the weather is much cooler—the mornings and evenings are quite fresh, though not so cold but that I can sketch in the shade an hour after sunrise in summer clothes. The natives, however, seem to

take a severe view of the temperature, and leave nothing unmuffled but their mouths, with which they occasionally blow their fingers in the most approved winter fashion. Was more struck than before with Gebel Aboofada—the infinite and strongly marked strata of which it is made up writhe and heave in a very grand and fantastic manner. Some of the Egyptian mountains are ruled like a copy book from head to foot, and are very monotonous.

At the foot of Aboofada, I saw, for an instant, my first and last crocodile; a small one. They are very seldom seen from a steamer below the cataracts, as the noise frightens away the few there are. I had looked forward to getting a shot at one, and was a good deal disappointed at finding none up the river. It is curious how rapidly time lends its perspective to the past. Every now and then a boat from the cataracts laden with dates comes floating down the river, and the melancholy chant of the Nubian sailors, as they strain at the oars, already falls on my ear as a sudden memory of an almost distant past—not a month old.

Arrived at Roda this evening. I have been reading, amongst other things, a book everybody else read thirty years ago, "Les Natchez," and am greatly disappointed with it. I am especially struck with the extraordinary contrast between the masterful sobriety and simplicity of the style, and the far-fetched affectation of the ideas which are, more often than not, distorted, tawdry and inflated, sometimes disgusting and not seldom maudlin in the extreme. This singular discrepancy between form and matter is especially French, and may frequently be traced in the works of their painters and sculptors. No living people has so sensitive a perception of form or so artistic an epiderm, but an ineradicable self-consciousness develops in them a theatrical attitude of mind which too often betrays itself in their artistic and literary conceptions. It is the absolute consent between conception and execution which constitutes one of the chief sources of delight in the art of the Greeks, to whom they are fond, too rashly, of comparing themselves.^[41]

I notice in the Natchez a peculiar use of comparisons. That mode of adding light and colour to an idea which consists in suggesting analogies, has always been the delight of poets; but Chateaubriand

(whose analogies, by the way, are often singularly far fetched and unfortunate) occasionally, in a morbid endeavour to be original, seeks his effects in a suggestion of dissimilarities; I remember an instance: he has been describing with minute and gratuitously sickening detail a mangled heap of dead and dying warriors after a ferocious encounter. "How different," he exclaims, but in more flowery terms, "is a haycock in a field with girls rolling down it!" Few will be disposed to contradict him. His exorbitant personal vanity which continues to peep through everywhere, and makes even his unbounded praise of his country seem an oblique tribute to himself, is droll and nauseating at the same time.

Took a stroll in the evening, and met an English baby! pink and delicate like a flower; with cape and cockade complete—a pretty sight.

Thick folds of rose and violet-coloured cloud hung along the horizon at sunset, and looked autumnal. I have left eternal summer behind me.

Friday, 27th.—Such a morning as the evening of yesterday foreboded; rather chilly and misty, and as near an approach to winter as Upper Egypt may be expected to afford. The sky was veiled on all sides with soft grey clouds, wrinkled and fretted like the grey sands when the sea has left them. It was a fitting background to the desolate tombs of Beni Hassan, which I visited an hour or two after sunrise. The range of hills on the face of which these tombs are excavated is not unlike Gebel Aboofada in its configuration, except that the strata with which it is scored are more level and regular. This monotony is, however, relieved by the sky-line, which is extremely fine. Along the foot of these hills runs a level strip of barren land, broken abruptly in its whole length by a steep bank which rises like a ruined wall from the plain below, and which is, when the Nile is exceptionally high, the bank of the river itself. Standing, as it now does, nearly a mile inland, and crested with two deserted villages, it has a grand but uncanny aspect. I had long been eager to see the tombs, which show what is considered by many to be the first rudiment of the Doric order. The similarity, more striking even than I expected, is so great that, taken with our knowledge of

the early and frequent intercourse of the Greeks with Egypt and of the assimilating power of their genius, it certainly offers a strong *prima facie* presumption in favour of this view. It may be objected that the echinus, the conical form of the shaft and its entasis, all three inseparable features and especial beauties of the Greek order, are wanting here, though they are present in the earliest specimen of the style preserved in Greece, the temple of Corinth. This argument would deserve more consideration if it could be conceived that the order as seen at Corinth was a spontaneous conception, and not a development of some more elementary form which, whether native or imported at a remote period, has not been handed down to us. In point of fact, the chamfering of a simple stone pier into an octagon and then further to a polygon of sixteen, or more, sides (specimens of the two forms are seen side by side in two of the tombs of Beni Hassan) is so elementary an effort of architecture and one so obvious, that its independent and spontaneous adoption by two different nations would be matter for no surprise. On the other hand, it is to be remarked that these tombs and the early temple at Karnak already mentioned are the only instances of this style known in Africa—that not only are they isolated in themselves, but they form a step to no further developments—a link in no chain; that in character and conception they have nothing in common with any of the great monuments of Egypt, to which indeed they are antagonistic in feeling; that they stand side by side with other monuments of the *same* date (about 2000 B.C.?) of a developed and absolutely different type—a type certainly indigenous and based on the imitation of natural forms which is especially characteristic of Egyptian architecture; and lastly, that the tombs of Beni Hassan show certain dissonances, such as one might expect to find in the case of an unintelligent and unperceptive manipulation of a foreign style. In the face of these considerations, I find it difficult to resist a suspicion that the view generally received exactly reverses the truth of the case, and that these tombs are not indeed the prototypes of the Doric temple, but rather the results, themselves, of contact at some remote period between the Egyptians and that branch of the great Aryan family which, at long intervals, and in successive waves, covered the shores of the Egean Sea, and one of the latest offshoots

of which poured down into Greece from the heights of Thessaly under the name of Dorians. I believe the earliest Egyptian *record* of the pressure of Greeks in this country goes no further back than 1500 B.C.; but a peaceful intercourse between the two races may have existed over a long period, without necessarily finding a place in public records.

The (quasi) Doric tombs are divided into a nave and aisles by two rows of piers, carrying an architrave and disposed at right angles to the portico, agreeably carrying out the likeness of a Greek temple. The circles which intersect the extremity of the other group of tombs are *parallel* to the portico, and have a deplorable effect, much heightened by the shape of the ceiling, which is that of a very flat pediment. The architrave follows the line of the roof, but at a still more open angle. It would be difficult to conceive anything more hideous. Nearly all the tombs are decorated with frescoes of a rude kind, but displaying frequently an amount of freedom unusual in Egyptian art.

Our guide was a splendid fellow, looking, in his flowing robes, like a figure from the "School of Athens" on the "Disputa." The longer I live, the more I am struck by the identity of Raphael's frescoes with the noblest aspects of Nature.

To Benisoëf in the evening. Passed some travellers; nothing looks so gay and pretty as a dahabieh with its colours flying and its sails spread.

Saturday, 28th.—Lovely morning once again. Reached Sakkara early, but found that the road to the Pyramids was obstructed by water, so moved on at once to Ghizeh, opposite to Old Cairo, where I shall remain till to-morrow morning; meanwhile I have sent on Hosseyn to secure a room at the inn, and to fetch the means of leaving a pleasant memory of me on board the *Sheberkheyt*.

I have stripped the walls of my cabin of the paintings I had hung round them, and they look desolate and like the coffin of my now past journey. A most enjoyable journey it has been, full of pleasant things to remember; full, too, I hope, of artistic profit and teaching. I have been indeed fortunate, for, as I now see more clearly than ever,

in a dahabieh I could not have achieved a third of the journey, and in a passenger steamer I could not have done a stroke of work. Every study I take home I owe entirely to the viceroy's munificent kindness.

Sunday, 29th.—Left for Boulay, my destination—gave a parting sheep to the crew, distributed *largesse*, shook hands all round, and drove off to the hotel.

FOOTNOTES:

[41] See [Chap. IV. p. 239.](#)

CHAPTER IV [ToC](#)

ROYAL ACADEMICIAN—MUSIC—ARAB HALL

1869-1878

In 1869, the year after his journeyings in Egypt, Leighton was elected a Royal Academician. The picture which he chose as his Diploma work to be deposited in the Academy on his election was the "S. Jerome," one of those few works which reflected the side of his nature about which he was profoundly reserved. Another work of which the same might be said is "Elijah in the Wilderness," painted in 1879. Leighton told a friend he had put more of himself into that picture than into any other he had ever invented. Three paintings which are among Leighton's very best appeared on the walls of the Academy in 1869—"Dædalus and Icarus," "Electra at the Tomb of Agamemnon," and "Helios and Rhodos." In no work did Leighton indulge his passion for colour so successfully as in the last-named picture. He wrote to his master, Steinle, in 1860: "You will perhaps be surprised, but, in spite of my fanatic preference for colour, I promised

myself to be a draughtsman before I became a colourist." Again, in a letter to a friend in 1879 he wrote: "Colour was supposed to be my *forte* (*par parenthèse*, though I am not a colourist, albeit passionately fond of colour, I have always been, and am, a great *cuisinier*; I have tried quite innumerable methods and vehicles)." Some of Leighton's appreciators cannot help feeling jealous of this obstinate determination to struggle with those gifts for which nature had not given him the preference, many considering his artistic error to have been that of putting the screw too tightly on his preconceived determinations. Had he *sometimes*, at all events, allowed his "fanatic preference" to have free play, more of his works might have glowed with the revelry in rich colour we find on the canvas of "Helios and Rhodos."



ST. JEROME. 1869. DIPLOMA WORK
Deposited in the Academy on Lord Leighton's election as an
Academician [ToList](#)



"ELECTRA AT THE TOMB OF AGAMEMNON"[To List](#)

No complete work evinces more conclusively the force of Leighton's dramatic gift than "Electra"; and—further—masterly and beautiful as are all Leighton's arrangements of drapery, those in this design strike me as specially expressive. They are truly superb. The balance of the masses, and the sweeping lines from the feet up to the shoulder and over the chest, are grandly conceived—the arrangement of the folds notably adding to the suggestion of tragic feeling in the attitude of the figure.

"Icarus," in the picture of the inventive father and the aspiring son, is a beautiful figure of a youth. The conception, design, and colouring of the picture are worthy of Leighton at his best.

Though Egypt had made a deep impression on Leighton's æsthetic emotions, as is obvious from his Diary, his visit there apparently did not actually suggest any pictures except "A Nile Woman"—the only work

exhibited at the Academy in 1870—and "Egyptian Slinger Scaring Birds in Harvest-time: Moonrise," exhibited in 1875. A subject suggested by an event, which had occurred some years previously, appears to have been engrossing his mind, before he found expression for it, in the painting "Heracles Wrestling with Death for the Body of Alcestis," exhibited 1871. Many persons admired this work more than any that had previously appeared.^[42] It evoked the lines from Browning:—

"I know, too, a great Kaunian painter, strong
As Hercules, though rosy with a robe
Of Grace that softens down the sinewy
strength:
And he has made a picture of it all.
There lies Alcestis dead, beneath the sun
She longed to look her last upon, beside
The sea, which somehow tempts the life in us
To come trip over its white waste of waves,
And try escape from earth, and fleet as free.
Behind the body I suppose there bends
Old Pheres in his hoary impotence;
And women-wailers, in a corner crouch
—Four, beautiful as you four,—yes, indeed!
Close, each to other, agonising all,
As fastened, in fear's rhythmic sympathy,
To two contending opposite. There strains
The might o' the hero 'gainst his more than
match,
—Death, dreadful not in thew and bone, but
like
The envenomed substance that exudes some
dew,
Whereby the merely honest flesh and blood
Will fester up and run to ruin straight,
Ere they can close with, clasp and overcome,
The poisonous impalpability
That simulates a form beneath the flow

Of those grey garments; I pronounce that
piece
Worthy to set up in our Poikilé!"

Leighton had taken the lines from Euripides as his text:—

"There slept a silent palace in the sun,
With plains adjacent and Thessalian peace."

"....Yea, I will go and lie in wait for Death, the king of souls departed, with the dusky robes, and methinks I shall find him hard by the grave drinking the sacrificial wine. And if I can seize him by this ambush, springing from my lair, and throw my arms in circle round him, none shall snatch his panting body from my grasp till he give back the woman to me."



"HERACLES STRUGGLING WITH DEATH FOR THE BODY OF
ALCESTIS." 1871

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This work made a landmark in Leighton's career. "Dante at Verona" had combined a complicated design of many figures with a dramatic feeling; "Cimabue's Madonna" and the "Syracusan Bride" had proved Leighton's "great power of rich arrangement," to quote D.G. Rossetti's words

respecting "Cimabue's Madonna"; but in the "Heracles Wrestling with Death" there was felt to be a more profound tragedy; indeed, the objective treatment had in this instance ceded to one more subjective, in so far that the subject had appealed to him through a personal experience, though the feeling was, as in nearly all Leighton's greatest works, veiled in a classic garb. In a letter to his mother, dated November 13, 1864, he wrote:—

November 13, 1864.

I returned so suddenly on account of a grave and terrible anxiety, *now quite removed*, about my dear friend Mrs. Sartoris.

I must tell you that for some time past she has been looking dreadfully ill, getting daily worse, haggard and thin. I, in common with all her friends, had been growing very anxious, and conjectured that some day or other a crisis must come in which only the surgeon could avail her. I little thought how near at hand the moment was! She on her part had borne up with an amount of moral and physical courage which everybody says was quite incredible. Her nearest relations have not known from her that she was in so dangerous a state. A week ago I arrived at Francport, the château of the Marquis de l'Aigle, where I expected to find Mr. and Mrs. Sartoris and their children. I found instead Mme. de l'Aigle in the deepest anxiety and commotion, having received a letter saying that on that very day poor Mrs. S. was undergoing an operation of which the event was very doubtful! I need hardly say that I instantly hurried off to England in the greatest alarm, and in fear and trembling lest she should have succumbed. You may judge of my relief, next morning, on hearing from the servant in Park Place that she was doing well. I hurried off to the doctor, a friend of mine, and heard that for six hours her life had been in jeopardy, but that, thank God, she was doing amazingly well, that for a week there could be no *certainty* of her recovery, but that the possible chances doubled every day. Since then, thank God, she has progressed so *astoundingly* owing to her immense roots of vitality and health, that one may be almost *certain* (*unberufen*) of her complete recovery, in which event she will enjoy life more than she has done for several

years. Her family and friends have escaped an entirely irreparable loss.

The very beautiful picture, "Greek Girls Picking up Pebbles by the Shore of the Sea," was also exhibited in the Academy in 1871, likewise a smaller work, "Cleoboulos Instructing his Daughter Cleobouline." This is one of several which proves Leighton's gift for catching the grace and singular refinement of childhood. "Lord Leighton's drawings and paintings of children show the protecting, caressing tenderness he felt towards them. He loved little things, little children, kittens—'caressing littleness, that littleness in which there is much of the whole woeful heart of things'—everything lovely that had in it the unconscious grace of helplessness seemed especially to touch him."

In 1872 "Summer Moon" was exhibited—the picture Watts told me he thought he preferred to all of Leighton's paintings. I believe the cause of this preference arose from the fact that the quality and texture in "Summer Moon" is looser and more vibrating, and gives a greater sense of atmosphere than is suggested by Leighton's works as a rule. Moonlight mystifies the tints of purple and blue, and creeps over and into every fold of the beautiful drapery—glistening on the white garment of the recumbent figure. In every line and touch in the exquisite design of the figures and drapery lurks the poetry of moonlight; the song of a nightingale perched on the branch of a pomegranate tree enhancing the sense of deep restfulness in the scene.^[43]



"SUMMER MOON." 1872

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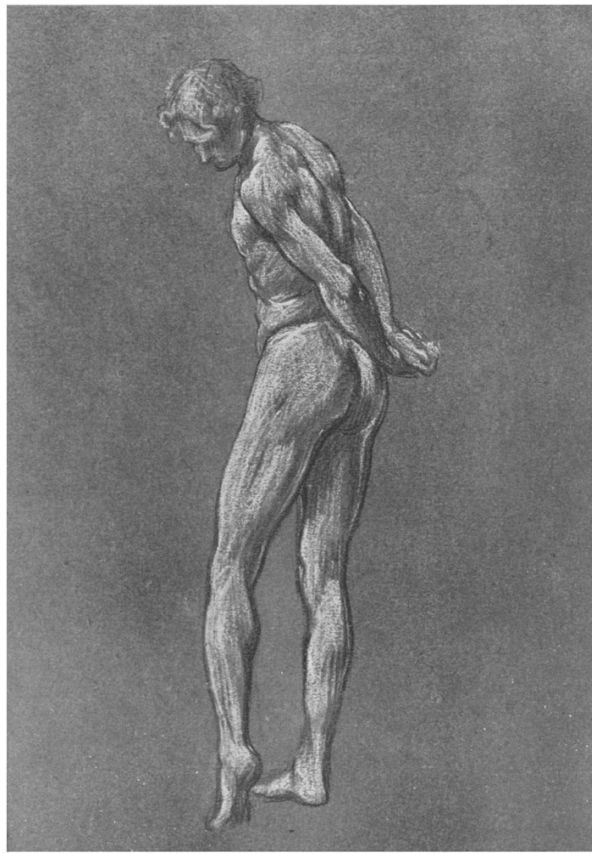
"A CONDOTTIERE." 1872 [ToList](#)



STUDY FOR FIGURE IN FRIEZE. "MUSIC." 1886
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



STUDY FOR FIGURE IN "THE ARTS OF WAR,"
Victoria and Albert Museum. 1872
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



STUDY FOR FIGURE IN "THE ARTS OF WAR,"
Victoria and Albert Museum. 1872
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)

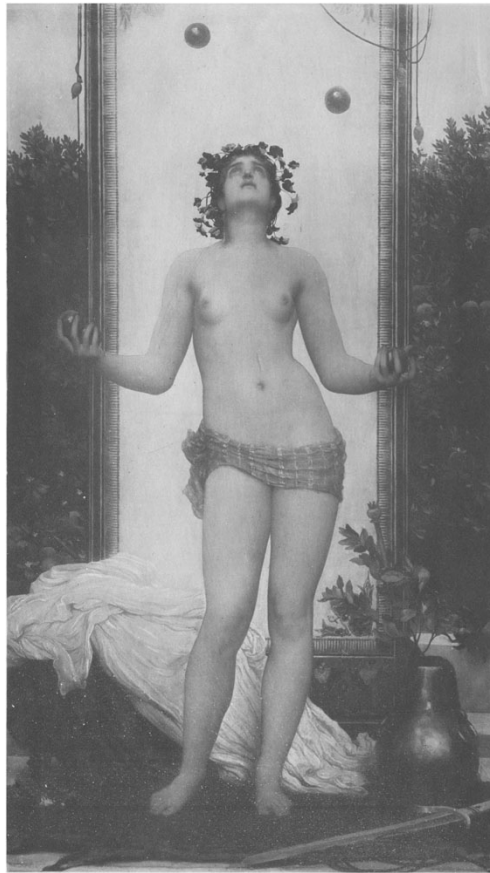


STUDY FOR FIGURE IN "THE ARTS OF WAR,"
Victoria and Albert Museum. 1872
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)

It is thought by some that the design would have carried out the feeling of absolute repose better had the lower curves of the round aperture behind the figures been absent—these lines rather suggesting horns springing up on either side of the group. The end of the foot of the sitting figure being cut off by the bottom line of the picture has also a somewhat uncomfortable effect. The same thing occurs in the picture "Greek Girl Dancing," producing the feeling that the canvas has run short. These criticisms, however, only refer to minor matters. "Summer Moon" is an exquisitely beautiful picture, one which will ever sustain the great reputation of its creator. "A Condottiere" and the monochrome version of "The Industrial Arts of War" (76 × 177 in.), exhibited at the South Kensington International Exhibition the same year, strikingly contrast in character with "Summer

Moon." If the one is notable for gentle, womanly grace and a sense of relaxation induced by slumber, "A Condottiere" is full of verve and virile power,^[44] and in the design for "The Industrial Arts of War" all is action and movement. Leighton made many studies for all his principal pictures, but the finest group of sketches are certainly those made for mural decorations. Being executed under more difficult conditions than the easel pictures, doubtless he felt more preparation for frescoes was required. The studies in Leighton House for the "Arts of War," "Arts of Peace," two friezes, "Music," "The Dance," "And the Sea gave up the Dead that were in it," the painted decoration for the ceiling of a music room, "Phœnicians Bartering with Britons," are the most completely worked out and powerful studies in the collection. In the following year, 1873, the companion lunette in monochrome, "The Industrial Arts of Peace," was exhibited at the Royal Academy. This design is more comfortably fitted into its space than that of the "Arts of War," as the whole is lifted up from the bottom line of the lunette, and no part of the figures is cut off (as in the case of the men's feet and the drapery of the otherwise most beautiful group of women on the left hand in the "Arts of War"). "Weaving the Wreath," a small picture of lovely colour and subtle technique, appeared in 1873, and in 1874 three of the most remarkable of Leighton's pictures of single figures. "In a Moorish Garden: a Dream of Granada" the charming child "Cleobouline" reappears in an Eastern turban and drapery, holding a copper vessel and followed by two peacocks, walking across a square canvas filled in by a background of the delightful garden at Generalife at Granada. "The Antique Juggling Girl" is one of the best examples in Leighton's work of his "ardent passion for colour," and his perfect mastery in painting the beauty of an undraped figure. The form of the torso recalls the exquisite fragment from the Naples Museum.^[45] The actual painting, however, exemplifies the truth of Leighton's very notable words written to Steinle, "What reveals true knowledge of form is a powerful, organic, refined finish of modelling full of feeling and knowledge—and that is the affair of the brush." The principal scheme of colour is effectively carried throughout the picture—in the golden flesh tint against the ivory-white of the parchment banner hung as a screen background, the crown of dark ivy leaves and the golden balls telling out as notes of a deeper tone; the crinkled folds of white drapery resting on the darker mass, the full tawny browns and yellows of the leopard skins on which the figure stands making a dark, luminous basis, the metal jar and the

dense foliage of deep verdant green enriched by the orange of the fruit springing up and continuing the dark framework of the central design. This picture is a very original work, and should, I think, be placed very high in the rank of Leighton's achievements. "Clytemnestra from the battlements of Argos watches for the beacon fires which are to announce the return of Agamemnon" is, in every sense, a contrast to the "Antique Juggling Girl." The figure is powerful and heavily draped, the drapery being superb, and the limbs those which might truly overpower even Agamemnon.^[46]



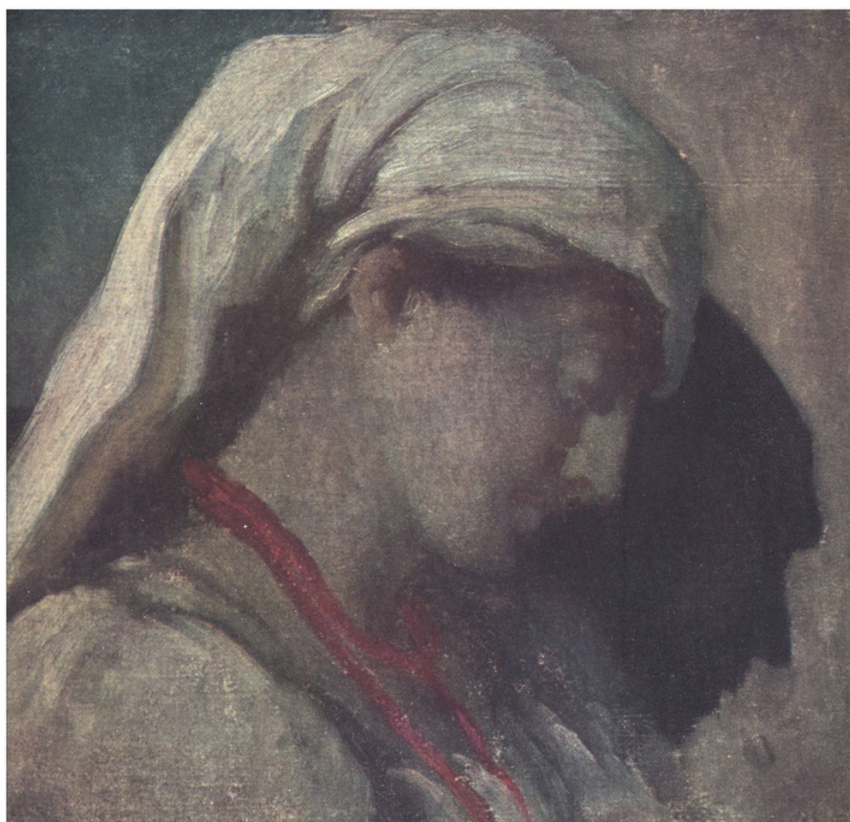
"ANTIQUE JUGGLING GIRL." 1874
By permission of Mr. George Hodges [ToList](#)



"CLYTEMNESTRA WATCHES FROM THE BATTLEMENTS OF
ARGOS FOR THE BEACON
FIRES WHICH ARE TO ANNOUNCE THE RETURN OF
AGAMEMNON." 1874
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



STUDY FOR "CLYTEMNESTRA." 1874
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



STUDY FOR "SUMMER MOON"

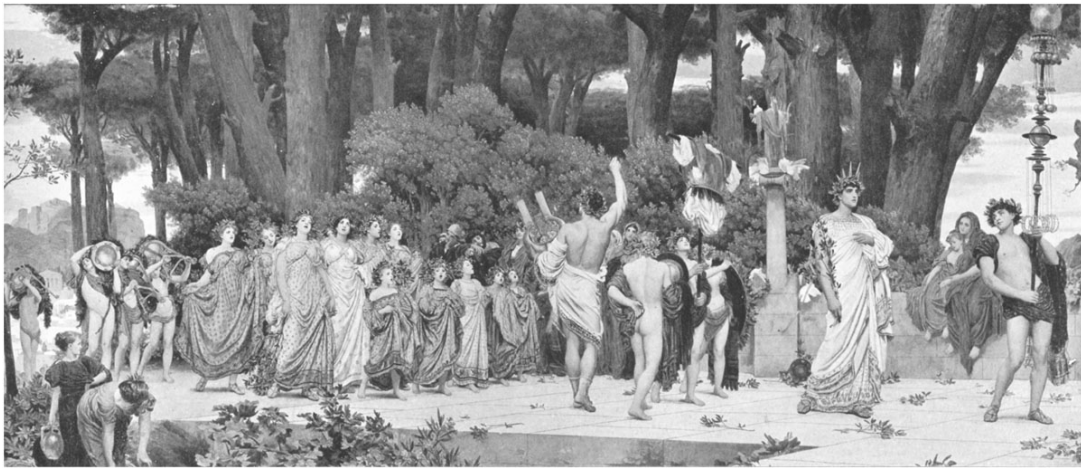
From Oil Sketch painted by Moonlight in Rome

Given by the late A. Waterhouse, R.A., to the Leighton House
Collection [ToList](#)

The bar of red, which strikes a warm note among the cool lights and shadows of moonlight, adding immensely to the value of these tones, was suggested by the coral necklace, worn by the model from whom Leighton painted the study by moonlight for "Summer Moon" in Rome. "Egyptian Slinger" was Leighton's principal work exhibited in 1875, "The Daphnephoria" already engrossing most of his time and thought. This picture (89 × 204 inches), "a triumphal procession held every ninth year at Thebes in honour of Apollo and to commemorate a victory of the Thebans over the Aeolians of Arne" (see Proclus, "Chrestomath," p. 11), and the very fine portrait of Sir Richard Burton were exhibited in 1876. From some points of view "The Daphnephoria" is Leighton's greatest achievement. The difficulties he surmounted successfully in the work were of a character with

which few English artists could cope at all. The size of the canvas alone would certainly have insisted on ten years' devotion to it from most modern artist-workmen. The extreme breadth of the arrangement of the masses, united with great beauty of line and form in the detail; the sense of the moving of a procession swinging along to the rhythmic phrases of chanted music; the brilliant light of Greece, striking on the fine surface of the marble platform along which the procession is moving and on the town below, which it has left behind, contrasting with the deep shadowed cypress grove rising as background to the figures;—all this is more than masterly: it is convincing. It is probably quite unlike what took place at Thebes every ninth year;—but Art is not Archæology. The written account of what took place fired Leighton's imagination to create a scene in which he treated the Greek function as the text; the wonderful light and the fineness of Greek atmosphere as the tone; the processional majesty and grace of movement as the action. The element of beauty which the record suggested to him was the truth of the scene to Leighton, and he has recorded the essence of it in an extraordinarily original work.

It was after Leighton's death that the picture first "struck home" to me. The last day of the exhibition of a wonderful man's life-work had come to an end one Saturday afternoon in the spring of 1897. It had been a record day at Burlington House; crowds had filled the galleries from morning till the light had begun to wane. Only a very few stragglers remained, but the keeper, Mr. Calderon, R.A., was there. One of the porters in his red gown came up to him, and petitioned for a half-hour more before the final closing of the doors on the message which Leighton had left to the world. Both men, the keeper and the porter, looked grave and sad. The great President had been beloved by all. The porter's request was granted, and it was during that short half-hour that I seemed for the first time fully to realise the great qualities of "The Daphnephoria"; the room being empty, it could be seen from the right distance, and the conception of the work and its completion spoke out very plainly and convincingly.



"THE DAPHNEPHORIA"—A TRIUMPHAL PROCESSION HELD
AT THEBES IN HONOUR OF APOLLO. 1876

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"AT A READING-DESK." 1877

By permission of Messrs. L.H. Lefevre & Son, the owners of the

Different as a picture could be was the exquisite "Music Lesson" of 1877. Again we have the lovely little Cleobouline, her delicate fingers learning to make music on a mandoline. The grouping and grace in the attitude of the teacher and the pupil, the ease and pleasant arrangement of the draperies, the texture and fine distinction in the feeling and technique of the work, can only be suggested by a reproduction; whereas to appreciate in any way the delicate brightness and charm of the colour is impossible without seeing the original. This is the one of all Leighton's paintings which—perhaps more than any other—conclusively contradicts the statement made, that "the inspiration stage was practically passed when he took the crayon in his hand." Another Cleobouline also appeared in the same Academy Exhibition—as fascinating as the little lady learning music; "Study" it was called—a child in a delightfully painted glistening pink silk dressing-gown, sitting cross-kneed on an Eastern carpet before an inlaid prayer-desk. Very characteristic of Leighton's bewitching painting of children's feet are the little toes of the child peeping out between the folds of pink drapery. The finest woman's portrait Leighton ever painted appeared the same year as a "Music Lesson." This was Miss Mabel Mills.^[47] The breadth and delicacy in the modelling of the cheek and throat rivals the work of Greek sculpture. The most serious work exhibited in 1877 was the bronze version of Leighton's "Athlete Strangling a Python,"^[48] the small sketch of which was made in 1874. This statue showed to the world his power as a sculptor. Every work he modelled evinced in an equal degree his consummate ability as such, though the more flexible treatment—in the modelled sketches for the "Python," the sleeping group in "Cymon and Iphigenia,"^[49] and the "Perseus and Andromeda"—may carry with it a greater charm than is found in the completed statues. The following letters from the French sculptor Dalou, the painter George Boughton, and Sir Edgar Boehm are testimonies to the effect which the "Python" in bronze, and the sketch, produced on artists at the time they were executed:—

217A GLEBE PLACE, CHELSEA, S.W.,
2 Mai 1877.

MON CHER LEIGHTON,—Si mes humbles félicitations peuvent vous toucher j'en serais très heureux.

J'espérais vous voir lundi dernier à l'Academy et vous complimenter comme vous le méritez pour votre belle statue. À quoi sert de gratter toute sa vie un morceau de terre, quand près de soi on voit tout à coup surgir un chef d'œuvre d'une main à qui la sculpture était jusque là restée étrangère?

Si j'étais envieux ce serait une belle occasion pour moi, mais loin de là j'ai été très heureux d'admirer votre œuvre, et très flatté de l'honneur qu'on a fait à ma pauvre terre cuite, en la plaçant en pendant avec votre bronze; c'est encore un bon souvenir de plus qui me viens de l'Academy et de vous, mon cher Leighton, car je sais toute la part que vous avez prise au déplacement dont ma figure a été l'objet.

Aussi croyez que je suis heureux de pouvoir me dire votre sincère admirateur et très reconnaissant ami,

J. DALOU.



"AN ATHLETE STRANGLING A PYTHON"

From small sketch, 1876 [ToList](#)

GROVE LODGE,
PALACE GARDENS TERRACE, KENSINGTON, W.,
December 11, 1874.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I fear that the note which I sent with the bronze did not explain itself sufficiently. I *meant* to ask you to *accept* it—"to have and to hold for yourself your heirs and assigns for ever," to speak legally.

I can in no way express the pleasure I felt when I saw your small study for the man battling with the serpent. I hope the report in the *Academy* that it is to be done life-size in bronze is true. It will be worthy to go with the best of the antiques. The other study for the singing maidens was delightful^[50] as the other was grand. To put it

in the picturesque parlance of the Far West, "I was knocked over and sat on." It will be a slight relief to give my words a little form and weight; as I am unfortunately not a Roman Emperor and have not a golden crown of laurel about me, pray do me the favour to accept the only thing I have worth sending.—Believe me, yours very sincerely,

GEO. H. BOUGHTON.

GROVE LODGE,
PALACE GARDENS TERRACE, KENSINGTON,
December 14, 1874.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I don't know which to admire most—the "sketch," as *you* call it (it seems "heroic" in size even now), or your great kindness in sending it to me. Now that I may enjoy it at my leisure—and I take my leisure very often—it seems finer even than I thought it was. Not merely the *spirit* of the antique, but the antique *itself*, and the "antique" I mean is the everlasting, the best mortal may ever hope to make.

This is, as far as my capacity for judging is worth, *sincere*. I know how perilous it is to say warmly what one feels, how it is put down as "gush" and "bad form"; but when in this very London fog of Art one sees a spark of pure light, there is some excuse for shouting with joy.

I should reproach myself with taking up overmuch of your time in this matter, but I know that you are very good-natured; besides you might have taken my poor little bronze tribute in as few words as I sent it, and there it might have ended—though for myself I am glad you did not, and shall be ever selfishly thankful that you acted as kindly as you did.

Pray don't bother to reply to this, I am too much your debtor already.—Yours very sincerely,

GEO. H. BOUGHTON.

78 CORNWALL GARDENS,
QUEEN'S GATE, *May 11, 1877.*

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I follow my instinct and sincere desire in congratulating you on your magnificent statue in the Academy, which I have just seen. It is superb. I think it the best statue of modern days. I was riveted with admiration and astonishment; and whatever you may think of my judgment, pray take this as my humble and heartfelt tribute to a work of genius, which to my mind ranks nearer "zur Antiken" than anything I have seen, during my career, produced in any school or country.

Believe me, with sincere admiration, yours,

J.E. BOEHM.

In 1890 Leighton made a replica of the statue in marble for the Glyptothek in Copenhagen. It was exhibited in the Royal Academy Exhibition in 1891.

Many were the voices heard exclaiming that Leighton ought to give himself entirely to sculpture. His masterly power in understanding form, and giving expression to it in Art, was readily understood and appreciated when he worked in the round, whereas it had been but scantily appreciated in his painting; the fact being, that the public is unaccustomed to find that power developed in modern pictures, whereas in sculpture it is the principal and obvious aim in any statue. However, whatever the public thought or expressed, Leighton went on painting. In 1878 "Nausicaa" and "Winding the Skein" were exhibited, both among Leighton's happiest works. A reticent grace in the attitude of the figure, and a tender yearning sadness in the face, makes this rendering of "Nausicaa" very attractive. "Winding the Skein" is the best example of those fair pictures which Leighton painted, and evidently delighted in painting, as records of Southern—and more particularly—Greek light and atmosphere. For the special charm in the tone and colouring to be understood, the picture itself must be seen; but the design and delightful feeling in the movement of the figures can be rendered in the reproduction. Again in this work the fascinating little figure of Cleoboulina appears and also the teacher in the "Music Lesson." In all,

Leighton painted thirty-six important pictures, twenty-six slighter works, [\[51\]](#) and executed his first statue, "Athlete Strangling a Python," in the ten years between 1869 and 1879.



"NAUSICAA." 1878 [ToList](#)

During these years the Royal Academy Exhibition took place in Burlington House, it having previously been held in a suite of rooms at the National Gallery in Trafalgar Square.

Leighton sent photographs of the cartoons for the "Industrial Arts of War" and of "Peace" [\[52\]](#) to Steinle, who wrote his criticisms on the designs. The following is Leighton's answer:—

Translation.]

February 3, 1874.

MY VERY DEAR FRIEND,—Your very welcome lines arrived auspiciously a few days ago. I need not say how delighted I am that you are not displeased with the two compositions of your old pupil, and that you recognise in them a not unworthy effort. I am especially grateful to you that while giving your approbation you have enclosed a criticism, and only regret that you have blamed but one thing, where there are unfortunately so many faults. I shall endeavour, if these cartoons ever come to be carried out, as far as possible to repress the faults which you remark in "Peace"; for, as I am by all means passionate for the true *Hellenic* art, and am touched beyond everything by its noble simplicity and its unaffected directness, so the *Roman* or Napoleonic at its highest is antipathetic to me—I had almost said disgusting. The two compositions are intended for a large court (where there are objects from all parts of the world and of all epochs); they will not, however, stand *near*, but opposite to one another. The figures will be life-size, the foremost ones almost colossal. The "Arts of Peace" I transported to Greece, partly out of sympathy, and partly on account of the special beauty of the Greek ceramic and jewel work; the conduct of arms seemed to me to find its highest expression in mediæval Italy, and I gladly seized this opportunity to tread the old path again in which my feet now so seldom wander.

If you really believe that my old friends in Frankfurt will be interested in these works, I shall be extremely pleased if you will put them in the Gallery; I wish only one thing, namely, that it may be made quite clear to the spectator that they are merely *cartoons*; their entire lack of effect would otherwise be surprising.

But the Pinta, of which you write, haunts my mind! If I had only time to run over myself!—but it is impossible.

Once more heartiest greetings, from your devoted pupil,

FRED LEIGHTON.

The Prince Consort, I believe, first conceived the idea of decorating spaces on the walls of the Victoria and Albert Museum with frescoes, as a memorial of the nation's gratitude on the close of the Crimean War, and

mentioned the subject to Leighton. It was not, however, till 1868 that Sir Henry Cole approached him officially on the subject in the following letter:

July 14, 1868.

SIR,—The Lords of the Committee of Council on Education having had under their consideration the subject of the permanent decoration of the lunettes at the ends of the South Court of the South Kensington Museum, have directed me to inquire if it would be agreeable to you to undertake to execute a picture for one of these lunettes, for which lunette their Lordships would be prepared to authorise a payment of £1000, it being understood that all rights of copying the work belong to the Department.

When the court is completed, there will be four lunettes of a similar size. At the present time, however, there are only two spaces actually ready; and should you be willing to accept the commission now offered to you, your picture would be placed in one of these two finished lunettes. Mr. Watts, R.A., has been asked to execute a similar commission for the second lunette; and, in order that the works may have a certain symmetry in respect of the scale of the figures, &c., it would be desirable that you should place yourself into communication with him.—I am, Sir, your obedient servant,

HENRY COLE.



STUDY FOR GROUP IN "THE ARTS OF PEACE,"
Victoria and Albert Museum. 1873
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



FIRST SKETCH FOR FIGURE OF CIMABUE
Carried out in Mosaic in the Victoria and Albert Museum, 1868[To List](#)



ORIGINAL SKETCH FOR THE FIGURE OF NICCOLA PISANO
Carried out in Mosaic in the Victoria and Albert Museum, 1868[To List](#)

Watts was not prepared to accept the commission to execute one of the frescoes, being already immersed in work which absorbed his whole time and attention. He did, however, accept the commission to make a cartoon for the figure of Titian to be worked in mosaic in one of the spaces which form a kind of frieze along the side of the Southern Court. Leighton, besides agreeing finally to paint frescoes on the lunettes at each end of the court, made cartoons in 1868 for two of these side spaces, one of the figure of Cimabue, the other of Niccolò Pisano. Sketches for these are in the Leighton House Collection. (See [List of Illustrations](#).)

A controversy took place between Leighton and Sir Henry Cole respecting the question whether these figures were to be treated pictorially or decoratively, whether the background was to be of plain gold mosaic or

whether there were to be objects depicted in perspective behind the figures. The following part of a letter from Leighton concluded the agreement.

I submit that I have given reasons *why* the figures under discussion should not be pictures, and that you, on the other hand, have not put forward a single reason *why*, a single principle on which they *should* be pictures. You have contented yourself with adducing some precedents; as the question, however, is entirely one of principles, precedent alone means nothing, one way or another; if it were not so, I should have opposed to you cases in which the, to my mind, sounder principle is observed.

Raphael's ceiling in the Vatican, for instance—an example you will scarcely cavil at. There is not in the whole range of art a single aberration that cannot be endorsed with some good name. To glance once more at the principle: whether the gold behind the figures be in effect the background of flat, or whether it be, as you hold, "essentially something round"; whether or not it be this, as I certainly assert, the wall throughout the decoration, it is unanswerably a conventional *abstraction*, it represents no concrete object, and as an *abstraction* is incompatible with any perspective representations of solid objects, which presuppose space and distance—everything that is on the *same* plane as the figure is submitted to the same conditions, hence any accessory on the pedestal is admissible; everything *beyond* the pedestal is part of the background, which may be abstract or concrete, as you please, but *cannot* logically be *both*.

I am the first to admit and admire the intimate connection which existed formerly between architecture and painting: to say "architecture and pictures," is to beg the whole question. In condemning the loose practice of modern times, you cannot propose upholding for admiration the mere fact that in old times picture and wall were sometimes one, but no doubt allude with just admiration to the harmony existing between them, in the best examples, and to the wise adaptation of the one to the other. You, I submit, are attacking and attempting to subvert the very principles on which this harmony rests; my sole desire is to assert and defend them, and I

earnestly desire that, actuated, as I am entirely convinced you are, more by the desire to forward the truth than to triumph in argument, the views I have put before you may eventually commend themselves to you, and deter you from further encouraging a practice which may be supported by precedent, but cannot be made tenable in theory.

In the autumn of 1873 Leighton visited Damascus, where he made studies for the picture exhibited in the 1874 Academy, "Old Damascus—Jews' Quarter,"^[53] and a fine sketch of the interior of the Grand Mosque which he enlarged into a picture 62 × 49 inches, and exhibited in 1875. He also made a remarkable moonlight study preserved in the Leighton House Collection.

"One afternoon, late in the autumn of 1872," wrote Dr. William Wright, "I was on the roof of my house trying to cool after a long ride in the sun, when there came a loud knock at my door; the latch was lifted, and presently a resplendent kavass mounted to my platform. He explained to me that a noble Englishman was coming up to see me, and with that Frederic Leighton skipped gaily up the steps. After a courteous greeting and apology, he sat down and became silent, absolutely wrapped up in the pageantry of the sky. When I excused myself for the lapse of the time, he looked at me, and said quietly, 'No artist ever wasted time in accurately observing natural phenomena,' and added, 'That sunset will mix with my paint, and will tint your ink as long as either of us lives. It will never be over, it has dyed our spirits in colours which can never be washed out.'"

To his father he wrote:—

DAMASCUS, *October 18, 1873.*

DEAR PAPA,—I find that I am not as completely cut off from the western world here as I have been led to believe I was, and that boats leave Damascus for Alexandria weekly, and not fortnightly, as

I told you in my hasty line of the other day; although, therefore, you are no longer uneasy about my health, I will not defer till the later boat thanking you for your welcome letter which reached me two or three days ago. I am much shocked and concerned to hear of the death of my poor friend Benson, for which I was in no way prepared, the last accounts I had received before leaving England being of a decidedly hopeful nature. A kinder heart never beat than his, and I felt really attached to him; he is a great loss to me. And now to tell you about myself. Three tedious days on board a Russian boat which tossed and rolled like a cork over a sea on which a P. and O. would have been motionless, brought me to Beyrout, a cheery, picturesque, sunny port at the foot of Lebanon; gay and glad I was to land, and Andrea's cool, clean inn overlooking the sea was a delightful haven of rest, and my first meal at a steady table (or a real chair) was ambrosial. Being in a hurry to get to the end of my journey, I did not stay more than half a day, but started by diligence for Damascus, a journey of some thirteen hours, first over Lebanon itself (which is fine, but by no means grand as I had hoped), then across the Valley of Coelesyria, and lastly over Antilebanon, at the foot of which the town lies. At the last relay I found waiting for me a horse and dragoman, for which and whom I had telegraphed in order that I might get the famous view of Damascus about which travellers have told wonders from time immemorial, and which is only to be seen from a bridle path over the hill above the suburb of Sala'aiejeh; unfortunately the days are getting short, and I did not reach the proper spot till just after sunset; not too late, however, to enjoy the marvellous prospect before me, and to feel that it is worthy of all that has been said in its praise. It is impossible to conceive anything more startling than the suddenness with which, emerging from a narrow and absolutely barren cleft in the rock, you see spread before your eyes and at your feet a dense mass of exuberant trees spreading for miles on to the plain which looks towards Palmyra, and, rising white in the midst of it, the Damascus of the thousand and one nights. It is a great and a rare thing for an old traveller not to be disappointed, and I am grateful that it has been so with me this time. About the town *itself*—as seen, I mean, *from within*—I have a mixed feeling. In some respects it equals all

my hopes, or at least in one respect; in others it falls short of them. I have remarked that to be prepared for disappointment never in the slightest degree deadens the blow, and, accordingly, although I have both read and been told to my heart's content that I should find the streets unpicturesque and without character, relatively of course (relatively say, to Cairo, not to Baker Street), I was, nevertheless, depressed and in a way surprised to find them so. Of course, there are, as in every Eastern town, numberless delightful bits, and those ennobled as regularly as the day comes by a right royal sun and canopy of blue, yet in the main, Cairo and, in a very different way, Algiers, are far more brilliant, and by-the-bye although you see here an extraordinary variety of costumes from the remotest corners of the East (I have met Indians in the streets), a group of Algerine Bedouins in their stately white robes is worth a whole bazaar full of the peasants and pilgrims that throng Damascus. Then in architecture, Damascus falls far behind Cairo, both for abundance and beauty of its specimens. Its background, too, Antilebanon, is unsatisfactory, humpy and without power of character or beauty of line, such as makes the Red Mountains on the skirt of the Cairene desert so delightful. Here then are the shortcomings; but I have my compensation in the houses, the old houses of which some few are standing, though grey and perishing, and which are still lovely to enchantment. I can't hope to convey to you in writing any idea of this loveliness, and it is not within the scope of sketching (though I am doing one or two little corners), but I am having three or four photographs made (for there are none!) from which you will be able to gather something of their charm. They cannot, however, give you the splendour of the light, and the fanciful delicacy of the colour in the open courts, or the intense and fantastic gorgeousness of the interior. Indeed I shall probably not attempt the latter, and though you will see lemon and myrtle trees rising tall and slim out of the marble floors and bending over tanks of running water, you will miss the vivid sparkling of the leaves, and you will not hear the unceasing song of the bubbling fountains. I wish I could report that I am doing much work. I am doing some, and think I see my way to one or two pot-boilers (the fatal, inevitable pot-boilers!); but distances here are great, and so is the heat, and there is not much

that is within the compass of *sketching*, though there is endless paintable material. I am doing a bit in the great mosque, which is very delightful to me, in colour, and, if I can render it, may strike others in the same way. I am having the spot photographed in case I try to make a picture of it. The second p.-b. would probably be some unambitious corner of a court with a figure or two, *et voilà*. It is late and I am sleepy, so good-night and good-bye. I wish you gave me a brighter account of Lina; give her too my best love. It was hardly worth while, by-the-bye, to have my letters forwarded. I shall only get them, if at all, just before leaving Damascus next week! I fear I can't get back to England till end of third week in November.—Your affectionate son,

FRED.

In the autumn of 1877 Leighton revisited Spain. A letter dated September 21, 1877, Madrid, in which Leighton answers certain questions asked by Mrs. Mark Pattison concerning art galleries and dealers, ends with the following sentence:—

Thank you for what you tell me about Puvis de Chavannes' work. I admire the designs for Ste. Geneviève hugely, and am altogether an *aficionado* of that odd, incomplete, but refined and poetic painter; but for emptiness of modelling he seeks his peer in vain. I am seeing Velasquez again for the third time; this is the place in which to see him in all his splendour, and in all his nakedness—but that would be a chapter, and not a hasty note.—Very truly yours,

FRED LEIGHTON.

From Spain Leighton crossed to Tangiers, whence he wrote:—

TANGIERS, *October 4, 1877.*

MY DEAR PAPA,—You are probably not a little surprised at the superscription of this letter; so am I. It was a sudden and a happy thought that brought me here. I reflected that, whilst I had long wished to see Tangiers, I should not very probably come to Spain

again, and should therefore not have another chance of visiting Morocco without a journey made on purpose. The run from Gibraltar is only four hours, and I wonder the trip did not form part of my original scheme. It will have one drawback for me, that I shall get to Granada a few days later, and be by so much the longer in getting news from England; but my journey will not be prolonged on the whole, as I shall endeavour to cut off at the end what I put on now. I the more owe myself what enjoyment I can get here, that as I told you—did I not?—in my last, my journey has been hitherto rather a dismal failure. I told you how vile the weather was in Madrid, so that all technical study of the pictures was out of the question. Well this is, since then, the first perfectly fine afternoon we have had. Observe, I only say afternoon, for it poured in the morning, and the phenomenon of a wholly bright day has still to come. I am also still further in arrears of enjoyment from the fact that I got rather out of order, God knows why, the day I went to Toledo, to the utter spoiling of what should have been one of my most delightful trips, and am only now pulling round again, having called in Æsculapius (at 2 dollars a consultation), whilst at Gibraltar. An attack of this nature is simply fatal to any real pleasure on one's journey, and, coming on the top of dark weather and the contretemps just as the closing of the Alcazar in Seville (one of the things I especially wanted to see) made rather an absurd failure of the whole thing. At Seville I was fool enough to go again to a bull-fight, and was so disgusted that I got up and went away when the performance was only half over. Meanwhile the aspect of the arena itself, with the Cathedral and its marvellous tower rising just above into the sky, is a very striking sight, and one I should regret to have missed. The processional entry, too, of the whole of the performers—picadors, capeadors, espadas, &c. &c.—is very picturesque and stately. It is when the goring and torturing begins that the sight is revolting; and the enormous popularity of this form of sport with a nation, not, that I am aware of, exceptionally cruel, only shows how easily our worst instincts stifle our better nature, such as it is.

This is a prodigiously picturesque place, and I enjoy more than I can say watching the Arabs swarming up the streets and markets, stately and grand in their picturesqueness beyond any population

that I know, and particularly instructive and valuable to an artist from the sculpturesque *definiteness* of their forms. The Jewish women here are said (by Ford) to be prodigiously handsome. I have seen no Rebeccas amongst them yet. I have not yet opened my box, and shall at best do little or nothing; I have no time. Next week I shall be in Granada, from where I hope to have to acknowledge a letter dated in Kensington Park Gardens. Meanwhile I am, with best love to Lina and yourself,—Yours affectionately,

FRED.

GRANADA, *October 19, 1877.*

MY DEAR PAPA,—To-morrow is my last day in Granada. On Sunday I turn my face Londonward, and my holiday will be pretty nearly at an end, as I have, from want of time, given up my original intention of seeing Valencia, Alicante, Tarragona, &c. &c. Travelling in Spain is so infinitely slower than I had remembered it, and so ideally inconvenient in regard to hours of starting and arriving, that my programme has altogether undergone considerable modifications. I reached this place a good week later than I expected, and I did not get your letter till some days later yet, owing, I suppose, to the difficulty experienced by the postal authorities in the art of reading. This will account to you for the time that will have elapsed between your receipt of my two epistles. I am truly sorry to hear that poor Lina is below par; tell her so, with my love. As you do not speak of yourself, I presume that you are in good form, and am glad to hear it. There is one passage in your letter which suggests to me a strong protest. I think it preposterous that the ambulant spinsters, or otherwise, with whom you foregather on your journeys, should expect *you* to furnish them with photos of your "celebrated son." I like enthusiasm; but *genuine* enthusiasm does not halt at a shilling, which is the sum for which my effigy is obtainable in the public market; *verb. sap.* I will not describe to you Toledo, Cordova, Seville, Granada, &c. (under which heads see Murray's guide-book). I have done so before (probably), and they have altered less than I, with the exception, perhaps, of Granada, or

rather the Alhambra, which, alas! is changed indeed, thanks to the restoring mania, and is now all but brand new. I ought, perhaps, to remark that the changes in *me* are not precisely in that direction. Taking a bird's-eye view of my holiday, I don't think I should call it altogether a success, though I have had many very delightful moments, and have seen many very beautiful things; but, in the first place, I have failed to fulfil one of the special objects of my trip, that, namely, of making a few sketches of sky effects, particularly seaside skies, which I sorely want for my picture of the girls and the skein of worsted. I have not done so, because I have not *once* seen anything even resembling the skies I mean, and which are generally forthcoming at this season. The weather has indeed of late been fine, often if not always, and here even, at times, superb; but it is the before the rains, and not, as it should be, the clear, keen, autumn weather, after the air has been well swept and purged by the equinoctial broom and pail, which I had a right to demand of a Mediterranean October. This is a great disappointment. I did not want to *work*, and God knows I have not (five little sketches in all!); but just this document I did peremptorily require. In the second place, I have been rather seedy (am all right now), not very, but enough to poison my pleasure; and just so much that, after two or three little amateur attempts (local apothecary, fellow-travellers, &c. &c.), I thought it right (at Gibraltar) to see a doctor, not *because* I was ill, but *lest* I should get worse and develop more serious symptoms, as internal disturbance occasionally does in hot countries. In a few days (and two large bottles of physic) I was much better, and am now, I repeat, quite "myself" again.

But I perceive that this uninteresting twaddle has filled my paper, and barely left me space to tell that I have been to Africa, and shall be home on the 28th (evening). Yes, to Africa; Tangiers in four hours' steam from Gibraltar, and a most picturesque spot, of which more when we meet. On my way home I shall spend part of a day in Madrid, in the hopes of seeing the pictures this time. On my road through France I shall make a short break at Poitiers. *À bientôt*.—
Affectionate son,

FRED.

During the nine years that Leighton was a Royal Academician he worked most energetically in many directions towards establishing the principles which he considered sound and essential to the growth of the best Art instincts in England. He was one of the Professional Examiners in Art from 1866 to 1875 at the Victoria and Albert Museum. In 1884 he became one of the Art Referees for the Museum, and was consulted by Sir Henry Cole to a considerable extent. He aided, as far as lay in his power, all Art Societies to expand and to grow on the lines of Catholicity. He was a member of the Committee of the Society of Dilettanti, for the purpose of obtaining information as to the probable success of renewed search for monuments of Greek Art. The following extract from a report proves what an active part he took in the business of the society:—

"In the autumn of the same year two hundred cases of inscriptions and sculptures from Priene were transported from Priene to Smyrna, and thence conveyed to England in H.M.S. *Antelope*. In March 1870 the society presented these marbles to the trustees of the British Museum. In May 1870 the committee, then consisting of Earl Somers, Lord Houghton, Mr. Watkiss Lloyd, Mr. Penrose, Mr. Cartwright, Mr. Leighton, and Mr. Newton, held several meetings. The committee at their meetings went carefully over all the drawings and details obtained by the society of the Temple of Bacchus at Teos, Apollo Smintheus, and Minerva Polias at Priene; they were of opinion that they would form an interesting and valuable publication, and should be proceeded with as soon as possible, and executed in a style worthy of the former productions of the society. Mr. Leighton offered to redraw the sculpture on some of the friezes, and Lord Somers to prepare the landscape illustrations."

In 1871 the President of the Artist Benevolent Fund, Mr. J.K. Kempton Hope, wrote to Leighton: "I am peculiarly proud that the first act which I have to perform in my new character is to say how honoured and grateful

we all should be if you would kindly consent to accept the position of Vice-President."

The following letter to his father announces that Leighton had been elected President of the International Jury of Painting, Paris Exhibition, 1878:—

HÔTEL WESTMINSTER, 1878,
Friday.

DEAR PAPA,—I have been waiting to write till I should have something to say beyond the fact that the weather is odious, and shows no signs of relenting. On Saturday afternoon we had our meeting of the Royal Commissioners, which had for its object the hearing of an address from the Prince of Wales. On Monday morning the *whole* International Jury (some six hundred or seven hundred members) met at the Ministère de Commerce, and was little more than formal. *To-day* the group of sections which are concerned with Art held its first meeting under the presidency of Signor Tullio Massarani, an Italian, with Meissonier as Vice-President, the chief object of the meeting being to inform the various sections of the groups whom the Minister had appointed as their respective presidents. My section, composed of forty members, is *Paintings and Drawings*; there are twenty Frenchmen—nearly all the first artists of the country, in fact—and you will be surprised and very much gratified to learn that I was named president of this section—a very high honour, of course, and one of which I am extremely sensible, but which we must not misinterpret; it is, of course, only by an act of international courtesy that the French placed a foreigner at the head of their section, and amongst the other foreign artists there were few names of much weight or standing; still, it is a courtesy which will, I am sure, give you pleasure. Our section being thus constituted, we then appointed our own *vice-president*, reporter, and secretary; they were unanimously elected; the first was my old friend, Robert Fleury; the second was Emile de Savelege, the Belgian writer whom you know of; and the third an old and kind friend of mine, Maurice Cottier, a man much mixed up in the official artistic world and possessing a magnificent picture gallery.

To-morrow we begin our labours at the Exhibition, and in the afternoon I shall go to the *séance* of the *Institut*, which always takes place on Saturdays. This is my budget.

Perhaps the most important work inside the Academy which Leighton effected during this time was that of establishing the winter exhibitions of Old Masters at Burlington House. No one exemplified practically better than did Leighton the value of the motto, "What is worth having is worth sharing." He had been fed from early youth from the fountain-heads of Art, and one of his first objects after being elected a member of the Royal Academy was to endeavour to secure the same inspiring stimulus for students which he had himself imbibed from the work of the greatest men. He told me also that his chief object in making conscientious studies in colour when he travelled, was to endeavour to convey to students who were not able to go abroad some idea of the varieties in the aspects of nature found in different countries. Leighton was much appreciated in London society, but the *intimes* of the old Roman days remained still the nucleus of his friendships; also every year he tried to find himself in his beloved Italy, and he generally succeeded. From his old friend Lady William Russell, mother of Odo Russell (afterwards Lord Ampthill and Leighton's ally in Rome), and Arthur Russell—the notable lady whose charm attracted to her *salon* all that was most interesting among the magnates of Europe—two notes record her affection for Leighton and the death of Henry Greville in 1872, the severest blow which Leighton had sustained since the death of his mother.

I was in hopes of seeing you, to thank you *vivâ voce* for the *ambrosia* you sent me from Italy. I did *not* write during your pictorial tour, not exactly knowing *where* you might be. It was, *and is*, for I have some still, *excellent*; Paolo Veronese did not eat any better, nor Titian, nor any of your *Brethren in Apollo*.

Guido you *are*—the English Guido—but *not* "da Polenta"; I will *not* accept that "terre à terre" denomination. I now thank you most gratefully—it was one of the seven works of mercy, for I really could not eat and was *starving*. The Indian cornflour was a *renovation*. If ever you can make up your mind to pay a visit to una

povera vealisa—zoppa—sorda—brutta and seccante, and forget "Aurora," I shall be charmed. But I know that your time is better employed; so a million of thanks, and as many regrets not to be able to see your *marvels* of which I hear.—Believe me, most sincerely your obliged Serva and Amica,

E.A.R.

2 AUDLEY SQUARE MAYFAIR, W.
Sunday, 26th November 1871.

DEAR GUIDO (but *not* of Polenta),—I have been quite *mortified* at your neglect of me, and invoked the muses in vain! and call'd on the ghosts of Titian and Raffael, but they did not heed my sighs! I am always glad to see you, and wish I could *see your works*! All my cotemporaries and comrades are dying off, and I *cannot* last long—so come to my "Evenings at Home" when you dine in my "Quartier" and are going to your club.

Alas! for dear Henry Greville! I knew him from his most early youth. *Both* his parents were my *early* friends from *my* youth, and his elder brother my cotemporary.

Come! Benvenuto Cellini—venite!

Monday, February 1873.

Leighton's passion for music led him to encourage all that was best in instrumental as well as in vocal performance. The Monday Popular Concerts were started by Messrs. Chappell in 1859, the first being given on the 3rd January. From their commencement Leighton was a subscriber, and very rarely missed being present.

It was in the 'seventies that Leighton instituted those yearly feasts of music, which were among the real treats of the year.^[54] His dear friend Joachim was to the end the *pièce de résistance* of these gatherings. Never did the Great Master seem so inspired as when he played in that studio. Leighton wrote to his sister, Mrs. Matthews, April 1871:—

DEAREST GUSSY,—You heard, no doubt, that I gave a party the other day, and that it went off well. To me perhaps the most striking thing of the evening was Joachim's playing of Bach's "Chacone" up in my gallery. I was at the other end of the room, and the effect from the distance of the dark figure in the uncertain light up there, and barely relieved from the gold background and dark recess, struck me as one of the most poetic and fascinating things that I remember. At the opposite end of the room in the apse was a blazing crimson rhododendron tree, which looked glorious where it reached up into the golden semi-dome. Madame Viardot sang the "Divinités du Styx," from the "Alceste," quite magnificently, and then, later in the evening, a composition of her own in which I delight—a Spanish-Arab ditty, with a sort of intermittent mandoline scraping accompaniment. It is the complaint of some forsaken woman, and wanders and quavers in a doleful sort of way that calls up to me in a startling manner visions and memories of Cadiz and Cordova, and sunny distant lands that smell of jasmine. A little Miss Brandes, a pupil of Madame Schumann, played too. She is full of talent and promise, and has had an immense success. Mme. Joachim sang "Mignon" (Beethoven) excellently.



Sketch executed on the spot by Mr. Theodore Blake Wirgman of their Majesties the King and Queen attending a Popular Concert in St. James's Hall, Lord Leighton being one of the Royal party. About 1893.[ToList](#)

Mrs. Watts Hughes writes the following notes relating to those years of the 'seventies:—

I remember the incident you refer to at Eton College. The *Orfeo* performance was given by the Eton boys, who had formed a society among themselves with the view of making acquaintance with the music of the great masters. I took the part of *Orfeo*, and a niece of Darwin's, Miss Wedgwood, who is now Lady Farrer, sang Euridice's part. I believe Lord Leighton sang in some of the quartettes and choruses. I often met Lord Leighton at Mrs. Sartoris' musical gatherings at her house in Park Place, St. James', when he would sing very heartily the tenor parts of the old madrigals, in which also Mrs. Douglas Freshfield, Miss Ritchie, and others took part with

Mrs. Sartoris, who on some occasions would sing one of her great operatic *Arias* which brought her so much fame in her former years.

In 1877 Leighton began to build the famous Arab Hall.^[55]

The following letters from Sir Richard Burton refer to the collecting and sending of one instalment of the precious tiles:—

DAMASCUS, *March 22, 1871.*

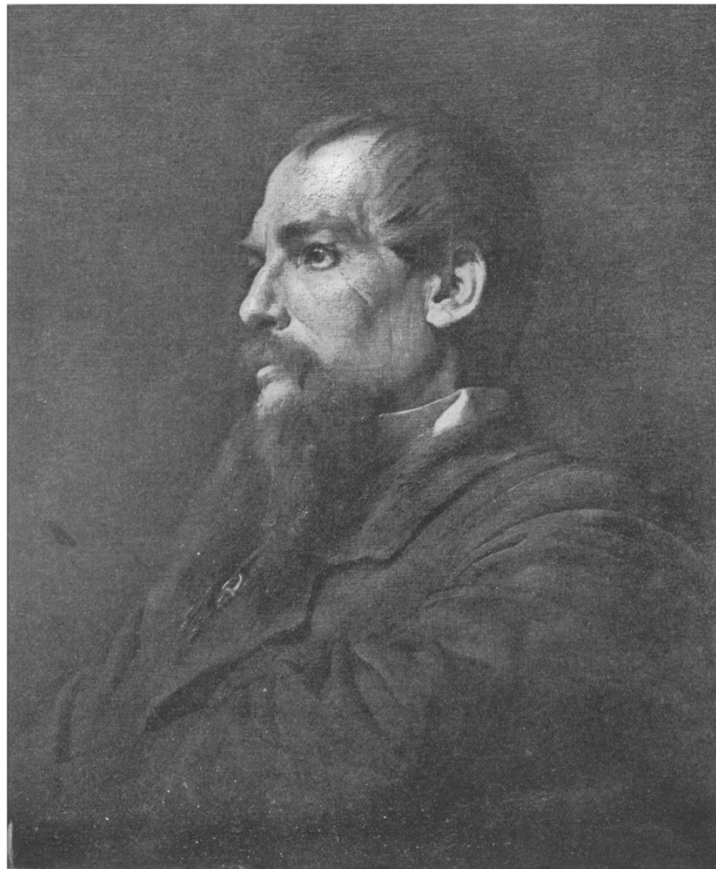
DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I have just returned from a pilgrimage to Jerusalem, or yours of April 14th, 1871, would not have remained so long unanswered. And now to business. I am quite as willing to have a house pulled down for you now as when at Vichy,^[56] but the difficulty is to find a house with tiles. The *bric-à-brac* sellers have quite learned their value, and demand extravagant sums for poor articles. Of course you want good old specimens, and these are waxing very rare. My friends, Drake and Palmer, were lucky enough, when at Jerusalem, to nobble a score or so from the so-called Mosque of Omar. Large stores are there found, but unhappily under charge of the Wakf, and I fancy that long payments would be required. However, I shall send your letter to my colleague, Moore, who will do what he can for you. The fact is, it is a work of patience. My wife and I will keep a sharp look-out for you, and buy up as many as we can find which seem to answer your description. If native inscriptions—white or blue, for instance—are to be had, I shall secure them, but not if imperfect. Some clearing away of rubbish is expected at Damascus; the Englishman who superintends is a friend of mine, and I shall not neglect to get from him as much as possible.

We met Holman Hunt at Jerusalem; he was looking a little worn, like a veritable denizen of the Holy City. I hope that you have quite recovered health. Swinburne, the papers say, has been sick; his "Songs before Sunrise" show even more genius than "Poems and Ballads." What has become of Mrs. Sartoris? I saw her son's appointment in the papers. Poor Vichy must be quite ruined—veritably it was a Cockney hole. Syria is a poor Chili; the Libanus is

a mole-hill compared with the Andes—do you remember? I am planning a realistic book which has no Holy Land on the brain, and the public will curse her like our army in Flanders. Pilgrims see everything through a peculiar medium, and tourists shake hands (like madmen) when they sight the Plain of Esdraelon or Sharon, as the case may be.

N.B.—Both plains are like the poorer parts of our midland counties. My wife joins in kind remembrances.—Ever yours sincerely,

RICHARD F. BURTON.



PORTRAIT OF SIR RICHARD BURTON, K.C.M.G. 1876[ToList](#)

TRIESTE, *July 13, 1876.*

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—One word to say that the tiles are packed, and will be sent by the first London steamer—opportunities are rare here. Some are perfect, many are broken; but they will make a bit of mosaic after a little trimming, and illustrate the difference between Syriac and Sindi. They are taken from the tomb (Moslem) of Sakhar, on the Indus. I can give you analysis of glaze if you want it; but I fancy you don't care for analyses. The yellow colour is by far the rarest and least durable apparently. The blues are the favourites and the best.

Here we are living in a typhoon of lies. I am losing patience, and shall probably bolt to Belgrade in search of truth. Austria is behaving in her usual currish manner, allowing her policy to be managed by a minority of light-headed, Paddy-whack Magyars and pudding-headed, beer-brained Austro-Germans. How all Europe funks the Slavs, and how well the latter are beginning to know it.

Very grand of *la grande Bretagne* to propose occupying Egypt without any army to speak of. Sorry that you don't understand the force of the expression, the "world generally," but will try some time or other to make it clear. United best regards and wishes. Why don't you take a holiday to Turkey?—Ever yours,

R.F. BURTON.

P.S.—I hear that W. Wright has subsided into an Irish conventicle, and that Green doesn't like prospect of returning to Dan!

The construction of this thing of beauty, the Arab Hall, is a visible and permanent proof of the side in Leighton's artistic endowments which are so rarely found in northern, or indeed any modern nations, and the want of which are gradually leading our world into being very ugly—namely, the sense of the appropriate, of balance, of proportion, and of harmony in the construction and decoration of buildings. As an adherent of the pre-Raphaelites, William Morris had been battling with this tasteless condition of things for some years—strenuously working to counteract the unmeaning adaptations of foreign designs of all times and of all countries into English work, and the general muddledom into which the decoration in the surroundings of domestic life had fallen, by starting afresh on the lines of

simple good designs of English pre-Puritan days. Leighton's taste had been inspired, in the first instance, by the crafts as well as by the art of Italy. Subsequently, the East had fascinated him. He admired greatly the frank, courageous beauty in the colouring of the decorations of her buildings; but, having an acute sense of the appropriate, he felt that they would not harmonise successfully with the necessary surroundings of English domestic life. He was therefore inspired to erect a special shrine for his collection of enamels. It has been truly said that the Arab Hall is as notable a creation in Art as any of Leighton's pictures or statues. The beauty of its effect is greatly enhanced by the arrangement of light and shade which leads on to the wonderfully beautiful casket of treasures. Monsieur Choisy, the distinguished French architect, wrote as follows in the *Times* of April 27, 1896, when advocating the preservation of this house for the public: "Nowhere have I found in an architectural monument a happier gradation of effects, nor a more complete knowledge of the play of light. The entrance to the house is by a plain hall that leads to a '*patio*' lit from the sky, where enamels shine brilliantly in the full light; from this '*patio*' one passes into a twilight corridor, where enamel and gold detach themselves from an architectural ground of richness somewhat severe; it is a transition which prepares the eye for a jewel of Oriental Art, where the most brilliant productions of the Persian potter are set in architectural frame inspired by Arab Art, but treated freely; the harmony is so perfect that one asks oneself if the architecture has been conceived for the enamels, or the enamels for the hall. This gradation, perhaps unique in contemporary architecture, was Leighton's idea; and the illustrious painter found in his old friend Mr. G. Aitchison, who built his house, a worthy interpreter of his fine conception. This hall, where colour is triumphant, was dear to Leighton, and even forms the background to some of his pictures. Towards the end of his life he still meant to embellish it by substituting marble for that small part that was only painted. The generous employment of his fortune alone prevented him from realising his intention.

"England has at all times given the example of honouring great men; she will, I am sure, find the means of preserving for Art a monument of which she has such reason to be proud."[\[57\]](#)



VIEW OF ARAB HALL. 1906 [ToList](#)

FOOTNOTES:

[42] In the Leighton House Collection is a splendid study for the wrestling figure of Heracles, also for the recumbent Alcestis, and the drapery for the phantom figure of Death. The figure of Heracles, fine as it is in the picture, lacks somewhat of the ardent quality in the action of the sketch. Owing to the public-spirited generosity of its owner, the late Right Hon. Sir Bernhard Samuelson, this picture has travelled all over the world for exhibition. It was also lent to Leighton House for more than a year in 1901.

[43] In the Leighton House Collection is a head in oils (presented by the late Alfred Waterhouse, R.A.) which Leighton painted actually by moonlight in Rome, as a study for one of the figures in "Summer Moon." See [List of Illustrations](#).

[44] See study for picture in Leighton House Collection.

[45] Leighton had a cast made of this, and his copy is still in the collection in his house. Another copy he gave to Watts, who admired it beyond measure. Watts recounted to me that so preciously did he value it, that, not daring to expose it to the danger of housemaids' dusting, he carefully wrapped it up in handkerchiefs and put it in a drawer. One day, alas! forgetting it was there, in a hurry, he pulled the bundle of handkerchiefs out; it fell to the floor and was smashed.

[46] *The Athenæum* described the work when it appeared. "There is the grandeur of Greek tragedy in Mr. Leighton's 'Clytemnestra watching for the signal of her husband's return from Troy.' The time is deep in the fateful night, while the city sleeps; moonlight floods the walls, the roofs, the gates, and the towers with a ghastly glare, which seems presageful, and casts shadows as dark as they are mysterious and terrible. The dense blue of the sky is dim, sad, and ominous. But the most ominous and impressive element of the picture is a grim figure—the tall woman on the palace roof before us, who looks Titanic in her stateliness, and huge beyond humanity in the voluminous white drapery that wraps her limbs and bosom. Her hands are clenched and her arms thrust down straight and rigidly, each finger locked as in a struggle to strangle its fellow; the muscles swell on the bulky limbs. Drawn erect and with set features, which are so pale that the moonlight could not make them paler, the queen stares fixedly and yet eagerly into the distance, as if she had the will to look over the very edge of the world for the light to come."

[47] The Hon. Mrs. Grenfell.

[48] Purchased by the trustees of the Chantrey Bequest and placed in the Tate Gallery.

[49] Leighton gave this group to Watts, who expressed to me an unbounded admiration for it. "Nothing more beautiful has ever been done! Pheidias never did anything better. I believe it was better even than Pheidias!" were the words Watts used when deploring the fact that he had lent it to a sculptor to be cast—something had gone wrong in the process of casting, and it had been destroyed. When giving me the modelled sketch for the "Python," Watts said, "I am giving you the most beautiful thing I have in my place."

[50] The group of singing girls modelled as a study for "The Daphnephoria."

[51] See complete list in [Appendix](#).

[52] The "Arts of War" lunette was commenced in 1870 and finished in 1880. The "Arts of Peace," begun in 1881, was completed in 1886. An account of these two frescoes appeared in the *Magazine of Art* written by Mr. J. Ward, the master of the Macclesfield School of Art, who assisted Leighton in the work.

[53] In a letter from Mr. J.G. Hodgson, A.R.A., praises are bestowed on this picture and the "Moorish Garden" at the expense of "Clytemnestra" and the "Antique Juggling Girl." The letter is a good example of the criticisms which Leighton's serious work often received—that work in which, nevertheless, he was most true to himself. The ordinary English eye neither longed for nor appreciated Leighton's native Hellenic strain.

5 HILL ROAD,
Friday, April 4, 1874.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I was immensely delighted with your two pictures of the Jew's house and the Alhambra ("Moorish Garden: A Dream of Granada"). I was at the opera last night, but thought much less of Crispin and his Comara than of them; they are quite charming, and excite me with the desire of emulation, at that safe distance which is inherent in the nature of things. For your "Clytemnestra" and the other ("Antique Juggling Girl"), I, being a Philister, care nothing at all. From those to turn to these, seems like leaving a garden fragrant with roses and citron blossoms, where I hear the murmur of cooling streams, Abanah and Pharpar, rivers of Damascus, to enter a museum filled with dusty plaster casts.

After all, the woes of the house of Atreus are now of very little importance to mankind, or interest either. The most of the latter they possess, is that they serve as themes for some good Greek play, which had better have been burnt, as they have hampered the genius of modern Europe and taught us nothing. Had only Homer and the lyrics survived, we should have done better. At all events, if a man must illustrate, why does he not illustrate Shakespeare, a bigger man head and shoulders than any of the Greek tragedists? But it appears to me you are made for a much better and more intellectual purpose than illustrating anybody. You have the eye to see and power to represent what you see. You have special gifts and faculties highly trained. The aspect of nature, as it appears to such a mind, would be of the highest intellectual value to us, and would lead to progress. I don't think modern art differs from that of any other day. It has always been the effort to represent what is seen every day, bringing to bear upon the representation the greatest possible amount of culture, *i.e.* of reflection and selection. The women and that dear little girl in the courtyard of your Jew's house will outlive all the "Clytemnestras," &c.; they live with blood in their veins, the others are but galvanised corpses. There I have had it out; you must not complain, because you have had to apologise for slashing into me, and now it is my turn. In the prologue to Goethe's "Faust," if you remember, the poet, a stubborn fellow, has his notions of the high aim of his art. He will do nothing but what is extremely sublime, &c. The clown quite agrees that such things may possibly do for the future, but who, says he, is to amuse the present? I am that sort of clown, I suppose. Don't be riled, and believe me,—Very much your admiring friend,

J.G. HODGSON.

[54] Mr. William Spottiswoode wrote of one of these:—

"DEAR LEIGHTON,—Best of thanks from Mrs. Spottiswoode and myself for another of the happiest day-dreams of the year, viz. your afternoons at home."

[55] Mr. Aitchison, R.A., wrote: "During his visits to Rhodes, to Cairo, and Damascus, he made a large collection of lovely Saracenic tiles, and had besides bought two inscriptions, one of the most delicate colour and beautiful design, and the other sixteen feet long and strikingly magnificent, besides getting some panels, stained glass, and lattice-work from Damascus afterwards; these were fitted into an Arab Hall, something like La Zira at Palermo, in 1877."

The Arab Hall was begun November 1877, virtually completed by the end of 1879, but some small matters not till 1881. Materials—Bastard statuary, *i.e.* the marble columns in the angle recesses. These caps are of alabaster, designed by George Aitchison, R.A., and modelled by Sir E. Boehm. The large columns are of Caserta marble, caps of stone, birds modelled by Caldecott; column niches lined with Devonshire spar; dado, Irish black; string, Irish green, and bases of small columns. Those of the large columns are of Genoa green and Belgian blue; the marble lining behind big columns is of Pyrennean green, and the panel overhead; the lintel of Irish red. The marble work was done by White & Son, Vauxhall Bridge Road. Mosaic floor, designed by George Aitchison, R.A.; executed by Messrs. Burke & Co., who replaced fountain of white marble with the single slab of Belgian black. Chandelier, designed by G.A. Aitchison, R.A., executed by Forrest & Son, now extinct. The lattices to the lower part of the gallery designed by George Aitchison, R.A.

Sir Caspar P. Clarke wrote: "I was commissioned in 1876, by the authorities at South Kensington, to proceed to the East to buy artistic objects for the Museum. Before I started Leighton asked me, if I went to Damascus, to go to certain houses and try to effect the purchase of certain tiles. I had no difficulty in finding my market, for Leighton, with his customary precision, had accurately indicated every point about the dwellings concerned, and their treasures. I returned with a precious load, and in it some large family tiles, the two finest of which are built into the sides of the alcove of the Arab Hall. Leighton made no difficulty about the price, and insisted upon paying double what I had given. He never spoke of picking things up cheap, and scouted the idea of 'bargains in Art objects.'"

[56] Leighton, Sir Richard Burton, Algernon Swinburne, and Adelaide Sartoris passed some weeks together at Vichy in September 1869. Swinburne wrote in 1875: "We all owe so much to Leighton for the selection and intention of his subjects—always noble, always beautiful—and these are always worthy of a great and grave art."—"Essays and Studies," A.C. Swinburne.

[57] Letters from Lord and Lady Strangford to Leighton exist on matters concerning the East, on which both were great authorities.

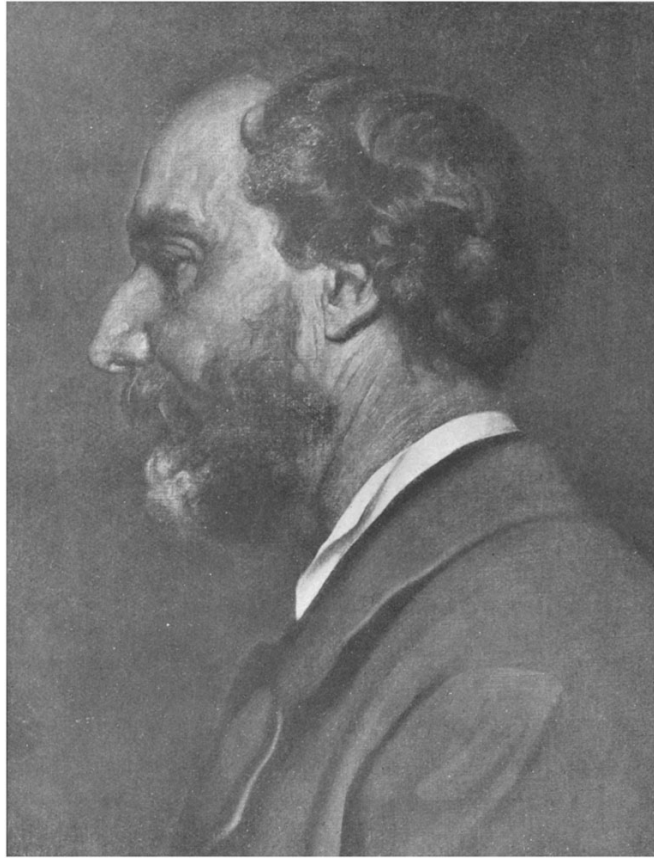
"Will you accept," Lady Strangford wrote, "as a token of my admiration of your house, a piece of ancient Persian needlework? It is really old, and it is said that they no longer do anything of the kind in Persia, and that these pieces are valuable. I do not know if this is true or not, but *if you like* the thing, please use it among the many treasures you have already accumulated. It is to my eyes a nice bit of harmonious colouring. Let it say to you how much, how very much, I enjoyed your sketches.—Yours very truly,

E.A. STRANGFORD.

"P.S.—I bought the work from a Persian at Antioch."

To Professor Church Mr. Aitchison wrote after Leighton's death: "I cannot urge the preservation of his home and surroundings, as I built the house, for there are always too many to attribute low motives to everybody, and it would be called personal advertisement; though when one's work is done it becomes almost impersonal, and if it did not, the fact remains the same, that here he (Leighton) lived and drew part of his culture and inspiration from his surroundings. As a

mere matter of reverence, how many would come from all parts of the civilised world to see his abode!"



PROFESSOR GIOVANNI COSTA
Painted at Lerici, October 1878[ToList](#)

CHAPTER V[ToC](#)

LEIGHTON AS PRESIDENT OF THE ROYAL ACADEMY

1878-1896

Leighton was at Lerici in the autumn of 1878, visiting his dear old friend Giovanni Costa ("an artist in a hundred—a man in ten thousand," were Leighton's words describing him), when he received a telegram stating that Sir Francis Grant was dead. "The President is dead! Long live the President!" exclaimed Costa. Leighton remained in Italy, sketching landscapes and painting heads—one, the portrait of Costa—till his holiday was over, the end of October. On the 18th of November he was elected President of the Royal Academy. Thirty-five Academicians voted for Leighton, five for Mr. Horsley.

Leighton wrote to his younger sister:—

1878.

DEAREST GUSSY,—You perhaps have heard from Lina that I had an overwhelming majority, and that the outer world beyond artistic has warmly received my election, which is of course infinitely gratifying, but fills me with a dread of disappointing everybody. Monday I go to Windsor to be knighted. Yes, I got a first-class gold medal for my statue^[58]—at least, it was awarded, and I shall get it some time. I also don't mind telling you in *strict confidence*—because it is not yet a *fait accompli*—that I am, I believe, to have the "ruban" of an Officier de la Légion d'Honneur. I am so glad, dear, your wrists are better—may they keep so. Love to old Joseph (Joseph Joachim) when you see him.

Most treasured of all congratulations were doubtless these lines from his beloved master, Steinle:—

Translation.]

FRANKFURT AM MAIN,
December 1, 1878.

DEAR AND HONOURED FRIEND,—To-day I have read in the paper that the choice of President of the Royal Academy has fallen upon you, and since I am convinced that this distinguished position is both appropriate to your services to art, and also certainly well merited, you must permit an old friend, who remains bound to you in love only, to offer you his dearest and warmest good wishes upon this honour. I pray God, that your position may provide you with great power in your country for good so as to enable you to encourage the noblest things in art. I am convinced that you, dear friend, will make a right and fruitful use of it. I often set my pupils to make enlarged drawings of single groups from your medieval Equipment for the Defence of the Town,^[59] and rejoice in the admirable studies which you made for that cartoon. I, dear friend, am in my old age still active and industrious, and would gladly go on learning. Should God grant life, I shall next year complete my work on the Strassburg master, which will demand all my love and strength. Here we have now built a new gallery, on the other side of the river Main, and a new studio. The collections are good, and more suitably accommodated than heretofore, and there is no want of space for future additions. Perhaps one of your journeys will bring you again to the old Main town, and so to the arms of your old friend. My dear President, I repeat my good wishes, and remain with all my heart, your truly devoted,

EDW. STEINLE.

From his birthplace Leighton received the following announcement:—

BOROUGH OF SCARBOROUGH.

At a meeting of the Council of the Borough of Scarborough, in the County of York, held in the Town Hall in the said Borough, on Monday the ninth day of December, 1878,—

Present,—

THE MAYOR (W.C. LAND, Esq.) in the chair,—

It was moved by the Mayor, seconded by Alderman Woodall, and resolved unanimously: "That this Council learns with peculiar

satisfaction and pleasure of the election of a native of Scarborough, in the person of SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON, to the Presidency of the Royal Academy, and respectfully offers to Sir Frederic its warm congratulations, and records its conviction that his great talents as an artist, his attainments as a scholar, and his many striking qualifications, eminently fit him to adorn the high position to which he has been called."

W.C. LAND, Mayor.

Robert Browning wrote:—

19 WARWICK CRESCENT, W.,
November 14, 1878.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I wish you joy with all my heart, and congratulate us all on your election. There ought to have been no sort of doubt as to the result, but the best of us are misconceived sometimes, though in your case never was a right more incontestable. All I hope is that your new duties will in no way interfere with the practice of your Art. I only venture to write, now, as one who, so many a year ago, saw your beginning with "Cimabue," and from that time to this remained confident what your career would be. But you know all this, and it requires no answer, being rather a spurt of satisfaction at my own original discernment than any assurance which I can fancy you need from,—Yours very truly,

ROBERT BROWNING.

Pen's letter to me, two days since, contained his earnest wishes for what has just happened, and he will be delighted accordingly.

From Matthew Arnold:—

ATHENÆUM CLUB, PALL MALL, S.W.,
November 15.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—One line (which you need not answer) to say how delighted I am to see what an excellent choice the Royal Academy has made.

I only hope poor O'Connor may not take advantage of the occasion to plant an ode and a letter.—Ever sincerely yours,

MATTHEW ARNOLD.

From Hubert Herkomer:—

November 27, 1878.

MY DEAR SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON,—I am just recovering from an attack of brain fever, and although I am not allowed yet to write, I can no longer wait without dictating a letter to express my own individual pleasure at your being the new President.

Three years ago you wrote me a letter after seeing my "Chelsea Pensioners." Perhaps you little dreamt of the tears of joy that that letter caused in a young painter, who will always feel that he owes you a debt of gratitude; and now he glories in your being the chief of that body which attracts to it all the principal art of the country. All England feels that you, from your new position, will give new life to it. Perhaps you will allow me, when I am sufficiently recovered, to come and see you.

In the meantime believe me to be, with most heartfelt congratulations,—Sincerely yours,

A.H., *pro* HUBERT HERKOMER.

SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON, P.R.A.

A friend writes:—

November 15.

DEAR MR. LEIGHTON,—I have tried to keep silence, telling myself that it cannot matter what I think or feel on the subject (and that it

may seem to you a very unnecessary proceeding!); but I *cannot* resist the temptation to tell you how warmly I rejoice, and how earnestly I congratulate *myself* and all other hungerers after wholesome beauty of colour and form, and high ideals of greatness and purity, on your acceptance of a position that one may hope will, nay must, influence the Art of this time for good in every sense. One takes a great breath of relief as one thinks of it!

Were I to describe to you the effect your works produce on me, and the feeling of real reverence I have for them, I should appear to exaggerate, and should certainly bore you, so I will say no more! and I am not given to that sort of thing.

My beloved Lady Waterford was much disappointed that you could not come and meet her; I need not say, so were we: it was a great enjoyment to have her, she is like no one else; and I yet hope you may come and meet here some day. Pray do not answer this; of course you are overwhelmed with business, and it would hurt me to have it considered and acknowledged as a complimentary civility! whereas it is nothing but an involuntary overflowing to relieve my mind.

From Lord Coleridge:—

1 SUSSEX SQUARE, W.,
November 24, 1878.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—Let me add one voice more, small but true, to the great chorus of applause with which your election has been greeted. It might seem left-handed praise to say that your election was the only possible one; but it is very true praise to say it was the only possible one if the highest interests of English Art, and of the Academy itself, were the sole object of the electors.

It would have pleased and touched you to hear old Boxall speak of it. I dined with him alone on Friday, and he was just and generous, as he always is, in his appreciation of you, and looked forward to your reign as likely to be one of high aims and noble

motives. It is a small thing to say, but I venture to agree with him.—
Ever sincerely yours,

COLERIDGE.

These are a few among many hundred congratulatory letters Leighton received on his election. One from Mrs. Fanny Kemble he answered in the following March, when already he was beset by requests to use his influence to get friends' friends' work hung on the walls of the Academy:—

March 20, 1879.

DEAR MRS. KEMBLE,—Many thanks for your very amiable words of congratulations on the honour done me by the Royal Academy. The kind sympathy shown towards me by my friends had added very greatly indeed to the pleasure my election gave me. The belief entertained by Miss —— that the admission of works to an exhibition is a simple matter of personal favour, is shared by all foreigners—and I fear by many English people—and places me at this time of year in much and often painful embarrassment. So robust is this belief, that those who, having applied to me, fail to find their works on our walls ascribe their absence to personal unfriendliness or discourtesy on my part, or, to say the least, to lukewarmness. As a matter of fact each work of art is admitted or rejected by a separate vote of the Council, and that in complete ignorance (except where authorship *saute aux yeux*) of the artist's name. This applies equally to English painters and foreign artists who reside here. In regard, however, to foreigners sending *from abroad*, whilst the vote is taken in the same way, admission is much more difficult. We have so many Anglo-foreign painters who live amongst us that, our Exhibition not being international, we can only admit a very limited number of really prize works. These works are therefore brought before us separately, and a small number of them selected, according to the space we have to deal with; I myself as a rule dissuade my foreign friends from sending except in cases where their merit is really very great; this may be Miss —— case; you will best know. I am quite sure, my dear Mrs. Kemble, that you do not

doubt the pleasure it would give me to serve you in the person of your friend, and will not misinterpret these lengthy explanations.

And now I have a favour to ask of you. On Wednesday the 26th, at 3 o'clock in the afternoon, Joe will, I hope, play at my studio, and with him Miss Janotha and Piatti; Henschel will, I hope, sing. Will you give me the great pleasure of seeing you amongst my friends on that occasion?—Believe me always, yours very truly,

FRED LEIGHTON.

On December 10, 1879, Leighton delivered his first address to the students of the Royal Academy—one of the finest of the many fine achievements of Leighton's life. "Purely practical and technical matters" he put aside to look into a wider and deeper question, that of the position of Art in its relation to the world at large in the present and in the past time, in order to gather something of its prospects in the future. If the question why Leighton held indisputably the great position he did were asked me by one who for a first time had heard his name, I should be inclined to answer, "Because he contained within him the combined powers to execute completely the art which he created, and to think out and feel such profound, sympathetic, and wise truths as those to be found in this address."
[\[60\]](#)

Among the large number of appreciative letters Leighton received were the following.

Millais wrote:—

2 PALACE GATE, KENSINGTON,
December 11, 1879.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I was suffering all yesterday with tooth-ache, otherwise I would have attended the distribution last night. The ceremony is always most interesting to me, awakening as it does many anxious and happy recollections. My object in writing to you is to say I have read your address, which I think so beautiful, true, and *useful* that I cannot but obey an impulse of congratulating you upon it. For some time past I have been putting down notes on Art

which some day may be put into form, and I find we are thinking precisely in the same way. I have used identical words in what I have written to those you delivered yesterday.

The exponents of Art surround it in such a cloud of mystery that it is a real gain when a practical authority is able to say something definite and clear the way.—Yours sincerely,

J.E. MILLAIS.

His poet-friend wrote:—

WOODBERRIE, LOUGHTON, ESSEX,
December 11, 1883.

MY DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—Have any of the multitude of men who love you ever called you Chrysostom? It seems so natural after reading yesterday's address. Will it be published by itself and obtainable in some handier form than the broadsheet of the *Times*? I want it as part of the education of my daughter, who now, at sixteen, is beginning to take a new interest in whatsoever things are lovely and of good report, and I want it for myself, for in its lovely suggestiveness and exquisite English I could often find refreshment when I wanted (and needed) to "travel in the realms of gold," and forget my own invalided personality under the magic of such guidance.

My wife desires me to say a word of gracious remembrance to you, and I am ever, faithfully yours,

ROBIN ALLEN.

Mr. Briton Rivière:

FLAXLEY, 82 FINCHLEY ROAD, N.W.,
December 11, 1879.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—After hearing your admirable address last night, I came home in despair, for what little basis of thought is

contained in my lectures (more especially in the second one) is built chiefly upon two or three of the lines of argument that you have already expressed so beautifully: Sincerity in the student—The effect of his own time upon him—That time in its relation to the time of the Old Masters, and the temper of mind in which the Old Masters should be studied; on these points my lectures are but a feeble echo of what I heard last night.

My first thought was to change my whole line of battle, and re-write them, but the extreme limitation of my powers of work would make this too great a sacrifice. To throw them up altogether, which I should much like, is impossible, for I am pledged to the Academy to do my best.

Clearly, I must go on, but I shall do so more easily now that I have explained my position, so that if any one who hears me should tell you that my lectures were only a parody of what you had already said so well, you will believe that it has been the misfortune and not the fault of yours very truly,

BRITON RIVIÈRE.

Don't trouble to answer this.

Matthew Arnold:—

ATHENÆUM CLUB, PALL MALL,
April 19, 1880.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—You have been *better* than your word, for I see you have made me the actual possessor of your "address." From the glance I have already taken at it, I see that I shall both like it and you with it; but of this I might have been sure beforehand. A thousand thanks, and believe me, always sincerely yours,

MATTHEW ARNOLD.

The scheme Leighton formed, when first considering the duty among all others he undertook, [\[61\]](#) of addressing the students at the biennial meetings, was begun and continued in the nine addresses he gave, but unfortunately it

could not be completed, a fact he sorely regretted when discussing the question with me three months before his death. On December 10, 1879, "The position of Art in the World" was the subject. In 1881, "Relation of Art to Time, Place, and Racial Conditions; Underlying Mystery of its Growth and Decay." In 1885, "Summary of Foregoing Lecture." In 1887, "Art in Mediæval and Modern Italy." In 1889, "Relation of Artistic Production to Surrounding Conditions considered in reference to Spain." In 1891, "The Art of France: its uninterrupted development; its wide field; eminent achievement in Architecture; the Gothic style." In 1893, "The Art of Germany: its high qualities; deficient Æsthetic Inspiration." The tenth was to have consisted, Leighton told me, in a summing up of the nine former addresses, in order to prove how they had affected the past and present condition of Art in England. To any thoughtful artist these utterances, delivered by so great and accomplished an authority, cannot fail to prove profoundly interesting and invaluable as references, on account of the sound knowledge and the absolutely reliable quality of the facts given; but it may be doubted whether the more informative matter, contained in the six later lectures, suited Leighton's style of oratory so happily as did the more abstract quality of the three first. There appeared to be too many names crowded into the comparatively short time which Leighton allotted to himself for the delivery of these discourses, for the normal taking-in power of an audience; the very finished rhetoric, moreover, in which the enormous amount of information contained in each was disclosed, did not seem quite appropriate to their condensed form. In conversation I have heard Leighton far more convincing, on the same subjects as those he treated in the last six discourses. The same intense sense of the duty he felt to do the thing as completely as it was possible, which he evinced in painting, cropped up again in his oratory, no less than the intense modesty—which would not recognise how great he could be if he relaxed all effort, and was simply himself.

Mr. Briton Rivière, in the notes he furnishes for this book, writes:—

"Those perhaps sometimes too perfectly built-up sentences, of which his admirable addresses and speeches were formed, were the outcome of this same quality of mind. One of his most intimate friends, when we were talking about the mental strain occasioned by

these, once said to me: 'Leighton would never get over a slight lapse of grammar,' and I can believe it. The accidental was hateful to him when considered in reference to his own work of any kind, though probably no one knew better than he did its value in a work of art; but, as Watts deplored, he never would use it or admit it into his own pictures. This quality and its strain upon him was illustrated by an accident which occurred at his last R.A. Banquet speech, the last he ever made, and which gained immensely from the fact that in one place he forgot for a moment the next sentence, and came to a pause (as he told me afterwards), in fear that he had broken down altogether; but his suspense, painful as it must have been to him, looked perfectly natural and spontaneous, and gave to his speech that touch of something which his better remembered periods did not express so well. This system of speaking entirely from memory added much to the constant strain of his Academy work. He had what he called a 'topical memory,' viz. he remembered the place of each word in his written speech and used to read it off in the air with never-failing accuracy, but did so always with the belief that a forgotten sentence would shipwreck the whole. If he would have been content now and then to lapse from this high pitch of the accuracy he aimed at in all his work, few could have reached a safer or higher standard spontaneously, as he proved in the Royal Academy, General Assembly, and Council meetings, when he never failed to speak admirably on the spur of the moment; and his summing up of a debate there on any subject was invariably marked by the same elegance and cleverness as his prepared speeches, but with more vitality and flexibility, which, however, never led him into anything that was not almost fastidiously exact and precise. I have always felt that no one who had heard only his elaborately prepared speeches knew his real power as a speaker."

There rang out perhaps, at times, just a note reminding one of the German pedant in these discourses—a note singularly discordant when sounding together with an ornate diction; but this was only heard when Leighton was not deeply moved by his subject; when, on the other hand, the not over-tutored, bigger instinctive self had full sway, as, in the subjects he chose for the first three discourses, the glowing style harmonised most

rightly as the appropriate language for the earnest and lofty feeling in the thought. If, as suggested above, it is only facts and information of an historical character which words have to convey, much eloquence and an ornate style seems inappropriate. Each mood is obviously best expressed when the style is adjusted to it by an intuitive instinct. Leighton, though possessing abnormally flexible and subtle æsthetic instincts when he allowed himself to be his natural self, seemed at times to force himself into a theoretic rigidity when he was at his lessons. And all his official duties he viewed as lessons, which, after he left his easel, it was his first duty in life to learn to perform as correctly as he could. But whatever criticisms may be made on the style of the later discourses, students desiring to possess something more than a merely provincial knowledge of the special power of the magnates in whose work culminates the great Art of the world, should surely not neglect to possess themselves of the wisdom to be acquired from these discourses.

Throughout their pages are to be found most suggestive passages, inspiring new thoughts and, to any but experts, new facts on vitally interesting art matters. For instance, take the description of Velasquez:—

"For a long period Italian painting did not cease to enjoy the favour of the Court; it ceased, however, towards the beginning of the seventeenth century to exercise that paralysing influence which had marked its first advent, and the ground was cleared for a new impulse from within. At this conjuncture a man of commanding genius and fearless initiative was given to Spain in the person of Diego Velasquez. It may perhaps have surprised you that with such a name before my mind I should have spoken of Zurbaran, a man so vastly his inferior in the painter's gift, as perhaps the most representative of Spanish artists. I have done so because beyond any other artist he sums up in himself, as I have pointed out to you, all the complex elements of the Spanish genius. In Velasquez, Spanish as he is to the finger-tips, this comprehensiveness is not found. Of Velasquez all was Spanish, but Zurbaran was all Spain.

"Viewed simply as a painter, the great Sevillian was, as I have just said, vastly the superior of the Estremeño. He was in more intimate touch with Nature, and none, perhaps, have equalled the

swift magic of his brush. On the other hand, depth of feeling, poetry, imagination were refused to him. The painter of the 'Lanzas,' the 'Hilanderas,' the 'Meninas'—works in their kind unapproached in Art by any other man—painted also, be it remembered, the 'Coronation of the Virgin' and the 'Mars' of the Madrid Gallery—types of prosaic treatment. In one work, indeed, Religion seems for a moment to have winged his pencil; but striking and pathetic as is his famous 'Crucifixion,' it does not equal in poignancy and imaginative grasp the presentment of the same subject by Zurbaran in Seville. But if we miss in Velasquez the higher gifts of the imagination, we find him also free from all those blemishes of extravagance which we have so often noted in this land of powerful impulses unrestrained by tact. Whatever gifts may have been refused to Velasquez, in his grave simplicity he is unsurpassed. If fancy seldom lifts him above the level of intimate daily things, neither does she obstruct for him with purple wings the white light of sober truth. In days in which the young Herrera could find favour; in a country in which Churriguera was possible, and euphuism was applauded, he never overstepped the modesty of Nature, nor forgot in Art the value of reticent control. I have not here to follow his career, nor the evolution of his unique and dazzling genius. Still less need I, before young artists of the present day, dwell on the wizardry and the luscious fascination of the brush of this most modern of the old masters. I will only, in conclusion, touch briefly on one or two points that are of interest, and one that is, perhaps, of warning.

"First, I would notice the purity and decorum of his art; a decorum not, I think, due to the characteristically Spanish laws under which the Inquisition visited with heavy penalties every semblance even of impurity in a work of art, but to a spirit dwelling in the people itself, of which those laws were but the somewhat exaggerated expression. It may be worth while also to note that yet another virtue of the Spaniards is, in one of his works, reflected in an unexpected manner, namely, their sobriety. It is a curious thing that in a certain class of Spanish literature a peculiar relish is shown for the portraying of moral squalor and the grovelling criminality of social outcasts. In Spanish Art, on the other hand, the picturesqueness alone of low life seems to have sought expression.

You know what gentle Murillo made of his melon-eating beggar boys. Again, you saw not long ago upon these walls, in the 'Water-Carrier of Seville,' how at the outset of his career Velasquez turned his thoughts to subjects drawn from humble life, and you know how to the end he dwelt with peculiar gusto on the fantastic physiognomy of the privileged buffoons, dwarfs, and *hombres de placer* who haunted the Palace in his day. You know further that one of the most powerful works painted by him before reality of atmospheric effect had become his chief preoccupation, and when he sought exclusively after truth of character, a picture known as 'Los Borrachos,' represents a group of drunkards doing homage to Bacchus. It is a work of the most naked realism. Bacchus (Dionysos!), showing his repulsive vulgarity (what a blank to Velasquez was the poetic side of classic myths), is surrounded by a circle of kneeling rascals, rude and ragged enough, and supposed, no doubt, to be carousing; but here is the strange peculiarity of this work—in spite of all the accessories of a revel, and the flash of grinning teeth, we are unable to persuade ourselves that any one of the disreputable crew could ever be *drunk*. Imagine the subject treated by a Fleming.

"And now, though I am loth to touch one leaf of the laurels of so dazzling and so great an artist, I cannot pass in silence a circumstance which must be weighed in estimating Velasquez as a man, and which is not without bearing on his art. The virtues of his race, as we have seen, purified his work and gave it dignity; a Spanish foible, though it could not dim his genius, cramped, no doubt, and curtailed its production—namely, a tendency to subordinate everything to the pursuit of royal favour. I said a Spanish foible; for a superstitious rendering up of will and conscience to the sovereign, such as is, I believe, without example, had long been a growing characteristic of the Spaniard. On a memorable occasion Gonzalo de Cordoba himself, one of the noblest figures recorded in Spanish history—a man of a mind so fearless that he was bold to rebuke Pope Borgia himself face to face in the Vatican for the scandals of his life—did not scruple to break, in deference to what he considered this higher duty of obedience to his king, his solemn pledge and oath to the unfortunate young Duke

of Calabria. So all but divine did majesty appear to the Spaniards, that divinity and majesty became almost as one in their eyes, and they spoke, in all solemnity, as 'Su Majestad,' not only of the Divine persons of the Trinity, but also of the sacrificial wafer. The prevalence of this feeling must plead to some extent in mitigation of the tenacity with which Velasquez canvassed—with success, alas!—to obtain at Court a post of an onerous and wholly prosaic character—the office of 'Aposentador Mayor,' a sort of purveyor and quartermaster, who, when his Majesty moved from one place to another, had to convey, to house, to feed, not the sovereign only, but all his suite. A post demanding all his attention, says Polomino, who goes on to deplore that this exalted office (which he has just told us any one could fill) should have deprived the world of so many samples of the painter's genius. We shall agree with our sententious friend, not, perhaps, in the satisfaction he derived from the honour conferred, as he imagines, on his calling, but in his sorrow over the loss we have sustained! And in the sight of canvases in which the execution of a sketch is carried out on the full scale of life we shall at once bow before the product of a splendid genius, and regret the signs of haste, the evidence of too scanty leisure, by which its expression has been marred. Truly it has been said, 'Art requires the whole man.'"[\[62\]](#)

Again, the seventh discourse is replete with inspiring suggestions about French architecture,[\[63\]](#) and in the last discourse the description of Albert Dürer is one which, in a few lines, gives a complete and vividly interesting setting to the great name.

"Albert Dürer may be regarded as *par excellence* the typical German artist—far more so than his great contemporary Holbein. He was a man of a strong and upright nature, bent on pure and high ideals; a man ever seeking, if I may use his own characteristic expression, to make known through his work the mysterious treasure that was laid up in his heart; he was a thinker, a theorist, and, as you know, a writer; like many of the great artists of the Renaissance, he was steeped also in the love of science. His work

was in his own image; it was, like nearly all German art, primarily ethic in its complexion; like all German art it bore traces of foreign influence—drawn, in his case, first from Flanders and later from Italy. In his work, as in all German art, the national character asserted itself above every trammel of external influence. Superbly inexhaustible as a designer, as a draughtsman he was powerful, thorough, and minute to a marvel, but never without a certain almost caligraphic mannerism of hand, wanting in spontaneous simplicity—never broadly serene. In his colour he was rich and vivid, not always unerring as to his harmonies, not alluring in his execution—withal a giant."

When the last addresses were given Leighton was getting very tired. The wheels were running down—vitality was waning. The great mental machine had begun to work more mechanically. We trace this in the manner in which he tackled his last discourse. While writing it at Perugia he wrote to his elder sister:—

PERUGIA, *Thursday, October 12, 1893.*

You have misconstrued my knee; I have no *pain* in it, at most occasionally a dull ache in the muscles and a slight soreness in the joint; but it is an incapacitating and depressing nuisance, and it won't move on. (I am writing near a window opening on to a clear, star-bright sky; far below, in the *paese*, I hear the tinkle of a wandering, nocturnal mandoline—how I like it!) You do me the honour to appreciate my having, during my recent precipitate odyssey, visited thirty towns in thirty days, noting things of which I had already accurate knowledge *d'avance*; but I can "go one better" than that: *ten* of the towns were *absolutely new* to me, and of the whole subject on which I am preaching, I knew as good as nothing when you last saw me. I suspect that, in spite of a lack of memory which *baffles belief*, I have a certain "uptaking" knack. My preachment will bore you, but you will (if you read it) detect an *ensemble*; but, for goodness' sake, *zitti!* They'll think, when they hear the P.R.A., that, Lor' bless him! he'd known it all his life.

Nevertheless, enough for the day, &c. Best love to Gussy.—Affect.
bro.,

FRED.

I remember—when my husband and I were sitting with him one afternoon after his return home that autumn—his saying, "I feel distinctly I have dropped one step down off of the ladder," and it was truly about that time that his doctor, Doctor Roberts, discerned the beginning of the disease which proved fatal. Already in 1888 he wrote:—

"The reasons which have now for a good many years impelled me to decline any 'public utterances' outside Burlington House have increased in weight and force as life and strength wanes, and as demands on me grow in every direction. I am sometimes asked to speak in public, not only in London, but all over the country, and in all cases the demand is grounded on strong claims in so far as I am an 'official' artist. Assent once is assent always—assent in half the cases would mean the *gravest* injury to my *work*, and I am a workman first and an official afterwards. Things have their humorous side, for those who press me most are sometimes those who on other occasions most earnestly assure me that I '*do too much*.' How tired I am of hearing it."

The speeches at the yearly banquets of the Royal Academy were extraordinary *tours de force*. Wherever Leighton took the lead—and he was seldom anywhere when he did not take the lead,^[64]—he raised the tone of the proceedings, and convinced the outside world, no less than those taking a part in them, that the matter in hand was important and essentially worth doing. Personally I have always felt that the finished form of Leighton's diction tended rather to hide than to explain the real nature of the power which had this vitalising, elevating influence. This influence emanated, I believe, from the greatness of his "magnificent intellect" (to use Watts' words) being united with extraordinary will-force invariably employed in the service of the principles in which he had a profound faith. It was his persistent loyalty to these principles—backed by this abnormal will-force, giving it extra weight—which lifted Leighton's work in all directions on to

so distinguished a level—and not—in the case of his speeches—his rounded periods, or his power over words, or his gift of facility in grasping a subject, though the Banquet speeches are also remarkable on account of the versatility he displayed in grasping many subjects from the point of view of the expert. Whether it was the Army, the Navy, Politics, Music—whatever, in fact, was the affair of the moment, he proposed the toast from what might be called the inside of the question, not merely treating his text as a matter of form.^[65]

On asking Gladstone to the Banquet of 1880, Leighton received the following characteristic answer:—

MY DEAR PRESIDENT,—I have received your letter with mixed feelings. You do me great honour, and I must obey you. But I long for the return of the good old times, lying within the long range of my memory, when the dinners of the Academy did not suffer the contamination of political toasts, and kept us all for three precious hours in purer air. Can you tell me when the practice was changed? I am not, I think, under the dominion of a pleasant delusion.—Yours most faithfully,

W.E. GLADSTONE.

In 1883 Leighton found it impossible to continue his duties as Lieutenant-Colonel of the 20th Middlesex (Artists) Volunteers, which post he had held since 1876, and he therefore resigned. He was then made Hon. Colonel and holder of the Volunteer Decoration.^[66]

A few years later he made the following speech at a dinner given by his Corps, in response to a toast proposed to himself:—

We live in times so hustling and breathless, times in which so much happens in so short a space, that a few years seem to divide men and habits like a deep gulf, and I feel that in the eyes of many of you the toast that your C.O. has invited you in such friendly terms to drink is one possessing an almost antiquarian flavour interest; the more grateful therefore am I for the cordial response with which, not, I hope, solely in a spirit of discipline, but from a more human point of view, you have given to the call of Colonel Edis.

The sight of the old uniform recalls to me, in a vivid manner, a period when not only my years, but my circumferencial inches, were fewer, during which it was my pride, first in one grade, then successively in others, from the ranks to the command, to take my share in the doings of and the life of what I hope I may call, without egotism, one of the finest corps in the Volunteer service. I have now for some years laid by the coat, to be furbished up only for these annual gatherings, not without misgivings as to my power of getting

into it; but I have not laid by, nor shall I lay by while I have life, my deep interest and my high respect for that great defensive force of which it is the sign, and which, having sprung into existence in a moment of emergency and national excitement, has shown through over more than a quarter of a century that it requires no excitement to sustain it, and is fed by no transitory fires.

But whilst I watch this great sign of national vitality with unchanging interest, there is of course an inmost corner of my heart in which that national movement appears to me clad in grey and silver, and the old corps still sits in the warmest place; praise of its performance is always to me the most grateful praise; strictures on its shortcomings, if like other human things it has any, will always find me sensitive, and the account which your excellent Colonel furnishes on these occasions of your year's growth, comes home to me more than other like utterances. Gentlemen, I have named your energetic and efficient commanding officer; there is this year a special reason why his name should be on my lips; he is about shortly to acquire by length of service the full colonelcy of which his long devotion to the cause makes him so worthy a recipient; and I should wish before sitting down to offer him an old comrade's hearty congratulation, and the expression of my confident hope that his advanced rank will only confirm him in his loyal and faithful efforts to promote the honour of the corps to which he, more fortunate than I, is still privileged to belong as an active member.

In 1894, on the occasion of fêting his friend Joseph Joachim and presenting the gift to the great master of a Stradivarius violin and bow from his friends, in recognition of the fiftieth anniversary of his first performance in London, Leighton made the following speech:—

1894.

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN,—It was necessary that the motives and feelings which have drawn us together to-night should find brief expression on somebody's lips; and, in obedience to a command which has been laid on me by this Committee, I have to ask you to accept me, for a few moments, as your mouthpiece. Of the varied

duties which life lays on us, there are some which we perform in simple discharge of conscience and with little joy; some, if few, into the discharge of which we can pour all our hearts; and such a duty is this which I have risen to perform.

I have said that I shall only ask your attention for a few moments, and you will feel with me the fitness of brevity; for besides that, in every case, taste imposes restraint in praise of those who are present before us, long drawn and redundant eulogy would clash strangely with that rare simplicity which is one of the qualities by which Joachim, the Man, compels the esteem of all whose fortune it is to know him. But there would be in it, I think, also a further deeper-lying incongruity, for we know that Joachim, the Artist, has risen to the heights he occupies, perhaps alone, by fixing his constant gaze on high ideals, and lifting and sustaining his mind in a region above the shifting fickle atmosphere of praise or blame. Well, it is now fifty years since he took his first step along the upward path, which he has trodden in wholeness of heart and singleness of purpose from earliest boyhood to mellow middle age. During these fifty years he has not only ripened to the full his splendid gifts as an interpreter, ever interpreting the noblest works in the noblest manner, leading his hearers to their better comprehension; not only marked his place in the front ranks of living composers by works instinct with fire and imagination; but shown us also, as a man, how much high gifts are enhanced by modesty, and how good a thing to see is the life of an Artist who has never paltered with the dignity of his Art.

Deep appreciation of these titles to respect and admiration has, as you know, led in Germany, the country of his adoption and his home, to an enthusiastic celebration of this, the fiftieth year of his artistic career; and we, his English friends, living in a country which we hope, nay, believe, is, after his own, not the least dear to him, have felt strongly impelled to express to him also in some form our gratitude, our sympathy, and our esteem. It has seemed to your Committee that these sentiments could not take a more fitting outward shape than that of the instrument over which he is lord: such an instrument, signed with the famous name of Stradivarius, and, as I am told, not unworthy of his fame, flanked with a bow the

work of Tourte, and once the property of Kiesenwetter—such a fiddle and such a bow I now offer to him in your name. Its sensitive and well-seasoned shell will acknowledge and respond to the hand of the master, and the souls of many great musicians will, we hope, often speak through it to spellbound hearers. But we nourish another hope—the hope that, through the great waves of melody that shall roll forth from it under his compelling bow, a still small voice may now and again be interfused which, reaching his heart through his ears, shall speak to it of the many friends who, in spirit or in the body, are gathered round him affectionately to-night.

In 1888 Leighton delivered the superb Address at the Art Congress held at Liverpool on December 3 (see [Appendix](#)). No Life of this great man would be complete were his utterances on this occasion not given in full, for therein is found his creed on Art, and the records of those principles on which it was founded, expounded with clear force, fine analysis, and, above all, with supreme courage. The subject, moreover, as touching England's condition respecting Art, is one directly affecting English readers.

A matter of interest to the general Art world came under discussion at the Council meetings of the Academy in the winter of 1879 and 1880, namely, whether women were to be admitted as members of their body. A correspondence took place between Leighton and the late Mr. Henry Wells, R.A., on the subject. Leighton's personal inclination was certainly for admitting women into the body of the elect, as I know from conversations he had with me on the subject. He invariably sought to extend all art privileges to those who were, as artists, worthy to receive them. He told me, however, that the majority of votes against the inroad of women would be given as having regard to a question of convenience rather than to one of principle, namely, the difficulty the Academicians foresaw in admitting only one or two lady artist Academicians to the yearly Banquets, and the greater difficulty of extending invitations to lady guests.^[67]

The following letters from Leighton to Mr. Wells give an insight into the kind of work which his office of President entailed, and of the characteristically thorough manner in which Leighton fulfilled them.

Thursday Evening, 1879 or 1880.

DEAR WELLS,—I have noticed during my last two sittings at your studio, that, whenever the deeply interesting subject of our Academy appeared on the tapis, it stood in the way of your work, and I have therefore purposely abstained, as you no doubt remarked, from going beyond the merest surface in the discussion of any of the points on which we have touched. I felt that the sittings I gave you being so few and so scantily measured out, the least I could do was not, wittingly, to make you lose your time. That is to say, I did not *tell* you to-day orally what I now *write*, namely, my impression on your proposed question concerning the Chantrey purchases. The characteristic straightforwardness and loyalty with which you wished me to be informed on the point beforehand will not permit me to be silent in regard to your view. I have looked with the greatest care into the extract from the will which we all have, and have given the matter that thought which is due to your earnest conscientiousness, and I have satisfied myself that the General Assembly is wholly without a *locus standi* in claiming to control the expenditure of the Chantrey trust moneys in any way whatever; those moneys never pass into its hands or come under its cognisance; they are paid into the hands of the president and treasurer, against their receipt, and are dealt with solely by the president and council for the time being. An attempt, therefore, on the part of the General Assembly to assume control in this matter is in my view *out of order*, and it would therefore be out of order to ask or answer a question based, as yours is, on that assumption. I think you will find this view in harmony with the opinion of the body; if it is largely challenged, I shall postpone the answer till I have taken a legal opinion, as the point is very important. Here are my cards on the table.—In haste, yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Private.]

Monday.

DEAR WELLS,—The usual stress of business has prevented me till now from thanking you for your note and valuable information; I

shall, with great interest, turn to the passages you allude to as soon as I get a good opportunity, and what I read will have the greatest weight with me when I vote again on a purchase. It would not, however, touch my point in regard to the *General Assembly*, which can only interfere with a past purchase if it can be shown to be illegal; this can, of course, only be established by legal authority, and I am, myself, sorry that your first resolution does not run thus: That the President be requested to consult high legal authority as to whether such and such purchases are barred by the will of Sir F. Ch. If your misgivings on that head are shared by a majority the thing would pass immediately and undiscussed, almost.

As concerns your motion on the pension resolution, I own to much misgiving; *I should not dream of alluding to this had you not yourself taken me aside about it the other day*. I am so far at one with you in principle that I feel, I can't say how deeply, that it is our paramount duty to interpret in the largest and most elevated sense our duty to the art of the country that we may be worthy in the eyes of the enlightened portion of the community of our high place, and that it is equally incumbent on us to keep our personal interests vigilantly in sub-ordination. I think that one of the present resolutions militates against this last view, and I need not conceal from you that it has not my sympathy. I am, however, very strongly of opinion that the form of your opposition to it will not be supported, and that in your desire for a logical comprehensiveness, you will fail of your end, which by simple direct opposition to the particular measure on the principle you have already enunciated and explained, you might *very probably*, I believe, achieve. I need not, I think, assure you, my dear Wells, that nothing is further from my thoughts than any *interference* with a member's freedom; indeed, on that head my views are known to you; but I can't refrain from saying thus much to give you an opportunity of quietly thinking matters over (*don't answer this*) before Wednesday. After all, you want primarily to get rid of paragraph 6, not to ensure a dialectical triumph. If the alternative is between your Committee and the resolution as it stands, I feel absolutely convinced that you will be left in a very cold minority; but if you point out that paragraph 6 takes our bounties off the ground of necessity, our only tenable

ground, in fact commutes a *bounty* into an unconditional *claim* (of a formidable pecuniary nature, too), you will march in, I can't help thinking, with flying colours.

Don't, I repeat, be at the trouble to answer this expression of the opinion of,—Yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Monday, February 1, (?) 1881.

DEAR WELLS,—Since receiving your letter I have been so absolutely engrossed with business and work that I have not had time till now to answer it. I am sincerely glad you have asked for a little modification in the terms of the Lucy petition; meanwhile I have written to Gladstone, and my letter has been acknowledged with a promise to note its contents.

In regard to your Chantrey resolution, I feel that, after the manner of very busy men, I have written in haste and not made myself quite clear. I should like, first, to remove one apprehension which you seem to have entertained; however strongly I may be convinced of the correctness of my own view on the matter under discussion, I cannot too emphatically say that as long as the points at issue were still *sub judice* I should not countenance a purchase which should assume my view to be the right one; but no such postponement as would lead to this dilemma is to be feared; what I propose is this: as soon as ever we have closed the discussion on the schools, and whilst they are being printed in their amended form for final consideration, therefore, on Friday next, if we get through on Wednesday, or failing that on the 22nd or 23rd of February, the resolutions of Council will be put on the table in their rotation; as, however, the next step in the Chantrey affair is to merely *hear* my answer to your memorandum, and as I understand that discussion on it will not be expected till members shall have had it to consider at their leisure, I will read it and lay it on the table *before* I take up the resolutions of Council which stand on the paper before it, so that when it comes up for final discussion, presumably in the first days of March, it can be discussed and voted on with full mastery of the

subject. It is on the agenda paper of THAT *meeting* that your affirmative motion will stand; it does not come into force till then, since it is contingent on the effect produced on your mind by my answer of Friday (or of the next meeting after).

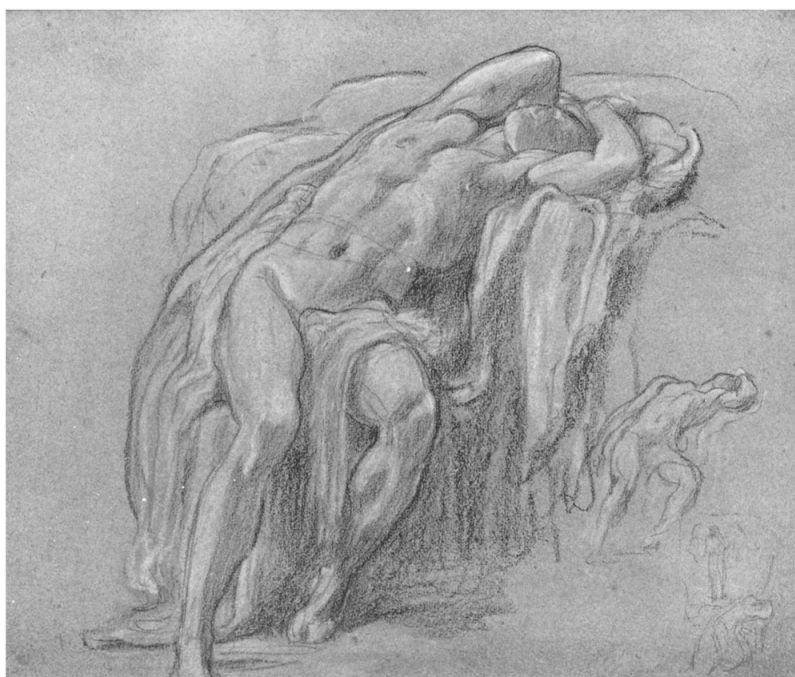
With respect to Redgrave's motion, it may lead to a technical "censure" of the Council; but there are censures and censures, and nobody will suppose, certainly I never dreamt, that you meant to imply moral obliquity to us in regard to what we have done. I have not a word to object to what you advance about the right of complaint, but it does not exactly cover the case: if you caught us, say, taking our friends to the Exhibition (or ourselves) on Sunday, a matter on which no two opinions are admissible, then "a complaint" would be in its place; but in the matter of payment to Treasurer, two opinions may and do exist, and they can only be measured against one another by a vote, and a vote can only be taken on a motion.

Lastly, as to the new codification committee, I think with you, *in strictest confidence*, that —— was not a good choice; but he was chosen in the usual manner by a majority of votes: that your labours were not remunerated in the usual manner is an oversight, which, of course, must and shall be set right. There seems altogether, and your letter corroborates that impression, to have been much vagueness about the doings of the Committee *as a Committee*, though, as usual, much zealous work on your part. I do not gather that attendances were entered in a book, which is the machinery by which payment is generally regulated, and the Committee having lapsed without reporting to the Council on its labours (being a *sub-committee* of the Council of 1878, it lapsed by a natural death with that Council), the whole thing had fallen out of notice. I hope that the old sub-committee will put in their claims, which will very certainly be satisfied. The codification has frequently been in my mind, for I consider it of very great importance, but as it is my impression that I am considered to drive the work of the Academy full hard as it is, I have hesitated to impose more labours on my colleagues, even though I am always ready to share them.—
Sincerely yours,

FRED LEIGHTON.



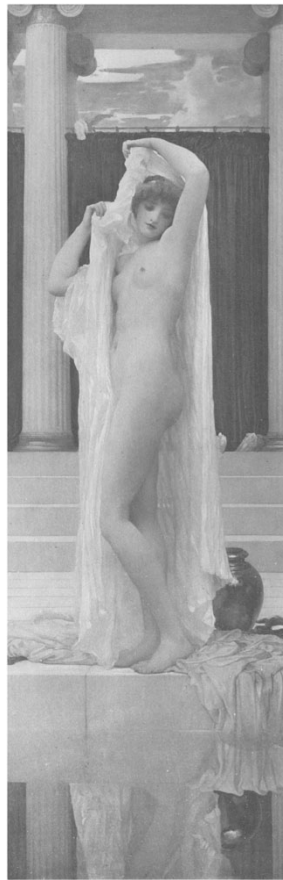
"ELIJAH IN THE WILDERNESS." 1879 [To List](#)



SKETCH FOR "ELIJAH IN THE WILDERNESS." 1879
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



"NERUCCIA." 1879
By permission of Mrs. Lees [ToList](#)



"THE BATH OF PSYCHE." 1890
National Gallery of British Art (Tate Gallery)[ToList](#)

Tuesday Morning,
2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
March 18, 1884.

DEAR WELLS,—Thank you for your letter received yesterday, which only lack of time prevented me from answering at once. I am happy to say that Richmond cheerfully acceded to my wish in regard to clauses 6 and 7. I do not think with Calderon, who has written to me, that the words of a man so high-minded as Richmond will indispose members in this matter, and, though I feel the importance of raising no prejudice against the proposal as keenly as ever, still wish him to initiate it. It is, I agree with you, a pity that the question of the retiring pensions must come off first; but that is,

I fear, quite unavoidable, and it connects itself with the very first resolution. I assure you, my dear Wells, that I *see* the bearing of all you say on this head as plainly as possible, and have done so all along; but it does not prevail with me, because it does not cover the whole ground, and because I do not anticipate the dangers for which you think it might be used as a precedent.

In view of my own personal painful position in this matter, I shall *ask* the Assembly *not* to ratify the clause which affects *me*.—In great haste, yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Leighton's official life, as understood and carried out by him, entailed infinitely more strain and occupation than can be described in these pages, but, notwithstanding, unless the call away from his easel was imperative, he kept certain hours in the day sacred to his art. These were from 9 A.M. till noon, and from 1 P.M. till 4. It was only in the off hours that he got through his other labours, which he performed, nevertheless, with most assiduous conscientiousness.

Among his duties outside the Academy were those at the British Museum. Mr. H.A. Grueber, Keeper of the Coins and Medals, writes: "Sir Frederic Leighton was elected a Trustee of the British Museum on May 14, 1881. He was an active member of the Standing Committee, who practically manage the affairs of the Museum, and he took great interest in the place. He was also a member of the Sub-committees on Buildings, on Antiquities, Prints and Drawings, also of those on Coins and Medals."

In the first R.A. Exhibition after his election, three pictures of the eight Leighton sent have, I think, a special interest—"Elijah in the Wilderness" (the picture into which he said he put more of himself than into any other he had painted up to that time); the portrait of his very dear friend Professor Costa, painted in the previous autumn at Lerici, and the head "Neruccia." Leighton with Costa studied the methods used in painting by the Venetians and Correggio, and Costa wrote the following with reference to them:—

The result of these studies and of the experience of years was that Leighton and I definitely adopted the following method. Take a

canvas or panel with the whitest possible preparation and non-absorbent—the drawing of the subject to be done with precision and indelible. On this seek to model in monochrome so strongly that it will bear the local colours painted with exaggeration, and then the grey, which is to be the ground of all the future half-tones; on this paint the lights, for which use only white, red, and black, avoiding yellow, and, stabbing (*botteggiando*) with the brush while the colour is wet, make the half-tints tell out from the grey beneath, which should be thoroughly dry. When all is dry, finish the picture with scumbles (*spegazzi*), adding yellow to complete the colour.

Leighton formed his method of painting from these general maxims, and he painted my portrait at Lerici on these principles as an experiment, and then in 1878 we adopted the system definitely. For this portrait he had four sittings—one for the drawing and the monochrome *chiaroscuro*, one for the local colours; then, having covered all with grey, he painted the lights with red, white, and black, making use of the thoroughly dried grey beneath for his half-tints. With scumbles he completed the colour and the modelling.



"THE LIGHT OF THE HAREM." 1880

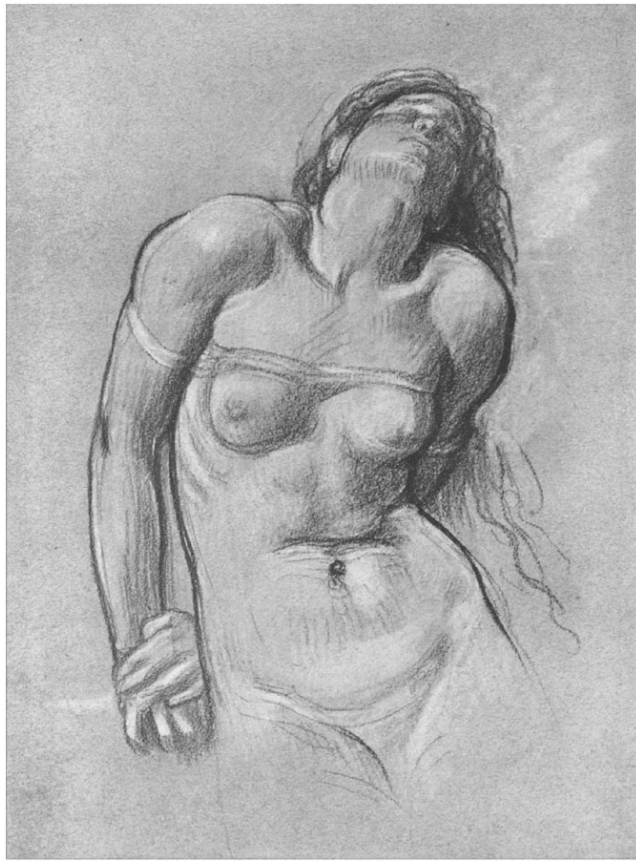
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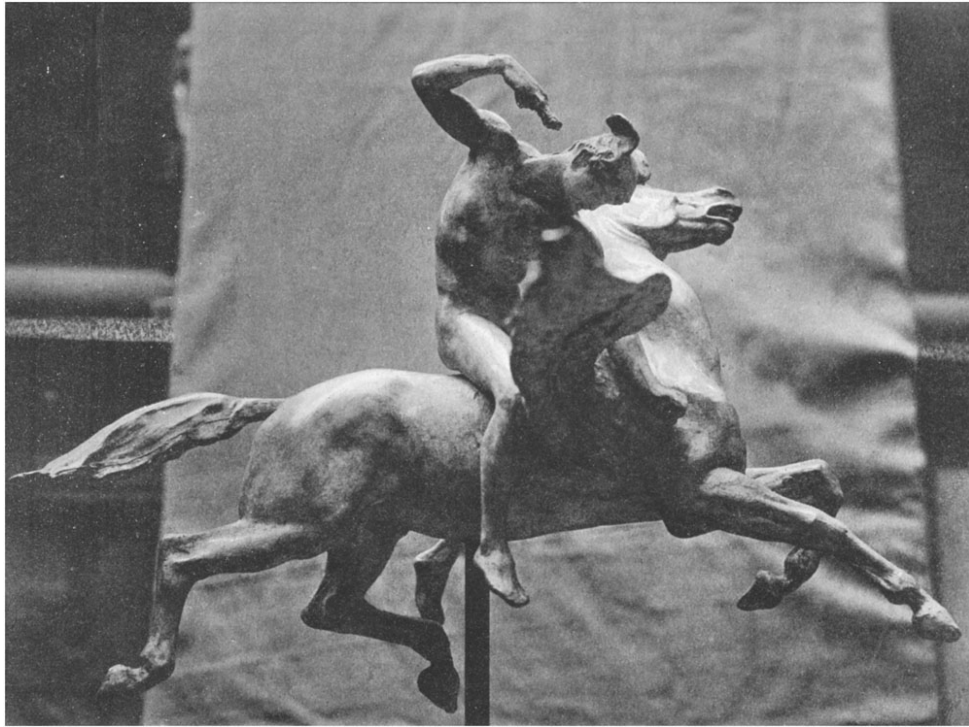
"AND THE SEA GAVE UP THE DEAD WHICH WERE IN IT"
Sketch for Complete Design, 1892 [To List](#)



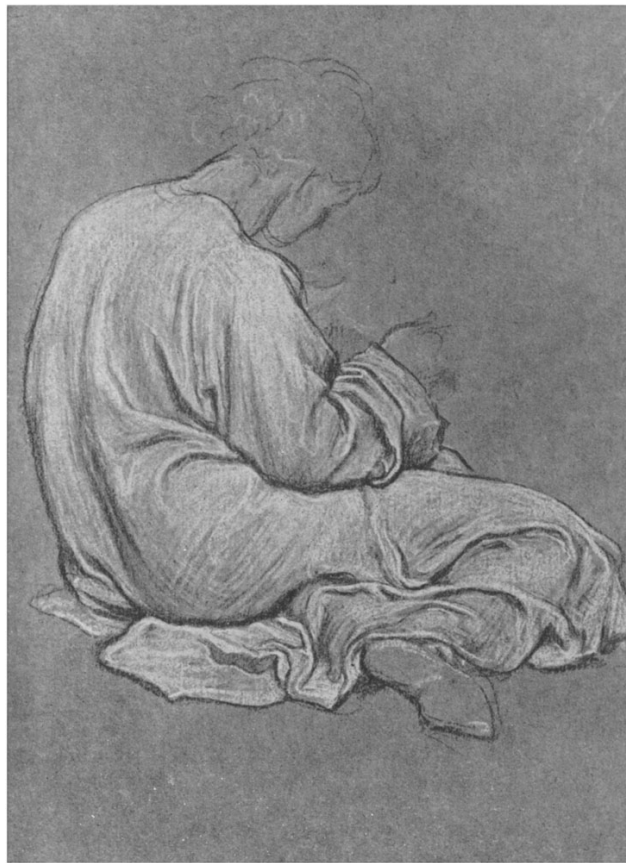
STUDY FOR FIGURE IN FRIEZE, "MUSIC." 1886
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



STUDY FOR "ANDROMEDA." 1890
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



FROM SKETCH IN CLAY FOR PERSEUS, IN THE PICTURE
"PERSEUS AND ANDROMEDA." 1891 [ToList](#)



STUDY FOR FIGURE IN PANEL IN ROYAL EXCHANGE
—"PHŒNICIANS BARTERING WITH BRITONS"
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



"CYMON AND IPHIGENIA." 1884
The Corporation of Leeds [ToList](#)



STUDY IN COLOUR FOR "CYMON AND IPHIGENIA." 1884
By permission of Mrs. Stewart Hodgson [ToList](#)



STUDY FOR SLEEPING GROUP FOR "CYMON AND
IPHIGENIA"

Given by Lord Leighton to G.F. Watts, O.M., and given by the latter to
the Collection in Leighton House, 1883 [ToList](#)

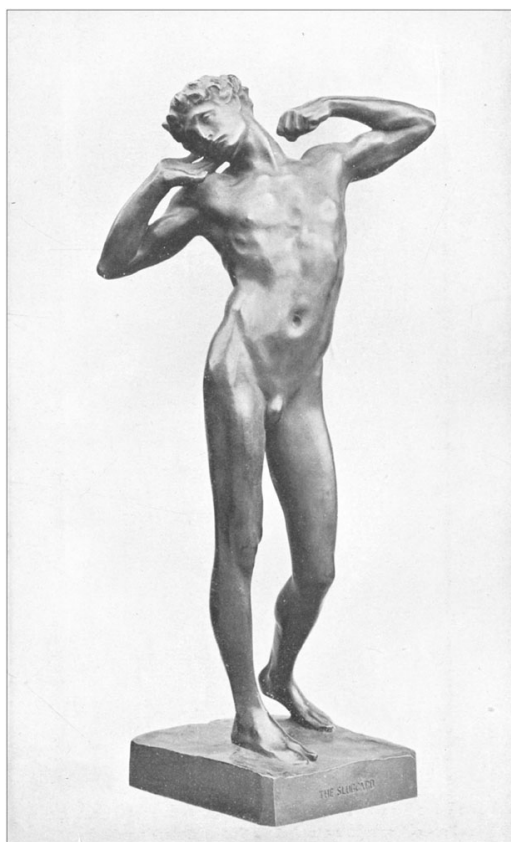
As the exquisite fragments in pencil of cyclamen, bramble and vine branch,^[68] explain most intimately Leighton's genius as a draughtsman, so this head of Neruccia appears to me, together with one other work, to explain most explicitly his genius as a painter—a modeller with the brush. In 1890 Leighton painted "The Bath of Psyche."^[69] The modelling in the torso of this figure, and in the head of Neruccia, reach the zenith as exemplifying Leighton's individuality as a painter. They might truly earn for him the title—Praxiteles of the brush.

It would be tedious for writer and reader alike to describe too minutely the special characteristics of even the most notable pictures painted during the seventeen years when Leighton occupied the position of President of the Royal Academy. Words are but poor interpreters of painting such as his. Eighty canvases, two statues, and two designs—the reverse of the Jubilee Medallion, "And the sea gave up its dead which were in it"—were exhibited at the Royal Academy; eighteen slighter works at the Suffolk Street, and twenty-three at the Grosvenor Galleries. On referring to the list in the [Appendix](#) it will be realised how great was the amount of labour involved in the achievement of many of these works, considering their size, the complication of their designs, and also the completeness of their finish. It must also be remembered that Leighton made many hundreds of studies for his pictures. More especially numerous were these for the designs "And the sea gave up the dead which were in it," "The Dance, Decorative Frieze"; "Cymon and Iphigenia"; "Music, a Frieze"; "Design for the reverse of the Jubilee Medallion," "Captive Andromache," "Perseus and Andromeda," "Return of Persephone," "The Garden of the Hesperides," "Rizpah," "Summer Slumbers," "The Spirit of the Summit," "Flaming June," "Phœnicians Bartering with Britons," and "Clytie." When all these achievements are taken into account it will be realised that Leighton, to the end, however important his duties outside his studios, was true to his vocation, and proved himself the "workman first and the official after."

As a work combining poetic feeling, power of design, and great beauty in the arrangement of line, while at the same time expressing most explicitly Leighton's creed of creeds—namely, the ennobling and elevating influence of beauty in the lives of men and women—"Cymon and Iphigenia" is perhaps the picture he himself would have chosen as the most representative among these later works. He chose it as the one he wished

sent to the Berlin Exhibition in 1885. When beginning it he described to me the moment of the day he wished to catch for the scene—"the most mysteriously beautiful in the whole twenty-four hours, when the *merest lip* of the moon has risen from behind the sea horizon, and the air is haunted still with the flush of the after-glow from the sun already hidden in the west."[\[70\]](#)

The study for the group of sleeping figures reproduced here is almost identical in design with the sketch in plaster from the clay, so lamentably destroyed when Watts lent it to be cast in bronze after Leighton's death. Leighton also gave the drawing of this group to his fellow artist, so enthusiastically did Watts admire it. He, in his turn, gave it to the Leighton House Collection in the year 1897, together with the fine painting which Leighton exchanged for his own portrait, painted about 1863, and which greeted friends as they mounted the staircase in Leighton House during all the years he lived in Holland Park Road (see [frontispiece to Vol. I.](#)). The study for "Cymon and Iphigenia" is particularly valuable now as an example of Leighton's rapid sketches where every touch reflects a mine of knowledge, because it was put under glass before any of the crispness of the touch was blurred by rubbing.[\[71\]](#)



"THE SLUGGARD"

From the Bronze Statuette—a direct reproduction from Lord Leighton's small sketch, 1886. Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



"NEEDLESS ALARMS"

From Bronze Statuette, 1886. Leighton House Collection [To List](#)



"THE LAST WATCH OF HERO." 1887 [ToList](#)



STUDY IN COLOUR FOR "TRAGIC POETESS." 1890

By permission of Mrs. Stewart Hodgson[ToList](#)

In a letter dated 1886 Watts wrote: "Leighton will carry off all the honours this year with his ceiling[\[72\]](#) and his two statues."

"An Athlete Awakening from Sleep" (given to the Tate Gallery by Sir Henry Tate) is generally known as "The Sluggard," a name bestowed on it by Leighton himself. The victor's garland lies at the feet of the athlete, a garland which does not preserve the owner from a sad weariness. Mr. Brock, R.A., in whose studio "An Athlete" was modelled, executed the fine bust of Leighton which was deposited in the Academy as Mr. Brock's diploma work.[\[73\]](#)

Sir John Millais admired greatly the other work alluded to in Watts' letter, "Needless Alarms." Leighton gave him this statuette, and Millais, desiring

to show his gratitude in a tangible form, painted the picture "Shelling Peas" for Leighton.

In at least fourteen of the eighty pictures shown at the Academy during the last seventeen years of Leighton's life, there can be traced an earnest sentiment beyond the "sincerity of emotion" for beauty which all evince. This feeling is, however, always guarded by a marked reticence from sentimentalism. "Elijah in the Wilderness," "Elisha Raising the Son of the Shunammite," "The Jealousy of Simœtha, the Sorceress," "The Last Watch of Hero," "Captive Andromache," "Return of Persephone," "Rizpah," "Tragic Poetess," "Sibyl," "Farewell," "The Spirit of the Summit," "Fatidica," "Lachrymæ," and the last passionate figure of "Clytie." The most popular pictures Leighton painted during these years appear to be "Sister's Kiss," "The Light of the Harem" (developed into a picture from the design of a group in the fresco, "The Industrial Arts of Peace"), "Idyll," "Whispers," "Wedded" (now in Australia), "Memories," "Letty," "Invocation," "Solitude," "The Bath of Psyche," "Bacchante," "Corinna of Tanagra," "The Bracelet," "Summer Slumber," "Atalanta," "Flaming June," and "The Fair Persian" (unfinished). Two sketches in the Leighton House Collection record effects which greatly fascinated Leighton in Scotland—"A Pool, Findhorn River," deep tortoiseshell brown; and "Rocks in the Findhorn," pink and grey enriched by lichen, and it was in Scotland that the Lynn of Dee inspired the subject of "Solitude." Leighton described to me the deep impression this Lynn of Dee had made on him. "It is the veriest note of solitude! a wonderful spot, full of poetic inspiration." In order to transmit a vivid record of this sentiment to his canvas, he took a second journey to the place.^[74]

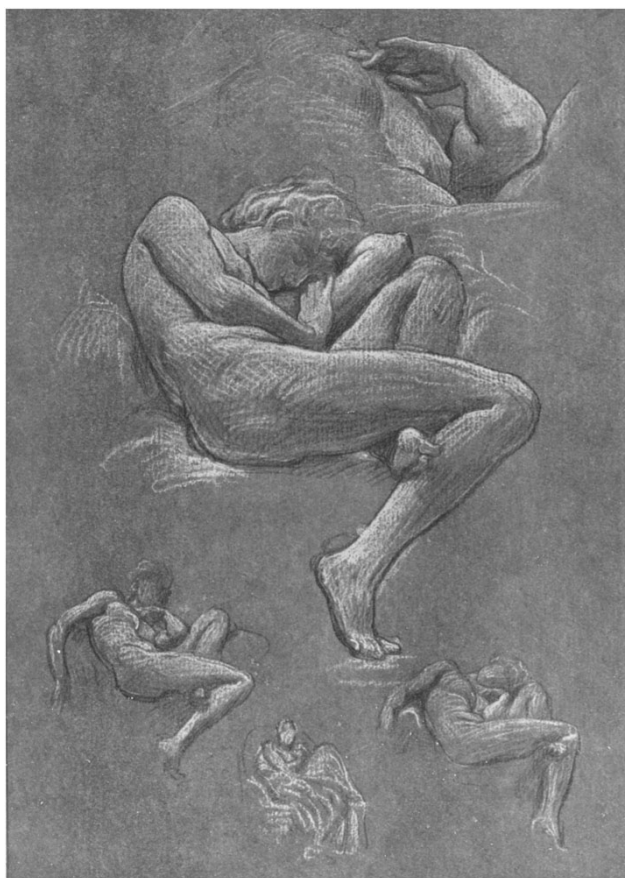


"ATALANTA." 1893

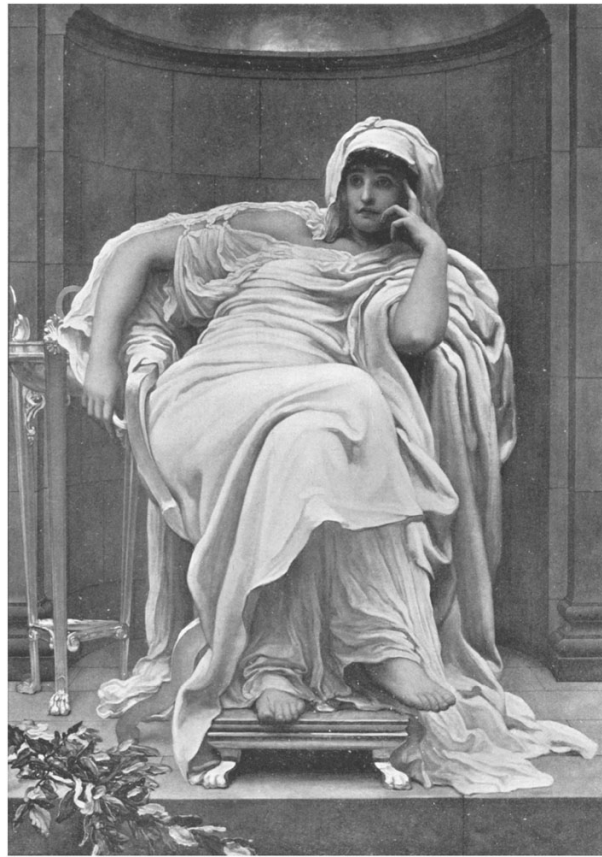
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"FLAMING JUNE." 1895
By permission of Mrs. Watney [ToList](#)

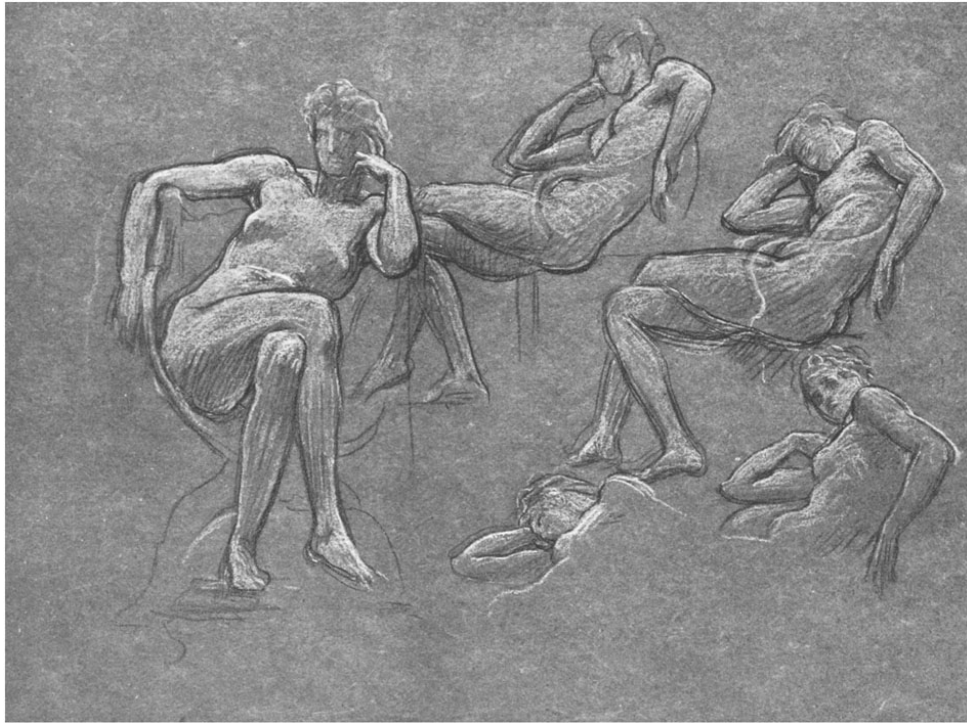


STUDY FOR "FLAMING JUNE." 1895 [To List](#)



"FATIDICA." 1894

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STUDIES FOR "FATIDICA." 1894

Leighton House Collection [To List](#)

Leighton wrote the following letter to his father when first visiting Forres, in which he described the "craze" he had for these "dark brown Scotch rivers":—

ROYAL STATION HOTEL,
FORRES, N.B.

I drove over to Dunkeld (twelve and a half miles) to lunch at the Millais'; I think the drive one of the most enchanting things I know, and I was favoured, moreover, by a few of those divine glimpses of blue and silver sky of which Scotland has the monopoly (a monopoly which she uses, perhaps, just a trifle too modestly). This is Forres, as the paper shows you; if Macbeth's witches really did live in this neighbourhood, it is just as well they had their hands pretty full, for they would have found the place uncommonly dull otherwise, especially on the "Sawbath." On the other hand, the drive to and the walk along the banks of the Findhorn—the excursion for

which one comes here—is quite delightful, and indeed surpassed my expectations. I must tell you that I have nothing short of a craze for your dark brown Scotch (and Irish) rivers, as dark as treacle, and as clear as a cairngorm. This particular stream contrives to rush part of the way through fantastic rocks of pink granite—you may imagine the effect. Here again from the heights over the river I *ought* to have seen the sea and the coast of Sutherlandshire; but the weather was sulky and I had to draw on my imagination for the view.

In the forenoon I went over by train to Elgin, to see the ruined cathedral, which is fine, but, like all Scotch architecture that I have seen, crude and barbaric. As I stood on the platform before starting, I heard a gruff, good-humoured voice hailing me from a train on the other side; it was the voice which goes so well with the rubicund face of the Duke of Cambridge. I was going by the same train, so he made me get into his compartment; he was going to Balmoral or Aberfeldie. He was very comic about B—— and his article in the *Nineteenth Century*—"A fellow who fouls his own nest is always a d——d bad lot—a d——d bad lot," with which sentiment I close a d——d long letter.—From your affectionate son,

FRED.

"Atalanta" may be noted, perhaps, as the strongest work achieved by Leighton. Here is "enormous power," though shown on a comparatively small canvas. For noble beauty of the Pheidian type in the grand and simple pose and modelling of the throat and shoulder, it would be difficult to find its peer in Modern Art, and yet it was only the worthy record of the beauty of an English girl. "Flaming June" (a design first made to decorate as a bas-relief the marble bath on which the figure in "Summer Slumber" reposes), is equally perfect in the fine fulness of the modelling, but it lacks the direct simplicity which gives such a distinguished strength to the "Atalanta." In the sketch for "Flaming June" reproduced in these pages the pose is better explained than in the completed picture, the foreshortened line of the back and shoulder being confused somewhat by the drapery in the painting.

At the age of twenty-five, in the wing-like petals of a cyclamen, Leighton had succeeded in securing with the pencil the quality towards which he aimed from the beginning to the end of his studies—and these only ended with his life—namely, absolute completeness as far as human eye and hand can reach completeness in rendering the perfection of nature's forms. Notably in "Neruccia" and in "Psyche" he reached that aim with the brush, but in "Atalanta," and in such studies as those for "Flaming June," "Fatidica," and—imbued with a yet further interest of dramatic feeling—for "Clytie," his aim was reached with more freedom and power of touch. The quality of beauty in these works was no invention of his—only, as has been noted before, a discernment and echo in the artist's apprehension of nobler truths in nature than are discovered by the many. They are nobler, because possessing the germ of life and movement. In all nature's forms, beauty and style result from the spring and moving on—the development of growth, whether it requires æons to develop the form as in mountains, years as in trees, or only days as in flowers. In the human limbs there is the further power of varied movement, and in the countenance of varied expressions. The greatest art stamps a suggestion of this power of growth and movement into the form and line expressing the facts it records; and, making it harmonise graciously with perfect structure in nature, the great artist evolves a thing of beauty. In our northern climes, and in our modern civilisation, beauty of form and line excite little genuine emotion. That is reserved for colour, tone, texture, and, in these very latter days, for the cleverness of the executant. The greatest opposer Leighton's teaching has had is laziness. Students will not take the trouble to go through irksome labour to secure knowledge, therefore they only aim at those qualities which are made comparatively easy by an emotional preference; and such emotional preference is rarely excited by form. There are exceptions, such as Watts, whose greatest artistic emotion was excited when he seized the beauty and style in Pheidias. He felt also the same enthusiastic excitement over Leighton's studies, stamped with a like Pheidian quality of style. Because the modern eye is so often blind to these qualities, therefore Leighton's work has been disposed of by many as merely academical and the result solely of taking inordinate pains! Surely those desirous of any true culture might learn one lesson at all events of Leighton: the value of Catholicity through learning "to master what they reject as fully as what they adopt ... the better motives of men" with whom they are not in

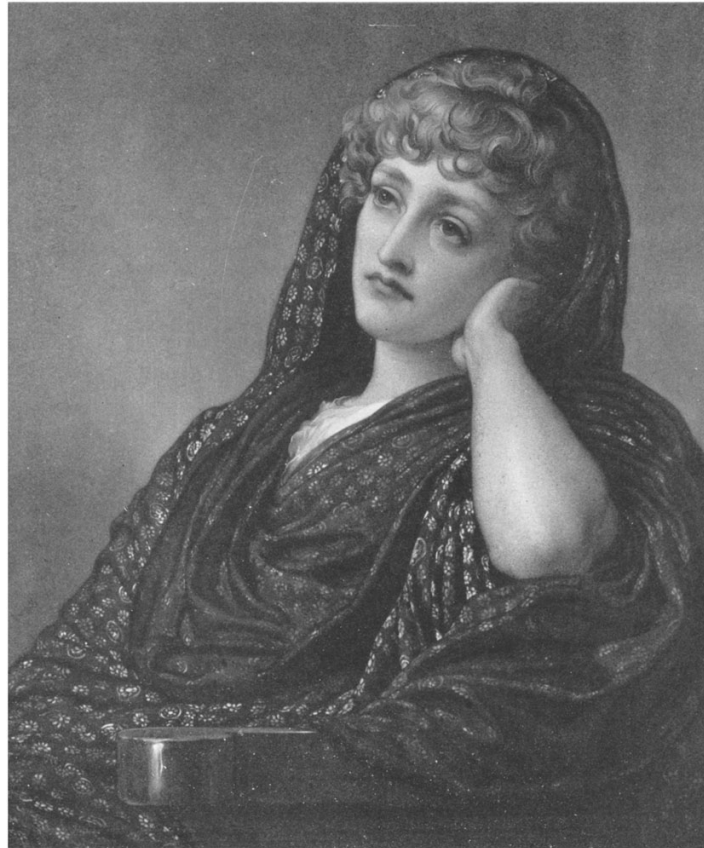
sympathy. Catholicity is the outcome of the best natures, the best understandings, the best educations. It overrides those subtle egoisms and commercial interests which so often guide while distorting a true judgment in art matters, keeping the preferences of the public wriggling about without any definite instinct or principle on a never truly-convincing dead level. The mainspring of catholicity in art is a fervent reverence for nature. All works in which such fervent reverence is found, in whatever direction it is displayed, are worthy to be admitted into the fold, whether it be form, colour, or tone in nature's aspect—whether it be the stirring whirls of northern tempests, the rural peace of English glades, or the fineness of rarefied atmosphere in the south, as in Greek isles and sea. Whichever mood of nature appeals to a true artist and inspires in him the sacred fire, and consequently the expression in his touch, should find a place in the heart of the true lover of art. Because the æsthetic pores of a music-lover are open to the rapturous tumult of the wildly whirling Schumann symphony in A minor, is he, therefore, incapable of being entranced by the rare refinement of Palestrina's cameo-like phrases? Because he feels a rapturous excitement as the curtain falls at the end of the first act of "Lohengrin," can he not also feel a soul-satisfaction in the elevated serenity of Bach's "Christmas Oratorio"? Does it not rather denote a want of elasticity in the æsthetic perceptions, a want of flexibility in the sensibilities flavouring somewhat of the Philistine, to be touched by a limited range of emotions? Because Leighton is not Whistler, or Watts is not Sargent, why must the one be admired at the expense of the other? With Leighton's rare intellectual acumen he knew well that these limitations in viewing various outlooks on art arose chiefly from a want of wide culture and experience. In the great galleries of Europe, among the treasures in the churches of Italy, his own vision had been enlarged, and he had felt how nourishing to his own best instincts such enlargement had proved. Hence his earnest endeavours when first entering the Academy to establish the Winter Exhibitions of Old Masters, and later, when President, to give as many facilities as possible for students to travel abroad. Probably, it never will be fully realised how greatly Leighton's initiations in starting new ventures for young students and artists have helped the real progress of English art. His great modesty and rare tact prevented this initiation from being fully appreciated even at the time. When such an one as Leighton is working on great lines, the last thing he thinks of is, Who is really achieving the work?

The aim has to be accomplished; it matters little who is used as the tool to achieve the work. The real satisfaction to such a nature is the fact that the work *has* been achieved.

Perhaps of all the ways in which Leighton helped to forward the condition of art in England, the most valuable was his industry in searching out unknown work, discovering what merit existed in it, hunting up the artist, and, by becoming personally acquainted with him, encouraging in every manner his onward progress. What he effected in Mason's case with such a rich harvest to the world as the result, he did in many other cases when the artist was a perfect stranger to him. Mr. Alfred East, the President of the Royal Society of British Artists, writes: "Lord Leighton was a man of broad sympathies in his appreciation of Art, an earnest worker with a lofty purpose and a high ideal. He liked to see these qualities in others, and spoke of the dignity and privilege of being an artist, and lived up to it in his own house. To those who knew him well he was singularly modest about his work, soliciting criticism with a frankness which was as unaffected as it was sincere. He never posed, but was a fellow-worker and a comrade. Such were the characteristics of the artist at home. I owe more to his encouragement than to any other influence of my life. Our acquaintanceship grew into friendship; he helped me to speak to him as I could speak to no other, of my own aims and ideals. This is the great artist as I knew him."

Singularly chary of accepting favours or putting himself under any obligation where he did not feel certain he could requite it by any feeling or action of his own, the response Leighton's nature made when any person, thing, or place gave him delight was that of a spontaneous, unstinting gratitude. Never did any one enjoy more fully the best of blessings—a grateful heart. Moreover, once the tender spot of pity touched, a self-ignoring energy of helpfulness and desire to benefit arose, which was at once the most beautiful and the least fully understood trait in his character. It is difficult for many to understand a *passion* for unselfishness. "We bear with resignation the sorrows of others," is one of the good sayings of Walter Bagehot. No rule without an exception—Leighton did not bear with resignation the sorrows of his friends, nor of those he pitied as overweighted and in any need of help which he could give. No better proof exists of the fineness, the distinction of a nature, or the reverse, than the effect which misfortune or suffering produces on it. Pity with Leighton was

ever allied with profound respect. He gave help as one indulging himself in a privilege rather than as one conferring a benefit. A beautiful story, for which I happen to be the best authority, is interwoven with the last years of his life.



"MEMORIES." 1883

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"THE JEALOUSY OF SIMŒTHA, THE SORCERESS." 1887 [ToList](#)



"LETTY." 1884

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One day, somewhere in the winter of 1879, on opening a gate which leads from our garden to the Holland Park Studios, I saw standing at one of the studio doors a figure which I described to Leighton as a "vision of beauty"—a young girl with a lovely white face, dressed in deepest black, evidently a model. Needless to say, Leighton, ever eager to procure good models, obtained her name from the artist to whom she was sitting when I first saw her, and engaged her as a model for the head. Shortly after she began to sit to Leighton, he wrote to me saying the young girl was in sad circumstances, and he would be very glad if I could help her by making some studies from her. I agreed, and he arranged with her to give me sittings. She told me that she had recently lost her mother, her father had deserted his family of five girls and two boys, and she with her elder brother were left to support them. She was endeavouring to act the part of mother to her younger sisters and brother. As Leighton and I grew to know

her better we found her very intelligent and conscientious in acting this part, and she enlisted our sympathies entirely. She confided to me, while sitting one day, that she longed greatly to find something to do more interesting and remunerative than spending her days as a model. She thought she could act. I consulted Leighton. His first exclamation was, "*Impossible!* with *that* voice! How *could* she go on the stage?" I thought the voice, which had a singularly unpleasant Cockney twang in it, might be trained, as I had observed how very eager she was to learn to speak in a more educated manner, quite realising her own shortcomings. Leighton came round to my opinion; and, once having made up his mind that she was bent on educating herself for the stage, showed himself as ever the most unselfish and untiring befriender. Meanwhile four of these beautiful children became useful to him as models. From the second daughter, who afterwards married an artist, Leighton painted "Memories," reproduced here; from the third, Hetty, he painted "Simœtha the Sorceress" and "Farewell"; but it was the youngest, Lina, quite a small child, who delighted him most, and who had a rare, refined charm which must have captivated any child-lover. She took the place of little Connie Gilchrist of the "Cleobouline," the "Music Lesson," and other of the earlier paintings, in the later pictures. She sat for "Sister's Kiss," "The Light of the Harem," "Letty," the sleeping group in "Cymon and Iphigenia," "Kittens," in the friezes "The Dance" and "Music," and "A little girl with golden hair and pale blue eyes"—

"Yellow and pale as ripened corn
Which Autumn's kiss frees—grain from
sheath
Such was her hair, while her eyes beneath,
Showed Spring's faint violets freshly born."

ROBERT

BROWN

ING.

—also the child in "Captive Andromache." Of the sister-mother of this little family, beautiful as she was, Leighton declared he never could paint a successful likeness, notwithstanding his attempts in "Viola,"^[75] "Bianca," "Serenely wandering in a trance of sober thought," and "Miss Dene." Her very beautiful throat, however, was reproduced worthily in many of his

subject-pictures, and the true dramatic instinct she undoubtedly possessed enabled her to be of help in such pictures as "Antigone," "Return of Persephone," and the last picture, the passionate "Clytie." But however useful she proved as a model, Leighton never for a moment thought of his own interests before the serious welfare of the young girl's life. He realised that if she was to make a successful actress, it involved serious and concentrated study. One morning I received the following note:—

DEAR MRS. BARRINGTON,—Miss Pullen will be very happy to sit to you on Monday, and will talk over the rest when you meet. You are very kind about it all, as is, indeed, your wont.

P.S.—You see my harassed old head does sometimes remember what I promise.



STUDIES FROM DOROTHY DENE FOR "CLYTIE." 1895
Leighton House Collection [To List](#)

And later:—

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD,
KENSINGTON, W.

DEAR MRS. BARRINGTON,—I want you to help me in a little conspiracy against (?) our young tragic friend. Mrs. Glyn frequently urges that she ought, at all events for a time, to give her *whole* mind and being to the study of her art. I need not say I share that opinion, and I have at last, after infinite trouble and persistence (my *nose*, you know)^[76] induced her to leave off sitting for a *month*, in the hope, if you will all help, of making it a *quarter*. This would, I am confident, be of the greatest value to her, giving her time also to read a little and concentrate her thoughts. I am quite prepared to give up painting from her for three months; but she is in mortal dread lest her other friends should think her unkind and ungrateful for their sympathy. I have told her I believe no such thing, and that I feel sure that Schmaltz and you (who work most from her) will, as willingly as I, postpone your studies in order to aid her in so important a matter. She is going to call on you to-day; if you agree with me, *be very firm*—have a *nose*! *Refuse* to paint from her for three months.

We succeeded in making the little girl work exclusively at her acting, and Leighton, Watts, and I frequently visited the school where she was being trained under Mrs. Glyn, to hear her and her fellow-students perform the pieces they had studied. Eventually she appeared in London and in the provinces, and quickly communicated all her successes and failures to Leighton and to me. Constant notes passed between us as we each received news from our young *protégée*, or when we thought some fresh step might be taken for her advantage. For instance, one of these notes runs as follows:

DEAR MRS. BARRINGTON,—It has occurred to me that I perhaps seemed this morning what I certainly did not mean to seem, churlish in regard to that letter from Irving.^[77] *If Miss Pullen is now ripe for him to hear her*—this is the most important point (for to go to him *too soon* would be the most unwise thing possible in view of her

getting a good engagement)—and if, having declined a letter on a previous occasion, she has any unnecessary scruple about now asking for one, it will be quite enough for you to tell me from her that she wishes for one, and I will at once write it. *Kemp will always be able to tell you where to get at me.* I can write as easily from Vienna or Constantinople as from here.

From Exeter Dorothy Dene wrote to Leighton after recounting an unwonted success:—

"Don't be frightened that I shall let all this praise turn my head. I know how much better it could be done, and after every scene a great weight falls on my heart that I have done no better. But I like you to warn me; it is good for me, so don't leave off, please. I am sorry that your friend, Lord Mount-Edgcumbe, will not see me, and that you had the bother of writing for nothing. Please do not fash yourself about finding out any one else. I must leave off now, as it is time to go to the theatre, and you will not get this any sooner if it were posted to-night than to-morrow.

Sunday, 24th.

"To continue, our lodgings are very comfortable, and nearly opposite the theatre; the food is good, and very fairly cooked, but I am very pleased with the tuck parcel; we had one of the birds when we arrived, the other things we have hardly touched. I thought it better to save them for places where the food may be bad. Please send me Mr. B. Tree's letter. I thought as you think about its advice. Thank you so much for *your* kind advice and gentle reminders, I shall try so hard to remember all you have said to me at different times; and if I do become anything in the future, I shall owe all the best part of it to you."

An engagement for two matinées was made for her début in London.

"Dear Mrs. Barrington, 'Dorothy' acts at the *Globe* on Monday and Tuesday afternoons," wrote Leighton; "I mean to go on Monday." I took a party of eight to see her, including the late Lord Lytton, who took much

interest in the stage. After the performance Leighton wrote to me, "Poor Dorothy was paralysed with terror yesterday—but I hope intelligent people will have seen *through* that." Again, later, "she is adding, as she deserves, to the number of her friends, several of whom treat her with really maternal kindness." I can indeed very truly endorse Leighton's good opinion. Dorothy and three of her sisters were worthy of all the interest shown in them. They were entirely self-respecting, conscientious children, most affectionately devoted to one another, and striving their utmost to improve in every sense, and make themselves worthy of the help they received. Naturally they adored their chief benefactor, Leighton. Unfortunately, Dorothy, notwithstanding dramatic gifts, great perseverance and intelligence, lacked charm on the stage. Her very beautiful face and throat were not seen to advantage, as they were hardly in proportion with her figure, which was short and too stiffly set to move gracefully on the stage. Leighton in fun always called her "the little tee-to-tum," or when she wore a large hat, "the mushroom." As he felt vitality waning and mental effort a greater strain, the little family of Pullens had to Leighton somewhat the same resting charm that Italy had in early days, when he turned from the German austerity in study to the relaxation of the *dolce far niente* of Italian national life. "I go to see them," he used to say, "when I want to let my back hair down and get off the stilts." When Leighton was dying, his sister, Mrs. Sutherland Orr, took Dorothy into his room. He was too ill to speak, but only smiled to her in answer to her saying, "If I have or ever will do anything worth doing, I owe it all to you—everything I owe to you." It is almost unnecessary, as it is distasteful, to mention that this beautiful paternal attitude Leighton displayed towards these orphans was made the subject of ugly gossip—for are there not always the *misérables* of the world who seek the ugly rather than the beautiful? misinterpreting the beautiful so that it should come within the range of their scandalous arrows, more especially when the darts attack a man in the high position Leighton held. Some of these offshoots of envy and jealousy came within earshot of Leighton's sisters, who thought it well to warn him in a letter that such malice was in the air. He wrote a lengthy answer, ending with the following sentence: "But let me turn away from the whole thing, it has pained me more than enough. I implore you not to reopen it. On the only thing that matters, you are *absolutely assured, if you believe in my honour*. If you hear these rumours again, meet them with a flat, ungarnished denial. Let that

suffice—it does for me." To a lady friend he wrote still more explicitly, in order, as he said, that there should exist in his own handwriting an implicit and unmitigated denial of the malicious falsehood. Leighton never knew under whose auspices this scandal was conducted. As is the case invariably, it was impossible to put the finger exactly on the culprit—for these fulsome things have to be propagated under the rose, in order that they should get a firm root before an authoritative denial can be given. However, after Leighton's death, the lie was stated more boldly—even directly to his two sisters. It is necessary, therefore, to include in the account of his life the full and truthful version of the kind and fatherly protection Leighton gave to this family.

The interests of the Kyrle Society were another cause which I had in common with Leighton. He spoke at the first public meeting that was held in the Kensington Town Hall on January 27, 1881, and I possess an interesting correspondence with him on the subject, which space will not allow me to quote. The important matter contained in it appears in the following correspondence between Mr. T.C. Horsfall, the chief mover in establishing the Art Museum and Galleries in Manchester, and Leighton, together with a discussion on other vital points connected with Art:—

April 7, about 1880.

DEAR SIR,—I am probably too late to be of any use, but have nevertheless much pleasure in assuring you once again of the sympathy with which I view your endeavours to bring the refining influences of Art in all its forms, and, so to speak, in co-operation on the masses in the vast industrial centre from which you write. I believe that in seeking to elicit and to cultivate their sense of what is beautiful you are opening up to them a deep source of enjoyment, and by opposing good to bad influences, rendering them great and lasting service.—Yours very faithfully,

FRED LEIGHTON.

February 17, 1881.

I have carefully read over the programme of your enterprise, and there is much in it with which I can warmly sympathise. I desire nothing more deeply than to see the love and knowledge of Art penetrate into the masses of the people in this country—there is no end which I would more willingly serve; but there is in your programme a paragraph which I cannot too emphatically repudiate—that, namely, which excludes from Art, as far as the public is concerned, that which is the root of the finest Art as Art, the human form, the noblest of visible things. That you should sternly and stringently exclude all work which reveals an offensive aim or prurient mind is what I should be the first to claim, but that you should lay down as a corner-stone of your scheme an enactment which would exclude by implication more than half the loftiest work we owe to Art—*nearly all Michael Angelo*, much of Raphael's best, Sebastiano del Piomba's "Raising of Lazarus," Titian's "Bacchus and Ariadne," Botticelli's "Birth of Venus"—this is indeed a measure from which I must most distinctly dissociate myself, and which makes it impossible for me to connect my name with an enterprise which would else command my sympathy.



STUDY IN COLOUR FOR "GREEK GIRLS PLAYING AT BALL."
1889

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From the "Manchester Courier," August 30, 1890.

SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON ON THE MANAGEMENT OF ART GALLERIES.

To the Editor of the *Manchester Courier*.

SIR,—On the 4th and 6th inst. I published two long letters on the management of art galleries, of some part of which this is a summary:—No one can intelligently and fully enjoy any picture or statue unless he has some measure of three kinds of knowledge. (1) He must know something about the subject represented, or he cannot enjoy the expression by the work of the artist's feeling and thought; (2) he must know something of the processes of the art in which the artist has worked, or he cannot know what effects the artist sought or might have sought; (3) he must know something of the history of the art, or he cannot understand what elements in the work are due to the artist himself and what to his time and place; or enjoy at all some of the finest works ever produced. For the giving of the second and third of these three kinds of knowledge there ought to be subsidiary collections in our Manchester galleries, kept distinct from the principal collection, and for the giving of the first kind there ought to be several distinct subsidiary collections, of which some should be for the purpose of giving knowledge of flowers, birds, trees, and the other beautiful objects which are "elements of landscape." As a very large proportion of the people of all large towns are ignorant of all that is interesting in nature, and of all that is noblest and most interesting in history and in contemporary life, and as pictures can very effectively give some knowledge both of nature and of the deeds of men while fulfilling their special function, which is to give certain kinds of æsthetic pleasure, the principal collections in our galleries ought to be used for the purpose of giving knowledge of nature and of noble human nature. A gallery of good pictures of the kind would, by reason of the interest of the subjects represented, attract so much attention that

the public would to a far larger extent than now feel the influence of the artistic qualities of pictures. In order to obtain pictures of suitable subjects, the directors of art galleries, instead of only buying pictures in exhibitions and studios as they now do, should, as a rule, revert to the custom which prevailed in the ages when art influenced life deeply, and should ask artists to paint pictures of prescribed subjects. I believe that they would get thus better pictures and at lower prices. Many artists certainly would be at their best when they knew they were working to enlighten a great community, and would gladly accept a moderate price for a picture ordered for a public gallery.

I sent a copy of my letters to Sir Frederic Leighton, and asked him if he would let me have his opinion respecting the principal suggestions contained in them. With the great kindness which distinguishes him, Sir Frederic Leighton has written me the following letter, which contains advice so valuable that I am sure every person in Manchester who cares for art will be glad to have an opportunity of reading it:—

"DEAR MR. HORSFALL,—I must apologise for my very long delay in answering your letter—a delay due in great part to lack of time, but in part also to the fact that your questions could not be answered hastily, or without due consideration. I may say at the outset that I very warmly appreciate the depth of your interest in the subject of art, and the constancy of your efforts to spread its influence in Manchester; and I am glad to be able to add that on not a few points, I find myself in harmony with your views.

"It is evidently not possible for me to touch, within the compass of a letter, upon more than one or two of the matters with which you deal in your two long communications to the Manchester press; and, indeed, the question on which you mainly dilate, and in regard to which I am not wholly at one with you, would require to be dealt with at far greater length than is possible to me here. I must content myself with saying what little seems to me sufficient to indicate the grounds of

my dissent from you. But first I should like to say a word in passing on the vexed subject of *copies*.

"There can be no doubt that it would be an immense advantage to those who cannot travel—that is to say, to the enormous majority of men—to bring before their eyes, through reproductions—if these reproductions were absolutely faithful—the masterpieces to which distance deprives them of access. This is, in the case of sculpture and architectural detail, in a large measure achieved by the means of plaster casts, though it is needless to point out that the capacity of the material robs the reproduction of much of the life and light of the original. With pictures the case is different. The subtle and infinite charm which resides in the *handiwork* of a master, and in the absence of which half the personality of his work is lost, can hardly ever be rendered by a copyist. For this reason the overwhelming majority of even reasonable copies is to my mind worse than useless. Such copies can kindle no enthusiasm, and they virtually misinform the student. It has always seemed to me that the best way to acquaint young people with pictures which they are not able to see is to put before them photographs of the originals, which, besides giving design, form, and light and shade, with absolute fidelity, render, in a wonderful way, the executive physiognomy of the work; and by the side of these photographs free, but faithful, coloured sketches of the pictures should hang, giving the scheme, harmony, and tone of the colour, but not, like finished copies, professing an identity with the original, which is never achieved.

"Turning now to what you say on the subject of the acquisition of works for a public gallery, I should at once dissuade you from any idea of giving definite commissions—I mean commission to paint specially selected subjects. I have always felt very strongly that artistic work, to be of real value, must be the outcome of entirely spontaneous impulse in an artist. I believe that in the immense majority of cases work done under any other conditions lacks vitality and

sincerity, and will not show the worker at his best. A subject which does not impose itself unbidden on the artist will never elicit his full powers. I have myself on that ground for many years past invariably declined to paint under any kind of restriction.

"Neither does your idea of—practically—refusing encouragement to any work which does not commemorate a noble deed, and, if possible, the noble deed of a well-known personage, commend itself to me. It seems to me, on the contrary, to be a harmful one, inasmuch as it misdirects the mind of a people, already little open to pure artistic emotion, as to the special function of Art. This can, of course, only be the doing of something which it *alone* can achieve. Now, direct ethical teaching is specially the province of the written and the spoken word. A page or two from the pen of a great and nobly-inspired moralist—a Newman, say, or a Liddon, or a Martineau—can fire us more potently and definitely for good than a whole gallery of paintings. This does not, of course, mean that a moral lesson may not indirectly be conveyed by a work of art, and thereby enhance its purely moral value. *But it cannot be the highest function of any form of expression to convey that which can be more forcibly, more clearly, and more certainly brought home through another channel.* You may no more make this direct *explicit* ethical teaching a test of worth in a painted work than you may do so in the case of instrumental music; indeed by doing so you will turn the attention of those before whom you place it from the true character of its excellence—you will, so to speak, mis-focus their emotional sensibility. It is only by concentrating his attention on essentially artistic attributes that you can hope to intensify in the spectator that perception of what is beautiful in the highest, widest, and fullest sense of the word, through which he may enrich his life by the multiplication of precious moments akin to those which the noblest and most entrancing music may bestow on him through different forms of æsthetic emotion. It is in the power to lift us out of ourselves into regions of such pure and

penetrating enjoyment that the privilege and greatness of art reside. If, in a fine painting, a further wholly human source of emotion is present, and if that emotion is more vividly kindled in the spectator by the fact that he is attuned to receive it by the excitement of æsthetic perception through the beauty of the work of art as such, that work will gain no doubt in interest and in width of appeal. But it will not therefore be of a loftier order than a great work in architecture or music—than the Parthenon, for instance, or a symphony of Beethoven, neither of which preaches a direct moral lesson.

"But I am being led away into undue length without the possibility, after all, of doing more than roughly indicate the grounds of my dissent from a rather vital article of your creed—a dissent which will, I am afraid, jar on you in proportion to the great sincerity with which you hold your faith. I may say, by the way, that I dwelt at rather greater length on this very subject in my first presidential address to the Royal Academy, delivered on 16th December 1879.—And, herewith, I remain, dear Mr. Horsfall, yours very truly,

FRED LEIGHTON.

"2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON,
"August 18, 1890."

Examples of the kind of copies which Sir F. Leighton recommends can be seen in the Art Museum in No. 1 Room. We have there a photograph of the "Adoration of the Magi" of Paul Veronese, with a series of studies by Mr. F. Shields of the composition, the light and shade, and the arrangement of colour in the picture. These copies suffice to prove that such a collection as Sir F. Leighton recommends would be of the greatest value and interest. May I say with regard to two points in the letter, that my proposal to use some parts of the collections in our galleries for the purpose of revealing the beauty of nature and the greatness of

human nature, does not involve any belief that the giving of ethical teaching ought to be one of the functions of pictures, and that the proposal is made partly for the purpose of increasing the width of appeal of works of art. While trying to make that appeal reach a large part of the community, we may usefully teach, by means of other parts of the collections, that the excellence of paintings has no relation to ethical teaching.

With regard to the influence on the artist of the choice by others of his subjects, I think that Sir F. Leighton is misled by his own great gifts. A man of remarkably wide culture, and of great poetical power, he has been enabled, by the great range and strength of his imagination, to choose subjects giving ample scope for the exercise of the qualities peculiar to the painter, and yet appealing strongly to the powers of thought and feeling of all fairly educated people. To such a man, and to such a man only, spontaneous impulse can now be a sufficient guide in the choice of his subject; and to such a man, and only to such a man, the choice of his subject by other persons of intelligence would be a harmful restriction. In every picture gallery it is but too obvious that the majority of even able painters, though unrestricted by the will of any committee, are impeded by more hampering restrictions than any intelligent committee would impose, and are unable to find subjects interesting both to themselves and to others. For many able painters the intelligent choice by others of subjects for their work would remove, and not impose, restrictions. It must be remembered that the subjects of the works of Pheidias, of Cimabue, of Giotto, and indeed those of most of the works which have been much cared for, were chosen for, and not by, the artists.—Yours, &c.,

T.C. HORSFALL.

The following letter is Mr. Horsfall's answer to the one published in the *Manchester Courier*, August 30, 1890:—

SWANSCOE PARK, NEAR MACCLESFIELD,
August 20, 1890.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON,—It is most kind of you to answer my letter so fully. I shall show my gratitude by doing my best to make your counsel as useful as possible to Manchester.

The system which you suggest for giving some idea of masterpieces which are too distant to be visited seems to me to be admirable, and I cannot but believe that it will be adopted in one of our Manchester Galleries.

With regard to the advisableness of choosing for public galleries chiefly pictures of noble subjects respecting which most people have, when they see the pictures, or can be expected to gain, some knowledge, though I feel the great weight of your argument, I am still of the same opinion. I may say this without presumption, because the great question which we are discussing: "How can Art be made most useful to England?" involves the two other questions: "What are the best conditions under which artists can work?" and "How can the best work of artists be made to influence the rest of the community?" In considering the second of these questions an artist is, I think, impeded by his special gifts, while I, not an artist, aided by the *qualités de mes défauts*, and by the results of several years of experiment in the use of pictures, believe myself to have gained much trustworthy knowledge! Speaking from the standpoint which I have thus reached, I should say that whilst the artist is most conscious of the analogy which exists between painting and instrumental music, there is really a much closer analogy between painting and poetry, or between painting and song, and that it is this closer analogy which should guide the action of the directors of public galleries. Painting deals, while instrumental music does not, with subjects respecting which we think and feel, and it must accept the results for good and evil of this; its products cannot be, as instrumental music is, without definite relation to our feeling and thought, and a simply neutral relation being impossible, the relation must be ennobling or debasing in some degree. I think that my analysis of the conditions which must be fulfilled if the relations is to be an ennobling one was sound.

In asking that painters shall choose subjects pure and lovely "and of good report," I am not asking that painting shall leave its special

function—shall cease to do that which it can do better than any other art; but only that it shall recognise that its function differs from that of instrumental music, and is the creation in us of a symphony of feeling or emotional thought and enjoyment of form and colour, and human skill, and love of beauty.—With very many thanks, I am, dear Sir Frederic Leighton, yours sincerely,

T.C. HORSFALL.

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
August 22, 1890.

DEAR MR. HORSFALL,—I have to thank you for your kind and interesting letter of the 20th.

Knowing of old the views you entertain, and the radical divergence which exists between them and my own, I had fully anticipated the spirit of your answer; in fact, it almost seemed to me when I wrote at some length the other day that I ought to explain that it was out of deference to your wish and in high appreciation of the long and earnest thought which you have given to a grave subject that I did so, rather than in the hope that my views would carry conviction or commend themselves to you.

The divergence between us is, as I said, at the root of things, and is one on which I do not think experience either qualifies or disqualifies us to judge. The question is not what effect pictures may have had on certain people, but what the *proper* function of Art is. The question is theoretic rather than practical. *If* the primary function of Art is definitely didactic, *if* its first duty is to inculcate a specific moral truth, then, indeed, there is, as you very rightly say, no neutral ground. Either the teaching is wholesome or it is mischievous.

Meanwhile, our brief correspondence only throws into stronger light the impossibility to which I believe I alluded in my first letter, of dealing with such a subject within the compass of a letter, and in broad and sweeping outlines. So, for instance, when I used instrumental music as a parallel, I did not for a moment mean to

describe its province as being identical with that of painting. Neither, on the other hand, would you, I presume, in instancing song on your side wish to be taken too literally; for you would have, according to your theory, to excommunicate, let us say, for instance, Schubert, the king of song-writers, who has played on more varied chords of feeling and imagination than any other musician of his kind, and of whom I am not aware that he ever inculcated (I feel pretty certain that he never meant to inculcate) a definite moral lesson.

But I am beginning again. Let me at once draw rein, and abandoning a barren, however interesting controversy, remain, dear Mr. Horsfall, yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
August 28, 1890.

DEAR MR. HORSFALL,—Before starting for my holiday, of which I stand in much need, I write one line to acknowledge and thank you for your amiable and interesting letter, which shows me, I am very glad to see, that we are much less divided in opinion than I should have gathered from what you had previously written, and indeed printed.

Judgments given as absolute in your letters to the Manchester press are shown by the commentary which your last letter furnishes to be in a manner conditional, and without that commentary your words were rather misleading. I was not unnaturally a little startled—I, who do not think a "subject" in the ordinary sense of the word imperative at all—to find you condemn the purchase of Yeames's "Arthur and Hubert" (which, for the element of human emotion, certainly satisfies the Aristotelian demand in reference to tragedy), because the emotion does not turn on an heroic act; and I may say, in passing, that I am unable to see how a scene in which deep pity for the helpless is aroused, can be justly described as a "horror which it is foolish to try to realise."

Meanwhile, I fully feel the practical difficulty which your last letter describes. It is a difficulty of the most perplexing kind. For it must be evident that whilst with a people of strong moral fibre and an almost entire absence of æsthetic sensibility—at all events, on the side of form—you may indirectly insinuate some perception of the beautiful—of that essence which lifts us out of ourselves—under the cover and pretext of a *moral* emotion—we cannot ignore the danger of producing the exactly opposite effect of confirming the dully-strung spectator in the belief that the stirring of that moral emotion is in fact the *raison d'être* of the work. One is, of course, glad, as the world goes, that the doors of righteousness should be opened, even by the wrong key; but one would still more desire that the door which yields only to that key should not itself remain closed.

Pray do not take the trouble to acknowledge these parting words: but believe me, very truly yours,

FRED LEIGHTON.

With regard to Leighton's acute artistic sense of fitness when it was a matter of choosing a site for buildings or monuments, so that such placing should give them their full value of effect, I remember, after a site had been decided on for Cleopatra's Needle in London, Leighton vehemently denouncing the idea of placing it where it now stands. The conversation we had respecting it was recalled by finding the following letter:—

DEAR SIR,—It is a source of regret to me that I am unable to be present as a listener at the discussion to-morrow. Meanwhile the question of the base, though a very important one, is in my mind very secondary to that of the site, and the (in my poor opinion) radical wrongness of the present selection much mars my interest in the whole affair. A monument which, intended to be conspicuous, is not the *focus* of the avenues that lead to it, I think against the most primary perceptions of effect. Two magnificent avenues give access to Cleopatra's Needle, the finest river and the finest embankment in Europe; *both of these run past it* as if they had forgotten it. I may add that what would only have been feeble is rendered worse than

feeble by the (of course accidental) semblance of matching with the short tower over the way.

Pray excuse the great haste in which I write and the consequent abruptness of my expressions, and believe me, yours very truly,

FRED LEIGHTON.

Mr. J. Goodall, in his *Reminiscences*, says: "Many years before it was removed from Egypt I used to see it lying on the seashore near Alexandria. I agree with Lord Leighton's opinion that it was not erected on a suitable site. It is a pity it was not put up in front of the British Museum."

Leighton, needless to say, took infinite interest in Sir Henry Tate's splendid scheme for memorialising the success of a commercial life, by presenting to his nation a gallery in which the best British works of art might find a home, and, moreover, by the gift to the public of the nucleus of such a collection. It was truly amazing to see the amount of time and trouble which Leighton devoted to this scheme, considering how full to overflowing his life already appeared to be. But, whether it was a question of a splendid enterprise, or a struggling artist of whom the world had never heard, or even an earnest amateur, once his sense aroused that he could be of help, Leighton manufactured time somehow to give that help.^[78] But the high-minded, public-spirited view Sir Henry Tate took of the responsibilities of wealth specially enlisted Leighton's sympathies, and he evinced an intense interest in helping to work out the great idea.

Another matter which concerned him very seriously was the fact that a work by the greatest sculptor England can claim—Alfred Stevens—purporting to memorialise our great warrior, the Duke of Wellington, was allowed to remain unfinished and shunted away in a side chapel of St. Paul's Cathedral, instead of being completed and placed in the position for which it was designed. The following letters to Mr. Henry Wells show that in 1888 Leighton had induced others to view the matter in the same light:—

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD,
August 12, 1888.

DEAR WELLS,—The list for the Memorial Committee is practically complete, and though it is not in every particular the list which you or I might have drawn up, it is a good one, and as I told you I think in a previous note, I have not liked to interfere too much, as Agnew has so zealously taken the work on himself. I meant to send you the list, but have cleverly come away from home (I am writing at the Senior United Service Club) without it. I have of course asked Agnew to add his own name; for the Academy I have proposed to him the four Trustees—not as Trustees, but because they offer a ready-made group in a body where none is afore or after—Sir J. Gilbert, Linton, and Coutts Lindsay will complete the artistic section for the present. The next step, as I have suggested to Agnew, is to get at the Dean of St. Paul's—this I have offered to do. A chairman will have to be appointed; I should suggest, or rather have suggested, the D. of Cleveland—if he joins; I believe his answer has not yet come in. And there must be a banker: then a letter from the Committee should appear in the *Times* inviting adhesions and subscriptions, to be published from time to time: is all this in harmony with your own view? Are you not afraid that the moment when "everybody" (for *our* purposes it *is* everybody) is leaving town or has left it—I go myself in a few days—is a very bad one? Many people lose sight of their *Times*, or would not write from the country or foreign parts. How would it strike you to wait a month or two, having now laid the foundation? It is a nice point. There are pros, but there are also cons. With all good wishes, yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

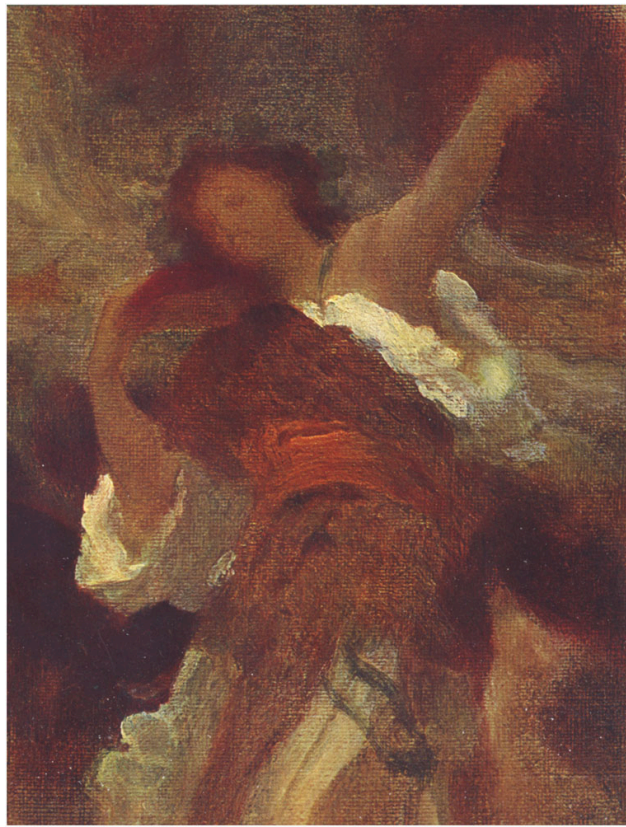
You have seen no doubt in your *Times* that we mean to exhibit our lamented friend's work in a worthy manner.

P.P.S.—By-the-bye, *S. Kensington* ought to be represented. I will ask Agnew to write to T. Armstrong.



"BACCHANTE." 1892

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STUDY IN OILS FOR "BACCHANTE." 1892
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2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
November 2, 1892.

DEAR WELLS,—Best thanks for your cheque and kind note. You will be glad to hear that the removal is going on capitally. I did not wait for the full money-promise; I had *determined* to do the thing, and I set it going on my personal guarantee when we were £300 short of the full sum. Now we have the money, young Lehmann munificently sending a cheque *for that amount*.

The great monument having been moved to its right position, the next question was to raise funds for the completion of the work. This was perplexing Leighton during the last weeks of his life. Having written a letter

to the *Times* in 1895, and the donations having come in but scantily, he was puzzled to know what further steps to take.

Leighton himself, so distinguished a sculptor, took a special interest in all efforts to promote the knowledge and love of plastic art. When, therefore, his old friend Mr. Walter Copland Perry called a meeting at Grosvenor House—at which the late Duke of Westminster presided—to lay before it his scheme for the formation of a gallery of casts from all the best Greek and Roman statues, Leighton was one of the most zealous and active promoters of the scheme.^[79]

Leighton was commissioned by the Government to execute the medallion for Queen Victoria's Jubilee in 1887. M. Edouard Lantéri, now Professor of Modelling at the South Kensington schools, assisted him in carrying out the design, and became an ardent admirer of the President. M. Lantéri described to me how certain difficulties occurred in the casting. Leighton said they must work on till these were set right—and they *did* work eighteen hours on end.

All to whom the work of Watts, Burne-Jones, and Rossetti has appealed, owe Leighton a debt of gratitude. Before the Grosvenor Gallery Exhibition of his work took place in 1882, Watts, in talking to me of the unpopularity of the pictures he felt most inspired to paint, would often give as a proof of this that, with one exception, no one had ever cared to engrave his pictures; and truly, without Mr. Fred Hollyer's photographs the general public would have known little of the special value of this work, nor of the art of Rossetti and Burne-Jones. Mr. Hollyer's photographs are not merely copies—they have as art an atmosphere of charm in themselves; they render what may be called the *soul* of a picture. He writes:—

"About 1875 I received a letter from Baroness ———, requesting me to call upon her in order to arrange to photograph the collection of works of art in her country house. She had employed other photographers, but the results had not been satisfactory. I carried the matter through, and not only received a considerable amount in remuneration, but was given great encouragement to persevere with my work at a time when I had nearly decided on going to America. The Baroness never mentioned who it was that had recommended

me, and though I had been constantly working for him during many years, it was not till six months after his death that I discovered it was Lord Leighton who had been my good friend. I should be glad to bear testimony to his great heart and loving kindness, and do regret not having been able to thank him myself."

Leighton was made a Baronet in 1886. The following letter from Gladstone, written in 1885, refers to Leighton having submitted to him the names of Millais and Watts as artists worthy to receive the honour, at the same time begging him earnestly not to include his own:—

Private.]

10 DOWNING STREET, WHITEHALL,
June 17, 1885.

MY DEAR SIR F. LEIGHTON,—Your letter has given me much pleasure. I can assure you that I in return highly appreciate the generous spirit you have shown, and I value the advice you kindly tendered in this matter of Art Honours. I am reporting rather fully to Her Majesty on our conversation of Monday, and on the personal abnegation on your own part, which commands my cordial respect. —I remain always, very faithfully yours,

W.E. GLADSTONE.

On Watts declining the honour, Leighton was at first much vexed; but Watts, having explained to him the reason which made it inadvisable for him to accept a baronetcy, Leighton fully, as he told my husband and myself, saw the necessity of his declining.

Since the first years when Leighton settled in London he had been favoured by the personal friendship of many members of the Royal family, who very greatly esteemed him. He not only attended the State banquets and entertainments to which he was summoned, but was frequently the guest at receptions of a private and a more intimate character at Marlborough House and elsewhere.

In these pages there is only space to note a few, among the very many directions in which he served the Art interests of his country. In foreign lands, and in the Colonies no less than in England, he extended the knowledge and appreciation of the best English Art by his unwearying exertions; and yet it must always be remembered he ever remained "a workman first, an official after."

Professor Church, appointed in 1879 to the Professorship of Chemistry in the Royal Academy of Arts in London, has preserved letters and notes from Leighton on the subject of pigments.^[80] It is almost incredible that his mind could have penetrated with such accuracy into all the details of his craft as fresh questions arose as to the value of new vehicles and colours, considering his endless labours connected with the wider interests of Art, and the absorbing nature of his own work. But there exist over sixty letters, and more than twenty cards, dating from 1880 to November 1895, two months before his death, in which he proves his insistency to master thoroughly every detail of his craft. He wrote: "It is, I feel, rather a duty in me to ascertain about these various new vehicles."

The following extracts may prove of interest and value to painters.^[81]

8th.

DEAR PROF. CHURCH,—I write to acknowledge your letter of the 6th, the information in which (Jaune de Naples) is to me of very great importance indeed. I believe Hills to be really anxious to help us in the matter of medium. I should be peculiarly glad if we could send forth a thoroughly trustworthy, hard-drying, supple, and not yellowing vehicle. Let us consider it. I find myself using a mixture, roughly, of equal parts of amber varnish (Roberson's) and oil of spike; and, say, a sixth of the whole of poppy oil (Roberson's): that is, $\frac{3}{7}$ amber, $\frac{3}{7}$ spike, $\frac{1}{7}$ poppy; but I vary according to the work; and again I don't know what Roberson's amber varnish is, it does not seem very drying. Of course one would want a good middle drying power, to which, *mixing the ingredients*, one might add any one at will. I think that "Siccatif de Haarlem" has about that middle quality, if I remember it rightly. It is, I think, copal, poppy oil, and turps.; but it seemed to me to yellow a little, why, I don't

know; poppy should not darken. Chromophile is delightful up to a certain point, and then the work sinks extraordinarily blind and tallowy; and as you want something in the way of varnish at the end, it seems desirable to carry that or *some* varnish in a moderate degree right through. Chromoph. becomes a little *milky* in a bottle with spir. of turp., and turns bright green when left in a dipper.

Your proposal to *report* to us annually is very valuable, and could be worked to the *general* advantage.

I am delighted to find that you are in co-operation with my friend Mr. Hills, who has a warm and genuine desire to serve Art and his friends the artists. I find his poppy oil *clarified with charcoal* very delightful stuff. Am I wrong in thinking the action of the charcoal on it has been to render it more *drying*? I think that a vehicle made with that oil, amber varnish, and oil of spike will be a very satisfactory vehicle indeed; particularly if you can, between you, *bleach* the oil yet more. Chromophile is quite colourless. The mastic varnish *that won't bloom* will be a great triumph. *Pace* our detractors, it shall, I hope, be seen in time that the R.A. is not unmindful of the needs of artists even in the matter of material appliances.

I observe that you speak in your valuable manual of Aureolin as a *very slow-drying* colour when ground with oil; finding, in use, that *Roberson's* Aureolin dries, on the contrary, extremely quick—it is always absolutely dry the next day, and I use no vehicle but Bell's Medium, *i.e.* linseed and oil of spike and turps.—I wrote to ask him what he grinds the colour in. He answers "*pure linseed oil without the addition of any drier.*" This puzzles me. Where is the solution? Are there different kinds of Aureolin? When you have a leisure moment send me a post-card.

Among the madders in your handbook *scarlet* madder does not appear; I hope it is not a treacherous colour; I use it freely, but only

mixture with other *dark* colours, to give them richness. I also use cadmium *red*; is that wrong? A line on a post-card will greatly oblige.

P.S.—Of course I only use cadmium red when I want a *very* deep orange in drapery or sky—nothing could replace it.

Feb. 2, 1885.

Here is a little problem: I thought all *burnt* colours were *ipso facto* sound. Roberson tells me that burnt white (Chremnitz do.), a lovely colour *like ivory*, plays most amazing tricks, darkens and lightens again in rapid succession. WHY? When you are in Long Acre make him show you his samples.

Thanks for your letter. I don't use any particular colours other than those you mentioned in your lectures, although I thought of trying deep yellow madder again; I used to like it very much. I suppose you have the list—it is a very long one—of Edouard's colours. Smith is his agent here (14 Charles Street, Middlesex Hospital). I use one or two colours (Tadema I think *all*) from Mommen's in Brussels; his burnt sienna is *superb*. Asphaltum would reward study; it was *universally* used by the Venetians, and seems never to have cracked with them. I am very glad that you are steadily pursuing your collection of specimens and experiments, which I hope will by degrees become an exhaustive one, and of infinite value to the profession. *Grounds*, too, will deserve much attention.

Kindly tell me whether there is any harm in putting a *thin* coat of mastic, softened perhaps with a drop or two of oil, over works *finished quite recently* but *begun* a year or more ago? If I understand rightly, cracking is caused by atmospheric action through the *back* of the canvas, by *distension* of underlying partially soft paint and, consequent disruption of the upper, harder layer of varnish. If the

first painting is a year old, is it not tough enough to resist the atmosphere, and is it not *anyhow* pretty safe when the canvas is *backed*?

I suppose "Mutrie yellow" is quite safe alone and mixed with other pigments?

Thanks for your note. Yes, I do like the white oil, but I add copal to it if I want it to be very drying, or mix copal on the palette with a slow-drying colour, say a lake. This, I suppose, is all right; if so, don't trouble to acknowledge this. The oil of orange is delightful on account of its smell, but dries less quickly than turpentine (rectfd. spirit). Is it not *always* better to have *some* resin in a picture *throughout* since it has to be varnished at the end?

April 21, 1888.

I am so much enamoured with the method, so far as vehicle is concerned, which I have used during the last year, that I should like to feel quite certain that it is *absolutely safe*. I use a "single-primed" canvas, and underpaint with "Bell's medium" and rect. spir. turps., which, under your advice, I have in *small* bottles, so that using it freely a bottle lasts a very short time, and the stuff is therefore always fresh. The mixture I *use up to the end* (except when I now and then use the pigment *alone*), and letting the turps. rather *preponderate* as I advance. I have found to my amazement that this mixture dries even in winter weather excellently, and that I can use with it even scarlet madder and aureolin, which, at least the former, hitherto I never attempted to use except stiffened with amber or copal; and I further find that this mixture, though of course it "sinks" to some extent (and especially with the blues), in the main bears up very fairly, incomparably better than I should have expected, and in fact quite enough. Before beginning to paint I rub over the part each time with Bell's medium and saliva nearly equal parts, or say five oil to four saliva beaten up with the knife on the palette to a white mucilage. This, if left alone, makes a good

varnish, and is delightful to paint into. So far, so good; at least I suppose so. (Do you see any elements of danger? cracking? darkening?) But at the end something must go over it all, if only to lock it up (I suppose), certainly to get uniform gloss and strength. I propose in the Academy to put Roberson's medium over the whole of my large one and to retouch with the same. A portrait on to which I *don't* intend to work I should cover with mastic and *a little poppy oil*; there is no harm in this, I suppose, and the small quantity of mastic is not likely to yellow, is it? I know this mixture *won't come off*, but why should it?

May 30, 1889.

Messrs. Reeves send me a colour in which I delight, but which I have hitherto always avoided as being unsafe, to wit, indigo. I suppose one ought not to use it, ought one? although my old friend, and in some ways my master, Robert Fleury, employed it extensively in *underpainting* blue draperies.

December 23, 1889.

I have got a recipe—a very simple one—from a friend of mine in Italy, who paints a good deal in distemper, and who in technical matters is quite the most leery person I ever came across. In this recipe he mentions what he calls "Gum Damar," which he, in his characteristic ignorance of spelling (for Italians are not very strong in orthography), writes with an apostrophe, D'Amar. Now I presume he means "Gum Dammar" (I believe there is such a thing, is there not?), but I should like to feel sure. Perhaps you will kindly enlighten me on a post-card.

The distemper itself is the simplest thing in the world. It is only a proportion of water and yolk of egg (he deprecates the use of vinegar), to which he adds a certain number of drops (I have not the recipe by me) of this gum. Of course it would be important not to use the wrong gum. Hence the trouble I am giving you.

January 27, 1890.

I have just received from Perugia the enclosed sample of Gum Dammar, which you were kind enough to say that you would report upon to me. A few drops of this (by-the-bye, I do not know how it is to be dissolved) and the yolk of an egg stirred in water, form the distemper used by my friend Mariani.

I don't know whether I told you that he is rather an interesting fellow. He is one of those extremely dexterous Italian workmen-artists who know and can work in every material, and whose forgeries of sixteenth century bric-à-brac, cassoni, reliefs in pastiglia, &c. &c., have, I am afraid, not infrequently been purchased as original by very crafty persons.

Several friends of mine who use distemper, and he amongst the number, tell me that by putting a preparatory coating of distemper over thoroughly dry oil, you can with perfect safety interpose a layer of *painting* in distemper between two paintings in oil—an extremely valuable thing for us *for recovering quality*.

January 31, 1890.

Many thanks for your valuable letter. I have had the information entered in a little book, where I keep the outpourings of your wisdom on matters chemical.

Thanks also for the card, in which you give me a somewhat long name for my Gomme Dammar. I suppose in an appeal to a chemist the *first* portion would suffice.

February 14, 1890.

Many thanks for your valuable note. I may say in passing that the specimen of "Ruby Madder" sent by Mr. Laurie appears to me to be inferior in brilliancy to both the Rose Madder and the Madder Carmine furnished by Messrs. Roberson; and I have no reason to doubt that the latter colours are perfectly trustworthy.

It will give me great pleasure to receive the dedication of your book, which I look forward to seeing with pleasure, and using with profit.

May 19, 1890.

Many thanks for your note, which seems to open up an interesting point. I gather from what you say that the mode of *manufacture* of a colour may affect its drying properties over a range extending from drying very slowly to drying very rapidly; and I shall be much interested in hearing what your experiments lead to under this head.

January 30, 1891.

Many thanks for your letter. I see that I had better wait for a final opinion until the few months have expired which you still require as tests of permanence. Meanwhile, I am a little unhappy to see in the case of colour after colour the expression "semi-permanent." I do not quite know what that means. Let me know *at your leisure* whether it means permanent under certain conditions, and, if so, what; or merely in a general way that the pigment stands, but only pretty well. The Rosso Saturno I quite understand is to be set aside.

Another perplexity is in regard to the Burnt Madder. If the madders are in themselves sound colours, as I have always understood them to be, how do they lose their permanence by burning? I should like to use the Gialletto, and I rather gather from what you say that I may do so. I hear with interest what you tell me of your new varnish. As for myself, I have got to dislike the use of any resins in my work to such an extent that I have completely set them aside. Of course when a picture is finished it requires some gum, not only to protect it, but to bring up the colour to its full value. Will you let me know—but this will do at your leisure, for the time has not come yet—whether a picture being painted as I paint mine, exclusively with Bell's medium and turpentine from first to last, and, I may add, worked on up to the last moment of sending in, *i.e.* a fortnight later, may on the walls of the Academy be safely

varnished with this new material of yours, either alone or diluted with a little poppy oil? I look forward with interest to Heyl's Madder Green.

December 5, 1891.

I shall certainly try the Heyl's Madder Green, which I hear of through you for the first time. Laurie's daffodil cadmium is very pretty. I have got some; but my new delight now is yellow cobalt, which you have found to be absolutely safe, and which is absolutely delightful as a colour.

My tempera is come from Italy, and I am told that it is made of the tails (feelers?) of the cuttle-fish (sepia). Would you like to look at it again from curiosity? I understand that with the reservation that it darkens, I may use it with impunity in, under, and with the oil—that is enough for *my* purpose.

October 16, 1894.

Will you kindly advise me on the tempera, of which I send a tube? It is used by my friend, Prof. Costa, who gave it me; he likes it vastly. It coalesces *with oil*; he uses it also by itself *between* two paintings in oil. I have often longed for something to keep down the *greasiness* and *slipperiness* of oil paint when correcting or going over a surface often, oil and water *do* coalesce sufficiently. The most luminous thing I ever painted (and it has stood like a rock) was painted (or certainly *thickly underpainted*) with a vehicle made of *starch and oil*. What *this* medium is, I don't know. Please advise.

March 7, 1894.

Forgive secretary again.

I am much obliged by your note, and read with great satisfaction what you say about Newman's golden ochre. I shall now, until I hear

from you further, adopt the motto "Ex uno disce omnes," and assume that the *yellow* ochre is equally sound and serviceable; although the colour is so much finer than any yellow ochre of my acquaintance that I cannot quite close my mind to a lurking suspicion that it is stimulated or refreshed by some foreign ingredient.

March 13, 1894.

Many thanks. You send me good tidings. The yellow ochre is by far the finest I have ever seen.

I enclose, because we think (Watts and I) that it will interest you, a specimen of purple *lake* (*not madder*), such as Watts has used *all his life*, which has been baking in the sun for *two* years; it is slightly browner, but more beautiful than ever, and has, you see, retained its full *body*; this is remarkable.

June 22, 1894.

Very many thanks for your interesting and exhaustive investigations on the French lakes. I observe that in several cases you mention lakes having *cracked*. I presume, however, there is no reason to suppose they would do this when embodied with other colours, and that *if* otherwise safe they might therefore be used. The purple lake used by our friend Watts is furnished to him, I have always understood, by Messrs. Newton of Rathbone Place. I am glad to hear so good an account of the pale boiled linseed oil from May & Baker, Ltd., of Battersea. I do not, however, gather from what you say that there can be any reason for substituting it for Bell's medium, to which I am much attached, and which, as you know, is, with the admixture of one-third rectified essence of turpentine, the only vehicle I use. This note, of course, requires no acknowledgment—anything you may have to say on these various

points will abundantly keep until I get a further account of your investigations on the purple lake.

Many thanks for your valuable caution. Amongst the lakes you tried, did you include the garance *nuance brun* and do. *brun foncé*? Both are superb colours, and it would be nice to think one might use them. It is very comfortable to feel that one has a *conscience* one can tune at Shelsley.

April 19, 1894.

I am about now to take up a large decorative painting for the Exchange, a work which cannot be done on the spot on account, *inter alia*, of the darkness of the place, and will, therefore, be carried out here at the studio on *canvas*, and then "marouflé" on the wall. Macbeth (A.R.A.), who is also doing one, is using *Parris's* "Marble medium," in which, a thousand years ago, I painted two figures for mosaic at South Kensington; great brilliancy is obtainable, but I rather fear a certain tendency to look waxy and almost shiny. I myself incline to use Gambier *Parry's* material, which I have used on the *wall* at South Kensington and greatly like. But now the question arises, ought the canvas to be *prepared*? and on this I shall be grateful for your opinion, as the matter is very important. G. Parry told me that canvas either *could* or *should* be prepared for his medium, I don't remember which. Roberson's man tells me that Madox Brown and Fredk. Shields (I think) both had canvases prepared for a similar purpose. I shall postpone ordering mine till I have your instructions; till when, and always, I am, in much haste.

April 23, 1894.

Many thanks for your letter. I shall, of course, obey your instructions punctually, and substitute paraffin wax for the ordinary Brecknell and Turner beeswax, as prescribed by Parry himself. I

will see Roberson immediately, for I should not think it right, as he ground the colours and prepared the medium throughout for my two large frescoes at South Kensington, to abandon him in favour of Laurie, or anybody else.

You suggest that I should make a little experiment on a small canvas. Do you think that would be necessary? I presume that the material will work exactly as it did before, and that the surface will be—bar the granulation—very much the same as on a wall. I ask this question, because I ought to get to work immediately, and I gather from a reference to your work that it will take several weeks before the process of preparation is complete.

I wish I could throw light for you on the verb "maroufler," and should like to know what subterranean connection there is, or can be, between it and the word "maroufle" which is, as you say, being interpreted, a "rascal."

At all events, when the moment comes for the operation, I must endeavour to obtain information from France, where the process is in very frequent use.

February 27, 1895.

A contretemps has occurred of which I think I ought to inform you, as it relates to the very interesting subject of grounds and pigments.

Robersons, when they came to roll up my fresco to transport it to the Exchange, found that either the ground or the pigment—probably both, as they are of the same substance—was extremely brittle and cracked right across, cracking at a rather abrupt tangent from the circumference of the circle; so that they immediately struck work, and declined to go any further.

As far as the painting itself is concerned, I do not believe that any serious damage is done, because on re-straining it flat, the cracks are barely perceptible, and probably would not be at all perceptible *in situ*.

Meanwhile, if any question arises as to the ground, it has occurred to me, and it is on this point I wish to consult you, that the cause may be the substitution of paraffin wax for the ordinary wax hitherto used in Gambier Parry's material, which, though perhaps not absolutely so durable as paraffin, is sufficiently so, and very malleable. One does not see what else could have cracked in that abrupt and sharp manner—certainly not the copal, which has oil in it and is further made supple by the oil of spike. If it turned out that the paraffin was the peccant element, I should be, *entre nous*, rather glad, because it diminished the facility of the work.

With reference to the cracking of this work Professor Church writes:—

This unrolling was begun in very cold weather; if the temperature had been a little higher, nothing of this kind would have taken place. The picture now shows no sign of defect or injury, and is in perfect condition. By substituting *ceresin*, a paraffin obtained from ozokerite or earthwax, for crystalline paraffin, the chance of cracking is obviated. The ceresin, which should have a melting-point of 150° or 160° Fahrenheit, constitutes a safe substitute for the beeswax commonly employed in Gambier Parry's Spirit Fresco Medium.

FOGGIA, *October 15, 1895.*

You will be surprised to get a letter from me with an Italian superscription; I am writing thus early before my return to save time. When I was in Venice the other day, Van Haanen spoke to me, *with approval*, of a certain vehicle, of which I had already heard before vaguely, the invention of the French painter, Vibert. You probably know of it, as the subject of media has occupied you. There are, it appears, three forms of this medium: the vehicle for painting, the medium for painting *into* in retouching, and the final *varnish*. As far as I understood Van Haanen in a hurried conversation—he was a little vague—the painting medium contains

no gum, only, he seemed to think, petroleum and oil; I assume that in the final "verniss" there *is* gum of some kind.

I am perfectly satisfied with Bell's medium and fresh turpentine for the very little use I make of vehicle in painting; but there is always the difficulty of the *final* varnish in the Academy. I don't like risking mastic or copal *so soon* on work which contains *nothing* but oil (and if I ever do use a little, I put poppy oil with it), and the result is that I generally varnish with Roberson's medium, which is safe, but I fear a little inclined to *yellow* in time.

Now what I want you kindly to tell me, my dear Church, is the exact composition of the *three* Vibert media, and your opinion about the safety of using *all three* in the prescribed order; and this I should like to know on my return at the *beginning* of November (hence my haste in writing), and also whether I can safely use these vehicles on work *begun in my usual medium*.

It is just possible you may not have heard of the Vibert vehicles; if so, I would ask you to be so kind as to obtain (of course at *my* expense) a bottle of each of the mixtures and to test them carefully.

A line to say this has reached you would find me at the Hôtel Royal Mazzeri, Via 20 Settembre, *Rome*.

With kind regards and anticipated thanks.

HÔTEL ROYAL MAZZERI, ROME,
October 22, 1895.

Many thanks for your prompt and amiable answer. I shall be interested to hear on my return the upshot of your analysis; but I *hate vernis* in painting, as Bocchini tells us the Venetians did, *comme la peste*.

I am very glad you are getting on so satisfactorily with your work on the frescoes.

In haste (for I have many letters before me).

P.S.—No; I am sorry to say I am no better of my special ailment though my *general* condition is good.

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
November 8, 1895.

Excuse the hand of my secretary.

Many thanks for your note about Vibert's varnishes, which I shall accordingly dismiss from my mind—the varnishes, I mean, not your note.

One chapter in which is revealed Leighton's serious inner life closed during the years he was President. The last letter which has been preserved from his beloved master, Steinle, is dated 22nd November 1883, Frankfurt:

DEAR FRIEND,—Yesterday evening I received your letter from Florence, and answer at once, partly to tell you how delighted I am at the result of the consultation with Quarfe, as also at your comfort and well-being, and partly because this part of your letter has greatly roused my curiosity for a second, which shall also tell me something about Vienna, Verona, and Florence. At the same time, however, I want to make use of a pause in my work to tell you that the first three coloured contours are completed. To the painting I dedicated all my small skill, and would have died in order to secure that the drawing and composition should produce a life-like effect; I believe also that these pictures will look like frescoes in their surroundings.

Some time after this Leighton wrote to Mrs. Pattison the following letter, which proves that to the end he retained his great affection for Eduard von Steinle. This friend and master died in 1886, but whether Leighton made this inquiry before or after that date I do not know, as his letter is not dated:

DEAR MRS. PATTISON,—I saw a paragraph not long ago in the *Academy* which concerned me deeply; it did not *say*, but it implied that my dear old friend and master, Ed. Steinle (professor at Frankfurt a/M) is dead. Did you by chance write the note? and do you know when or how he died, if he be indeed dead? His wife has not written to me. I am anxious to have some certainty in the matter.

(Influenced) "—for good far beyond all others by Steinle, a noble-minded, single-hearted artist, *s'il en fut* ... Steinle's is the indelible seal." In making any estimate of Leighton's character these words should ever be remembered. They prove how deeply rooted were those feelings on which his principles were grafted. These words were no mere outlet for youthful enthusiasm and affection, but were noted with reference to an account of his life about to be written for publication; therefore we may consider them to be a deliberate statement made for a purpose, when he had reached the zenith of his fame and was already President of the Academy. The design by Steinle here produced, called *Der Winter*, in which the artist has drawn his own portrait when old, throws a light on the mind and nature of Leighton's master, whose influence on him for good was greater "far beyond all others."

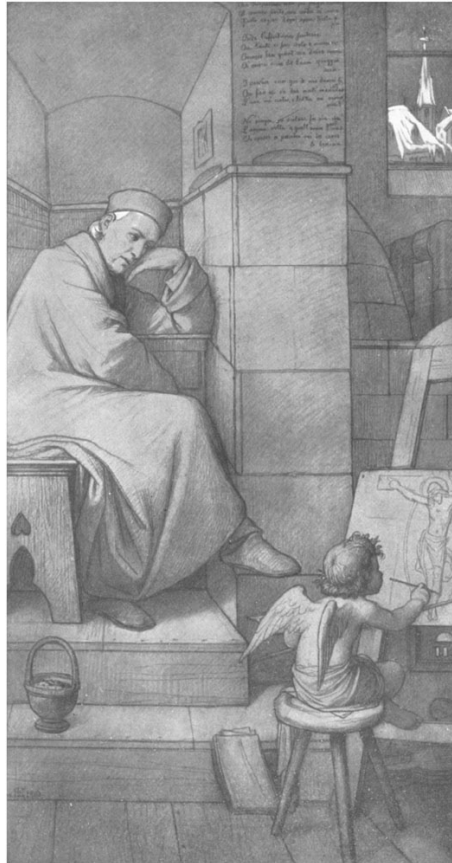
Written on the drawing are these lines, penned by Steinle:—

Giunto è già 'l corso della vita mia,
Che tempestoso mar per fragil barca
Al comun porto ov 'a render si varca
Giunto ragion d'ogni opera trista e pia.
Indi l'affettuosa fantasia
Che l'arte si fece idola e monarca
Conosco ben quant 'era d'error carica
Ch' errore è ciò che l'uom quaggiù desia.

.
I pensier miei già de' miei danni lieti
Che fian se s'a due morti m'avvicino
L'una m' è certa, l'altra mi minaccia?

.
Ne pinger ne scolpir fin più che queti

L'anima volta a quell' amor divino
Ch'aperse a prender noi in croce le braccia.



"DER WINTER"

Drawing by Eduard von Steinle [ToList](#)

No other member of Leighton's family was ever known to have been an artist, and neither his parents nor his sisters pretended to any knowledge of painting; but respecting literature he had an interest in common with both his sisters, also a very strong sympathy existed between Mrs. Matthews and Leighton in their love for music. In answer to a letter from Mrs. Orr relating to Mr. Augustine Birrell's well-known book, Leighton wrote, "I have read 'Obiter Dicta,' and am much charmed with its delicate humour and ease of its style. I thought 'Truth Seekers' charmingly written." With reference, however, to the Browning chapter he continues:—

Browning's obscurity hides a shorthand of which he keeps the key in *his* pocket. A matter of form, *not* of matter, as "O.D." hath it. Browning is not abstruse; he is a *deep* thinker, who *therefore* (*vide* "O.D.") requires obscure language; he is a most ingenious dialectician and a subtle analyst; but he is not a great poet on *that* account—he is a great poet because of his magnificent central heat, and the surface of interests over which he sheds it. All this is rather late in the day to remark, and one would not be exasperated by his friends if one had not a sort of feeling that they *have* done something to mar him. You say he would not be obscure if he *knew* it?—*distinguons*. His obscurity is not intentional—of course—it is inherent in a style which is strongly personal, and therefore sincere—but is it in no degree *wilful*?—does he *not* accept, virtually, some such (absolutely false) view of his obscurity as "O.D.'s"? A pity it certainly is; Browning is the last man who in his heart *wishes* to touch only the few—nobody knows better than he does that that is not the characteristic of the greatest poets, and that not for that is a poet's soul kindled to a white heat. Meanwhile, here *is* the fact that men of average culture and average brains (I claim both, for an example), and *desirous* of *understanding*, as well as full of admiration for his powers, often get at his meaning only by considerable effort, and sometimes not at all, and that not because the thought is obscure, but because it is wilfully written in cypher.

The following letter to a friend of his sister's contains a criticism of Leighton's on Goethe's *Sprüche* under the head of "Kunst":—

Private.]

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
17/8/91.

DEAR MR. BAILEY SAUNDERS,—Complying with your wish, expressed through my sister, Mrs. Orr, I have gone carefully through the *Sprüche* under the head "Kunst," and have marked certain passages. I have, however, deferred writing till the last moment (I am starting presently for the Continent), partly because I have been

overwhelmingly busy, and partly because I am a good deal "exercised" on the whole matter. To speak with entire frankness, I cannot feel sympathy with the idea of the publication, and feel that the connection of my name with it would imply an adhesion which does not exist. On re-reading more than once the maxims and sayings in question, which I had not seen for many years, I find myself confirmed in my earlier impression of them, that their value is in no way commensurate to the authority of Goethe's great name. Some of them are, in my opinion, wholly misleading and some obscure; some commonplace, some irrelevant to the subject. Again, my markings do not by any means always mean assent; and, on the other hand, the discrimination between the value of a marked paragraph is often a nice one, and is not represented by the difference between selection and omission, which, *on the face of it*, seems assent and dissent. In sum, I ask myself what the outcome is—what *is* the selection? it does not give to the world an important or instructive intellectual possession; it *seems* to express the selection of the best by a particular individual (who does not spontaneously desire to make such selections), and in *reality* does *not* represent anything that he assents to throughout.

But why a selection at all? I cannot refrain from asking myself. The interest of these particular *Sprüche* lies in the fact that *they are utterances of Goethe's* (and he gave them with a context)—but then what is the meaning of a selection?

You see I speak very bluntly in the matter, but also sincerely; and I have at all events shown my good will.—In much haste, yours faithfully,

FRED LEIGHTON.

I am, as I said, just off, but if you wished especially to communicate with me, a line sent *here* would reach me after some delay.

Though Leighton persisted in affirming that he hardly ever read, the number of letters, and answers to letters from scholars, referring to poems and general literature, which exist in the correspondence he preserved,

prove that if he did not read he nevertheless somehow got a knowledge of the inside of books. To a question having reference to the Nine Muses (he was then painting his frieze "Music") which he asked Swinburne, he received the answer:—

THE PINES, PUTNEY HILL, S.W.,
August 21, 1885.

DEAR LEIGHTON,—I doubt very much whether Shelley himself could have answered your question to your satisfaction. His scholarship was that of a clever but idle boy in the upper forms of a public school. His translation from Plato, as Mr. Jowett tells me, and his translation from Euripides, as I know by personal experiment, having carefully collated it with the original text, absolutely swarm with blunders, sometimes, certainly, resulting in sheer nonsense. I fancy he may have been thinking of Aphrodite Urania, and perhaps confounding (as indeed it seems to me that a Greek poet might possibly and pardonably have done) the goddess of divine love with the Muse who was *not* the Muse of astronomy when she first made her appearance in the Theogony of Hesiod, but simply the "heavenly one" in a general way, as I gather from a reference to the lexicon. I should have thought Calliope or Euterpe a fitter head mourner for Keats: but probably Shelley wished to introduce the most distinguished in the rank of the Muses in that capacity, on such an occasion. And if Urania was in a certain sense the chief of the Nine, she would naturally be most musical of mourners.—Ever yours sincerely,

A.C. SWINBURNE.

As years went on, Leighton became more and more enamoured of the beauty to be found in our own islands, and longed, as can be traced in his letters, that his sisters should share with him his intense love of nature.

To his elder sister, who was in Yorkshire, he wrote in 1887:—

"A broad shoulder of moor, lifted against a great field of sky, is one of the grandest and most pathetic things in nature (see Leopardi). The beauty of moorland is that it has a particular poetry and impressiveness for *every* condition of atmosphere and weather."

Again:—

"I am very glad you like Ilkley so much—moors have an immense fascination for me, but all English scenery of whatever kind has charm for me. It has two immense virtues: first, being entirely of its own *kind*, it never suggests a, to itself, disparaging comparison with the scenery of any other country, and secondly, it is steeped, every fold and nook of it, in English poetry, and is haunted with the murmur of the prettiest of peace-suggesting words: *home*. I wonder whether you both feel as I do the endearing quality in our old green-brown country."

It became his habit, in these later years, to visit Scotland in September before flying off to his second home. More and more did he realise the marvellous beauty of the scenery there. He told me, shortly before he died, that the most beautiful vision he had ever beheld on earth was the one he saw when approaching Skye by sea from the south, when the sun was setting and illuminating the range of the Cuillin Hills with magic light and colour. He wrote to his father from:—

THE HIGHLAND RAILWAY COMPANY'S STATION HOTEL,
INVERNESS.

Accurately the *charmingness* of Scotland, it is the starting-point for everything. But I observe that at the rate of writing I should fill a volume before I had given you the hastiest account of my journey, so I will e'en cut it short and simply say that, taking it altogether, my too brief stay in the Highlands has been a source of very great enjoyment to me, if not of any particular benefit to my health, for which indeed it has been too short. I have had more than the usual proportion of fine weather, and am corroborated in my old opinion that for beauty of colouring nothing north of the Alps will compare with this most lovely country, and that the wealth and variety of effects of light and shade is altogether unrivalled. Unfortunately, working here is very difficult, all the effects are so bafflingly fugitive; nevertheless, I have made three little sketches which, though hasty, will be of value if only to revive my recollections of the effects they very feebly render; they were all done in one day;

and no one day since I did them has been such as to make sketching possible—except this the last and one of the most enchanting, which I have spent delightfully but fruitlessly on the top of a coach.

From Gressoney, St. Jean, September 1, 1891, he wrote to Mrs. Matthews:—

Many thanks for your letter received last night; as it crossed one from me to the Dad, which I hope he could read (it was writ large), I should not write again at once (having, of course, nothing to say—except that it is, *pour changer*, a splendid afternoon, and I ought to be out of doors) but that I want you at once to tell the poor old Dad how concerned and sorry I am to hear that he has been so ailing, and ailing so long, and how I wonder at his superb power of recuperation. I don't ask in *this* letter how the Dad is, because I am sure he will send me a line in answer to my note to him. But I have another reason for writing at once; I want you, please, to thank Lina with best love, for her nice long letter (*she does not want a letter written from here*), and tell her, before it is too late, that I hope she won't give up her Ballater without *a very full trial*, because I know that it takes many people a considerable time to get acclimatised to that bracing air. Tell her also that I was myself going to suggest an *Ausflug* to Braemar; if she goes to the Invercauld Arms let her use my name, and she will be well treated. I should *peculiarly* like her to see the Lynn of Dee—she will only have to scramble five or six yards off the main road to look down into the stream from under some of the grandest old Scotch firs in Scotland; and I verily believe that the watching for a silent bit of those dark, dark, seemingly bottomless, noiselessly swirling pools, *tiny* as they are under the hollow grey craig, will, somehow, whisper a big peace and a strange wondering fascination into her being; the whole thing is not bigger than an expensive toy, but it lays a never-failing grip on *me*.^[82]—
Affectionate brother,

FRED.

To Mrs. Orr when in Scotland:—

August 22, 1891.

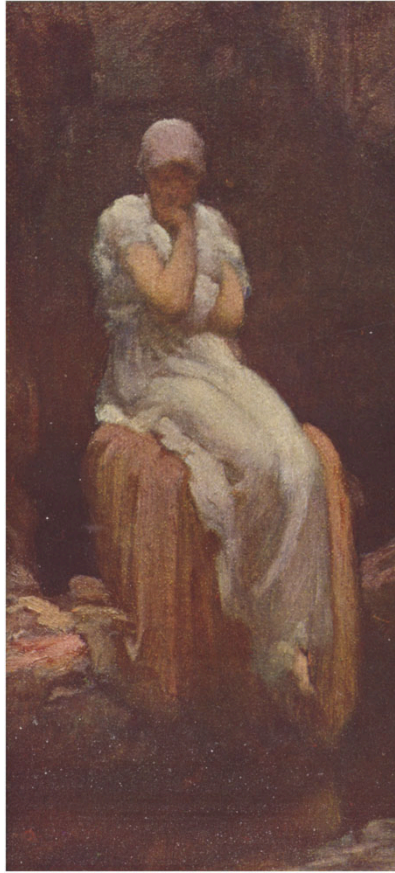
If you can manage it go to a favourite haunt of mine, the Lynn of Dee, quite a tiny tumble of green waters in fantastically scooped grey rocks, no higher than a cottage, under astounding old Scotch firs (by-the-bye the grandest tree in the world to my thinking), where I have sat interminably long looking down into the dark deep pools, from which now and then a salmon leaps. To me no spot about there is so fascinating.

GRAND HOTEL, BRUFANI, PERUGIA,
October 3, 1891.

DEAR LINA,—Well, I am glad you got to the Lynn of Dee, though sorry that you could not be there in solitude and see it without sitting in a pool of water. I am glad, too, that you saw the salmon leap; I did not mention that most exciting spectacle because it is not by any means *always* on view—you were in luck; but what you must make for another time is the bit three or four yards *below* the fall where the vehemence of the winter torrent has scooped and worn pools so deep that as your eye is drawn down past half-hidden submerged rocky shapes you come at last to absolute dark brown night, and whilst you are conscious of a rapid, swirling current, no *sound*, no faintest gurgle even, reaches your ear; the silent mystery of it all absolutely invades and possesses you; that is what I faintly tried to put into my "Solitude," of which a photogravure embellishes your staircase. I am vexed that you had so much rain; however, you had a few fine glimpses, and if a rainy day in Scotland is like the Scotch Sawbath, a fine one throws you the gates of Heaven. It is curious how much clearer the air is (*when clear*) than we get it south of the Tweed.

I am glad that the Dad has rallied so satisfactorily; tell him, with my love, that I have heard from the gentleman in Copenhagen for whom I carved the marble "Athlete." He is benighted enough to say that in his opinion it is one of the most important statues of modern

times; and he wants my bust, if there is one, for his collection of portraits.



STUDY IN COLOUR FOR "SOLITUDE." 1890

By permission of Mrs. Stewart Hodgson [ToList](#)

Leighton also particularly desired that his sister should see Malinmore, County Donegal, when visiting Ireland. He wrote from Kensington, "I am bent on your seeing Malinmore."

And again, from Scotland:—

INVERNESS, *September 13.*

DEAR LINA,—I can't help feeling a good deal of responsibility about the melancholy, treeless wilds to which I have sent you, because I happen to like them vastly; and I particularly feel that

everything will turn on your seeing, not indeed all or nearly all *I* saw—that is impossible—but as much as your strength will allow; take your courage, therefore, in one hand, your goloshes in another, and your umbrella in a third, and *from* the car—*abseits*—see the *whole coast-line* close to the rocks overlooking the sea; there is not an inch that won't reward you. There is a bit not more than half a mile from Malinmore (*to'ards* Malinhead), that is, though *small*, quite Dantesque in its grim blackness (a few wet feet *im Nothfall* won't hurt you). Of course, to do this well you must be in cars *every* day to take you in all directions to the point *from* which to make your *Abstecher*—sometimes towards Glencolumskill and the Hog's Back beyond (magnificent), sometimes towards Malinhead, where you must see every little bay, including the Silver Strand.

At first sight the breaking up of the weather is a bore, *mit Seitenblick auf Ihnen*—but is not as bad as it seems; bad (dirty) weather suits these parts, and the day will not dawn in which I shall have forgotten certain dramatic sunsets and the swooping of certain storm-clouds like the flight of huge fiery birds of prey, more than once witnessed and deposed to on canvas by me, over this treeless tract of moor.

FOOTNOTES:

[58] "Athlete Strangling a Python," exhibited in the International Exhibition, Paris, 1878.

[59] "The Arts of War."

[60] "Addresses delivered to the Students of the Royal Academy by the late Lord Leighton." Publishers: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trübner & Co. 1897.

[61] "Not everybody," wrote the late Mr. Underhill, who for some time, as private secretary to Sir Frederic Leighton, had special opportunities of knowing, "is aware of the tax upon a man's time and energy that is involved in the acceptance of the office in question. The post is a peculiar one, and requires a combination of talents not frequently to be found, inasmuch as it demands an

established standing as a painter, together with great urbanity and considerable social position. The inroads which the occupancy of the office makes upon an artist's time are very considerable. There is, on the average, at least one Council meeting for every three weeks throughout the whole year. There are, from time to time, general assemblies for the election of new members and for other purposes, over which the President is bound, of course, to preside. For ten days or a fortnight in every April he has to be in attendance with the Council daily at Burlington House, for the purpose of selecting the pictures which are to be hung in the Spring Exhibition. He has to preside over the banquet which yearly precedes the opening of the Academy, and he has to act as host at the annual *conversazione*. Finally, it is his duty every other year to deliver a long, elaborate, and carefully prepared 'Discourse' upon matters connected with art, to the students who are for that purpose assembled. It is a post of much honour and small profit." "To administer the affairs of the Academy, to fulfil a round of social semi-public and public engagements, and to paint pictures which invariably reach a high level of excellence, would, of course, be impossible—even to Sir Frederic Leighton—were it not for the fact that he makes the very most of the time at his disposal. 'That's the secret,' remarked a distinguished member of the Academy to the present writer some little time before the President's death; 'Sir Frederic knows exactly how long it will take to do a certain thing, and he apportions his time accordingly.'"—"Frederic, Lord Leighton, P.R.A.: His Life and Works." By Ernest Rhys.

[62] While writing this discourse Leighton wrote to his father:—

PERUGIA, *October 5, 1889.*

DEAR DAD,—You will be surprised to hear that your letter (for which best thanks) only came to my hands *yesterday* on my arrival here; it had apparently, after enjoying a junket through Spain, returned to England before its final despatch here. The envelope, which I enclose, will amuse you; Ulysses himself did not visit more cities of men! I am glad my Spanish tour is at an end; the insufferable heat, the long journeys, the frequent *night* travelling, have conspired to make it rather trying to me physically. I have never been thoroughly well the whole time. Here it is absolutely cold, and I shall probably soon begin firing; it rains also, and I fear the weather is altogether unpromising; but the air is magnificent, and I am very fond of the place, and I shall enjoy my stay as much as the necessity of writing my (adjective) Address will allow.

My journey through Spain, though fatiguing, was extremely interesting and very profitable to me for the matter in hand. My stay in Madrid was made more enjoyable by the extreme amiability of my very old friend our ambassador, who brought me into contact with two or three interesting people, from whom I gathered valuable information in regard to things Spanish; to say nothing of getting compartments reserved for me in trains, &c. &c. It is rather fortunate that our diplomatic representatives abroad are mostly personal friends of mine. Post is just going, so good-bye for the present.—Your affectionate son,

FRED.

Leighton mastered the Spanish language completely in the course of the few weeks he spent in Spain in 1866. A friend who was present gives an amusing account of an incident which occurred when Leighton dined with Mrs. Adelaide Sartoris after his return. He was sitting next Señor Garcia (only now just dead at the age of 102); the conversation was being carried on in Spanish. Mrs. Sartoris, in astonishment and admiration at the fluent manner in which Leighton was talking the language of which he did not know a word a few weeks before, exclaimed, "But, Señor Garcia, *do* say he makes some little mistakes!" "But he *doesn't*," replied Garcia; "he hasn't made one!"

[63] Mr. Norman Shaw wrote the following letter the day after he heard this address in 1891:—

6 ELLERDALE ROAD, HAMPSTEAD, N.W.,
December 11, 1891.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—I was so sorry I missed you last night. After the election I went into the galleries to find my people, and when I came out you had gone—and quite right too, for you must have been very tired.

I thank you very sincerely for your most admirable address. I had heard that it was to be on the subject of French Art, but I had not realised that it was to be entirely about Architecture! and as an architect I naturally feel very deeply its great and permanent value. It is altogether a new sensation to have a Presidential address devoted to the Mother of the Arts! and I am sure its influence will be wide, deep, and lasting.

Amongst the many regrettable phases of modern art, there is none that I feel more than the isolation that the three great branches of art exist under in this country (for in France I am sure it is quite different), and I cannot help feeling that your address is a tremendous step in the right direction; but, alas! I don't believe one in twenty of our colleagues understood what you were so clearly explaining, and I fear not one in fifty cared! But it is absurd to suppose that with the advancement of knowledge this state of things can last, so it is intensely satisfactory to have it on record that not merely have we had a President that knew all that is to be known about the art, but who also cared and loved it!

I thought your remarks on the French apse quite delightful. I have always felt this strongly, and though as an Englishman (Scotchman!) I like our square east ends, still I am bound to admit that there is a logical completeness about a chevet that the square end cannot claim. But I shall only weary you if I go on in this prosy way! so thanking you again most heartily for your grand contribution, believe me to remain,—Yours very sincerely,

R. NORMAN SHAW.

SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON, BART.

[64] From a boy, without any effort or thought on his part, he exercised an unquestioned domination over others. Speaking of the days when he, as a boy of seventeen, first made friends with Leighton in Rome, Sir E. Poynter said, "He knew he was clever, but he hadn't a particle of conceit. I never saw him cast

down, he was always jolly and noble; none ever thought of refusing him obedience." Again, Sir E. Poynter refers to these early days in his Dedication to Leighton of "Ten Lectures on Art": "I came to-day from the 'Varnishing Day' at the Royal Academy Exhibition with a pleasant conviction that there is, on all sides, a more decided tendency towards a higher standard in Art, both as regards treatment of subject and execution, than I have before noticed; and I have no hesitation in attributing this sudden improvement, in the main, to the stimulus given us all by the election of our new President, and to the influence of the energy, thoroughness, and nobility of aim which he displays in everything he undertakes. I was probably the first, when we were both young, and in Rome together, to whom he had the opportunity of showing the disinterested kindness which he has invariably extended to beginners; and to him, as the friend and master who first directed my ambition, and whose precepts I never fail to recall when at work (as many another will recall them), I venture to dedicate this book with affection and respect." Signor Giovanni Costa wrote: "I remember once in Siena there was an unemployed half-hour in our programme. Leighton happening to go to the window of the hotel, exclaimed, 'The Cupola of the Duomo is on fire!' and as he said it he rushed downstairs to go there. I, being lame, could not keep pace with him, but followed, and on arriving in the Piazza attempted to enter the Duomo past a line of soldiers who were keeping the ground; but they would not allow me to. Seeing them carrying wooden hoardings into the cathedral, I shouted. 'You are taking fuel to the fire! Let me in—I am an artist and a custodian of artistic treasures.' The word 'custodian' moved them, and they let me pass. When I got inside the Duomo I found Leighton commanding in the midst. He was saying, 'You are bringing fuel to the fire.' There was a major of infantry with his company, who cried out, 'Open the windows!' Leighton exclaimed, 'My dear sir, you are fanning the flames; you must shut the windows.' He had placed himself at the head of everybody, and the windows were shut. From the cupola into the church fell melting flakes of fire ('cadean di fuoco dilatate falde'—*Dante*) from the burning and liquefied lead, which would certainly have ignited the boards with which they had intended to cover the *graffitte* by Beccafumi on the marble pavement. Our half-hour was over. Leighton looked at his watch and said, 'In any case the cupola is burnt; let us be off to the Opera del Duomo; Duccio Buoninsegna is waiting for us!'"

[65] Sir George Grove wrote after the banquet in 1882: "Dear Leighton,—Let me say a word of most hearty congratulations on the brilliant way in which you got through your *Herculean* task on Saturday. You are really a prodigy! Your last speech reads just as fresh and gay and unembarrassed as the first, and every one of the nine is as neat, as pointed, as perfectly *à propos* as if there were nothing else to be said! Thank you especially for the reference to the music business."

[66] The following is one of many letters of regret expressed when Leighton resigned:—

19 QUEEN STREET, MAYFAIR, W.,
June 24.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—I trust you will allow me to express to you the sincere regret I feel at your being compelled to give up your command of the "Artists." To myself volunteering has always been so inseparably connected with your command, that I cannot at present realise the extent

of the blank which your resignation will create. I shall ever remember with pride that it was under your auspices that I rose through the ranks and obtained my commission.—Believe me, dear Sir Frederic, very truly yours,

W. PASTEUR.

SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON, P.R.A.

[67] The following correspondence took place between Leighton and Mr. Henry Wells, R.A.

To Sir FREDERIC LEIGHTON, P.R.A.

January 27, (?) 1880.

I will avail myself of this opportunity to remark upon the statement you made in your summing up, viz. that if women were made members under the existing law they would not have the right to sit on Council.

If you can establish this, if you can show us that any one elected a "member" under our law can be debarred on the score of sex from taking a seat on the Council, then I will instantly allow that our laws do provide for the election of women, and that the very ground of our argument is proved to be a quicksand. When you endorsed the statement that came so naturally from Millais, Calderon, and Leslie, I felt the matter was serious, for I saw at once that you could not do justice to our argument in the summing up because its very foundation was misapprehended by you. Although the question is now disposed of, I beg of you to look closely into the matter and assure yourself of it. I only wish I had known beforehand where your doubts were centered, for I would have done my best to remove them. I know you will find, beyond all doubt and controversy, that any one made a "member" by election can make good a claim to a seat on the Council, just as Mr. Tresham made good his claim; and it is because our laws provide for only one kind of members—a Council-sitting kind—that we felt the necessity of providing for the election of a non-Council-sitting kind.

In making this distinction we follow the example of George the Third and the founders of the Academy (who presumably knew something of the understanding upon which the two ladies became connected with the Society), for their decision, when they *administered* the law in the Tresham case, excluded women from a privilege which could not be denied to a "member" elected under the law. Of course their and our interpretation is open to dispute; but this much is beyond dispute, that if the law is interpreted as providing for women being "members," then it also places them (against the intention, as we see, of the founders) upon the Council; and as the great majority of the present Academicians have made up their minds that women shall not sit on Council, legislation would be necessary on either reading of the law.

The schedule of privileges to be given on the one hypothesis, would on the other give place to a subtraction of privileges, and either schedule

would be determined according to the varying shades of opinions of the members.

There would remain only this difference in the result; one schedule would be based upon a law that is open to varying interpretations, whereas according to our method the schedule was based upon a positive resolution providing for the election of women, thus removing the question from all future discussion and doubt.

H.T.W.

From Sir FREDERIC LEIGHTON, P.R.A.

January 30, 1880.

"In regard to the women question, I perfectly saw your contention and the logical cohesion of your view, and I was familiar with the Tresham episode, only I dissent from your view; I maintain that there were from the first non-Council-sitting members—for 'members' the women certainly were. 'It is the King's pleasure that the following forty persons be the original *members* of the Society,' and they did not serve on Council, as the roster shows, *though all members* were supposed to have sat; of course the laws were for the original as well as the elected members, and if the privilege could be refused to an original member whose name stands on the paper that says that all members shall serve in Council, it can and must on the same grounds be refused to elected female members after the custom is consecrated by Royal sanction."

January 31, 1880.

"DEAR WELLS,—I should much like to hear what you wish to say about the office of Treasurer—there are several points connected directly or indirectly with the office which it will be well to consider before I ask the Queen to appoint, and I have called a Council for *Thursday* (the funeral is not till Tuesday), at which these matters may be considered. It would seem advisable and convenient that the Treasurer's work be done at the Academy, and not away from it. I think also that the wording of the clause appointing a Surveyor might be made clearer; it ought not to be *possible* for any one to misunderstand or misinterpret its bearing. Unfortunately I have an appointment to-morrow afternoon at 4.30, and my work in the day is so urgent, having to be handed over on a fixed day, that I cannot leave it—would *Tuesday* at *five* do? say at the Athenæum, or here a little later? we should still be forty-eight hours in advance of the Council. In regard to the women question, I perfectly saw your contention and the logical cohesion of your view, and I was familiar with the Tresham episode, only I dissent from your view; I maintain that there were from the first 'non-Council-sitting' members—for 'members' the women certainly were: 'It is Her Majesty's pleasure that the following forty persons be the original *members* of the Society,' and they did not serve on Council as the roster shows, though *all members* were supposed to have sat. Of course the laws were for the 'original' as well as for the 'elected' members, and if the privilege could be refused to an

original member whose name stands on the paper, that says that all members shall serve on Council, it can and must on the same grounds be refused to 'elected' female members after the custom is consecrated by Royal sanction.—In haste, yours very truly,

FRED LEIGHTON.

"I have said nothing in this letter about poor Barry, but you may imagine whether the tragic event has moved and haunts me."

To Sir FREDERIC LEIGHTON, P.R.A.

February 1, 1880.

I am very glad indeed to have the statement of your views which you have given me on the women question. Everything is now clear, side matters are disposed of, and only a single point remains on which we have to join issue. On my part I hold that our laws are in a definite and unequivocal form. That their foundation is in the "Instrument" and that every addition to, or modification, or annulment of the provisions in that document has been made in the manner prescribed, viz. by "resolutions" passed by the General Assembly and afterwards sanctioned by the Sovereign. These acts of legislation are all drawn up in a special way (as to size and pattern), to receive the sign manual of the Sovereign; and the tablets arranged in the order of their dates constitute our Statute-Book. I hold that no law can be changed or privilege taken away except by a subsequent act of legislation done in the prescribed manner.

On your part you hold that laws can be changed and privileges taken away by a "custom consecrated by Royal sanction." Thus the issue raised is very clear and distinct indeed.

I will point out that the question as to women sitting on Council was only on one occasion, and then only incidentally, before the Academy. Until the Tresham case arose the ballot had been used in forming the Council, and consequently no question of rights could appear while that process remained unchallenged. But whether we are discussing a single act of adjudication, or such a succession of acts as may be called a "custom," is really immaterial, because the sole question before us is this—can any act or acts other than those of legislation override and supplant the enactments of our law?

If it could be established that our laws must give way to the class of acts you point to, it would then be the first duty of the Academy to have our records minutely searched to ascertain what other laws have been supplanted by administrative actions sanctioned by the Sovereign; and the historical method so much discountenanced at our last Assembly would in truth rise into paramount importance. Many cases would most probably be found. We have one in suspense before us at this moment—the case of the engravers.

The laws of the Academy distinctly provide (but not more distinctly than that without discrimination "members" shall sit on Council) that a vacancy in the case of R.A. engravers shall not be filled up until the

assent of the General Assembly has been taken by vote. Since the making of that law only two vacancies have occurred. They were both filled up without a preliminary permission, and the Sovereign sanctioned the election. On your contention, therefore, the custom consecrated by these sanctions must override the law itself, and nothing at this time stands between Barlow and the Queen's signature to his Diploma.

The Constitutional question you have raised is certainly one of the highest importance, and I shall watch its development with great interest. It is a matter of little moment what the view of an ordinary member like myself may be, but not so with the President, and I offer no apology for endeavouring to throw light upon the subject.

H.T.W.

[68] See [Chapter III](#).

[69] Now in the Tate Gallery, purchased under the terms of the Chantrey Bequest.

[70] The owners of Leighton's pictures must feel satisfaction, not only in the fact that in all cases the beauty of the forms and arrangements of line grow on the eye more and more the longer they are studied, but also that the work itself improves by keeping. I noticed this to be the case very decidedly in "Cymon and Iphigenia." I had seen it when completed, the day before it left the studio in 1884; and when it returned there in 1901 (the owner, Sir Cuthbert Quilter, having kindly lent it for exhibition), and was placed in precisely the same light, I was surprised to see how much it had improved in tone during those seventeen years; it had gained so very greatly in those qualities which suggest the feeling Leighton wished it to inspire.

[71] Leighton kept these precious studies he made for his pictures in a drawer where I was often invited, rather apologetically, to turn them over as if they were absolutely of no importance. I protested against the cursory treatment they received at the hand of their creator; and on seeing one superlatively beautiful study of drapery pinned on his easel one day, I implored him to have it glazed and framed before it ran any danger of being rubbed. He did so, and always alluded to it after as "that sketch you lost for me," because, being framed, he lent it to some one—he did not remember to whom—and it never came back. Periodically I asked if it had returned; "No—some one, I suppose, has taken a fancy to it," Leighton would reply. The pace at which he had to live in order to fulfil the work he had set himself, enforced great carelessness about his own interests in such matters. Unfortunately, after Leighton's death, the sketches were exposed to much defacement, a natural consequence of their being moved before being secured under glass.

[72] Ceiling for a music room, painted for Mr. Marquand, New York.

[73] Mr. Brock gave a replica of this bust to the Leighton House Collection in 1897. It is from some points of view the most characteristic portrait of Leighton in existence.

[74] Miss Emily Hickey, the poetess, was inspired by Leighton's picture to write the following lines:—

SOLITUDE

O'er the grey rocks, like monarchs robed and
crowned,
High tower the firs in swart magnificence,
Where, winter after winter, vehemence
Of the wild torrent's rush, unstayed, unbound,
Hath scooped and worn the rocks till so
profound
The deep pool's depth that all the gazer's
sense
Fills with the absolute, dark-brown night
intense.
The rapid current swirls, but never a sound.

By the high grandeur of the silence wooed
Into its bond of comradeship, the maid
Sits with the quiet on her bosom laid;
Not on the great unknowable to brood;
Only to wait a while till, unafraid,
She see the spirit of the solitude.

E.H. HICKEY.

Oct. 26,

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[75] As portraits, the two heads Watts painted from "Dorothy Dene" were superior to those Leighton painted.

[76] This referred to a joke we had had with reference to a photograph Mrs. Cameron had taken of my brother-in-law, Mr. W.R. Greg. Mrs. Cameron had insisted that all character, will-force, and superiority in general, evinced themselves through the size of the nose and the height of the bridge. The result was, in trying to accentuate this feature in my brother-in-law's photograph, she had made it almost *all* nose!

[77] Among Leighton's correspondence is the following interesting letter from Irving, who was an ardent admirer of Leighton's, and was among the first to join the committee formed to preserve his house for the public.

15A GRAFTON STREET, BOND STREET, W.,
January 1, 1889.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—I am glad that you are coming to "Macbeth," and I wish you had been with us on Saturday.

The seats you wish for I enclose, though I should ever look upon it as a great privilege to welcome you myself.

Ellen Terry's performance is remarkable, and perfectly delightful after the soulless and insipid imitations of Sarah Siddons to which we have been accustomed.

You will find the cobwebs of half a century brushed away.

There is an amusing article in to-day's *Standard*, which overshoots the mark, and clearly shows how offensive it is to some minds to be earnest and conscientious in one's work. But I need not point this out to you.—Remaining, my dear Sir Frederic, yours sincerely,

H. IRVING.

[78] Needless to say that time was invariably forthcoming to welcome and entertain the friends he loved. The following letter from Costa gives a picture of his delight in so doing:—

"LONDON, *Dec. 10, 1888*,
"2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD.

"DEAREST TONINA,—A thousand thanks for the twelve letters which I have found awaiting me here.

"I have just arrived from the station, where I found the President, who was shedding light all round him, all radiant with his white beard. Note that the train arrived at a quarter past five, and there was an hour's drive from the station to his house, and then he had to dine, and at half-past seven he was due at the Academy for a distribution of prizes to the students, where I, too, was to have accompanied him. However, in London there was one of those fogs which put a stop to all traffic, and it took us an hour and three-quarters to reach home.

"The cabman had to get down and lead the horse; with one hand he guided the animal, which was slipping on the ice, and with the other he held a lantern. What darkness,—the gloom of hell itself! Boys holding torches and shouting, showed us the way; foot passengers called out, 'Hi there! look where you're going to!' but, in spite of everything, the cabman with his lantern banged into a railing.

"At last we arrived at our destination, having discussed all the way along the speech which Leighton made at Liverpool. The dinner was ready, and eaten hurriedly, with the obligatory champagne. I had eaten nothing since the morning. Whilst dining, I got off accompanying him to the Academy, pleading my rheumatic pains, and I ate like a famished and attentive dog. But the President, spite of the hurry he was in, never once ceased from tracing the iron line along which I am to run as long as I am with him, and so he has set me down for a trip on Saturday.

"Good-night; I am going to bed, as I am deadly sleepy. Did you receive a letter of mine from Castle Howard?

"Thank for me the kind writers of the twelve little letters; in the midst of these fogs they have been twelve stars to me. A kiss to dear Tonachino. Frederic was much amused by Georgia's letter, and embraces you all.

"Love to all, from Ninaccio, who has the greatest possible desire to repass the Channel."—(See "Giovanni Costa: His Life, Work, and Times," by Olivia Rossetti Agresti.)

[79] It may interest his friends to know that the valuable collection of casts which Mr. Copland Perry spent four years in forming, after visits to all the collections of ancient sculptures in Europe, has been ceded to the British Museum, and will be transferred from the South Kensington Museum, where it has long been hidden away in a dark corridor, to suitable courts in the new buildings of the British Museum.

[80] Professor Church's Lectures were given to the outer world beyond the Academy in the form of a book, published in 1891, and dedicated by permission to Leighton.

[81] The questions raised in these letters have been very fully answered in the third edition of Professor Church's "Chemistry of Paints and Painting" (see Index), published in 1901.

[82] This spot inspired the picture "Solitude."

CHAPTER VI [ToC](#)

LIFE WANING—DEATH

1887-1896

Already in 1887 his friends noticed that Leighton showed at times that he was overtaking his strength. On retiring from the Academy as an active member, Mr. George Richmond wrote:—

20 YORK STREET, PORTMAN SQUARE, W.,
January 13, 1887.

MY DEAR SIR FREDERIC,—I have just received your most kind and generous note, and thank you and the Council for so promptly complying with my request to retire from the R. Academy as an active member.

To do it was much worse than making a will; but, having done it, I am greatly relieved.

Had it been earlier it would have been wiser; but as delay has not forfeited the esteem of my dear President and others, I am thankful and content.

But one word of parting advice I crave to offer, which my admiration of your rule and guidance in your high office constrains me to make.

Many of us have remarked that you draw upon your strength too severely; my parting words then are, and please accept, follow, and forgive them:—

Spare yourself when you can, that you may long be spared to give yourself, when you ought.

And now farewell, from your loyal and affectionate old friend,

GEO. RICHMOND.

From San Martino, 20th September 1889, Leighton wrote to his father:—

SAN MARTINO, *September 20 (1889).*

DEAR DAD,—I received your letter two or three days ago, but have deferred answering till I could say something one way or another about my health, for of course I have nothing else to tell of in these high latitudes. Well, I am in fairly good trim, and as well as I am likely to be till I leave, for San Martino will be shorn of my presence on Friday next as ever is (my address for the first fortnight in October will be Hotel Brufani, *Perugia*). On the other hand, if you were to ask me whether I am "as fit as a fiddle" or a "flea," or "as a strong man requiring to run a race," or "a giant refreshed," or "a bridegroom coming forth from his chamber," or whatever simile

you like, I am obliged to own that I am not. I am aware that the air is superb, and when I get on to an exposed slope and open my mouth like a carp I am further aware at (and for) the time—so to speak, "for this once only"—of very gratifying symptoms; then they are fugitive, and my *average* condition is perhaps a little less satisfactory than on Hampstead Heath. On the other hand, of course, such air *must* in some occult way be benefiting my tissues, and I shall no doubt, as the stock phrase is, "feel so much better *afterwards*." Meanwhile, I undergo much humiliation; whilst *ladies* make with comfort and ease delightful ascents to neighbouring peaks, I humbly pant up an anthill or two, resting at every third yard—puffy, helpless, effete. And lest I should console myself with inexpensive commonplace about my years, &c. &c., I have before me two acquaintances, *not* climbers by trade, one 65 and the other (most charming of men, Sir James Paget) 73, who put in their twelve, sixteen, or even at a pinch eighteen or twenty miles to my one, and back again without turning a hair or having a vestige of fatigue! Ugh!!

I am most truly sorry that your strength did not enable you to see Manchester; but it is *wonderful* that you do what you do on the doorstep of 89!—Your affectionate son,

FRED.

From Tours, October 30, he wrote to Mrs. Matthews:—

TOURS, *October 30, 1890.*

I hope, when I get back next week, that I shall find the old dad fairly well. More can't be expected; and especially I hope to find Lina drawing within sight of the end of her anxious toil.^[83] I am delighted to hear that she means to leave town again for a bit—a *good* bit, I hope. Tell her with my love that she is to make herself very comfortable, and *not to look at the money*, but *send for a cheque whenever convenient*. She *must*, in justice to herself, do her work under the most favourable circumstances she can command.

I have, of course, no particular news; I have been visiting *till now*. (I am going to-morrow to Blois and Chambord.) Nothing but old familiar scenes with the old familiar enjoyment, in the more serious sense of the word, but not of course with the old buoyancy of spirit—*that* must necessarily fade with every year now, and I must be content with an occasional little flicker of the waning candle. I have, however, been better in health during the second than during the first half of my holiday. In Rome I was the whole time with old Nino,^[84] whom I further took on a *Giro* to Siena and Florence. I also gave him a commission: very few things could give him so much pleasure (*inside*—he is not demonstrative!), and *nothing* is now so needful to him. His lameness is not as bad as I had feared; but he had a bad attack of his enemy, rheumatism, at Florence, and had to bolt back to his people. Of course, too, his anxiety about Georgina, my god-daughter, who has only just pulled through a terrible illness, has put a heavy strain on him in every way.

Weather has broken up; of late *bitter* cold, to-day cold *plus* rain, worthy of London.

On January 24, 1892, Doctor Leighton died at the age of ninety-two, at 11 Kensington Park Gardens, where for many years, every Sunday when in London, Leighton invariably went to see his father and his two sisters at five o'clock, remaining to the last minute before dinner. This regular habit he continued after Doctor Leighton's death; Mrs. Sutherland Orr living on in the same house and Mrs. Matthews in the close vicinity. In the autumn of 1893 Leighton was advised to go to the Hotel Riffel Alp, Zermatt. "What a stupendous view this is from my window," he wrote. "Weather in the main superb; it is finest for this scenery when it is not fine. Knee still rather troublesome—nuisance! Am seeing a doctor." In the October of the same year he wrote to Mrs. Matthews:—

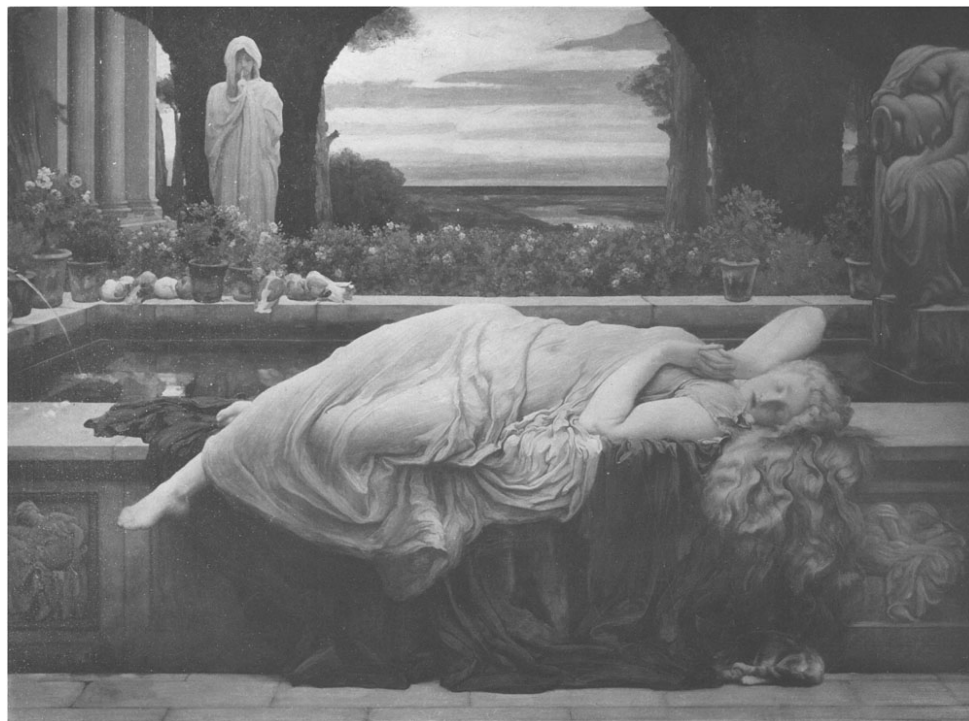
VERONA (Italy again!),
October 2, 1893.

DEAR GUSSY,—I hope you are not very savage with me for not writing sooner. I've had a tremendous "Hetztour" through Germany—*thirty* towns in thirty days; a Yankee might be proud of it; and

over an area contained between *Lübeck* (N.), if you please, and Berne (S.), Vienna (E.), and Colmar (W.), and I have made notes everywhere, *and* I have a game knee, with the result (not so much of the game knee as of the hurried travelling) that I have had little time for writing anything beyond notes of immediate necessity. But you *will* be savage at hearing that I never received your Munich letter (alluded to in Lina's last), either at the hotel or "Postlagernd"—can you remember at what *date* you wrote it? I would *try* to recover it—I hate losing letters, don't you? Thank Lina for her letter, and say that I am concerned at the very poor and shabby account given of her. She was going to send for the doctor; I hope he was able to help her (though I don't know on what plea one expects that of a doctor). By this time you may have recovered from your cure. What a rickety lot we are! At Perugia, where I shall be on Wednesday, I am going under physic for my knee, which, though hardly more than an inconvenience, is a very depressing prospect. I have written to Roberts, who has sent me prescriptions which I shall have made up (to-morrow) by his namesake in Florence. My journey has been, I am bound to say, in a high degree interesting and sometimes delightful. (I wonder whether you were ever at Hildesheim—its amazing picturesqueness, Renaissance houses, carved and painted, are enough to make your hair curl for the rest of your natural life.) But I have not bought a single German novel, after all the trouble you took twice over, except *Soll und Haben*, which I have just begun; how amazingly *altmodisch* and stodgy it is, but evidently very clever. I have grown very indolent about reading in trains. Wednesday I reach Perugia—Thursday I shall take a holiday—Friday I shall—but enough! In Berlin I saw dear old Joe (Dr. Joachim)—(the only person I did see, except Malet, the Ambassador, a very old friend of mine—very snug and *good* little bachelor dinner there—"just as you are"). He (Joe) seemed very fit after "les eaux" somewhere, and sent you kind messages. He was pleased at my calling, and came next day to see me off at the station.

In August 1894 he took his sister, Mrs. Matthews, to Bayreuth. On his rapidly returning to London he completed the panel he presented to the Royal Exchange. He worked hard at this for three weeks. He then went to

Scotland, and finished his holiday, as usual, in Italy. On his return, after attending the first Monday Popular concert at St. James' Hall, when walking to the Athenæum he was seized by his first attack of angina pectoris. Dr. Roberts, to whom Leighton was attached, and in whose judgment and skill he had had great confidence for years, writes, "I attended Lord Leighton for over twenty years. I was constantly seeing and watching him. He never was a robust man; but all his organs kept in health till two years before his death, when I discovered the commencement of the trouble that ultimately proved fatal. I never told him of this condition, as I felt its progress would be slow.... He once told me he considered my fees to him were too small, and asked me to increase them." Some years previous to this first attack Leighton would say, "I always see Dr. Roberts every Sunday for him to tell me I am not ill." In November 1894 Sir Lauder Brunton was called in for consultation, and he and Dr. Roberts prescribed a course of Swedish massage; and to this Leighton devoted the later hours of his afternoons for several months that winter. Work continued as vigorously as ever. The pictures—"Lachrymæ," "Twixt Hope and Fear," "Flaming June," "Listener," "Clytie," "Candida," "The Vestal," "A Bacchante," "The Fair Persian," were the fruit of the last year's labours, besides the sketches which he painted on his last journeys to Algiers, Ireland, and Italy.



"SUMMER SLUMBER." 1894
By permission of Mr. Phillipson[ToList](#)



SKETCH FOR "SUMMER SLUMBER." 1894
Presented by H.M. the King to the Leighton House Collection[ToList](#)

Very characteristic was the manner in which Leighton faced his condition. Absolutely natural as he invariably was, without nervousness, and considerate to the last degree in not making his state a burden on others, he never, even at this juncture, concentrated his thoughts on himself. Once when a friend implored him to draw in and not expend his strength unnecessarily, he answered, with almost impatience, "But that would not be life to me! I must go on, thinking about it as little as possible." There was something of the boy about Leighton up to the very end, and in those last months much of the pathos of the boy who is known to be doomed, but who plays his game with just as much eager verve up to the end.

Mr. Briton Rivière, the comrade whose nature was so worthily tuned to Leighton, writes:—

One of the last times that I met him actively employed was at a committee meeting of the Athenæum. He had some pain and difficulty in climbing the stairs to the committee-room, and evident pain in speaking; but because he felt that the candidate he proposed ought to be elected, and that no one else would propose him with more earnest conviction than he could (and he was the best proposer of a candidate I have ever heard), he came there at all risks to himself and *would* have done so against all opposition and all disadvantages, simply because he thought it his particular duty to do so. This is only a type of the manner in which he treated all his official work during those last years of physical suffering which he fought so bravely. Watching him, it was then I recognised that he was on the same plane as the seaman who never strikes his flag, and at the last goes down practically unvanquished.

Every day that grey pallor increased, and that sunken, indescribable look of waning life in the face. Nevertheless Leighton lived much as before, never making illness an excuse for avoiding any duty. As matters grew more serious his doctors enforced a rest—a voyage—an absence from the May Academy Banquet. At this juncture Leighton tendered his resignation as President of the Academy. It was not accepted.

To Mr. Briton Rivière he wrote:—

DEAR RIVIÈRE,—Many thanks for your most kind words. I have been deeply touched by the generous, and, I must almost say, affectionate attitude of my brother members in this painful conjuncture. How much I value *your* friendship, you, I am sure, know.—Sincerely yours always,

FRED LEIGHTON.

He decided on leaving England for two months, and fixed on Algiers as a dry climate likely to suit his health. It had lived in his memory also ever

since the first visit in 1857, as a country singularly fascinating to him. Before leaving he fulfilled his duties as President in choosing the pictures for that year's Exhibition. These duties he had often described as the most wearing of the whole year. His intense sense of duty, and desire to judge in every case the interests of the individual artist together with those of art, fairly and adequately, inflicted a strain and entailed an indescribable fatigue, he said, even when he was well. During those days in 1895 he suffered acutely.

From Hotel Continental, Tangiers, 18th April 1895, Leighton wrote:—

DEAR WELLS,—Although letters do not leave these wilds daily and take an unconscionable time, as I now find, on the way, I trust this will reach you in time for the first varnishing day, on which I believe you hold the general meeting; it carries with it warm and grateful—and *envious* greetings to you all. These you will, I know, deliver to my brother members at lunch, for then only is the *whole* body gathered together. They, knowing me, will understand my humiliation at not being under arms and at my post at this season. I wish I could ask you to tell them that I see much sign of betterment in my condition: the slowness of my cure—if cure it be—is, of course, depressing; but I shall comfort myself on Thursday with the thought that perhaps, at some time between one and two, you are wishing well to one who claims to be a faithful friend to you all. I look forward keenly to what will, I feel sure, be the admirable performance of our dear old Millais. Unfortunately, I have not the remotest notion of where I shall be when the news might reach me—in Africa or in Europe—but reach me it will in time. You perhaps think of me as basking in the sun between blue skies and blue seas. How different are the facts! Blustering winds, occasionally rain, chilly atmosphere, everything murky and without colour! A change *should* not be far off, for this sort of thing has prevailed for a month and more. I did not bargain for it.

I hope, my dear Wells—and indeed I do not doubt—that you are getting on well and comfortably with your vice-regency, and am always yours sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.

TANGIERS, *April 25, 1895.*

DEAR LINA,—The day before yesterday I received your nice long letter—you had not yet got mine from Gib.—and yesterday one came from poor Gussy, and I am going, as you will both believe when this reaches you, to kill two birds with one epistolary stone. First, let me say that I am grieved—I dare hardly say, *surprised*, for it is, alas! a wicked way you both have—to hear that neither of you has derived any benefit, to speak of, by your outing, and you indeed, poor dear, appear to be a little worse. The fact is that at our ages, *con rispetto*, when one happens to have pretty homes, one *does* miss them under the discomforts and shortcomings of lodgings or inns. As for me, though I am fairly comfortable here, I have whiffs of a certain "House Beautiful" in Kensington which are very tantalising. How am I? Well, I think I may at last claim a *little* improvement, of course I give myself every chance, and am superlatively, disgracefully lazy, *and put myself to no tests*; but I notice this, that though I have my regulation three attacks (when not more) a day, they are milder, I think, and I *know* that I can get rid of them almost immediately by certain respiratory exercises my Swede taught me. This I assume is again *no more capsules*, we shall see.

Yes, I do perfectly remember the old home in St. Katherine's at Bath, and should hugely like to see it. I hope when the old inhabitant goes off, it will fall into reverent hands.

No, I have not yet tackled Nordau. I am looking forward to him much, but have so far, except some Pater (Greek studies), mostly fribbled; two or three Spanish novels; a few short tales by Hardy, clever, but his figures are talking dolls, taught out of a book; *L'Innocente*, dull, but not so *coarse* as I had understood. "Tales of Mean Streets"—now there, if you like, is powerful stuff. For pithy terseness and absolute sobriety of means, for subtle and humorous observation and scathing directness, they are unrivalled; but oh! what a picture! what a state of things, and who shall ever let the light into the tenebrous and foul depths? But how funny too, and

grim; the old woman who pockets the ten shillings given for port, in order that she may have mutes at the funeral! Have also read "Keynotes." Clever, one or two even powerful, but other than I expected. Who is the woman? half Norse? half Irish? The writing is bad; intentionally, apparently; a cross between an interviewer and Ibsen for scrappy abruptness. *Her* keynote is belief in the *immeasurable* (but not explained) superiority of women, whom no man can *understand*; well, certainly, *I* don't know *wo sie hinaus will*.

I have had more kind notes, this is a kind world *tout de même*. When stodgy, elderly Englishmen talk to me of the number of people who *love* me, I feel quite a lump in my throat. Of another kind, but pretty, is the enclosed from W. Watson, the poet, whom I admire, you know; nice also the telegram. I wrote a *menschlich* letter when her husband died (*I* have known them nearly forty years), and again a pretty letter t'other day about the wedding.

But I *must* finish this scribble. I shall be gone when you get this, write *Algiers* (poste restante), I shall get it *some* time or other, but am still vague.

Love to poor Gussy.—Afft. bro.,

FRED.

Leighton enclosed the following from William Watson, and the telegram from the Comtesse de Paris:—

66 CHERITON ROAD, FOLKESTONE,
April 18, 1895.

DEAR SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON,—May I venture to say, somewhat superfluously, what a delight it was to be made free of your Palace of Art on a recent Sunday, and how highly I valued the privilege. Mr. Wilfrid Meynell had already made me happy by reporting the generous things you had said about my verses. I wish the great pleasure thus given me were not alloyed by the news of your temporarily impaired health. But in common with the rest of the

world I hope those sunnier regions to which you perhaps feel more spiritually akin than to our own may quickly renew your full energies.

Pray forgive anything which may be intrusive or otherwise unwarrantable in this letter, and believe me, dear Sir Frederick, with very grateful sense of your kindness, and pride in your good opinion, yours sincerely,

WILLIAM WATSON.

SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON, Bart., P.R.A.

Telegram.]

April 16, 1895.

TO SIR FREDERIC LEIGHTON,
2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD,
KENSINGTON, LONDON.

Profondement touchée de votre si bonne lettre et aimables vœux pour ma fille, je vous en remercie de tout mon cœur, y voyant une nouvelle preuve de votre amitié. Je regrette vivement pas avoir le plaisir de vous revoir avant longtemps, mais suis sûre penserez à moi.

COMTESSE PARIS.

BUCKINGHAM.

On arriving at Alger, Leighton wrote:—

HOTEL D'EUROPE, ALGER,
May 9, 1895.

DEAR WELLS,—I got your first kind letter three days ago at Tlencen, and this morning, on passing through this place, your very interesting account of the Banquet. I know you will not resent a very brief acknowledgment; I have *one* day here only, and a large pile of letters, with a good many of which I must deal, however laconically,

at once. I need not assure you that your most kind words, like so many manifestations of friendship that I have received, touch me to the quick and will not be forgotten. That my dear old friend Millais could carry away his audience by his earnest and intense personality, I was quite certain. I rejoice in my heart at his success, apart from what I feel about his affectionate and warm expressions. It is worth while to break down, to be treated with such infinite kindness as I have met with everywhere amongst my colleagues and friends. I know you will like to hear that I am at last very decidedly better; in another month—for I don't mean to come home sooner—I really expect to be externally quite patched up—of course, the warning and the constant threat will remain by me, but I shall try to be careful, and hope yet for long to be the devoted servant of my brother members in the Academy. Meanwhile, believe me, always sincerely yours,

FRED LEIGHTON.

P.S.—I trust you have not suffered in your throat, which is a frequent anxiety to you from the necessity of much speaking. *I* know how trying that is.

HOTEL D'EUROPE, ALGER,
May 21, 1895.

DEAR LINA,—In an hour or two I leave for Europe, and in three weeks I shall be home again in comfortable Kensington.

I am grieved that you should have been worried—as well you might—by that idiotic report that I should not return to society or my profession (I wonder who invented it!), but you were fortunately soon relieved; I think I told you about the trouble Reuter and Hardy took in the matter. By-the-bye, you were right in supposing that the "long walk" was also a figment of the correspondents.

I am very glad to hear that you and Gussy are both at all events a little better at last. My bulletin is chequered, but certain things are satisfactory; in the first place, I see that fine weather and sun and pure air and the rest of it have nothing whatever to do with my

condition; this, as I can't choose my climate, is distinctly reassuring; also, the fact of my having been much better shows that I may hope distinctly for much improvement: in the other, a certain relapse which is now upon me shows how needful caution is, only it is disappointing to have had to go back to capsules. I have had in the main a most enjoyable time; have been very fortunate in the weather, inasmuch as the heat has not yet been intolerable, and I have done some work which will be useful perhaps and certainly delightful as a reminiscence and suggestion. A variety of untoward things, one on the top of the other, no doubt quite account for my, I hope not durable, relapse, and I have no doubt when I write again I shall be able to report fresh improvement. The odd thing is, the bad effects *last* so curiously. I understand hot railway journeys, bad food, &c. &c., telling on me, but I have been now two whole days and a bit in Algiers in *utter* idleness, and a great deal on my back, and yet this morning I got an attack *lying in bed!* but don't let this disturb you—for several weeks I was much better and required *no* capsules at all. This short little note will reach you, I suppose, on Friday morning; a line on that day or on Saturday or Sunday, just to say that it has reached you would catch me at the Hotel Continental, Rue Castiglione, *Paris*. Please tell me, on the altogether improbable chance of my "looking in" on the Channel Islands, what the *best* hotels are—I *must* be comfortable. Best love to Gussy.—From your affectionate old brother,

FRED.

P.S.—I wrote to the P. of W.'s secretary, asking him to say how much H.R.H.'s kind words had gratified me—I enclose the answer, which is nice, I think.

On Leighton's return to London he resumed his duties as President. He tried to believe what Sir Lauder Brunton hoped, but found it somewhat difficult to do so in the face of *facts*, he used to say. He, however, assumed that he was mending. On 19th July 1895 he wrote:—

DEAR BRITON RIVIÈRE,—Very many thanks for your kind and thoughtful note. Do not think of postponing your motion; I have

already been the innocent cause of the postponement of two very contentious motions in Council; I could not think of standing further in the way—pray, therefore, proceed with it. I had a nasty attack at that meeting but have felt no after effects, and am no doubt slowly mending. In haste, yours ever sincerely,

FRED LEIGHTON.



"THE FAIR PERSIAN"

(Unfinished at the time of Lord Leighton's death.) 1896

By permission of Sir Elliott Lees [ToList](#)

From his account to his friends after his return, his health had varied while abroad in an unaccountable manner, except in one instance where, as my husband and I knew from personal experience, the conditions were normally unhealthy. This evidently was the cause for his having had specially violent attacks at Morlaix in Brittany, which he visited on his

journey home—and where, some years previously, our whole party had become more or less ill, owing, it was thought, to the unhealthiness of the place. His condition was much the same as when he left England. He worked steadily in his studio, and received the guests at the Annual Soirée of the Royal Academy. At the conclusion of the function a friend asked him how it had really fared with him—for apparently his vitality had appeared, as usual, inexhaustible. "I think the attacks must be greatly a matter of nerves," he answered. "I have stood here three hours and a quarter and have not had one,—while I was dressing and fearing how I should get through it, I had *three*."

Leighton did not go to Scotland that autumn but to the wild west coast of Ireland, again to that Malinmore that had so greatly fascinated him, and whose wild beauty he had longed for his sister to enjoy, "taking her courage in one hand, her goloshes in a second, and umbrella in the third."^[85] On his way there he wrote to Mrs. Orr:—

IMPERIAL HOTEL,
PEMBROKE STREET, CORK,
Thursday, September 5, 1895.

DEAR LINA,—I was glad to glean from your letter of last Thursday that, taking it all round, you are having a fairly good time, and Gussy ditto. (I can't stand *wind* either, it aggravates my system.) I've never seen Mull—should like to—but *not* being a sociable bird (like you) should wish to have no acquaintances. Is it Napier of *Magdala*? if so, I knew the old lord of that ilk; indeed, to be accurate, I knew him even if it was not so; or Lord Napier of *Ettrick*? if so ditto, ditto. It is always the previous lot *I* knew. By this time you will have been to Lindisfarne^[86] (lovely name!)—if you did not enjoy the sands and the Abbey you need not call on me again. I suppose you are at home now. In a week or two I shall no doubt know how I am. Just off to Killarney, then Galway, then *Malinmore*, County Donegal, where I shall be from (say) the 10th to (say) the 17th, your affectionate old brother.

In another letter he wrote to Mrs. Orr: "I am too glad that you have made acquaintances—been a gregarious person. If I make an acquaintance

anywhere, I have simply lost the game." From Malinmore on September 19th he wrote to me: "I'm sorry that you saw Scotland in a mist; its beauty is *succulent colour*—you want rain first and then a burst of sun—I am enjoying unsociable solitude keenly, like the bear I am; health so so; I'm sowing patience, but so far reaping nothing in particular. In a fortnight, off to Italy." On this visit to his "second home" Leighton began with Venice, from whence he wrote to me Oct. 9th: "The wind is howling and the rain pouring down in torrents—not a correct attitude in Venice—I'm no better." Leighton next went to Naples, where he wrote the following letter to Mrs. Orr:—

HOTEL BRISTOL, NAPLES,
October 18, 1895.

DEAR LINA,—I am sorry that you and Gussy don't see your way to going to Bayreuth, since it is your health that seems to stand in the way; other reasons are all my eye. I KNOW from Gussy's own mouth that she would particularly like to hear the Siegfried Tetralogy at Bayreuth (and this *may* be the last time of giving it *there*), I *know* also that, given, of course, the Fürsten Loge with its facilities, you would like to go, because you have said so. Well it will remain open in case you change what you, fondly and perhaps sincerely, regard as your minds.

I am very glad you take such a very sensible view of my ailment, because it makes it more easy to speak of it; I also live in the hope and, almost, expectation, that it will fizzle out some day of its own accord, and this enables me to bear up against the entire absence *at present* of any improvement. I have at last finished my "Nordau," which I have read through from cover to cover; it is a very vigorous and remarkable book and of riveting interest to any one who likes polemics (from *outside*) as I do. The author is at his best when he is dissecting a particular victim—say Nietzsche—on the other hand one is not a little repelled by his astoundingly unparliamentary insolence, his not infrequent disingenuousness and *spitzfindelei* and his curious narrownesses and lacunæ. The *Böcke die er schneidet* when he gets on the subject of graphic art are quite comic. The fact is he is in some respects absolutely devoid of perception, like an

otherwise most intelligent and cultured man who should have no ear for music. What, for instance, can we say of a man who asserts, as a truism, that æsthetic and *sexual*(!) feelings (not sensual but "*geschlechtlich*") are not merely akin but actually cover one another to a very large extent! I doubt whether there is anything chaster than the sense of beauty in abstract form; he has no inkling of this. When all is said and done he is himself in some measure a *cryptodegenerate*, if I may so call him; degeneracy is a *Zwangsvorstellung* with him, he sees it everywhere; a curious instance is his seeing it in the fondness of English writers for alliteration; of course he knows, with his wide culture, better than I do that this assonance of the beginning of words dates from the dawn of our literature; *he might*, no doubt, say, "Yes! it is a *Rückschlag*," but he would therein give another proof of his ineptitude in æsthetic matters. In *every Art, iteration*, of which alliteration is a form, has ever been a powerful source of expression and charm. Meanwhile his last, remarkable, chapter "Therapie" takes a good deal of the sting out of the book; he owns that certain peculiarities—excess of sensibility and the like—are present in *nearly all art*, that it is, in fact, only a question of a degree and, he adds, in a passage which Gussy has marked, "Who shall say *where*, exactly, madness begins?" Amen! And that little (or large) spice of something which *might* be madness if there was much more of it, has given to us poor mortals some of our keenest delights—"more grease to its elbow," say I, in my vulgar way. But, I say! Nietzsche!! eh?—I've also read J. Kowaleski, with great interest—but, crikey! *what* a creature to live with!!

Tell Gussy, with my love, that I have got the usual two seats (Queen's Hall) for the November *Wagner*. Tell her to keep the day open.—Afftly. yrs.

FRED.

From Naples he travelled to Rome to find his dear friend Giovanni Costa, with whom he spent the last weeks of his holiday. Of this visit Costa wrote the following in his "Notes":—

"His last study from nature was painted in Rome in October 1895, for the unfinished picture of 'Clytie,' exhibited in the Royal Academy, 1896. It was a study of fruit, and he enjoyed working on it for several hours, though he was then ill; and I believe that the hours he passed in the courtyard of the Palazzo Odeschalchi painting these fruits, which he had arranged on a marble sarcophagus, afforded him, perhaps, the last artistic pleasures he ever enjoyed. It is true that after this he went to the Vatican, to Siena, and to Florence, where he saw for the last time the masterpieces with which these towns abound. But, standing before the great works of the masters of the past, he could only sigh.

"He worshipped children, and his pictures of children with fruit and flowers are among the most delicious and spontaneous work ever done by him in painting. And I can see him again, during the last visit he paid to Rome in 1895, on his knees before my little girl, to accede to her request that she should have a lock of his hair as a remembrance."

Nothing could give a better record of two sides of Leighton's nature, often believed to be incompatible, than the contents of the letter from Naples to his sister, with its remarks on Nordau, Nietzsche, and the like, and this beautiful picture recalled by his old friend Costa—Leighton on his knees before a little child. The intellect which could crack the hardest of intellectual nuts was surmounted by lowly reverence for all beauty, most ardently adored when that beauty came to him in its most innocent childlike garb.

Writing to me on his return on November the 6th Leighton says: "I shall try to look in to-morrow at five. I want very much to hear Fuller-Maitland's preachment" (Lectures on Purcell were being given at our house previous to the Purcell Festival). "I am sorry to say I am no better, rather worse." On being asked the next day, as he came into our house, "How is it?" the answer Leighton gave was, "Oh, worse! Sometimes fifteen attacks a day." On his birthday, the 3rd of December, he wrote to his sister:—

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
December 3, 1895.

DEAR LINA,—The grand leaves in a mossy pot, and the sweet flowers, and the poems, and your letter, came all together. I know you will let me answer you both on one piece of paper. I know, dears, how true is your love, and though I am not a demonstrative person, it is very precious to me. I know you will both like to hear that after an *hour's* innings between L. Brunton, Dr. Tunncliffe his partner, Roberts, and three most ingenious scientific instruments, and after tapping and auscultating of my wretched ear cap fore and aft, it was pronounced that (in some mysterious way) I am *not* worse, but *better*; well, I am glad to hear it; meanwhile my medicine is being strengthened, and will be again in the (pretty certain) event of its requiring more strength. L.B. quite *hopes* to rig me out for the May banquet. Much love to both from affectionate old brother.

On the 14th he wrote to his friend Mr. Henry Wells:—

2 HOLLAND PARK ROAD, KENSINGTON, W.,
December 14, 1895.

DEAR WELLS,—Many thanks for your kind letter, relying on which I hasten to "nail" you for the 27th; I shall be very much disappointed if you say me "nay." I never give a *long* notice, in part so as to bring about a little shuffling of cards, and relieving my guests of a certain monotony of routine which might in the end irk them. I need not assure you that I am most warmly sensible to the vigilant and truly friendly interest which you manifest concerning my health; believe me, if I differ from you in not believing in the efficacy or feasibility of a suspension of activity for a year or two, it is in no unreasoning or perverse spirit (and let me, by-the-bye, say in passing that I have, for a few days past, certainly been a little better). Putting aside for a moment the fact that I have for the next year, and more, definite professional *obligations* in the way of commissioned work (which is, unfortunately, not incompatible with having a certain number of unsold works!), to withdraw from Academic duties would mean

leaving England for the period in question; it would be morally impossible to remain here, apparently in robust health, congratulated constantly, as I am, on my healthy appearance, going about unrebuked by a *very* cautious doctor (Lauder Brunton), taking the pleasures of life *apparently* without any stint (as a matter of *fact* I am very quiet and regular, and under *continuous* medical treatment), and then shirking all its *duties*; but experience has shown that I gain nothing by absence—by change of climate and the rest; and, on the other hand, my temperament being what you know, the withdrawal from my active life would infallibly prey on me and have a marked effect on my health through my spirits; this is also the opinion of Lauder Brunton. My care must be to live quietly but not idly, and thus try to mend gradually, as I doubtless shall, in the hands of my doctor *and my masseur*. *If*, which God forbid, I am pronounced still unfit in May, I will bow, with whatever bitterness, to the judgment, but till then I must not forego hope. Meanwhile, you have all done me infinite service in prohibiting the "Discourse" for this year—I can't say how grateful I was for that! I shall also avoid, as far as may be, all *controversy* at our table; that is the worst thing of all by far, for yours sincerely always,

FRED LEIGHTON.^[87]

With the New Year honours and among those bestowed was a Peerage on Leighton, who was created Lord Leighton, Baron of Stretton (see [chap. i. vol. i., Antecedents](#)). Needless to say, congratulations poured in from all sorts and conditions. One of these in writing was preserved because enclosed in a note to his sister.

January 13, 1896.

MY DEAR LEIGHTON,—I have just come back from Italy, and hope that it is not too late to tell you with how much satisfaction I read of the mark of honour that has been accepted by you. I am not a passionate admirer of the legislative feats of the House of Lords, but so long as it stands, it is well that such a man as you should sit there. I hope that the thing has given you pleasure, and for my poor part I

rejoice both as a friend and as a humble admirer of art and genius that this honourable recognition has fallen to you.—Yours sincerely,

JOHN MORLEY.

Not a word of reply, I pray.

From his native place Leighton received the following:—

When it was announced on Wednesday that the Queen had been pleased to confer the dignity of a Peerage of the United Kingdom upon Sir Frederic Leighton, Bart., President of the Royal Academy, who is a native of Scarborough, having been born here sixty-five years ago, the Mayor (Alderman Cross, J.P.) sent the following telegram:—"Sir Frederic Leighton, 2 Holland Park Road, London, the Mayor, Corporation, and inhabitants of Scarborough present their hearty congratulations on the honour conferred upon you.—The Mayor, Scarborough." The next morning the following reply was received:—"The Mayor of Scarborough,—Sincere thanks for congratulations from my birthplace.

LEIGHTON."

Leighton had been loath to acquaint his sisters with the real nature of his complaint, as he was aware how much their anxiety for him would be increased if they knew. However, he at last felt it was necessary to tell them. Very characteristically, he chose the moment when they were at the theatre, thinking it might produce a less painful shock when mentioned casually, and when their attention might be distracted more easily. It was difficult, however, under any circumstances to temper the blow. Leighton wrote the next Sunday—"I do hope I shall find you better this afternoon.... I ought not to have spoken to you about my ailment." I received the following in Somerset, dated January 20, dictated, ... "As I am (not to put too fine a point on it) in bed with a very bad cough at this moment, you will, I know, forgive my using the hand of a secretary in writing to you. I see that you want a contribution for Mrs. Watts Hughes' Home for Boys; I therefore enclose a cheque." ... On the day following, Tuesday, his doctors decreed that he should remain in his room, but on Wednesday, the day after,

Leighton insisted on getting into his studio, where he worked all the morning from models. In the afternoon he drove in his open carriage—certainly without the permission of his doctors!—to Westminster, getting out and standing in the raw damp of a cold January afternoon to watch the pulling down of some old houses which had interested him. In the evening he wrote to me a letter, which happened to be the last he penned. A Lecture was to be given for the benefit of Mrs. Watts Hughes' Home for Boys; and in return for Leighton's contribution I had sent him four five shilling tickets to give away, offering to change them for half guinea tickets, but suggesting it would be most rash of him to go himself. However, he intended to go, and wrote that Wednesday evening:—

DEAR MRS. BARRINGTON,—... Since you are good enough to offer to change the tickets for tenners, I will ask you to do so, and thank you in advance. Yes, Mackail's book, which oddly enough I *have* read—for, alas! I never read now—is an exquisite bit of work.

When the Lecture was given on the evening of January 29, Leighton had left us already four days!

At five o'clock on Thursday morning, January 23, he woke, feeling terrible pain and great distress in breathing, but would not ring for his servant because he believed him to be delicate, and thought it might hurt him to be disturbed so early. At seven he rang, and Dr. Roberts, who was telegraphed for, at once saw that the situation was of the gravest. Sir Lauder Brunton also was summoned. Leighton's servant had promised his sisters that they should be sent for at once if the symptoms at any time became more acute; but on his mentioning this, Leighton said he must not send for Mrs. Orr and Mrs. Matthews, as they were both more ill than he was. However, as the morning went on and there were no signs of any change for the better, the sisters were told of his condition, and at once came—not leaving him till the end.

On Thursday afternoon, when he was supposed to be sinking, and they were with him alone, he expressed his wishes as to his property—the sums of money he wished given to various friends—adding that he should like ten thousand pounds to be given to the Royal Academy. These were wishes expressed—not legacies, as he left his whole property unconditionally to his

sisters, and believed that they, as next-of-kin, would, as a matter of course, be his heirs.

Contrary to the doctor's expectations, Leighton rallied on the Friday, and hopes were expressed that he might recover from the acute attack from which he was suffering. On his hearing this, he exclaimed to his sisters, "Would it not have been a pity if I had had to die just when I was going to paint better!"

On the Saturday morning the gravest symptoms returned, and every hope vanished. It was then suggested to Leighton that it would be better for him to make a will, and his lawyer was sent for; but it was some time before he could arrive. Though the agony was great, Leighton refused all alleviations till his will was written out. It was as follows:—

This is the last will and testament of Frederic Leighton. I will and bequeath to my sisters, Alexandra Orr and Augusta Newnburg Matthews, the whole estate unconditionally.

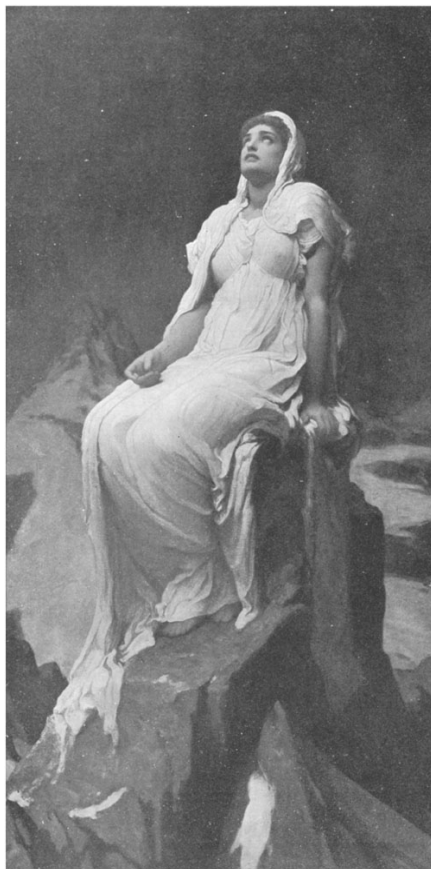
FRED LEIGHTON.

Mrs. Orr wrote: "When the official will had been drawn up and signed, he said, 'Does this give my sisters absolute control over all I have?' On the lawyer answering in the affirmative, Leighton asked, 'Then no one can interfere with them?' 'No one,' answered the lawyer; 'they are paramount.' He was afraid that the brief paragraph was not sufficiently strong."

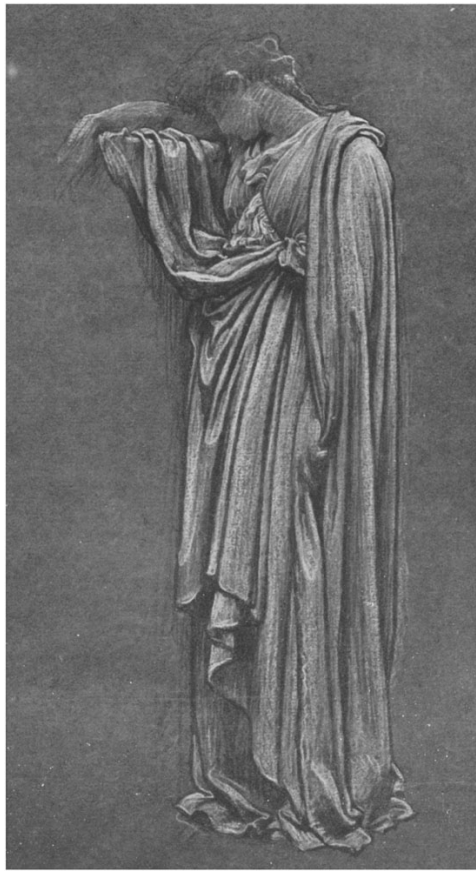
After signing it, he said, "My love to the Academy"; but his last words were spoken in German, and meant for his sisters' ears alone. Then came the end.

"We went together," writes Lady Loch, "to see Fred Leighton the Sunday before he died, and he said, 'Mind you come to "my concert." I have just settled it all with Villiers Stanford, and it will be beautiful.'" In about ten days after, with aching hearts at the loss of so true, so warm, so great a friend, we attended his burial service at St. Paul's Cathedral, seeing such

proofs of real mourning all along the Embankment and streets, for indeed every man, woman, and child had lost a real, true friend.



"THE SPIRIT OF THE SUMMIT." 1894 [To List](#)



STUDY FOR "LACHRYMÆ." 1895 [To List](#)

All who were present must ever remember the last "Music" in the March before, when (contrasting so strongly in colour and sentiment) "Lachrymæ" and "Flaming June" stood on the easels, and for the first time the silk room was open, hung with the work of Leighton's friends; how, through all the beautiful strains from Joachim and the rest, a tragic note rang out to tell, as it seemed, of the waning life of the centre of it all. No one said it, but all felt that the last chapter was ending of those many, many perfect pages in life known as "Leighton's music."

A voice sang with emotion Charles Kingsley's soul-stirring verse—

"When all the world is old, lad,
And all the trees are brown;
And all the sport is stale, lad,
And all the wheels run down,

Creep home, and take your place there,
The spent and maim'd among;
God grant you find one face there
You loved when all was young."

Cruelly pathetic did it seem that one who had ever had the vitality of a boy, who had ever been the inspirer and support of those weary overwrought ones whose wheels had run down before their time, should himself be stricken, creeping home "the spent and maimed among."

The studios emptied, and he came down the stairs with the last of us. Dainty figures of girls were dancing round the fountain in the empty Arab Hall; and as he went to the outer door they flew to him, throwing their arms round his neck. "They are all my god-children," he said, as each, fleet-footed, fled out of the gate. A clasp, a wring of a friend's hand; then, ashen pale, tired and haggard, he turned back lonely into the House Beautiful—and that book was closed.

Instead of strains of perfect song and music hailing their completion, the six pictures of the next year looked down on the coffin, and over a rich carpeting of beautiful flowers. In the centre, above the head, the sun-loving "Clytie" stretched out her arms, bidding a passionate farewell to her god.

The coffin was borne away to the Academy on Saturday, February 1, previous to the funeral on the Monday.



"CLYTIE." 1896

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The following is a correct account of the public funeral, written on the day it took place, and forwarded to Leighton's birthplace.

At half-past ten this morning, by which time a dense crowd had collected in the neighbourhood of the Royal Academy, the workmen commenced to remove the numerous wreaths from the Central Hall, where the body of Lord Leighton has rested since Saturday night, and to load the huge floral car. Prominent among these wreaths was one from the Princess Christian; but that from the Prince and Princess of Wales was conveyed in a separate carriage by representatives of the Prince and Princess, General Ellis and Lord Colville of Culross. The wreath consisted of choice white flowers

rising from a bank of delicate green foliage, and attached was a card written by the Princess of Wales, and inscribed as follows:—

"Life's race well run,
Life's work well done,
Life's Crown well won,
Now comes rest."

Then follow the words, "A mark of sincere and affectionate regard, esteem, and admiration for a great artist and much beloved friend, from Alexandra and Albert Edward." At the head of the card were the words, "To Sir Frederic Leighton." There was also a wreath from the Empress Frederick, bearing the words: "From Victoria, Empress Frederick," in the Empress's own writing.

The Queen's wreath for the funeral of Lord Leighton was sent from Buckingham Palace this morning to Colonel the Honourable W. Carington, by whom it was conveyed to St. Paul's Cathedral. The wreath is composed of laurel, entwined with which are immortelles, and it is tied with broad satin ribbon. Attached to the wreath is an autograph card from Her Majesty, with the following inscription: "A mark of respect from Victoria, R.I."

About five minutes to eleven the coffin was removed from the Central Hall, and carried through the vestibule into the quadrangle. A detachment of the Artists' Volunteers was drawn up here, and saluted the coffin as soon as it emerged into the open by presenting arms. The remains were placed in a glass hearse, and the volunteers took up their position at the front and sides. The pall-bearers, relatives, and others meanwhile formed in procession, and punctually at eleven the cortège left the Academy, the crowd reverentially uncovering as the hearse passed into the street. The whole length of the route, from Piccadilly to St. Paul's, was lined with people; but the crowds were quiet and orderly, and maintained a clear space for the funeral cortège without the assistance of the police. The volunteers marched with arms reversed, and the remains of the deceased artist were carried to their last resting-place with every manifestation of mournful regret. Flags were at half-mast on

many public buildings, and as the solemn procession passed slowly along, the remains were reverently saluted by the crowd. Passing into Pall Mall by Charing Cross, the procession wended its way through Northumberland Street, proceeding thence along the Thames Embankment, New Bridge Street, and Ludgate Hill, St. Paul's being reached shortly before noon.

The service in the Cathedral, which occupied an hour, was at once picturesque as a spectacle and impressive in its solemnity as a religious function.

More than an hour before the time appointed for the arrival of the funeral cortège, the space available to the public in St. Paul's was occupied, and a few minutes after eleven o'clock, visitors of distinction, who had been provided with special invitations, began to fill up the reserved seats in the transept.

Among those present were representatives of the Royal Family, the German Emperor, and the King of Belgium, members of both Houses of Parliament, including the Speaker; delegates from learned bodies and artistic associations, as well as from the art committees of various provincial municipalities.

The first lesson was read by the Dean, and the succeeding passages were given by the Bishop of Stepney; but the greater part of the service was undertaken by the Archbishop of York, chaplain of the Royal Academy. The musical portions of the service were exceptionally fine, and included, as a somewhat unusual feature, a trombone quartette.

Lord Salisbury had promised to be one of the pall-bearers, but found himself unable to attend. The pall-bearers were Major-General Ellis, representing the Prince and Princess of Wales; the Duke of Abercorn, Sir Joseph Lister, Sir J. Millais, Sir E. Thompson, Sir A. Mackenzie, and Professor Lecky.

After the coffin was lowered into the crypt by a central opening directly beneath the dome, the two sisters of the late Lord Leighton came to the front, and took a last look at it. When the coffin was lowered many beautiful flowers were placed upon it, and again,

after the opening was covered up, the space was more than covered by further wreaths sent by various Academicians, the Royal Academy, students, and personal friends, many of whom lingered some time after the conclusion of the solemn ceremony.

Scarborough Evening News, February 3, 1896.

Leighton's death touched, as did his life, all sorts and conditions of men; for he had been the true friend alike of the greatest and of the least. The soil in which true distinction is rooted is of a quality too rich, too fertile to be affected by class prejudice. Leighton's own life was made beautiful by the gratitude he felt for the joy nature's loveliness inspired in his soul, and by the passion to make known through his work the mysterious treasure, the never-failing fountain of delight, ever springing up in his heart. Lovingly human, he ardently desired not only to pass on his own joy in beauty to every fellow-creature who crossed his path, but, where he saw in any possible way help could be given, to give it.

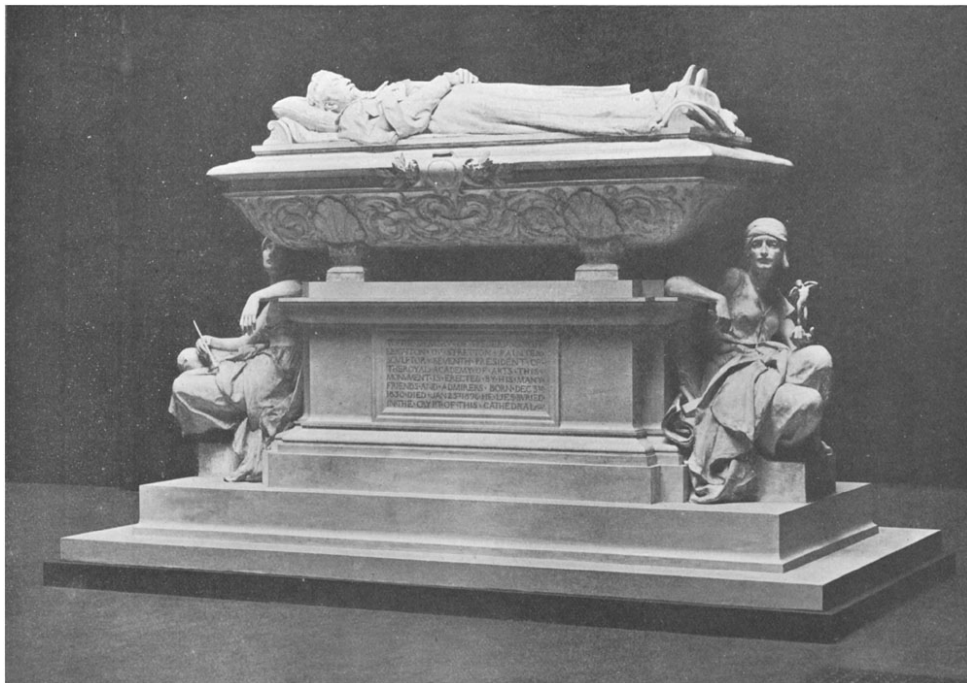
Of the eager, great-hearted Leighton, not a few can echo Romola's tribute to Savonarola—the last words of the great book whose pages he vivified with his art: "Perhaps I should never have learned to love him if he had not helped me when I was in great need."

A light has passed that never shall pass away,
A sun has set whose rays are unequalled of
might;
The loyal grace, the courtesy bright as day,
The strong, sweet, radiant spirit of life and
light,

That shone and smiled and lightened in all
men's sight,
The kindly life whose tune was the tune of
May,
For us now dark, for love and for fame is
bright.

ALGERNON CHARLES
SWINBURNE.

[\[88\]](#)



MONUMENT IN ST. PAUL'S CATHEDRAL, ERECTED AS A
MEMORIAL TO LORD LEIGHTON BY HIS FRIENDS AND
ADMIRERS

Sculptured by Thomas Brock, R.A. [ToList](#)



View of Inner Hall and Staircase of Leighton House, with reproduction of Mr. Thomas Brock's R.A. Diploma work, Bust of Lord Leighton, presented by Mr. Brock to the Leighton House Collection in 1898.

By permission of Mr. J. Harris Stone.[ToList](#)

FOOTNOTES:

[83] "Life and Letters of Robert Browning."

[84] Professor Giovanni Costa.

[85] It was during this last visit to Malinmore Leighton made those sketches of the sea thistle (see [chapter iii. vol. i.](#)), and also some last sketches in oil.

[86] Leighton had visited Mr. Pepys Cockerell and his family at Lindisfarne (Holy Island) more than once when going or returning from Scotland.

[87] Mr. Percy Fitzgerald wrote the following:—

"Being in the same club with Lord Leighton, I could note many instances of his good humour and sweetness of temper. I am happy to think, for it was a high compliment from him, that he made my acquaintance, not I his. He had always a pleasant word; as when, entering the writing-room with his hasty tramp, he looked over at me, seated at the window pencil in hand, and rushed over in his impetuous way: "Ah, one of *our* trade, I see!" He was particularly interested in a museum or institute at Camberwell, and one day thanked me most warmly for having gone down to lecture there, and that it was appreciated by the people, &c. This was good-natured.

"The day he received his title, an old gentleman of the club, who did not know him, congratulated him as he passed by in high-sounding Italian. He was delighted, and poured out a reply in the same tongue, adding some pleasant remark. This little incident quite illustrates his *bonhomie*. It is just what Dickens would do. I gave him a copy of Sir Joshua's Discourses, a presentation one to Burke. It was fitting that the modern President should have it.

"How tragic were his last appearances at the Academy *soirée*! How jaded, shrunk and haggard looked the once handsome painter! He must have suffered cruelly, and at the end seemed worn out. There was something of a likeness to the lamented Irving, the same sweetness of manner, the same grace and romantic view of things. His dress was characteristic, somewhat showy, yet not scrupulously neat like a dandy. His clothes, like Irving's, seemed old friends, and lay about him in roomy fashion. His somewhat unkempt beard left some traces on the lapels of his favourite snuff-coloured coat with the flowing tails. The blue or red silk, its ends flying free, was a note of colour. Three men of mark, and on some points resembling each other, had each this fancy for a somewhat theatrical attire.

"I noticed that a nervous guest innocently presented to the porter a ticket for some artistic *soirée*, which was declined, to the embarrassment of the visitor. But Leighton promptly stepped forward, and kindly came to his rescue. It was curious that those three eminent artistic beings, Dickens, Leighton, and Irving, should have perished from outwearing their nervous systems, Leighton and Irving from heart-failure, Dickens from an overtaxed brain."

[88] "A Reminiscence," Leighton, 1896.

APPENDIX [ToC](#)

PRESIDENTIAL ADDRESS [ToC](#)

*Delivered by SIR F. LEIGHTON, Bart., P.R.A., at the Art Congress, held at
Liverpool, December 3rd, 1888.*

I cannot but feel that to some of my hearers, and to not a few of those who do not hear me, but whom the words spoken in this place may chance to reach through the Press, some brief explanation is, at the outset, due as to my occupancy of this chair. To them it is known that weighty reasons have for many years compelled me to decline all requests—and those requests have been frequent, urgent, and most gratifying to me in form and spirit—that I should publicly address audiences, beyond the walls of Burlington House, on the subject which is to occupy this Congress, the subject of Art. It is not without some compunction that I have followed this course, but the exigencies, on the one hand, of the duties of my office, and, on the other, a firm purpose, which you will not, I hope, rebuke, to remain always and before all things a working artist, have left to my too limited strength and powers no alternative but that which I have adopted. Nevertheless, I have felt justified in obeying the summons of the founders of this Congress—and

for this reason that, while the far-reaching character of the effort here initiated, and my earnest desire to contribute, in however small a measure, to whatever of good may flow from it have seemed to make it incumbent on me to accept the duty of saying a few words on this occasion, its comprehensive and national character lifts it into a category wholly apart from and outside the sphere of purely local interests such as those which I had hitherto been invited to support.

I trust I shall be pardoned this short obtrusion of private considerations, and that you will see in it not a movement of egotism but the discharge of a simple debt of courtesy; which said, let me address myself to the task imposed upon me—the task of showing cause and need for the existence of the association which inaugurates to-day its public work, and of arousing, if it is in my power, your efficient sympathy in that work, that it may not remain barren and without fruit. But here I am at once conscious of a perplexity lurking in your minds. "Why," I hear you ask, "should an organisation have been called into life for the sole purpose of considering in public matters relating to the development and spread of art in this country? What hitherto unfulfilled ends do you seek to achieve? Do you aim at the wider extension of artistic education in this country? But vast sums from the public purse are annually devoted to its promotion; schools of art multiply, one might almost say swarm, over the face of the land. Or do you tax the great municipal bodies of England with remissness on this score? But day by day efforts in this direction among the great provincial centres of trade and industry become more marked and effectual. No announcement more frequently meets our eyes than that of the opening, with due ceremony and circumstance, and seemingly with full recognition that the event is an important one, of spacious public galleries for the annual exhibition, or for the permanent housing, of works of contemporary art. Or does art find private individuals lacking in that noble spirit which so often prompts Englishmen to devote to the enjoyment and profit of their fellow-citizens a large share of the wealth gained by them in the pursuit of their avocations? But a great gallery of art which rises hard by across the road would shame and silence any such assertion. Or, again, can it be denied that what encouragement to artists is afforded by the purchase of innumerable pictures, at all events, was never more liberally meted out to them than within our generation, and does not the crowding of exhibitions, of which the name is legion, evince abundantly the responsive attitude of the country,

as far at least as one of the arts is concerned? Are not statues multiplying in our streets? Is not architecture, as an art, finding at this time increasing, if tardy, acceptance at the hands of private individuals? Is not a wholesome sense dawning among us that even a private dwelling should not offend, nay, should conciliate, the eye of the passer-by in our public thoroughfares? and lastly, has not a more than marked improvement taken place within our day in the character of all those intimate domestic surroundings which are the daily diet of our eyes, and should be daily their delight? Are these not facts patent to all, and do they not seem to cut from under your feet the ground on which you seek to stand?" Yes, all this and more may be said; and I should be blind as an observer—I should be ungrateful as one speaking in the name of artists—did I not recognise the force of these words which I have put into the mouth of an imaginary querist. I acknowledge with joy that there is in all these facts, and still more in their significance, much on which we may justly congratulate ourselves, much that points to a quickening consciousness, a stirring of slumbering æsthetic impulse, a receptive readiness, a growing malleability in the general temper, which promise well; and it is precisely such a condition of things which justifies our hope of good results from this Congress, and in it we find our best encouragement.

Well, what then is our charge in respect to the present relation of the country to art? What are the shortcomings for which we are here to seek a remedy? Our charge is that with the great majority of Englishmen the appreciation of art, as art, is blunt, is superficial, is desultory, is spasmodic; that our countrymen have no adequate perception of the place of art as an element of national greatness; that they do not count its achievements among the sources of their national pride; that they do not appreciate its vital importance in the present day to certain branches of national prosperity; that while what is excellent receives from them honour and recognition, what is ignoble and hideous is not detested by them, is, indeed, accepted and borne with a dull, indifferent acquiescence; that the æsthetic consciousness is not with them a living force, impelling them towards the beautiful, and rebelling against the unsightly. We charge that while a desire to possess works of art, but especially pictures, is very widespread, it is in a large number, perhaps in a majority of cases, not the essential quality of art that has attracted the purchaser to his acquisition; not the emanation of beauty in any one of its innumerable forms, but something outside and

wholly independent of art. In a word, there is, we charge, among the many in our country, little consciousness that every product of men's hands claiming to rank as a work of art, be it lofty in its uses and monumental, or lowly and dedicated to humble ends, be it a temple or a palace, the sacred home of prayer or a Sovereign's boasted seat, be it a statue or a picture, or any implement or utensil bearing the traces of an artist's thought and the imprint of an artist's finger—there is, I say, little adequate consciousness that each of these works is a work of art only on condition that, is a work of art exactly in proportion as, it contains within itself the precious spark from the Promethean rod, the divine fire-germ of living beauty; and that the presence of this divine germ ennobles and lifts into one and the same family every creation which reveals it; for even as the life-sustaining fire which streams out in splendour from the sun's molten heart is one with the fire which lurks for our uses in the grey and homely flint, so the vital flame of beauty is one and the same, though kindled now to higher and now to humbler purpose, whether it be manifest in the creations of a Phidias or of a Michael Angelo, of an Ictinus or of some nameless builder of a sublime cathedral; in a jewel designed by Holbein or a lamp from Pompeii, a sword-hilt from Toledo, a caprice in ivory from Japan or the enamelled frontlet of an Egyptian queen. We say, further, that the absence of this perception is fraught with infinite mischief, direct and indirect, to the development of art among us, tending, as it does, to divorce from it whole classes of industrial production, and incalculably narrowing the field of the influence of beauty in our lives. And with the absence of this true æsthetic instinct, we find not unnaturally the absence of any national consciousness that the sense of what is beautiful, and the manifestation of that sense through the language of art, adorn and exalt a people in the face of the world and before the tribunal of history; a national consciousness which should become a national conscience—a sense, that is, of public duty and of a collective responsibility in regard to this loveliest flower of civilisation.

Well, it is in the belief that the consciousness of which I have spoken is rather dormant with us than absent, waiting to be aroused rather than wholly wanting, that the founders of this Association have initiated the movement which has brought you together, and laid upon me the ungracious task to which I am now addressing myself—a task I have accepted in the hope that, at least, some good to others may come out of the wreck and ruin of any character for courtesy which may hitherto have been conceded to me.

But let us now look closer into my indictment; and let us, first, for a moment, and by way of getting at a standard, turn our thoughts to one or two of those races among which art has reached its highest level and round whose memory art has shed an inextinguishable splendour. Let us first consider the Greek race in the day of its greatest achievements and the most perfect balance of its transcendent gifts. What is it that impresses us most in the contemplation of the artistic activity of this race? It is, first, that the stirring æsthetic instinct, the impulse towards and absolute need of beauty, was universal with it, and lay, a living force, at the root of its emotional being; and, secondly, that the Greeks were conscious of this impulse as of a just source of pride and a sign of their supremacy among the nations. So saturated were they with it that whatever left their hands bore its stamp. Whatever of Greek work has been preserved to us, temple or statue, vessel or implement, is marked with the same attributes of stately and rhythmic beauty; in all their creations, from the highest to the lowest, one spirit lives, and whatever be the rank of each of these creations in the hierarchy of works of art, in one thing they are even-born and kin—in the spirit of loveliness. And of the dignity of this artistic instinct, which they regarded as their birthright, they were, as I have said, proudly conscious. Would you have an instance of this high consciousness? Here is one. At the end of the first year of the Peloponnesian war the Athenians having, according to ancestral custom, decreed a public funeral to those who had fallen in battle, Pericles, the son of Xanthippus, was chosen by them to speak the praises of the dead. It is a famous speech, that in which he obeyed their injunction, and it opens with a lofty eulogy of the Republic for which the heroes whom they mourned had fallen. In this magnificent song of praise he enumerates the virtues of the Athenians; he shows them heroic, wise, just, tolerant, *lovers of beauty*, philosophers—in all things foremost amongst men. Mark this! At a celebration of the most moving solemnity—in a breathing space between two acts of a gigantic international struggle for hegemony—you have here a great statesman enumerating the titles of his fellow-citizens to headship among the nations, and placing not at the end of his panegyric and as an oratorical embellishment, but in its very heart and centre, these words: "We love the beautiful."

But we may gain, perhaps, a yet more vivid sense of the extent to which the artistic impulse possessed and filled this people in the fascinating epitome of Grecian handicraft which is presented to us in Pompeii, or rather

in the Museo Nazionale at Naples. Here you have the work, not of Athenian Greeks, of the Periclean or of the Alexandrian age, but the work of provincial Greeks inhabiting a watering-place of no very great importance, in the first century of our era; a period as far removed from the days of the Parthenon sculptures as we are from the days of the Canterbury Tales. And what a display it is! How full of interest! Here we are admitted into the most intimate privacy of a multitude of Pompeian houses—the kitchens, the pantries, the cellars of the contemporaries of the Plinies have here no secret for us; indeed, for aught we know, more than one of those dinners of which that delicate *bon vivant*, the nephew of the naturalist, was so appreciative a judge may have been cooked in one of these very ranges, one of these ladles may have skimmed his soup, his quails may have been roasted on yonder spit. Nothing is wanting that goes to make the complete armament of a kitchen—stoves, cauldrons, vessels of every kind, lamps of every shape, forks, spoons, ladles of every dimension. And in all this mass of manifold material perhaps the most marked characteristic is not the high level of executive merit it reveals, high as that level is, but the amazing wealth of *idea*, the marvellous intellectual activity brought to bear on what we now call objects of industrial art—whatever that may mean—in this outpost of Greek civilisation. These accumulated appliances of the kitchen and the pantry form a museum of art—a museum of art of inexhaustible fascination; and not only does this vast collection of necessary things contain nothing ugly, but it displays, as I have just said, an amazing wealth of ideas; each bowl, each lamp, each spoon almost, is an individual work of art, a separate and distinct conception, a special birth of the joy of creation in a genuine artist. But, above all, let us bear this fact in mind—the *absence there of any ugly thing*; for the instinct of what is beautiful not only delights and seeks to express itself in lovely work, but forbids and banishes whatever is graceless and unsightly.

As next to the Greeks, and as almost their equals in this craving for the beautiful, the Italians will occur to you. And here it may be well to note, in a parenthesis, that a vivid sense of abstract beauty in line and form does not necessarily carry with it a keen perception of shapeliness in the human frame. This curious fact we see strikingly illustrated in a race which possesses the artistic instinct in certain of its developments in a greater degree than any other in our time—I mean the Japanese. With them the sense of decorative distribution and of subtle loveliness of form and colour

is absolutely universal, and expresses itself in every most ordinary appliance of daily life, overflowing, indeed, into every toy or trifle that may amuse an idle moment; and yet majesty and beauty in the human form are as absent from their works as from their persons. Be this said without prejudice to the fact that in the movement imparted by them to the figures in their designs there is often much of daintiness and dignity, the outcome of that keen perception of beauty of line in the abstract which we have seen to be dominant in them. I need not follow further this, I think, interesting train of thought, but the digression seemed to me useful, not as illustrating the fact that beauty is not to be regarded only in connection with the human form, which is a mere truism, but as showing that the abstract sense of it, in certain aspects, may possess and penetrate a race in which the perception of comeliness in the human body is almost entirely absent; and I meet by it also, in anticipation, certain objections that may suggest themselves to you in connection with the Italians, as far, at least, as the Tuscans are concerned; for in them, too, we find occasionally, side by side with an unsurpassed sense of the expressiveness of line and form, a defective perception of beauty in the human frame—witness the ungainly angularities, for instance, of a Verrocchio, a Gozzoli, a Signorelli.

The thirst for the artistically delightful was the mark in Italy of no particular class; it was common to all, high and low, to the Pontiff on his throne, to the trader behind his counter, to the people in the market-place. And here, again, observe that this desire was not alone for the adornment of walls and public places with painting and statuary—though every wall in every church or public building was, in fact, enriched by the hand of painters and of sculptors—but it embraced every humbler form of artistic expression, and was, indeed, especially directed to one which has in our time touched, here and there, a melancholy depth—the craft of the goldsmith. I said "humbler form" of art for lack of a better word; for a craft cannot fitly be called humble which has occupied and delighted men of the very highest gifts. Did not the mind that conceived the "Perseus" of the Loggia dei Lanzi pour out some of its richest fancies in a jewelled salt-cellar for the table of a Pope? Did not the sublimest genius that ever shone upon the world of art receive its first guidance in the workshop of a jeweller—a jeweller who was himself a painter also of high renown? For was it not that painter-goldsmith whose hands adorned with noble frescoes the famous choir of Sta. Maria Novella?

Now, to a cultured audience such as that which I am here addressing, these facts are familiar and trite, so trite and so familiar that it may, perhaps, be doubted whether their true significance has ever stood quite clearly before your minds, and whether you have fully grasped the solidarity of the arts—if I may use an outlandish expression—which at one time prevailed. Let us in imagination transfer the last quoted fact into contemporary life. Let us suppose that the municipality of a great English city, proud of its annals and of its culture, determined to decorate with paintings in some comprehensive manner the walls of a great public building; and suppose, further, that an artist, admittedly of the first rank, were to answer to its call from the workshop—and I say advisedly from the workshop, for it is there, and not on an armchair in the office, that the head of the house would have been found in the old day—suppose, I say, that such an artist came forth from some great firm of jewellers, in Bond Street for instance, we should have, on the artistic side, the exact parallel of the case of the Dominicans of Sta. Maria Nuova and Domenico, the son of Thomas the garland-maker of Florence. Meanwhile, striking as is this instance of the unity of art in long past days, it is but just to add, and I rejoice to be able here to do so, that signs are not wanting on the side of our own artists of a strong tendency towards a return to closer bonds between its various branches, in which direction, indeed, a movement has been for some years increasingly marked and practical; and it is with a glad outlook into the future, and with a sense of breathing a wider air, that I place by the side of the cases which I have just mentioned—cases which were, in their time, of natural and frequent occurrence—one which is of yesterday. The chief magistrate of an important provincial centre of English industry, the Mayor of Preston, wears at this time a chain of office which is a beautiful work of art, and this chain was not only designed but wrought throughout by the sculptor who modelled the stately commemorative statue of the Queen that adorns the County Square of Winchester, the artist who presides over the section of sculpture in this Congress, my young friend and colleague, Mr. Alfred Gilbert.

I have pointed to the Italians and the Greeks as culminating instances of people filled with a love of beauty and achieving the highest excellence in its embodiment, and I have named the Japanese as manifesting the æsthetic temper in a high degree of sensitiveness, but within certain limitations. It is not necessary to remind you that I might extend this list, if with some

qualification, and that the same lesson—the lesson that the nations which love beauty seek it in the humblest as well as the highest things—is taught us by others than those I have mentioned. Whosoever, for instance, has wondered at the work of Persian looms, or felt the fascination of the manuscripts illuminated by the artists of Iran, or noted the unfailing grace of subtle line revealed in their metal-work, will feel that for this race also the merit of a work of art did not reside in its category, but in the degree to which it manifested the spirit which alone could ennoble it, the spirit of beauty. And if, further, this dominant instinct of the beautiful is not in our own time found in any Western race in its fullest force, and among one Eastern people, with, as we saw, important limitations, there is yet one modern nation in our own hemisphere in which the thirst for artistic excellence is widespread to a degree unknown elsewhere in Europe; a people with whom the sense of the dignity of artistic achievement, as an element of national greatness, an element which it is the duty of its Government to foster and to further, and to proclaim before the world, is keen and constant; I mean, of course, your brilliant neighbours, the people of France. Here, then, are standards to which we may appeal to see how far, all allowance being made for many signs of improvement in things concerning art, we yet fall short, as a nation, of the ideal which we should have before us.

Let me now revert to my indictment. I said that the sense of abstract beauty with the mass of our countrymen—and once again I must be understood not to ignore, but only to leave out of view for the moment, the considerable and growing number of those in whom this sense is astir and active—with the mass, I repeat, of our countrymen, the perception of beauty is blunt, and the desire for it sluggish and superficial; with them the beautiful is, indeed, sometimes a source of vague, half-conscious satisfaction, especially when it appeals to them conjointly with other incitements to emotion, but their perception of it is passive, and does not pass into active desire; it accepts, it does not demand; it is uncertain of itself, for it lacks definiteness of intuition, and having no definite intuition, it is necessarily uncritical. This weakness, among the many, of the critical faculty in æsthetic matters, and the curious bluntness of their perceptions, is seen not in connection with the plastic arts only, but over the whole artistic field, in the domains of music and the drama, as in that of painting and sculpture. Who, for instance, where a body of English men and women has

been gathered together in a concert room, has not, at one moment, heard a storm of applause go up to meet some matchless executant of noble music, and then, five minutes later, watched in wonder and dismay the same crepitation of eager hands proclaiming an equal satisfaction with the efforts of some feeblest servant of Apollo? Or have you not often, in your theatres, blushed to see the lowest buffoonery received with exuberant delight by an audience—and a cultivated audience—which had just before not seemed insensible to some fine piece of histrionic art? And what could proclaim the lack of true, spontaneous instinct in more startling fashion than the notorious fact that the most thrilling touch of pathos in the performance of an actor reputed to be comic will be infallibly received with a titter by a British audience, which has paid to laugh and come to the play focussed for the funny?

Now this little glimpse into the attitude of the public in regard to other arts than ours has its bearing upon our present subject. This same feebleness of the critical sense which arises out of the indefiniteness—to say the best of it—of the inner standard of artistic excellence, is not unnaturally accompanied by and fosters an apathy in regard to that excellence, and an attitude of callous acquiescence in the unsightly, which are inexpressibly mischievous; for you cannot too strongly print this on your minds, that what you demand that will you get, and according to what you accept will be that which is provided for you. Let an atmosphere be generated among you in which the appetite for what is beautiful and noble is whetted and becomes imperative, in which whatever is ugly and vulgar shall be repugnant and hateful to the beholder, and assuredly what is beautiful and noble will, in due time, be furnished to you, and in steadily increasing excellence, satisfying your taste, and at the same time further purifying it and heightening its sensitiveness.

The enemy, then, is this indifference in the presence of the ugly; it is only by the victory over this apathy that you can rise to better things, it is only by the rooting out and extermination of what is ugly that you can bring about conditions in which beauty shall be a power among you. Now, this callous tolerance of the unsightly, although it is, I am grateful to think, yielding by degrees to a healthier feeling, is still strangely prevalent and widespread among us, and its deadening influence is seen in the too frequent absence of

any articulate protest of public opinion against the disfigurement of our towns.

Let me give you an instance of this indifference. Our country is happy in possessing a collection of paintings by the old masters of exceptional interest and splendour, a collection which, thanks to the taste and highly trained discernment of its present accomplished head, Sir Frederick Burton, is, with what speed the short-sighted policy of successive Governments permits, rising steadily to a foremost place among the famous galleries in the world. Some years ago, the building destined to receive it being found no longer adequate, it became necessary to provide, by some means, ampler space for the display of the national treasure. It was resolved that another edifice should take the place of that designed by Wilkins, an edifice which, be it said in passing, has been made the butt of curiously unmerited ridicule in the world of connoisseurship, and which, apart from certain very obvious blemishes, it has always seemed to me to be much easier to deride than to better. A competition was opened, and designs were demanded for a spacious building, equal to present and future needs, and worthy of the magnificence of the collection it was to house. It is hardly necessary to say that we have here no concern whatever with the controversy which arose over these designs. My concern is with its final outcome, which is this: the original building has remained unaltered as to its exterior; but on the rear of one of its flanks loom now into view, first, an appendage in an entirely different style of architecture, and further on, an excrescence of no style of architecture at all; the one an Italian tower, the other a flat cone of glass, surmounted by a ventilator—a structure of the warehouse type—the whole resulting in a jarring jumble and an aspect of chaotic incongruity which would be ludicrous if it were not distressing; and we enjoy, further, this instructive phenomenon that a public opinion which sensitively shrank from the blemishes of the original edifice has accepted its retention, with all those blemishes unmodified, *plus* an appendage which adds to the whole the worst almost of all sins architectural—a lack of unity of conception. Now, I have never to my knowledge heard one single word of articulate public reprobation levelled at this now irremediable blot on what we complacently call the finest site in the world; and yet I cannot find it in me to believe that many have not, like myself, groaned in spirit before a spectacle so deplorable—a spectacle which, indeed, is only conceivable within these islands. I think that a good deal is summed up in this episode,

and I need not, for my present purpose, seek another in the domain of architecture.

In regard to sculpture, the public apathy and blindness are yet more depressing and complete, and illustrate the deadness of the many to the perception of the essential qualities of art. To the overwhelming majority of Englishmen sculpture means simply the perpetuation of the form of Mr. So-and-So in marble, bronze, or terra-cotta—this, and no more. That marble, bronze, or terra-cotta may, under cunning hands, become vehicles, for those who have eyes to see, of emotions, æsthetic and poetic, not less lofty than those which are stirred in us by the verse of a Dante or a Milton, or by strains of noblest music, of this the consciousness is for practical purposes non-existent. For sculpture, for an art through which alone the name of Greece would have been famous for all time, there is, outside portraiture, even now, under conditions admittedly improved, little or no field in this country. Portrait-statues galore bristle, indeed, within our streets; but the notion of setting up in public places pieces of monumental sculpture solely for adornment and dignity, or of monuments that shall remind us of deeds in which our country or our town has earned fame and deserved gratitude, and incite the young to emulation of those deeds, or that shall be the allegorised expression of any great idea—and yet our race has had great ideas, and clothed them in deeds as great—hardly ever, it would seem, enters the heads of a people whose aspirations are surely not less noble or less high than those of other nations. Nay, even a monument commemorative of the great public services of some individual man which shall be a monument *to* him rather than exclusively an image *of* him, a monument of which his effigy shall form a part, but of which the main feature shall be the embodiment or illustration, in forms of art, of the virtues that have earned for him the homage of his countrymen—even this is suggested in vain.

And if we are tolerant of treason against fitness in architecture, what shall we say of our tolerance in regard to its sculptural adornments? What shall we say of the complacent acceptance, above and about windows and doorways in clubs, offices, barracks, and the like buildings, of carven wonders such as no other civilised community would accept in silence? Though I fear I must here, with all deference, add that my brethren, the architects, who suffer their work to be so defaced, are themselves not wholly blameless; and indeed, it is a truth in the assertion of which the most

enlightened workmen in every branch of art will stand by me, that among ourselves also the sense of the kinship of the arts is too often a mere theory, received, no doubt, with respect as an abstract proposition, but not perceptibly colouring our practical activity.

In sculpture the inertness of demand and tolerance of inferior supply is due mainly to the want, to which I have alluded, of a sense of and a joy in the purely æsthetic quality in artistic production, an insensibility to the power inherent in form, by its own virtue, of producing the emotion and exciting the imagination, a power on which the dignity of this pure and severe art does or should mainly rest.

In the appreciation of painting, which on various grounds appeals as an art to a far wider public than either architecture or sculpture, the same shortcomings are evident, though in a less degree, and with less mischievous results; for the witchery of colour, at least, is felt and appreciated, more or less consciously, by a very large number of people. The inadequacy of the general standard of artistic insight is here seen in the fact that to a great multitude of persons the attractiveness of a painted canvas is in proportion to the amount of literary element which it carries, not in proportion to the degree of æsthetic emotion stirred by it, or of appeal to the imagination contained in it—persons, those, who regard a picture as a compound of anecdote and mechanism, and with whom looking at it would seem to mean only another form of reading. Time after time, in listening to the description—the enthusiastic description—of a picture, we become aware that the points emphasised by the speaker are such as did not specially call for treatment in art at all, were often not fitted for expression through form or colour, their natural vehicle being not paint but ink, which is the proper and appointed conveyor of abstract thoughts and concrete narrative. I have heard pictures extolled as works of genius simply because they expressed, not because they nobly clothed in forms of art, ideas not beyond the reach of the average penny-a-liner.

Now I know that in what I am here saying I skirt the burning ground of controversy long and hotly waged—skirt it only, for that controversy touches but the borders of my subject, and I shall of course not pursue it here. I will, nevertheless, to avoid misrepresentation in either sense, state, as briefly as I can, one or two definite principles on which it appears to me safe to stand. It is given to form and to colour to elicit in men powerful and

exquisite emotions, emotions covering a very wide range of sensibility, and to which they alone have the key. The chords within us which vibrate to these emotions are the instrument on which art plays, and a work of art deserves that name, as I have said, in proportion as, and in the extent to which, it sets those chords in motion. The power and solemnity of a simple appeal of form as such is seen in a noble building of imposing mass and stately outlines. When, however, form in arts is connected with the human frame, and when combinations of human forms are among the materials with which a beautiful design is built up, then another element is added to the sum of our sensations—an element due to the absorbing interest of man in all that belongs to his kind; and the emotion primarily produced by the force of a purely æsthetic appeal is enhanced and heightened by elements of a more intimate and universal order, one more nearly touching our affections, but not, therefore, necessarily of a higher order. Thus the episode, for instance, of Paolo and Francesca, clothed in the rare, grave melody of Dante's verse, entrances us with its pathos; but our emotion, intensely human as it is, is not therefore of a higher kind than that which holds us as we listen to sounds sublimely woven by some great musician; nor are the impressions received in watching from the floor of some great Christian church the gathering of the gloom within a dome's receding curves of less noble order than those aroused by a supreme work of sculpture or a painting—by, say, the "Notte" of Michael Angelo or the "Monna Lisa" of Lionardo; and yet in both of these last the chord of human sympathy is strongly swept, though in different ways—in the "Notte" by the poetic and pathetic suggestiveness of certain forms and movements of the human body; in the "Monna Lisa" by a more definitely personal charm and feminine sorcery which haunts about her shadowy eyes, and the subtle curling of her mysterious lips.

I say, then, that in a work of art the elements of emotion based on human sympathies are not of a loftier order than those arising out of abstract sublimity or loveliness of form, but that the presence of these elements in such a work, while not raising it as an artistic creation, does impart to it an added power of appeal, and that, therefore, a work in which these elements are combined will be with the great majority of mankind a more potent engine of delight than one which should rest exclusively on abstract qualities. And it follows, therefore, that while a work of art earns its title to that name on condition only, once again I say, of the purely æsthetic

element being present in it, and will rank as such in exact proportion to the degree in which this element prevails in it; and while, further, this element, carrying with it, as it does, imaginative suggestiveness of the highest order and of the widest scope, is all-sufficient in those branches of art in which the human form plays no part, the element which is inseparable in a work of art from the introduction of human beings is one which it is not possible for us to ignore in our appreciation of that work as a source and vehicle of emotion.

Every attempt at succinct exposition of a complex question risks being unsatisfactory and obscure, and I am painfully alive to the inadequacy of what I have just said. I trust, however, that I have conveyed my meaning, if roughly, yet sufficiently to shield me from misconception in regard to the special emphasis I am laying on the importance of a proper estimation of the essentially æsthetic quality in a work of art, an importance which I urge upon you, not so much here on account of the effect its absence may have exercised on the development of painting, as on account of the significant fact that its want—the lack of a perception that certain qualities are the very essence of art, and link into one great family every work of the hands of men in which they are found—has led with us to a disastrous divorce between what is considered as art proper and the arts which are called industrial. I say advisedly "disastrous," for the lowering among us in the present day of the status of forms of art, in the service of which such men as Albert Dürer, for example, and Holbein (men, by-the-by, of kindred blood with ourselves), Cellini and Lionardo, were glad to labour and create—and that not as a concession, but in the joyful exercise of their fullest powers—is one of its results, and carrying with it, as is natural, a lowering of standard in these arts, has generated the marvellous notion, not expressed in words, but too largely acted on, that art in any serious sense is not to be looked for at all in certain places—where, in truth, alas! neither is it often found—and led to the holding aloof to a great extent, until comparatively recent years, of much of the best talent from very delightful forms of artistic creation; and this notion has led further to the virtual banishment from certain provinces of designing of the human figure, or where it is not banished, to its defacement, too often, in the hands of the untrained or the inept.

We are to a wonderful degree creatures of habit, our thoughts are prone to run—or shall I say rather to stagnate?—within grooves; and if we are a people of many and great endowments, a swift and free play of thought is, as we have been forcibly told by a voice that we shall hear no more, and can ill miss, not a distinguishing feature among us. Is it not an amazing thing, for example, that human shapes, which in clay or plaster would be ignominiously excluded from a second-rate exhibition, are not only accepted, but displayed with a chuckle of elated pride, when cast in the precious metals, flanked, say by a palm-tree, borne aloft on a rock, and presented in the guise of a piece of ornamental plate? But is this even rare? Is it not of constant occurrence? Do you demur? Well, let me ask you a plain question: Of all the nymphs and goddesses, the satyrs, and the tritons, that disport themselves on the ceremonial goldsmithery of the United Kingdom, how many if cast in vulgar plaster, and not in glittering gold, would pass muster before the jury of an average exhibition? And if few, I ask why is this so? In the name of Cellini—nay, in the name of common sense, why? And is it on account of the low ebb of figure modelling for decorative purposes that on our carved furniture—what we mysteriously describe as "art furniture"—the human form is hardly ever seen? Then why is the best talent not enlisted in this work? Certain it is that the absence of living forms imparts to much of the furniture now made in England, unsurpassed as it is in regard to delicacy and finish of handiwork, and frequently elegant in design, a certain look of slightness and flimsy, faddy dilettantism which prevent it from taking that rank in the province of applied art in which it might and should aspire.

But I have, I fear, already unduly drawn upon your patience, and I must bring to a close these too disjointed prefatory words, leaving it to the accomplished gentlemen who head the various sections of this Congress to amplify and enrich as they will out of the wide fund of their knowledge and experience the bald outline I have sketched before you. They, in their turn, taking up, no doubt, our common parable, will emphasise and press on you the fact that by cultivating its æsthetic sense in a more comprehensive and harmoniously consistent spirit than hitherto, and with a clearer vision of the nature of all art and a more catholic receptiveness as to its charms, and by stimulating in a right direction the abundant productive energy which lies to its hand, this nation will not only be adding infinitely to the adornment and dignity of its public and private life, not only providing for itself an

increasing and manifold source of delight and renovating repose, mental and spiritual, in a day in which such resting and regenerating elements are more and more called for by our jaded nervous systems, and more and more needed for our intellectual equilibrium, but will be dealing with a subject which is every day becoming more and more important in relation to certain sides of the waning material prosperity of the country. For, as they will no doubt remind you, the industrial competition between this and other countries—a competition, keen and eager, which means to certain industries almost a race for life—runs, in many cases, no longer exclusively or mainly on the lines of excellence of material and solidity of workmanship, but greatly nowadays on the lines of artistic charm and beauty of design. This, to you, vital fact is one which they will, I am convinced, not suffer to fall into the background.

One last word in anticipation of certain objections not unlikely to be raised against an assumption which may seem to be implied in the existence of our Association—the assumption that the evils and shortcomings of which I have spoken with such unsparing frankness can be removed or remedied by the gathering together of a number of persons to listen to a series of addresses. The causes of these evils, we may be told, and their antidote, are not on the surface of things, but rest on conditions of a complex character, and are fundamental. "Who," I hear some one say, "is this dreamer of dreams, who hopes to cure by talking such deep-seated evils? Who is this shallow and unphilosophical thinker who does not see that the same primary conditions are operative in making the purchaser indifferent what he gets and the supplier indifferent to what he produces, and who attributes the circumstance that good work is not generally produced in certain forms of industry to the lack of demand, rather than to the deeper-lying fact that suppliers and demanders are of the same stock, having the same congenital failings; and satisfied with the same standards?" My answer to this imaginary, or I ought, perhaps, to say this foreseen objector would be, first, this—that I am not the visionary for whom he takes me, and that I do not believe in the efficacy of words either directly to remedy the state of things I have been deploring, or to create a love of art and a delicate sensitiveness to its charms in those to whom the responsive chords have been refused; neither is the eloquence, trumpet-toned and triumphant, conceivable by me before which the walls of the Jericho of the Philistine shall crumble in abrupt ruin to the ground; least of all do I believe

in sudden developments of the human intellect. But it has nevertheless seemed to me, as it has seemed to the framers of this Association, that words, if they be judicious and sincere, may rally and strengthen and prompt to action instincts and impulses which only await a signal to assert themselves—instincts, sometimes, perhaps, not fully conscious of themselves—and that a favouring temperature may be thus created within which, by the operation of natural laws, in due time, but by no stroke of the wand, a new and better order may arise. Neither, indeed, do I ignore the force of my critic's contention that the causes of mischief lie deep, and are not to be touched by surface-tinkering, if they are to be removed at all; although I demur to his pessimistic estimate of them as a final bar to our hopes. It is true that certain specific attributes are, or seem to be, feeble in our race; it is true, too true—I have it on the repeated assurance of apologetic vendors—that with us the ugliest objects—often, oh! how ugly—have the largest market; nevertheless, the amount of good artistic production in connection with industry—I purposely speak of this first—has grown within the last score or so of years, and through the initiative, mind, of a mere handful of enthusiastic and highly gifted men in an extraordinary degree; and in a proportionate degree has the number increased, also, of those who accept and desire it; and this growth has been steady and organic, and is of the best augury. Now, the increase in the number of those who desire good work, and the concurrent development of their critical sensitiveness in matters of taste, stimulate, in their turn, the energies, and sustain the upward efforts, of the producers, and thus, through action and reaction, a condition of things should be slowly but surely evolved which shall more nearly approach that general level of artistic culture and artistic production so anxiously looked for by us all. It is in the hastening of this desired result that we invoke, not your sympathy alone, but your patient, strenuous aid. And if I am further asked how, in my view, this association can best contribute to the furtherance of our common end, I would say, not merely by seeking to fan and kindle a more general interest in the things of art, but mainly by seeking to awaken a clearer perception of the true *essence* of a work of art, by insisting on the fundamental identity of all manifestations of the artistic creative impulse through whatever channels it may express itself, and by setting forth and establishing this pregnant truth—that whatever degrees of dignity and rank may exist in the scale of artistic productions, according to the order of emotion to which they

minister in us, they are in one kind; for the various and many channels through which beauty is made manifest to us in art are but the numerous several stops of one and the same divine instrument.

And if in what I have said I have laid especial stress on that branch of art which is called industrial, it is not solely to develop this cardinal doctrine, neither only because of the pressing, practical, paramount national importance of this part of our subject, but also because I, in truth, believe that it is in a great measure through these very forms of art that the improvement, to which I look with a steadfast faith, will be mainly operated. The almost unlimited area which they cover in itself constitutes them an engine of immense power, and I believe that through them, if at all, the sense of beauty and the love for it will be stimulated in, and communicated to, constantly increasing numbers. I believe that the day may come when public opinion, thus slowly but definitely moulded, will make itself loudly heard; when men will insist that what they do for the gracing and adornment of their homes shall be done also for the public buildings and thoroughfares of their cities; when they will remind their municipal representatives and the controllers of their guilds of what similar bodies of men did for the cities of Italy in the days of their proud prosperity in trade, and will ask why the walls of our public edifices are blank and silent, instead of being adorned and made delightful with things beautiful to see, or eloquent of whatever great deeds or good work enrich and honour the annals of the places of our birth. And lastly, I believe that an art desired by the whole people and fostered by the whole people's desire would reflect—for such art must be sincere—some of the best qualities of our race; its love of Nature, its imaginative force, its healthfulness, its strong simplicity.

And now, ladies and gentlemen, my task is ended. My duties to-night were purely prefatory; my words are but the prologue of the proceedings which begin to-morrow—a prologue which I undertook to speak less from any faith in its possible efficacy than in the belief that the first word spoken at such a time should be heard from the lips of one to whom, from the nature of the office he is privileged to fill, as well as from the whole bent of his mind, everything that concerns art, from end to end of its enchanting field, must be, and is, a source of deep, of constant, and engrossing interest. The curtain is now raised, the stage is spread before you, and I step aside to make room for others, leaving with you the expression of my fervent wish

that the hopes which have brought us together in this place may not have been entertained in vain.

LORD LEIGHTON'S HOUSE [ToC](#)

AND WHAT IT CONTAINS [89](#)

PREFACE TO CATALOGUE

Two miles and a quarter from Hyde Park Corner, removed but a few steps from the main thoroughfare between London and Hammersmith, and running parallel to it, is Holland Park Road, facing which stands Lord Leighton's House. "I live in a mews," he used to say. This meant more than a figure of speech merely, though the "mews" in question is very different from a London street mews. Low, odd-shaped, irregular buildings, formerly stables (a few are still used as such), were in Lord Leighton's life converted into studios by artists who wished to cluster around the President of the Royal Academy. These stand in old gardens and are studded at intervals along the road, bordered by trees branching across it, and taking away all idea of its being a London street. Screened by a hedge of closely-cut lime-trees, the Leighton House stands back but a few yards from the pavement. Through a porch and a small outer hall the House is entered. Monsieur Choisy, the distinguished French architect, in his letter to the *Times* of April the 27th, 1896, written with the view of trying to induce the English nation to rise to the value of preserving this House as a national treasure, writes as follows:—

"Allow me also to point out the original beauty of the house where so many masterpieces are grouped. The French public have been enabled to admire this house through the excellent article of my friend and fellow-member of the R.I.B.A., Mr. Charles Lucas.

"Nowhere have I found in an architectural monument a happier gradation of effects nor a more complete knowledge of the play of light.

"The entrance to the house is by a plain hall that leads to a 'patio,' lit from the sky, where enamels shine brilliantly in the full light; from this 'patio' one passes into a twilight corridor, where enamel and gold detach themselves from an architectural ground of a richness somewhat severe; it is a transition which prepares the eye for a jewel of Oriental art, where the most brilliant productions of the Persian potter are set in an architectural frame inspired by Arab art, but treated freely; the harmony is so perfect that one asks oneself if the architecture has been conceived for the enamels or the enamels for the hall. This gradation, perhaps unique in contemporary architecture, was Leighton's idea; and the illustrious painter found in his old friend Mr. G. Aitchison, who built his house, a worthy interpreter of his fine conception. This hall where colour is triumphant, was dear to Leighton, and even forms the background to some of his pictures. Towards the end of his life he still meant to embellish it by substituting marble for that small part that was only painted. The generous employment of his fortune alone prevented him from realising his intention.

"England has at all times given the example of honouring great men; she will, I am sure, find the means of preserving for art a monument of which she had such reason to be proud."

As is now well known, Lord Leighton's executrixes, his two sisters, have assigned the lease of the property, which has sixty-six years yet to run, to three gentlemen who are members of the committee formed to preserve it for the use and education of the public, in memory of Lord Leighton, and the committee are now tenants at will of the proprietors. Works by Lord Leighton have been collected and placed in the studios and other rooms of the House. A large collection of his drawings and sketches and a few finished paintings have been secured through the generosity of his sisters, Mrs. Sutherland Orr, Mrs. Matthews, and his personal friends, the list of these being headed by the Prince of Wales. This collection of original works numbers 1114, 594 being now framed and hung on the walls. The collection also contains 28 proof engravings from Lord Leighton's principal pictures, presented by those who own the copyrights, *i.e.* Mrs. James Watney (who has also given an original drawing), the Fine Arts Society, the Berlin Photographic Company, Messrs. Agnew, Graves, Colnaghi, and Tooth.

There are also 112 photographic reproductions by Mr. F. Hollyer and Messrs. Dixon, these, with a few exceptions, having been taken for Lord Leighton in his studio. The greater number of these photographs were given to the House by Mr. Wilfred Meynell, Mr. F. Hollyer, and Messrs. Dixon; the remainder by Lord Davey, Sir Henry Acland, Mr. A. Henderson, Mr. Philipson, Mr. A.G. Temple, and Mr. George Smith. The reproductions of completed pictures have been hung on the walls together with the sketches executed for them, in order that the student may realise how Leighton developed the designs he made into finished pictures. When funds permit, the 520 remaining drawings and sketches will be framed, and it is the desire of the committee that, though the Leighton House should always remain the chief centre of the collections, groups of sketches should be lent to exhibitors in the provinces and in the poorer parts of London. In the middle of the centre hall is now placed a reproduction presented by Mr. Brock, R.A., of the bust of Lord Leighton, executed by his sculptor friend—that perfect likeness in bronze of the President placed among the Diploma works in Burlington House. Surrounding this reproduction and lining the walls and staircase are plaques of Oriental designs, pictures in enamel, framed in by a background of Mr. William De Morgan's beautiful blue tiles.^[90] The same treatment is continued through the "twilight corridor" leading to the great casket of treasures known as the Arab Hall. In the summer of 1899 the Society of the Library Association was received at the Leighton House, and at the meeting which preceded the conversazione, Lord Crawford, President of the Association, ended the speech he made on the merits and rare gifts of his friend, Lord Leighton, by a reference to the unique value of this casket of treasures. "We often," he said, "see Persian tiles in England. They are chiefly made in England, but they are bought in Persia! A genuine Persian tile is a very rare thing. When you meet it, cherish it!" In this Arab Hall hundreds of these "rare" things are collected, each individually of a quality of uncommon beauty and almost priceless, owing to the fact that large spaces on the walls are filled with these gorgeous tiles, fitted together as originally designed and intended by the Persian artists who invented them. Travellers who went to the East when there was still a chance of buying genuine Persian tiles know how it came about that these could sometimes be procured. The owners of the houses on the walls of which they were placed would become impoverished and were easily induced to sell a single tile to a traveller as a specimen. When the money paid for it was spent and

more was wanted, if a second traveller came by another single tile was sold. The first purchaser might have been an Englishman, the second a Frenchman, the third a German, and so on. In this way the several tiles making one design got hopelessly dispersed. Lord Leighton, aided by his friend, Sir C. Purdon Clarke, the Director of the Art Museum, South Kensington, was extraordinarily lucky in obtaining large plaques of tiles intact. "During his visits to Rhodes, to Cairo, and to Damascus," writes Mr. George Aitchison, R.A., "he made a lovely collection of Saracenic tiles, and had, besides, bought two inscriptions, one of the most delicate colour and beautiful design, and the other about sixteen feet long and strikingly magnificent; besides getting some panels, stained glass, and lattice-work from Damascus afterwards; these were fitted into an Arab Hall in 1877." The enamelled tiles made the keynote of this beautiful creation, the Arab Hall, which, to repeat Mr. Choisy's words, forms a harmony "so perfect that one asks oneself if the architecture has been conceived for the enamels or the enamels for the Hall." Round three sides (the fourth being filled by the large inscription) runs a frieze in mosaics, the designs of which are among the most beautiful of those invented by our great English decorator, Walter Crane. Sir C. Purdon Clarke has designated this creation of Lord Leighton's, in which he was so ably assisted by his friend, Mr. George Aitchison, R.A., President of the Royal Society of British Architects, and in which is to be traced that generous delight which Leighton took in all that was good in the art of his contemporaries, as "the most beautiful structure which has been raised since the sixteenth century." It would, alone, make the preservation of the House as an effective medium for education in the beautiful a necessity to any truly art-loving people.

To turn to the collection of Leighton's own paintings, the most complete work secured is the "Clytemnestra from the battlements of Argos watches for the beacon fires that are to announce the return of Agamemnon" (No. 212).

Mr. G.F. Watts, R.A., writes: "I am more pleased than I can say that the picture is possible. It is very fine, a grand pictorial realisation of Greek sculpture and Greek poetry, very noble in form and expression, and singularly fine in the arrangement of drapery. Certainly a better example of Leighton at his happiest could not, I think, be found. It is also *especially* Leighton."

Mr. Watts has himself presented a finished painting by Leighton—a half-length figure of a man, which is an exquisite piece of work and given to Mr. Watts many years ago by the artist. When presenting it to the House Mr. Watts wrote that it was one of his possessions which he prized the most. Though the collection in Lord Leighton's House is mainly formed of his drawings, the few finished paintings and the several oil sketches of landscape belonging to it are sufficient to show how exquisite was his native sense of colour. The colour in "Clytemnestra" (No. 212) is both true to nature as a presentiment of the moonlight effect and to the dramatic feeling of the subject. The study (No. 110), for one of the heads in "Summer Moon" (No. 272), presented by Mr. Alfred Waterhouse, R.A., and executed actually by the light of the moon in Rome, is notably fine in texture and gives us the origin of that curiously happy note of colour in "Clytemnestra"—the bar of dull red cooled by moonlight. The model wore a scarlet ribbon, or might be, a row of coral beads round her neck while sitting to Leighton for the study, and this evidently gave him what he wanted, and suggested, when he was painting the "Clytemnestra" two years later, the contrast to the greys and blues in the red bar in this picture. Mr. A.G. Temple in his valuable work, "The Art of Painting in the Queen's Reign," alludes to this effect: "A picture *low in key*, but curiously strengthened by the massive bar of dark red that runs from the bottom to the top of the picture." Very fine colour and texture is seen in the sketch for a design of "St. George and the Dragon" made for some arched space (No. 115), and also in the small oil sketch for "Golden Hours" (No. 5-A), the study for the background of the picture "David" (No. 111), "A pool, Findhorn River" (No. 120), "Rocks in the Findhorn" (No. 123a), "Kynance Cove" (No. 125), "A View in Spain" (No. 122), "Simætha, the Sorceress" (No. 124), "Bay of Naples by Moonlight" (No. 112), are rapid though eminently careful sketches which prove, perhaps even more convincingly than highly-finished works, that in the very grain of his native art instinct was Leighton's delight in beauty of colour. In the sketch (No. 109), "The Entrance of a House," is one of many examples among his paintings which show what a master he was in the art of painting white; really true white, such as we see in marble and whitewashed walls in Greece, Sicily, and Italy. Surely no artist has ever painted more truly or poetically the quality of Southern light as it falls on white walls and columns. "Lieder ohne Worte"

is one of several examples of a successful treatment of white marble as a background painted as Leighton could paint it.

It is indeed to be hoped that Leighton's friends who possess any of those oil paintings of landscape, sea, and architecture which lined the walls of the great studio during his life may help in aiding to make his gifts as a colourist more adequately represented in this permanent collection. The above-named works are, one and all, good specimens for the purpose. Whatever key of colour was struck, each of these studies from nature is a faithful and beautiful record of a scene in some lovely part of the world; whether the scene was fair and bathed in southern sunlight, or glowing in rich depths of shadow as in the paintings of the golden-lined interior of St. Mark's, Venice, further enriched by the scintillating texture of mosaic surface.

Leighton's early education, however, especially when he was in Germany, tended more to the development of his gifts as a draughtsman than to his gifts as a colourist; still it is evident that as soon as he began working independently of any master, his love of colour at once asserted itself. At the age of twenty-five his first picture, "The Cimabue Procession" (No. 42), was exhibited at the Royal Academy and purchased by the Queen. Mr. Ruskin criticised it at the time as the work of a *colourist*. "This is a very important and very beautiful picture," he writes. "It has both sincerity and grace, and is painted on the purest principles of Venetian art.... The great secret of the Venetians was their simplicity. They were great colourists." (See Catalogue for full quotation.) A lengthy description of Leighton's complete pictures would not find an appropriate place in this preface. Those who had the good fortune to see the wonderful collection of his works in 1897 will hardly need to be reminded of the rich and glowing feast of colour enjoyed before such pictures as "Helios and Rhodos," painted 1869 (studies in Collections No. 218), nor the depth and beauty in "Weaving the Wreath"(No. 144), "Antique Juggling Girl" (No. 359), "Moorish Garden: a Dream of Granada" (No. 280), not to mention the splendour and harmony in many of the larger and more intricate compositions. No less beautiful, it will be remembered, was the colouring of pictures in which the scheme was light and fair rather than rich and glowing. In "Winding the Skein" (No. 198), for instance, there is a feeling of morning freshness in its lovely sea and mountain background and white-marble terrace foreground. Though

cool and pale the picture is full of colour. Again, in the slightly-turning figure of Psyche, now in the Tate Gallery (No. 59), the exquisite, pearly fairness of flesh tint must ever make this picture a standard of colour as well as of modelling. In its own line it is an achievement in painting that has surely never been surpassed. Almost equally beautiful is the passage in "Venus Disrobing for the Bath" (No. 151), where the line of the figure comes against the sea background. Leighton's native genius might perhaps be most truly described as one allied closely to, and echoing, that of the Greeks in Art, though trained, during a few important years of study, in Germany. The work of his great contemporaries, Rossetti, Millais, and Burne-Jones, might be described as revealing Italian, English, and Celtic sentiment, influenced by the fervour of pre-Raphaelite feeling. Leighton's genius as a colourist will probably be ever more and more appreciated as a partial allegiance to those three great colourists subsides as a fashion merely.

It is quite clear, from the evidence of the earliest studies, that the extraordinary facility evinced in Lord Leighton's drawings was the outcome of natural gifts. No one can study his art without realising very conclusively that he spared neither time nor trouble in order to make it as perfect as it was in his power to make it; but equally evident is it to those who examine his work with artistic and intelligent insight that the great power that he possessed for taking pains was inspired by a joyous, sensitive delight in beauty. The untiring industry which alone could have produced the unparalleled amount of work which he has left was clearly never weighted by any feeling that the toil of study was irksome. On the contrary there is, in every stroke, evidence that a fine delicate sense of beauty, a fervent, spontaneous "sincerity of emotion" (to use Leighton's own expression) was ever present, instigating and propelling the conscientious persistency of his efforts. Whether it be a flower, a face, a figure, a landscape, or but a piece of drapery—there is in every sketch in this collection that convincing stamp on the work which proves that the doing of it interested and delighted the artist; the test, in other words, that the work has in it the true fibre of the most genuine art. It is well to draw attention to this fact, because his abnormal industry has apparently been considered by some to be a sign of his having been deficient in rare and native art instincts. Some there are who hold that the most notable characteristic in Leighton's nature was an extraordinary power of will. That he exercised such a power is undoubtedly

true. In no other manner could he have achieved the main purposes of his life, but surely those who knew him best, and who were in the position best to appreciate his art, would say rather that such an exercise of will was used in the service of a still more powerful ingredient, in the truly leading passion of his life, the moving motive of all his labours, *i.e.* a reverent worship of beauty. Much has been said and written,—even, strange to say, with respect to the great exhibition of his works exhibited at Burlington House in the winter of 1897,—which implies that the scholarly element outweighed the qualities resulting from natural gifts. Happily, the unprejudiced mind of the widest public was not deluded into sparing its praise by unappreciative or unintelligent criticism. Those who had not the opportunity at the Burlington House Exhibition of judging for themselves of the very great qualities Lord Leighton's art possesses, have but to study the collection of drawings in his house in order to realise that his gifts as an artist were as rare and native as was the intellect and splendour of nature which made his personality one of the most striking of his era.

A strong dramatic power is shown in many of Leighton's early designs, and the best examples of these have been secured for this national collection. Of the "Plague in Florence" (project for a picture), a notable example, there is a photograph by Mr. Fred Hollyer (No. 175), taken for Lord Leighton, the original sketch being in South Kensington Museum. The evidence of this power recurs at intervals in the later work in such pictures as "Heracles struggling with Death for the Body of Alcestis" (No. 54), "Electra at the Tomb of Agamemnon" (No. 7), (in this picture the colour carries out the imaginative and truly-felt dramatic instinct with singular power and beauty), "Orpheus and Eurydice" (No. 236), "St. Jerome," "The Last Watch of Hero" (No. 28), "Rizpah" (No. 193), and in the last work exhibited in the Royal Academy after Lord Leighton's death, "Clytie" (No. 27), the sun-loving soul bidding farewell to this world. But in many of the later works, as the artist grew older, as the drama of real life became more absorbing and intricate, as the struggle to sustain the interests of the art of his country fell more and more directly on him individually, he seemed to turn with a sense of relief to the more serene, passive sentiment of such pictures as "Idyll," "Winding the Skein" (No. 198), "Summer Slumber" (No. 94), "The Bath of Psyche," as a contrast to the pressure and restless fever of his active life. The tenderness of feeling, such as is invariably united with the highest manly qualities, finds expression throughout every stage of

Leighton's art development, most notably in the drawing and painting of children. (Children had the greatest fascination for him.) In "Elisha and the Shunammite's Son" (No. 207), the tenderness is as touching as it is unobtrusive. "Sister's Kiss" (No. 275), and "Return of Persephone" (No. 53), are both examples in which wholesome, loving, human feeling is depicted with exquisite tenderness. In "Captive Andromache" (No. 21), such feeling in the group of the caressing parents and child is used as a contrast to enforce the loneliness of the captive widow. In "Ariadne abandoned by Theseus: Artemis releases her by Death" (many studies for which are in the collection still unframed), the whole picture breathes a feeling of tenderness which is in a high sense pathetic. In the sketches for "Michael Angelo nursing his Dying Servant" (No. 192), even more than in the completed picture, is seen evidence of the manly tender-heartedness which was a notable characteristic in Leighton's nature.

The hundreds of sketches and drawings now hung on the walls of the Leighton House form a diary of the artist's working life.

Here are records of the earliest student days in Florence in 1842. When twelve years old he studied at the Academy there under Bezzuoli and Servolini. Professor Costa writes of these two masters: "They were celebrated Florentines, excellent good men, but they could give but little light to this star, which was to become one of the first magnitude. Leighton, from his innate kindness, loved and esteemed his old masters much, though not agreeing in the judgment of his fellow-students, that they should be considered on the same level as the ancient Florentines. 'And who have you,' said Leighton one day to a certain Bettino (who is still living), 'who resembles your ancient masters?' And Bettino answered, 'We have still to-day our great Michael Angelos, and Raffaels, in Bezzuoli, in Servolini, in Ciseri.' But this boy of twelve years old could not believe this, and one fine day got into the diligence and left the Academy of Florence to return to England. Although the diligence went at a great pace, his fellow-students followed it on foot, running behind it, crying, 'Come back, Inglesino! come back, Inglesino! come back!' so much was he loved and respected. He did come back, in fact, many times to Italy, which he considered as his second fatherland."

There are also many records of the studies in Germany when Leighton was working under Steinle, of all his masters the one for whom he felt the

greatest enthusiasm. The drawing in the collection which shows most clearly the influence of Steinle's teaching, was made on the journey from Frankfort to Rome in 1852. The subject is a monk leading a man away from his enemy and teaching him a lesson in forgiveness. It is signed, "*Ulm, F.L., /52*" (No. 251).

There is the sketch for the picture which Leighton and one of his fellow-students, Signor Gamba, on that same journey, took it into their heads to paint on the walls of an old ruined castle near Darmstadt. "The schloss," writes Mrs. Andrew Lang, "where this piece was painted is still in ruins, but the Grand Duke has lately erected a wooden roof over the painting to preserve it from destruction." While still at Frankfort, Leighton had begun the design for the "*Cimabue's Procession*" (No. 42). In the collection we find the drawing of the first design. For extraordinary precision of outline and graceful arrangement of moving figures, this is one of the most remarkable on the walls. We have also the study of the head in pencil for the figure of Dante in the right-hand corner of the picture (No. 42-B), (given by Canon Rawnsley), and a large study in water-colour and pencil of the woman seated at the window (given by Mr. J.A. Fuller Maitland) (No. 42-C). Hanging near these is a very finely pencilled head of that boy whom Leighton called "The prettiest and the wickedest boy in Rome." On it is written "*Vincenzo—Roma, 1854, F.L.*" Another, on which is written "*Venezia, 1856, F.L.,*" is, for strength of character and beauty combined, one of the most powerful in the collection (purchased by a donation given by Lord Rosebery). These are a few out of fifty drawings of heads in the House, executed for the main part, between the years 1852 and 1856. There are many records in landscape and street scenes of Leighton's journeying to Capri, Athens, Rhodes, Damascus, and Algeria. Of the drawings made during his stay in Algeria (presented to the House by Mr. Walter Derham) (Nos. 284 and 285), Mr. Pepys Cockerell wrote in his interesting article which appeared in the *Nineteenth Century*, "The finest of all, except the famous 'Lemon Tree,' which is in silver point, and was done in 1859, are the products of a visit to Algeria in 1857. I do not believe that more perfect drawings, better defined or more entirely realised, than these studies of Moors, of camels, &c., were ever executed by the hand of man.... They are not particularly summary, nor do they look as if they had been done in a moment, or without trouble. The drawings in question are as complete as if they came from the hand of Lionardo or Holbein."

Among the most perfect drawings Lord Leighton has left, are also the studies from flowers and foliage. Professor Aitchison writes: "One day I found him (Leighton) drawing the flower of the pumpkin, and he said flowers were quite as hard to draw as human heads, if you drew them conscientiously, but doing that rested with yourself, for there could be no critics. He said of drawing that the great thing was to thoroughly understand the structure, and that then, by patience and labour, you could express the outline and the modelling. In 1859, while at Capri, he drew the celebrated 'Lemon Tree,' working from daylight to dusk for a week or two, and giving large details in the margin of the snails on the tree." Mr. Ruskin writes: "Two perfect early drawings are of 'A Lemon Tree,' and another of the same date, of 'A Byzantine Well,' which determine for you without appeal the question respecting necessity of delineation as the first skill of a painter. Of all our present masters, Sir Frederic Leighton delights most in softly-blended colours, and his ideal of beauty is more nearly that of Correggio than any since Correggio's time. But you see by what precision of terminal outline he at first restrained and exalted his gift of beautiful *vaghezza*."

Of this drawing of "A Lemon Tree," now in the Oxford Museum, lent by Mr. Ruskin, Sir Henry Acland has given a singularly fine photograph, very nearly the size of the original. Lord Leighton gave Mr. Ruskin for his life this wonderful drawing of "A Lemon Tree" to hang in his Oxford Museum, that it might serve to impede, if possible, the increasing wrong-headedness in study—the careless conceit, the irreverent dash, the incompetent confidence of many modern students.

How Leighton's theories as to the manner in which flowers should be drawn were carried out, is exemplified by two wonderful studies of the said pumpkin flower (Nos. 97 and 104), and fifty other studies from flowers and plants in this collection. This artist in his early twenties, brilliant in society, full of intellectual and every other kind of vitality, could nevertheless sit for hours perfecting the study of a flower or a plant. One who knew him well in 1854 and 1855, wrote in the *Times* of 28th January 1896, three days after Leighton's death: "I remember hearing a relative of his, a clergyman, deplore in 1854, the persistency with which Leighton was throwing away his chances in life to become a mere artist." Five years previously, Leighton had embodied in a design, now in his house, the longing, the home sickness, the *Sehnsucht* he felt for his own true much-loved vocation. It is in the

drawing of Giotto as a boy lying among his sheep upon a bank (No. 227). Below the sketch, in Leighton's handwriting, are the words "*Giotto, Sehnsucht.*" The same writer continues: "I enjoyed constant intercourse with him during the whole of 1854 and to the middle of 1855. The summer of the former year we passed at the Baths of Lucca, dining together every day for three months. Finding the solitary splendour of the hotel at 'Villa' irksome, he suggested that we should mess together in my lodgings, which happened to be close to a little restaurant. In after years, meeting in London houses, we always referred with pleasure to the modest, but always wholesome and cleanly feasts that Lucrezia, landlady, chef, and waitress, supplied us with at an almost nominal cost. To me, at least, that period was one of great value and interest, for it gave me the opportunity of studying the character of one whose personality was attractive in no small degree. He was the most brilliant man I ever met.... He longed for and desired success: but only in so far as he deserved it. When he was sharply checked in his upward career, he accepted the rebuke with humility, for he was a modest man.^[91] I had not met him for years when, coming into contact with him, I told him how keen the interest had been with which I had watched his progress. 'I am not satisfied,' he answered; 'I alone know how far I have fallen short of my ideal.'" In his House are two records of this visit to the Bagni di Lucca. One has been presented by Mr. J. MacWhirter, R.A. (No. 249). It is a highly finished drawing of a wreath of leaves exquisitely executed. On the same sheet is a drawing of a vine in fruit, and in Leighton's own writing "*Pomegranate Lucca Bagni Villa.*"

No work in the collection evinces the precision and exact truthfulness of Leighton's drawing better than the outline copies from pictures and frescoes by V. Carpaccio, Giorgione, Simone Memmi and Signorelli made in 1852-53. In the copy from the fresco in the Capella Spagnuola, Sta. Maria Novella, Florence (No. 292), we have the portraits of Cimabue, Giotto, Taddeo Gaddi and Simone Memmi whose work it is.^[92] The accuracy of the copy and the difficulty of making a copy at all, can hardly fully be realised, save by one who has attempted also to repeat the fading outlines of these

dim frescoes in the only half-lighted chapel. Slight and ineffective as Leighton's drawing may appear at a first glance, it is, on further acquaintance, found to be an exquisite piece of work. The absolute truth and precision with which in pencil lines, on a small scale, he has unravelled the outlines of the dim forms, and has depicted the quaint seriousness of these old-world Italian countenances, makes this copy an extraordinary feat of eye and hand. From this drawing he designed the dress of Cimabue for the figure in his large picture, and also for the Cimabue in the South Kensington Mosaic. Written by Leighton above the pencil drawing are the words: "*Simone Memmi Capella Spagnoli (St. Maria Novella, Florence), Taddeo Gaddi white and gold cap, Giotto gold and sea green, Cimabue gold flowers on white ground, Sim. Memmi with grey beard, head dress, yellow hood with black lining, Florence, 1853, F.L.*"

A study in brown (water-colour) (No. 91) signed "*Florence, 1854, F.L.,*" was used by Leighton forty years after it was made in his background for "*Lachrymæ*" (No. 147), an engraving of which was given to the collection by Messrs. A. Tooth. The same study was also used for a charming design, highly finished in pencil and Chinese white, apparently executed for a book illustration, which is now in the House. One of the most beautiful of the foliage studies tells of a happy day "*Near Bellosguardo, Sept./56.*" (No. 171). It is a perfect and highly-finished study of a vine. What joy Leighton must have had while looking at this exquisite thing in the September sunshine on that delicious Bellosguardo height! A butterfly and a bee were minutely pencilled on the paper as they flew round the vine-leaves as he drew them. "*Cyclamen Tivoli, Oct./56.*" is written on another of these tiny treasures. "*Aloes Pampl. Doria,*" "*Pyrte Roma,*" "*Thistle Rhodes,*" "*Lindos/67 Asphodel,*" "*Thistle Banks of Tiber, stalk light warm brown, leaf dark cld. brown, flow. dsk. warm brown, Roma/56,*" are notes on some of these pages of studies, which can only be said to compare with the work of a Leonardo or an Albert Dürer. There is absolutely no mannerism traceable; there is Nature's own quality of style. There is nothing slovenly in Nature, there is as surely nothing slovenly in Lord Leighton's art. The gift which in these modern days is perhaps most rare is a sense of style. Leighton's feeling for style was as much a part of his individual and native taste as was his delight in any other quality of beauty in Nature. Indeed what we call style in art is but the reflection of the same quality in Nature herself, the love which adds to the more oblivious facts of Nature a further quality of

truth, a completer insight into her. Leighton possessed a sculptor's feeling for form. It was his subtle grasp of truth in structure which gives a special value to his outline drawings. The keen sensitiveness to the right character of the form, to which his pencil outline was the limit, influenced the quality of his touch as he portrayed that limit. He felt things "in the round" as solid projections in various planes, advancing or receding from the eye. As in the best sculpture, to every aspect of the solid form you get a fine, subtle, absolutely clear outline; so in Leighton's drawing of a contour, never is there any vague or undecided passage. This insures to his work the quality of distinction. These studies have, one and all, that quality. They are *distinguished*, as are fragments of the best Greek sculpture. Every born artist falls in love specially with one class of sentiment in Nature. Whether his special gifts guide his passion, or his passion his gifts, who can say? Probably each urges the other. The special note of beauty in Nature which excited Leighton's deepest enthusiasm was the quality which is most like that in a shell. In the pumpkin flowers in the study given by Mr. Hamo Thornycroft of "*Kalmia Califolia*," and in many others, is recalled notably the fine, pure, carved distinctness of the forms in a shell—the shell that contains the form and colour that at once delights the sense both of the painter and the sculptor. In the oil sketches by Leighton, those poems of Southern sunlight and colour, records of voyages in the Ægean seas, and off the coasts and islands of Greece and Asia Minor, we again recall the special beauty in the quality and colour of a shell, the rainbow tints in mother-of-pearl, the faint translucence trembling in a sheen of light.

In gauging the exceptional quality of the gifts which all these studies evince it will be well to remember that Leighton, at the time they were made, was under no influence but that of his own high standard, and led by no lights save those of his own exquisitely delicate perceptions. For the last twenty or thirty years detail in Nature—vegetation and Nature which is called "still life"—has been truthfully popularised by photography, so that now all students have it in their power to study from such detail treated on a flat surface. Beauty of natural structure and grace of line rendered with right perspective on a sheet of paper can be enjoyed and made use of by every artist. Many do avail themselves of photographs to carry out and complete the details of their pictures. But when Leighton made these wonderful drawings no such standards of elaborate finish of detail had been diffused. Nor had he joined, nor in any way come under the influence of the Pre-

Raphaelite Brotherhood, nor received any inspiration from the teaching of Mr. Ruskin. Though we may truly liken these studies from "still life" to those by Leonardo as regards the truthful perfection of copies from Nature, there is no evidence in Leighton's drawings that the work, even of the great, much-revered-by-him Italian masters had influenced him when drawing from Nature. On the contrary, there is the strong stamp of his own peculiar genius on all of them, the stamp that proves rather that he saw and loved Nature as a Greek would have seen and loved her. Essentially Greek-like was the attitude in which Leighton approached Nature, *i.e.* with an emotion ever ardent in its intensity; but as ever restrained by the rare gift—the sense of *style* and of the right balance and proportion necessary in treating worthily the beauties of Nature in the language of art. Indeed, it may truly be affirmed that Leighton was made more like a Greek than like an Englishman as regarded his artistic powers, English though he was to the backbone in feeling and sentiment. The effect produced by that collected exhibition of his works in 1897 was, beyond all other effects, that of *achievement*; and achievement which was the result of a perfect mastery and grasp of aims meant to be achieved from the first to the last touch on the canvas. Leighton was far too great an artist ever to be satisfied with the results of his labour. Those who knew him best can testify to his terrible depressions and disappointments. Still, there was no "*muddling through*," to use Lord Rosebery's expression, such as so many English artists confess to in reaching the final result. Greek-like, Leighton saw everything in a definite, clearly outlined view, and, from the beginning to the end, his work was one direct forwarding of his purpose.

In 1860, Leighton migrated to his studio in Orme Square, Bayswater. The collection possesses several drawings made about that time, notably the studies for "Lieder ohne Worte" (No. 36). His young friend, now the well-known portrait-painter, Mr. Hanson Walker, sat for the head in the picture: "A Crowded Scene in Florence" (No. 198), a design full of interest and movement, was the gift to the House of this friend of Leighton's, who, at his instigation, took up art as a profession. In 1866 Leighton moved from Orme Square to the House he had built in Holland Park Road, and there we can now follow his yearly labours by studying the sketches and drawings made for all the well-known famous pictures of the last thirty years, till we come to the last—to that passionate appealing figure of Clytie (No. 27), drawn after the fatal warning had been given. The motive is the same as that of the

first design—the early design of the "Giotto" (No. 227), (made very nearly fifty years before), *i.e.* "Sehnsucht"—not the dreamy half-conscious Sehnsucht of the awakening artist-nature as is seen in the boy Giotto—but the passionate longing to remain in the rich existence that rare gifts and noble affections had secured for that artist-nature. After the studies for "Clytie" there but remain those made for pictures never to be painted, till we reach at last the drawings made on the 22nd of January 1896 (No. 268), the last day on which Leighton worked. Three days after, on the following Saturday, he died.

The object of the Committee is to make this House and its treasures a centre for Art in the Parish of Kensington, where Lord Leighton lived for thirty years. During seventeen of these years he was the President of the Royal Academy, and, by common consent, the greatest President that institution has ever had. The South Kensington Museum is not in the parish, and, though this is one of the richest in London, Kensington proper has no centre of Art, and is sufficiently far removed from the centre of the metropolis to make it important that it should possess such a centre. Since October 1898, the Committee has arranged for Concerts, Lectures, and Readings to take place in the Studios, and the public is now enlightened as to the exceptional acoustic qualities the Studios possess, a fact for long recognised by Leighton's personal friends at the yearly concerts he gave to them when his pictures were ready for the Royal Academy. It is proposed to add to the contents of the House an Art Library, and for this many valuable volumes are waiting to be presented for the book-shelves to contain them. The present proprietors are prepared to hand over the house and all it contains to any public body who will engage to maintain it and to meet the views of the Committee as to the use of the House. As a memorial to Lord Leighton, the most suitable use will be, they feel, to devote it to the furtherance of the interests of Art of the best in all lines and among all classes; in fact to continue in his own home the culture of that "sweetness and light" which emanated so notably from his own nature. To conclude with words written by his old and very intimate friend, Professor Costa, with whom he spent his last holiday in the autumn before he died: "Leighton solved certain problems which appeared insoluble. For instance, he combined a life at high pressure with the most exquisite politeness—truth with poetry, an iron will with the tenderness of a mother's heart, high

aims with a practical life and with the worship of beauty, the ardour of which was only equalled by its purity."

E.I.B.

FOOTNOTES:

[89] The greater portion of this preface appeared as an article in the *Magazine of Art*, October 1899. It is with the kind permission of the proprietors that it is reprinted.

[90] Mr. De Morgan is at present engaged in making two jars in pottery, which he intends to present to the House, to fill the niches in the Arab Hall.

[91] "Leighton has been cut up unmercifully by the critics, but bears on, Robert says, not without courage. That you should say his picture looked well, was comfort in the general gloom."—*Letter from Mrs. Browning to Mrs. Jameson, May 6th, 1856, Paris.*

[92] Nineteen years later, I happened to copy the same group in water-colour; but it was only after Leighton's death that I saw this extraordinarily beautiful drawing.

LIST OF DIGNITIES AND HONOURS CONFERRED ON FREDERIC LEIGHTON [ToC](#)

Knighted, 1878; created a Baronet, 1886; created Baron Leighton of Stretton, 1896; elected Associate of the Royal Academy, 1864; Royal Academician, 1869; President of the Royal Academy, 1878; Hon. Member,

Royal Scottish Academy, and Royal Hibernian Academy, Associate of the Institute of France, President of the International Jury of Painting, Paris Exhibition, 1878; Hon. Member, Berlin Academy, 1886; also Member of the Royal Academy of Vienna, 1888; Belgium, 1886; of the Academy of St. Luke, Rome, and the Academies of Florence (1882), Turin, Genoa, Perugia, and Antwerp (1885); Hon. D.C.L., Oxford, 1879; Hon. LL.D., Cambridge, 1879; Hon. LL.D., Edinburgh, 1884; Hon. D. Lit., Dublin, 1892; Hon. D.C.L., Durham, 1894; Hon. Fellow of Trinity College, London, 1876; Lieut.-Colonel of the 20th Middlesex (Artist's) Rifle Volunteers, 1876 to 1883 (resigned); then Hon. Colonel and Holder of the Volunteer Decoration; Commander of the Legion of Honour, 1889; Commander of the Order of Leopold; Knight of the Prussian Order "pour le Mérite," and of the Coburg Order Dem Verdienste.

LIST OF PRINCIPAL WORKS [ToC](#)

With Date and Place of Exhibition. [\[93\]](#) *Corrected and amplified from "Frederic, Lord Leighton, His Life and Work," by Ernest Rhys.*

1850 (*circa*). *Cimabue finding Giotto in the fields of Florence. (49½ × 37 inches.) Steinle Institute (Frankfort).

1850. The Duel between Romeo and Tybalt. (37 × 50 inches.)

1851 (*circa*). The Death of Brunelleschi. Steinle Institute.

1851. [Early Portrait of Leighton by Himself.]

1852. *A Persian Pedlar.

1852. [Buffalmacco, the Painter. A humorous subject, from Vasari, was undertaken about this date.] See Sketch in water-colour, Leighton House Collection.

1853. Portrait of Miss Laing (Lady Nias).

1855. Cimabue's celebrated Madonna is carried in procession through the streets of Florence. In front of the Madonna, and crowned with laurels, walks Cimabue himself, with his pupil Giotto; behind it, Arnolfo di Lappo, Taddeo Gaddi, Andrea Tafi, Niccola Pisano, Buffalmacco, and Simone Memmi; in the corner, Dante. (87½ × 205 inches.) R.A.^[94] Purchased by H.M. Queen Victoria, Buckingham Palace. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1855. The Reconciliation of the Montagues and Capulets over the dead bodies of Romeo and Juliet. Paris International Exhibition.^[95]

1856. The Triumph of Music. (80 × 110 inches.) R.A. Painted in Paris.

"Orpheus, by the power of his art, redeems his wife from Hades."

1856. Pan. [A subject from Keats' *Hymn to Pan*, in the first book of "Endymion."] Painted in Paris. A figure of Pan under a fig-tree, with this inscription:—

"O thou, to
whom
Broad-leaved fig-trees even
now foredoom
Their ripen'd fruitage."

1856. Venus. [A pendant to the Pan.] The figure of a nude nymph about to bathe, with a little Cupid loosening her sandal. Exhibited at the Manchester

Exhibition and sent to America after. Painted in Paris.

1857. *Salome, the daughter of Herodias. (44½ × 25 inches.) See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1858. *The Mermaid (the fisherman and the syren). (From a ballad by Goethe.) (26½ × 18½ inches.) R.A.

"Half drew she him,
Half sunk he in,
And never more was seen."

1858. "Count Paris, accompanied by Friar Lawrence and a band of musicians, comes to the house of the Capulets to claim his bride: he finds Juliet stretched apparently lifeless on the bed."—*Romeo and Juliet*, Act iv. sc. 5. (26½ × 18½ inches.) R.A.

1858. Reminiscence of Algiers: A Negro Dance. (Water-colour.) Suffolk Street Gallery.

1859. Sunny Hours. R.A.

1859. *Roman Lady (La Nanna). R.A.

1859. *Nanna (Pavonia). R.A.

1859. Samson and Delilah. S.S. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1860. Capri—Sunrise. R.A.

1861. *Portrait of Mrs. Sutherland Orr [Mrs. S.O., a Portrait]. (28 × 18 inches.) R.A.

1861. *Portrait of John Hanson Walker, Esq. (23 × 17 inches.) Owner, H.M. The King. R.A.

1861. Paolo e Francesca. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

"Ma solo un punto fu quel che
ci vinse
Quando legemmo il disiato riso
Esser baciato da cotanto
amante,
Questi, che mai da me non fia
diviso,
La bocca mi baciò tutto
tremante:
Galeotto fu 'l libro e chi lo
scrisse:
Quel giorno più non vi
legemmo avante."

1861. A Dream.

"...Not yet—not
yet—
Still there is trial for thee, still
the lot
To bear (the Father wills it)
strife and care;
With this sweet consciousness
in balance set
Against the world, to soothe
thy suffering there
The Lord rejects thee not.
Such tender words awoke me
hopeful, shriven
To life on earth again from
dream of heaven."

1861. Lieder ohne Worte. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton
House Collection.

1861. J.A. A Study. R.A.

1861. Capri—Paganos. R.A.

1862. Odalisque. R.A.

1862. *The Star of Bethlehem. (60 × 23½ inches.) One of the Magi, from the terrace of his house, stands looking at the star in the East; the lower part of the picture indicates a road, which he may be supposed just to have left. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1862. Sisters. R.A.

1862. *Michael Angelo Nursing his Dying Servant. (43 × 36 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1862. Duett. R.A.

1862. Sea Echoes. R.A.

1862. Rustic Music. R.A.

1863. Jezebel and Ahab, having caused Naboth to be put to death, go down to take possession of his vineyard; they are met at the entrance by Elijah the Tishbite. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

"Hast thou killed, and also taken possession?"

1863. *Eucharis. (A Girl with a Basket of Fruit.) (32½ × 22 inches.) R.A.

1863. A Girl Feeding Peacocks. R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1863. An Italian Crossbowman. (51 × 24½ inches.) R.A.

1864. Dante at Verona. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1864. *Orpheus and Eurydice. (49 × 42 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

"But give them—the mouth, the
eyes,—the brow—

Let them once more absorb me!
One look now
Will lap me round for ever, not
to pass
Out of its light, though
darkness lie beyond!
Hold me but safe again within
the bond
Of one immortal look! All woe
that was,
Forgotten, and all terror that
may be,
Defied—no past is mine, no
future! look at me!"

—Robert

Brown
ing: A
Fragm
ent.

1864. *Golden Hours. (36 × 48 inches.) R.A. See
Sketches in oil and chalk, Leighton House
Collection.

1864. *Portrait of the late Miss Lavinia I'Anson.
(Circular, 12½ inches.)

1865. *David. (37 × 47 inches.) R.A. See Sketches,
Leighton House Collection.

"Oh that I had wings like a dove! for then
would I fly away, and be at rest."—*Psalm* lv.

1865. Mother and Child. R.A.

1865. Widow's Prayer. R.A.

1865. Helen of Troy. R.A.

"Thus as she spoke, in Helen's
breast arose

Fond recollections of her
former lord,
Her home, and parents; o'er her
head she threw
A snowy veil; and shedding
tender tears
She issued forth not
unaccompanied;
For with her went fair Æthra,
Pittheus' child,
And stag-eyed Clymene, her
maidens twain.
They quickly at the Scæan gate
arrived."

1865. In St. Mark's. R.A.

1866. Painter's Honeymoon. R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1866. Portrait of Mrs. James Guthrie. R.A.

1866. Syracusan Bride leading wild beasts in procession to the Temple of Diana. (Suggested by a passage in the second Idyll of Theocritus.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

"And for her, then, many other wild beasts were going in procession round about, and among them a lioness."

1866. A Noble Lady of Venice. (Not exhibited till 1897.)

1866. The Wise and Foolish Virgins. (Fresco in Lyndhurst Church, finished 1864.) See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1867. *Pastoral. (51½ × 26 inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1867. *Greek Girl Dancing. (Spanish Dancing Girl; Cadiz in the old times.) (34 × 45 inches.) R.A.

1867. Knuckle-Bone Player. R.A.

1867. *Roman Mother. (24 × 19 inches.) R.A.

1867. *Venus disrobing for the Bath. (79 × 35½ inches.)
R.A.

1867. *Portrait of Mrs. John Hanson Walker. (18 × 16
inches.)

1868. Jonathan's Token to David. R.A.

"And it came to pass in the morning, that
Jonathan went out into the field at the time
appointed by David, and a little lad with him."

1868. *Portrait of Mrs. Frederick P. Cockerell. (23½ ×
19½ inches.) R.A.

1868. *Portrait of John Martineau, Esq. (23½ × 19½
inches.) R.A.

1868. *Ariadne abandoned by Theseus; Ariadne watches
for his return; Artemis releases her by death. (45 ×
62 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House
Collection.

1868. *Acme and Septimius. (Circular, 37½ inches.)
R.A.

"Then bending gently back her
head
With that sweet mouth, so rosy
red,
Upon his eyes she dropped a
kiss,
Intoxicating him with bliss."

—Catullus
(Th
eod
ore
Mar

tin's
tran
slati
on).

1868. *Actæa, the Nymph of the Shore. (22 × 40 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1869. *S. Jerome. (Diploma work, deposited in the Academy on his election as an Academician.) (72 × 55 inches.) R.A.
1869. *Dædalus and Icarus. (53½ × 40½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1869. *Electra at the Tomb of Agamemnon. (59½ × 29 inches.) R.A.
1869. *Helios and Rhodos. (65½ × 42 inches) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1870. A Nile Woman. (21½ × 11½ inches.) R.A.
1870. Study. S.S.
1871. *Hercules Wrestling with Death for the Body of Alcestis. (54 × 104½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1871. Greek Girls picking up Pebbles by the shore of the Sea. R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1871. *Cleoboulos instructing his daughter Cleobouline. (24 × 37½ inches.) R.A.
1871. View of Assiout (?). (A sketch.) S.S.
1871. Sunrise at Lougsor. (A sketch.) S.S.
1871. View of the Red Mountains near Cairo. (A sketch) S.S.
1872. *After Vespers. (43 × 27½ inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1872. *Summer Moon. (Guildhall, 1890.) (39½ × 50½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1872. Portrait of the Right Hon. Edward Ryan, Secretary of the Dilettante Society, for which the picture was painted. (S.P.P., 1893.) R.A.
1872. A Condottiere. R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1872. *The Industrial Arts of War, at the International Exhibition at South Kensington. (Monochrome, 76 × 177 inches.) Carried out in fresco on the wall of the Victoria and Albert Museum. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1872. The Captive. S.S.
1872. An Arab Café, Algiers. S.S.
1873. *Weaving the Wreath. (Guildhall, 1895.) R.A.
1873. Moretta. (Guildhall, 1894.) (20½ × 14½ inches.) R.A.
1873. The Industrial Arts of Peace. (Monochrome, 76 × 177 inches.) Carried out in fresco on the wall of the Victoria and Albert Museum. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1873. A Roman. S.S.
1873. Vittoria. S.S.
1874. *Moorish Garden: A Dream of Granada. (Guildhall 1895.) (41 × 40 inches.) R.A.
1874. Old Damascus: Jews' Quarter. R.A.
1874. *Antique Juggling Girl. (Guildhall, 1892.) (41½ × 24 inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

1874. Clytemnestra from the battlements of Argos watches for the Beacon Fires which are to announce the return of Agamemnon. R.A. Leighton House Collection. See also Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1874. Annarella, Ana Capri. D.G.
1874. Rubinella, Capri. D.G.
1874. Lemon Tree, Capri. D.G.
1874. West Court of Palazzo, Venice. D.G.
1875. *Portion of the Interior of the Grand Mosque of Damascus. (62 × 47 inches.) R.A.
1875. *Portrait of Mrs. H.E. Gordon. (35½ × 37 inches.) R.A.
1875. *Little Fatima. (15½ × 9¼ inches.) R.A.
1875. Venetian Girl. R.A.
1875. *Egyptian Slinger. (Eastern slinger scaring birds in harvest time: Moonrise.) (Guildhall, 1890.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1875. Florentine Youth. S.S.
1875. Ruined Mosque in Damascus. S.S.
1876. *Portrait of Sir Richard Francis Burton, K.C.M.G. (Portrait of Captain Richard Burton, H.M. Consul at Trieste.) (23½ × 19½ inches.) (Paris, 1878; Melbourne, 1888; S.P.P., 1892.) R.A. National Portrait Gallery.
1876. *The Daphnephoria. (89 × 204 inches.) A triumphal procession held every ninth year at Thebes, in honour of Apollo and to commemorate a victory of the Thebans over the Æolians of Arne. (See Proclus, "Chrestomath," p. 11.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

1876. Teresina. R.A.
1876. Paolo. R.A.
1877. *Music Lesson. ($36\frac{1}{2} \times 37\frac{1}{8}$ inches.) (Paris, 1878.) R.A.
1877. *Portrait of Miss Mabel Mills (The Hon. Mrs. Grenfell). (23×19 inches.) R.A.
1877. *An Athlete Strangling a Python.^[96] Bronze. (Paris, 1878.) R.A. See Sketch in plaster, Leighton House Collection, presented by G.F. Watts, O.M.
1877. *Portrait of H.E. Gordon. ($23\frac{1}{2} \times 19$ inches.) G.G.
1877. An Italian Girl. G.G.
1877. *Study. (A little girl with fair hair, in a pink robe.) (24×28 inches.) R.A.
1877. A Study. G.G.
1878. *Nausicaa. ($57\frac{1}{2} \times 26\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) (Guildhall, 1896.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1878. Serafina. R.A.
1878. *Winding the Skein. ($39\frac{1}{2} \times 63\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1878. A Study. R.A.
1878. *Portrait of Miss Ruth Stewart Hodgson. ($50\frac{1}{2} \times 35\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) G.G.
1878. Study of a Girl's Head. G.G.
1878. Sierra: Elviza in the distance, Granada. S.S.
1878. The Sierra Alhama, Granada. S.S.
1879. Biondina. R.A.
1879. Catarina. R.A.

1879. *Elijah in the Wilderness. (91 × 81½ inches.) R.A.
(Paris, 1878.) Corporation of Liverpool. See
Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1879. Portrait of Signor G. Costa. R.A.
1879. Amarilla. R.A.
1879. A Study. R.A.
1879. Portrait of the Countess Brownlow. R.A.
1879. *Neruccia. (19 × 16 inches.) R.A.
1879. A Study. S.S.
1879. The Carrara Hills. S.S.
1879. A Street in Lerici. S.S.
1879. Via Bianca, Capri. G.G.
1879. Archway in Algiers. G.G.
1879. Ruins of a Mosque, Damascus. G.G.
1879. Study of a Donkey. G.G.
1879. On the Terrace, Capri. G.G.
1879. Sketch near Damascus. G.G.
1879. View in Granada. G.G.
1879. Study of a Donkey, Egypt. G.G.
1879. Study of a Head. G.G.
1879. Nicandra. G.G.
1880. *Sister's Kiss. (48 × 21½ inches.) R.A. See
Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1880. *Iostephane. (37 × 19 inches.) R.A.
1880. The Light of the Harem. (60 × 33 inches.) R.A.
1880. Psamathe. (36 × 24 inches.) R.A.

1880. *The Nymph of the Dargle (Crenaia). (29½ × 10 inches.) R.A.
1880. Rubinella. G.G.
1880. The Pozzo Corner, Venice. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Jack and his Cider Can. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. The Painter's Honeymoon. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Winding of the Skein (with sketch). Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Head of Urbino. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Steps of the Bargello, Florence. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. A Contrast. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Garden at Capri. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1880. Twenty-nine Studies of Heads, Flowers, and Draperies. Winter Exhibition. G.G.
1881. Elisha raising the son of the Shunammite. (32 × 54 inches.) (Guildhall, 1895.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1881. Portrait of the Painter.[\[97\]](#) R.A.
1881. *Idyll. (41½ × 84 inches.) R.A. See Sketches in oil and chalk, Leighton House Collection.
1881. *Portrait of Mrs. Stephen Ralli. (48 × 33 inches.) R.A.
1881. *Whispers. (48 × 30 inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1881. Viola. R.A.
1881. *Bianca. (18 × 12½ inches.) R.A.

1881. Portrait of Mrs. Algernon Sartoris. G.G.
1882. *Day-Dreams. ($47\frac{1}{2} \times 35\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) R.A.
1882. Wedded. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1882. Phryne at Eleusis. (86×48 inches.) (Melbourne, 1888.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1882. Antigone. R.A.
1882. "And the sea gave up the dead which were in it"—Rev. xx. 13. (Design for a portion of a decoration in St. Paul's.) R.A. The Tate Gallery. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1882. Melittion. R.A.
1882. *Portrait of Mrs. Mocatta. ($23\frac{1}{2} \times 19\frac{1}{2}$ inches.)
1882. Zeyra. G.G.
1883. The Dance: decorative frieze for a drawing-room in a private house. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1883. *Vestal. ($24\frac{1}{2} \times 17$ inches.) R.A.
1883. *Kittens. ($48 \times 31\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) R.A.
1883. Memories. R.A.
1883. Portrait of Miss Nina Joachim. (16×13 inches.)
1884. *Letty. ($18 \times 15\frac{1}{2}$ inches.) R.A.
1884. *Cymon and Iphigenia. (64×129 inches.) (Berlin, 1885.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1884. A Nap. R.A.
1884. Sun Gleams. R.A.

1885. ... "Serenely wandering in a trance of sober thought." ... (46 × 27 inches.) R.A.
1885. Portrait of the Lady Sybil Primrose. R.A.
1885. *Portrait of Mrs. A. Hichens. (26½ × 20½ inches.) R.A.
1885. Music: a frieze. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1885. Phœbe. (Manchester, 1887.) R.A.
1885. A Study. G.G.
1885. Tombs of Muslim Saints. S.S.
1885. Mountains near Ronda Puerta de los Vientos. S.S.
1886. Painted decoration for the ceiling of a music-room.^[98] (7 × 20 feet.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1886. Gulnihal. R.A.
1886. *The Sluggard. Statue, bronze. R.A. Presented to the Tate Gallery by Sir Henry Tate. See Statuette, Leighton House Collection.
1886. *Needless Alarms. Statuette. R.A. See Bronze, Leighton House Collection.
1887. *The Jealousy of Simœtha, the Sorceress. (35 × 55½ inches.) R.A. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.
1887. *The Last Watch of Hero. (62½ × 35½ inches, with predella 12½ × 29½ inches.) R.A. Corporation of Manchester. See Sketch, Leighton House Collection.

"With aching heart she scanned
the sea-face dim.

.
.

Lo! at the turret's foot his body
lay,
Rolled on the stones, and
washed with breaking
spray."
—*Hero and Leander*:
Musæus
(translated by
Edwin Arnold).

1887. [Picture of a little girl with golden hair, and pale
blue eyes.]

"Yellow and pale as ripened
corn
Which Autumn's kiss frees—
grain from sheath—
Such was her hair, while her
eyes beneath,
Showed Spring's faint violets
freshly born."

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1887. *Design for the reverse of the Jubilee Medallion. (Executed for Her Majesty Queen Victoria's Government.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

Empire, enthroned in the centre, rests her right hand on the sword of Justice, and holds in her left the symbol of victorious rule. At her feet, on one side, Commerce proffers wealth; on the other, a winged figure holds emblems of Electricity and Steam-power. Flanking the throne to the right of the spectator are Agriculture and Industry; on the opposite side, Science, Literature, and the Arts. Above, interlocking wreaths, held by winged genii representing respectively the years 1837 and 1887, inclose the initials V.R.I.

1888. *Captive Andromache. (77 × 160 inches.) R.A. Corporation of Manchester. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.

... "Some
standi
ng by,
Marking thy tears fall, shall
say, "This is she,
The wife of that same Hector
that fought best
Of all the Trojans, when all
fought for Troy."

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1888. *Portrait of Amy, Lady Coleridge. (42 × 39½ inches.) (S.P.P., 1891.) R.A.
1888. *Portraits of the Misses Stewart Hodgson. (47 × 39½ inches.)
1888. Four Studies. R.W.S.

1888. Five Studies. S.S.
1889. *Sibyl. (59 × 34 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1889. *Invocation. (54 × 33½ inches.) R.A.
1889. Elegy. R.A.
1889. Greek Girls playing at Ball. (45 × 78 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1889. *Portrait of Mrs. Francis A. Lucas. (23½ × 19½ inches.) R.A.
1890. Solitude. R.A.
1890. *The Bath of Psyche.[\[99\]](#) (75 × 24½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1890. *Tragic Poetess. (63 × 34 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1890. *The Arab Hall. (33 × 16 inches.) (Guildhall, 1890.) R.A.
1891. *Perseus and Andromeda. (91½ × 50 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1891. *Portrait of A.B. Freeman-Mitford, Esq., C.B. (46¼ × 38½ inches.) R.A.
1891. *Return of Persephone. (79 × 59½ inches.) R.A. Corporation of Leeds. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1891. Athlete Struggling with a Python. Group, marble. R.A.
1892. *"And the sea gave up the dead which were in it." (Circular, 93 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1892. At the Fountain. (49 × 37 inches.) R.A.

1891. *The Garden of the Hesperides. (Circular, 66 inches.) (Chicago, 1893; Guildhall, 1895.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1892. Bacchante. R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1892. *Clytie. (32½ × 53½ inches.) R.A.
1892. Phryne at the Bath. (24 × 12 inches.) S.S. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1892. Malin Head, Donegal. S.S.
1892. St. Mark's, Venice. S.S.
1892. Interior of St. Mark's, Venice. S.S.
1892. The Doorway, North Aisle, Venice. S.S.
1892. Rizpah (the small study in oils). (7 × 7 inches.) S.S.
1893. *Farewell! (63 × 26½ inches.) R.A.
1893. *Hit! (29 × 22 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1893. Atalanta. (26½ × 19 inches.) R.A.
1893. Rizpah. (36 × 52 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1893. Corinna of Tanagra. (47½ × 21 inches.) R.A.
1894. *The Spirit of the Summit. (77½ × 39½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1894. *The Bracelet. (59½ × 23 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1894. *Fatidica. (59½ × 43 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
1894. *Summer Slumber. (45½ × 62 inches.) R.A. See Sketches, Leighton House Collection, one presented by H.M. The King.

- 1894. At the Window. R.A.
- 1894. Wide, Wondering Eyes. (20 × 15½ inches.)
Manchester.
- 1894. The Roman Campagna, Monte Soracte in the
distance. S.S.
- 1894. The Acropolis of Lindos. S.S.
- 1894. Fiume Morto, Gombo, Pisa. S.S.
- 1894. Gibraltar from San Rocque. S.S.
- 1895. Lachrymæ. (60 × 24 inches.) R.A. See Sketches,
Leighton House Collection.
- 1895. The Maid with the Yellow Hair. R.A.
- 1895. *Twixt Hope and Fear. (43½ × 38½ inches.) R.A.
- 1895. *Flaming June. (46 × 46 inches.) R.A. See
Sketches, Leighton House Collection.
- 1895. Listener. R.A.
- 1895. A Study. R.A.
- 1895. Phœnicians bartering with Britons. Presented to
the Royal Exchange by Lord Leighton. See Sketches,
Leighton House Collection.
- 1895. Boy with Pomegranate. Grafton Gallery.
- 1895. Miss Dene.
- 1895. Aqua Certosa, Rome. S.S.
- 1895. Chain of Hills seen from Ronda. S.S.
- 1895. Rocks, Malin Head, Donegal. S.S.
- 1895. Tlemcen, Algeria. S.S.
- 1896. *Clytie. (61½ × 53½ inches.) R.A. See Sketches,
Leighton House Collection.
- 1896. Candida. (21 × 41½ inches.) Antwerp, 1896.

1896. *The Vestal. (27 × 20½ inches.) Unfinished.
1896. *A Bacchante. (26½ × 21 inches.)
1896. *The Fair Persian. (25½ × 19½ inches.)
Unfinished.
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FOOTNOTES:

[93] The asterisk denotes works exhibited at the Winter Exhibition of the Royal Academy of Arts, 1897.

[94] R.A., Royal Academy; G.G., Grosvenor Gallery; R.W.S., Royal Society of Painters in Water-Colours; S.S., Royal Society of British Artists, Suffolk Street; D.G., Dudley Gallery; S.P.P., Society of Portrait Painters.

[95] Exhibited in the Roman section by some blunder of the Committee, the picture having been painted in Rome.

[96] Purchased for £2000 by the President and Council of the Royal Academy, under the terms of the Chantrey Bequest.

[97] Painted by invitation for the collection of Portraits of Artists painted by themselves, in the Uffizi Gallery, Florence.

[98] Painted for the house of Mr. Marquand, New York.

[99] Purchased for 1000 guineas by the President and Council of the Royal Academy, under the terms of the Chantrey Bequest.

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THE END

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ERRATA

Page 41, note 2, *for "sœür," read "sœur."*

Page 148, line 21, *for "Lindas," read "Lindos."*

Page 260, line 16, *for "Risbah," read "Rizpah."*

Page 316, line 1, *for "altmodish," read "altmodisch."*

Page 320, line 34, *for "men-schlich," read "menschlich."*

Page 301, line 10, *for "Gambia Parry," read "Gambier Parry."*

Typographical errors corrected in text:

Page 14: "This arrangement, if effected"
replaced with "This arrangement, is effected"

Page 46: "à quarelle" replaced with
"aquarelle"

Page 69: Rivere House replaced with Revere
House

Page 69: Mr. Caleot replaced with Mr. Cabot

Page 129: Mr. Bileith replaced with Mr.
Biliotti

Page 131: 1878 replaced with 1868. (Grant and
Colfax, mentioned later in the diary, were
elected in 1868, not 1878.)

Page 133: 1878 replaced with 1868. (see
above)

Page 145: Koorveh replaced with Koorneh

Page 183: fastastic replaced with fantastic

Page 192: "Cleaboulos Instructing his
Daughter Cleabouline" replaced with
"Cleoboulos Instructing his Daughter
Cleobouline"

Page 194: Cleabouline replaced with
Cleobouline

Page 197: Cleabouline replaced with
Cleobouline

Page 201: Cleabouline replaced with Cleobouline
Page 207: delighful replaced with delightful
Page 209: aficimado replaced with aficionado
Page 233: spontanteous replaced with spontaneous
Page 236: sociel replaced with social
Page 241: Gussey replaced with Gussy
Page 294: 'Are there differents kinds' replaced with 'Are there different kinds'
Page 320: mensch-lich replaced with menschlich (the errata includes the hyphen because it spans two lines)
Page 345: heirarchy replaced with hierarchy
Page 347: "a vivid scene of abstract beauty" replaced with "a vivid sense of abstract beauty"
Page 382: Keat's replaced with Keats'
Page 384: Æthra replaced with Æthra
Page 385: Longsor replaced with Lougsor
Page 386: 1886. *The Daphnephoria. changed to 1876. *The Daphnephoria.
Page 387: 1889. Catarina. replaced with 1879. Catarina.
Page 389: Hichins replaced with Hichens
Page 391: Mont replaced with Monte
Page 396: 'Garcia, Senor' replaced with 'Garcia, Señor'
Page 402: Phylae replaced with Phylæ

Note that the date "Friday, 28th" on page 147 is out of order. By checking the dates it clearly should be the 23rd, which is confirmed with the date Wednesday, 28th on page 153. This has been corrected to "Friday, 23rd" in the text.
"Friday Evening" on page 152 has been corrected to "Tuesday Evening" by the same logic.

Words that are not errors:

Page 9: distress.

Page 27: subtle.

Page 31: scumble.

Page 32: subtilty.

Page 47: the phrase 'tol-lol!' is 19th century slang for pretty good.

Page 198: trés

Page 236: euphuism.

Page 320: fribbled.

Page 347: shapliness.

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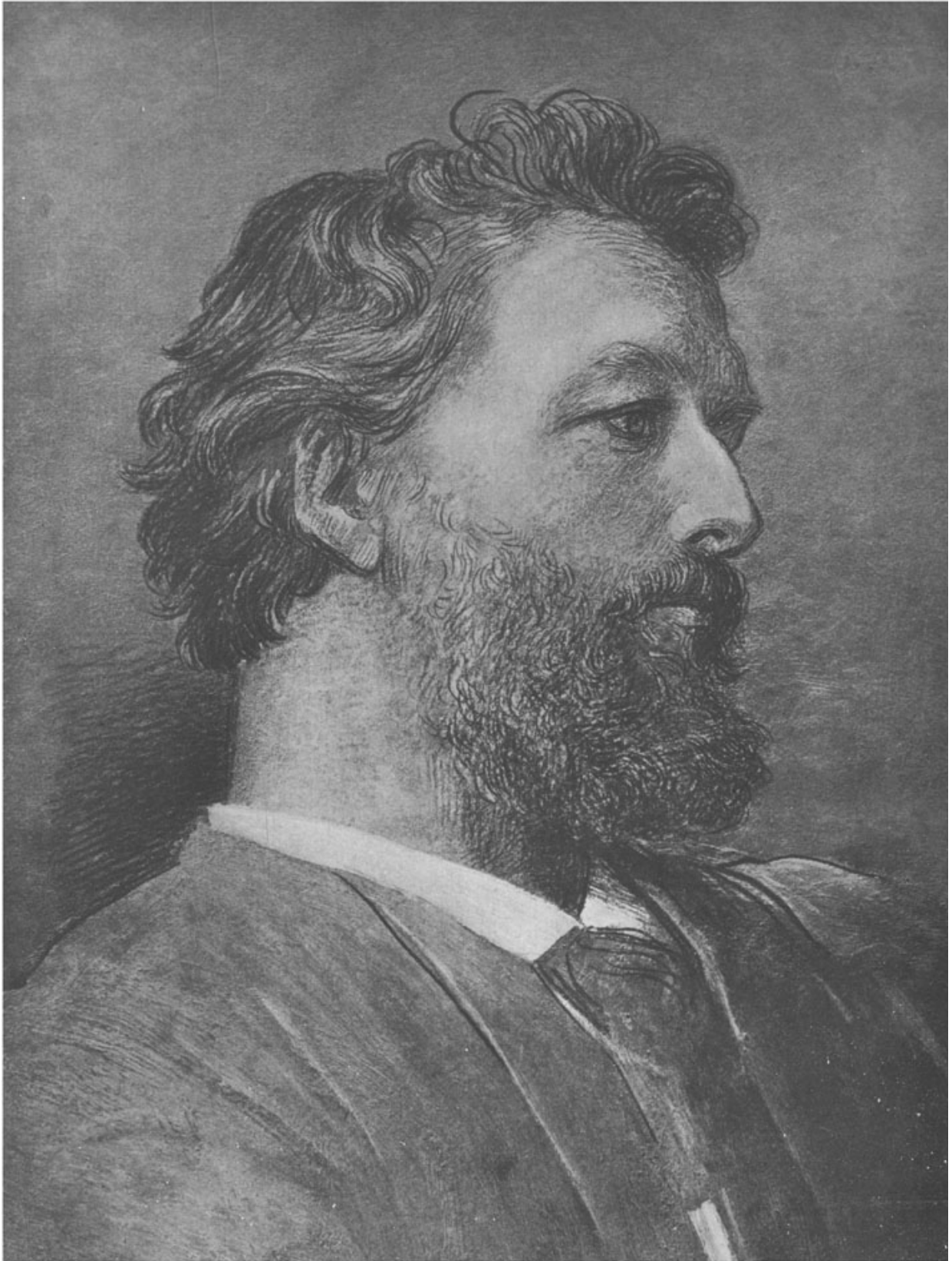
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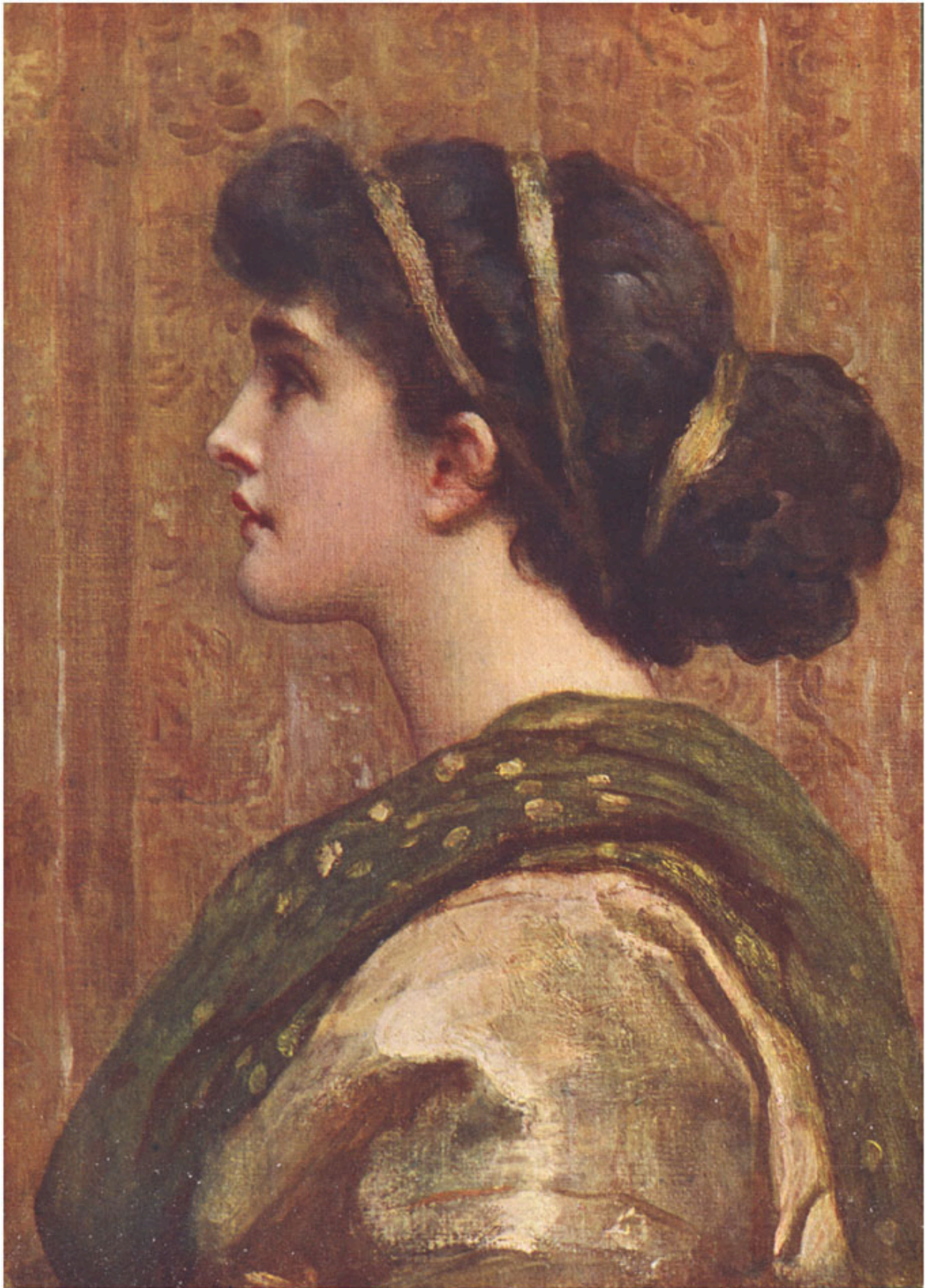
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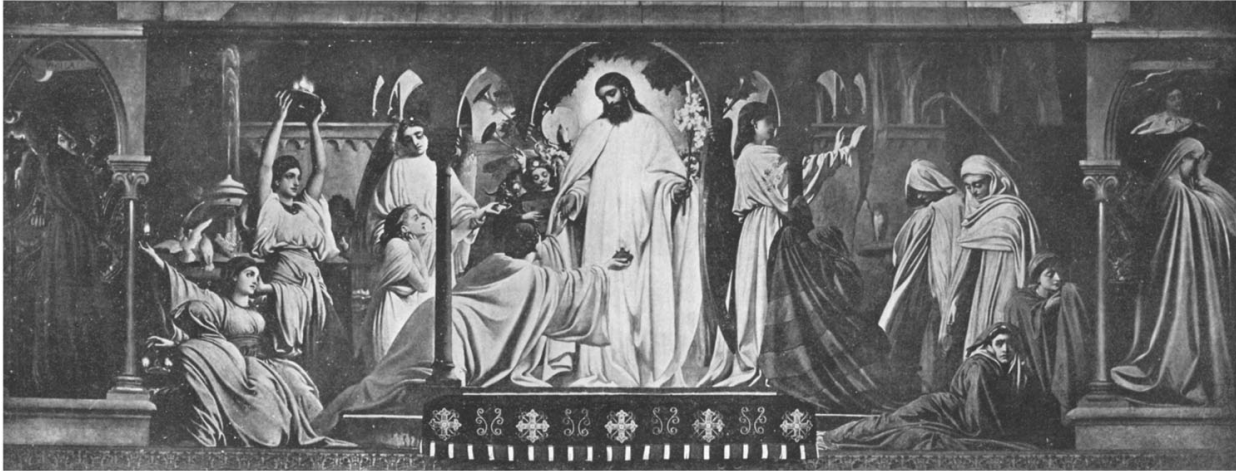
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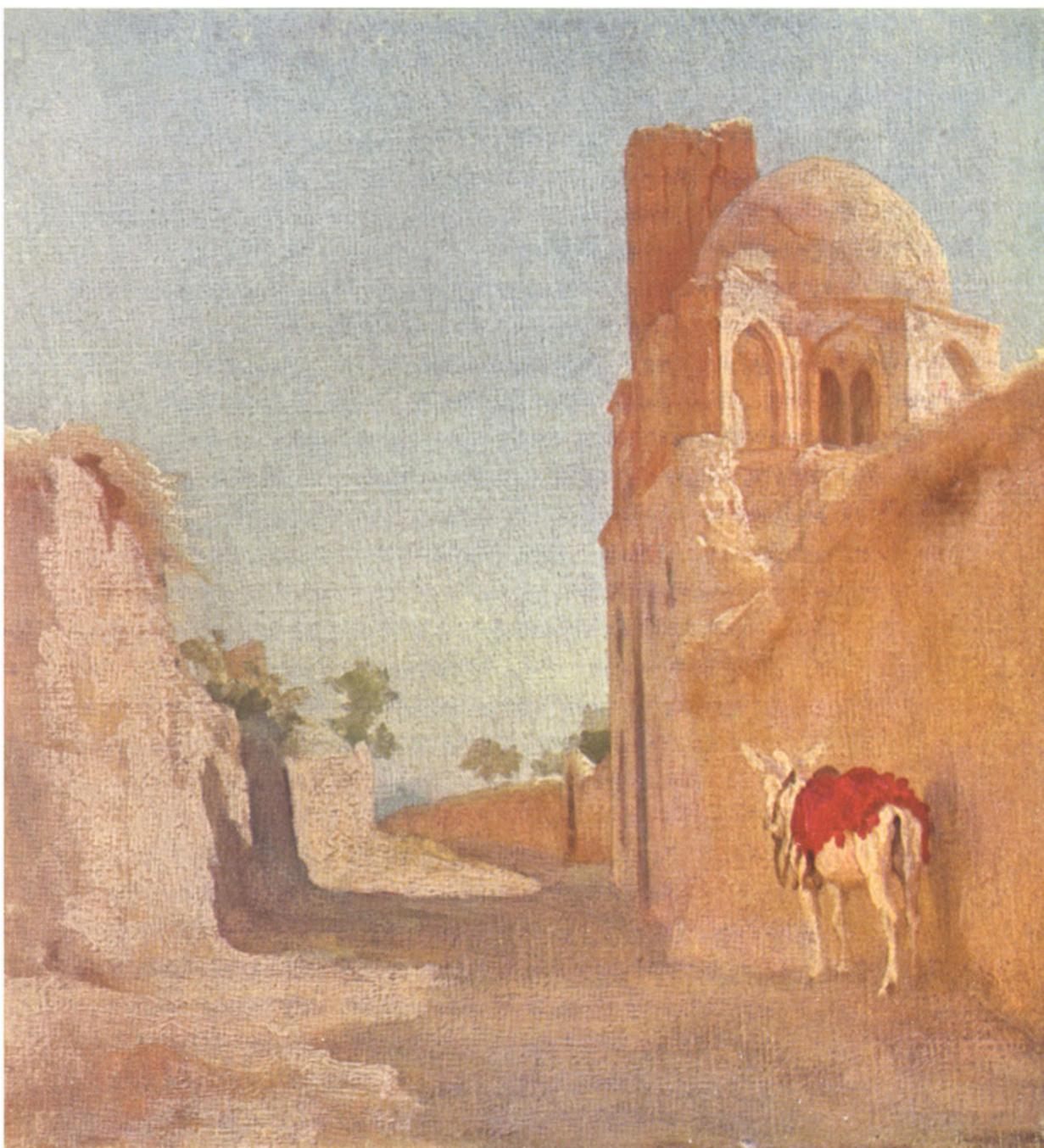
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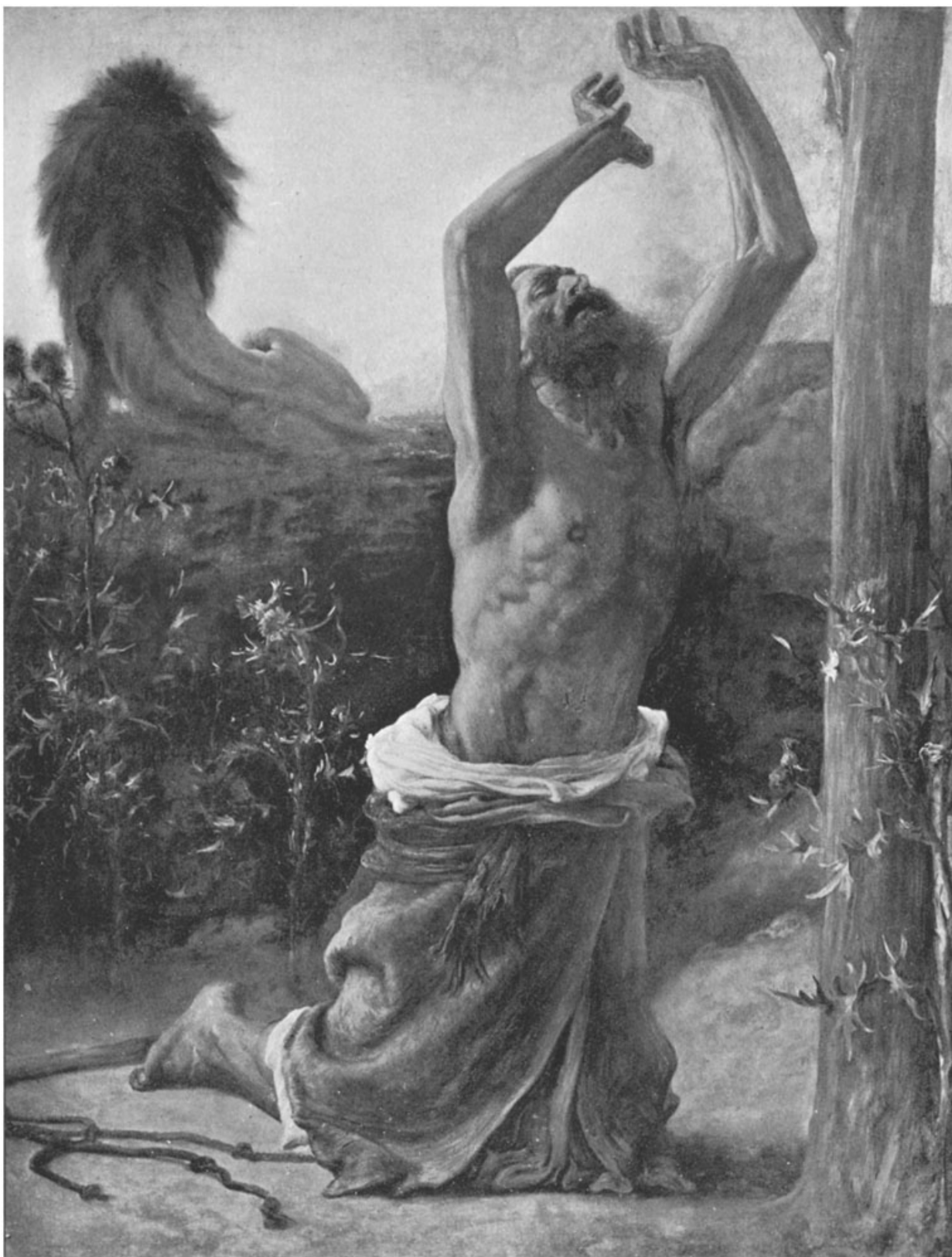
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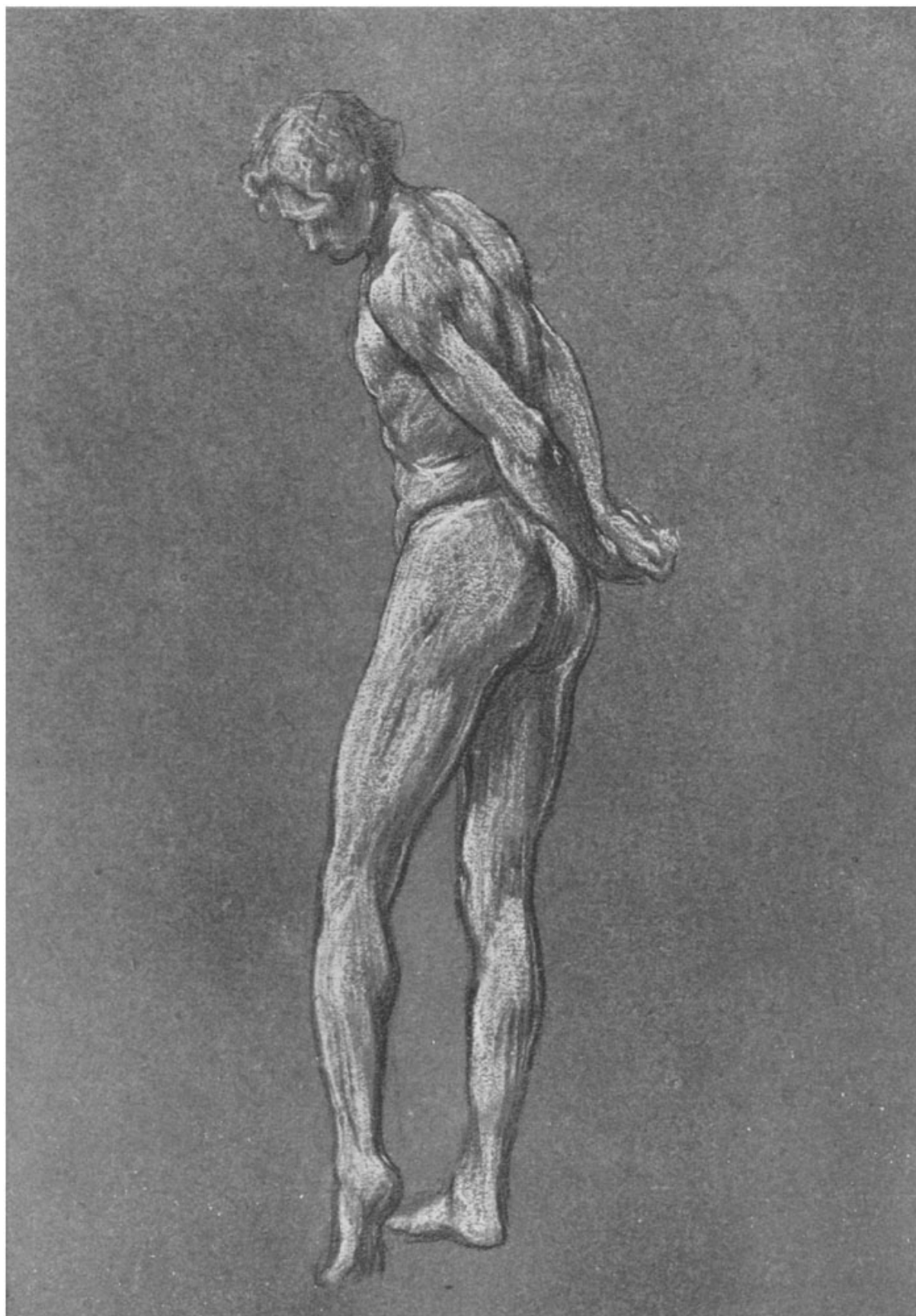
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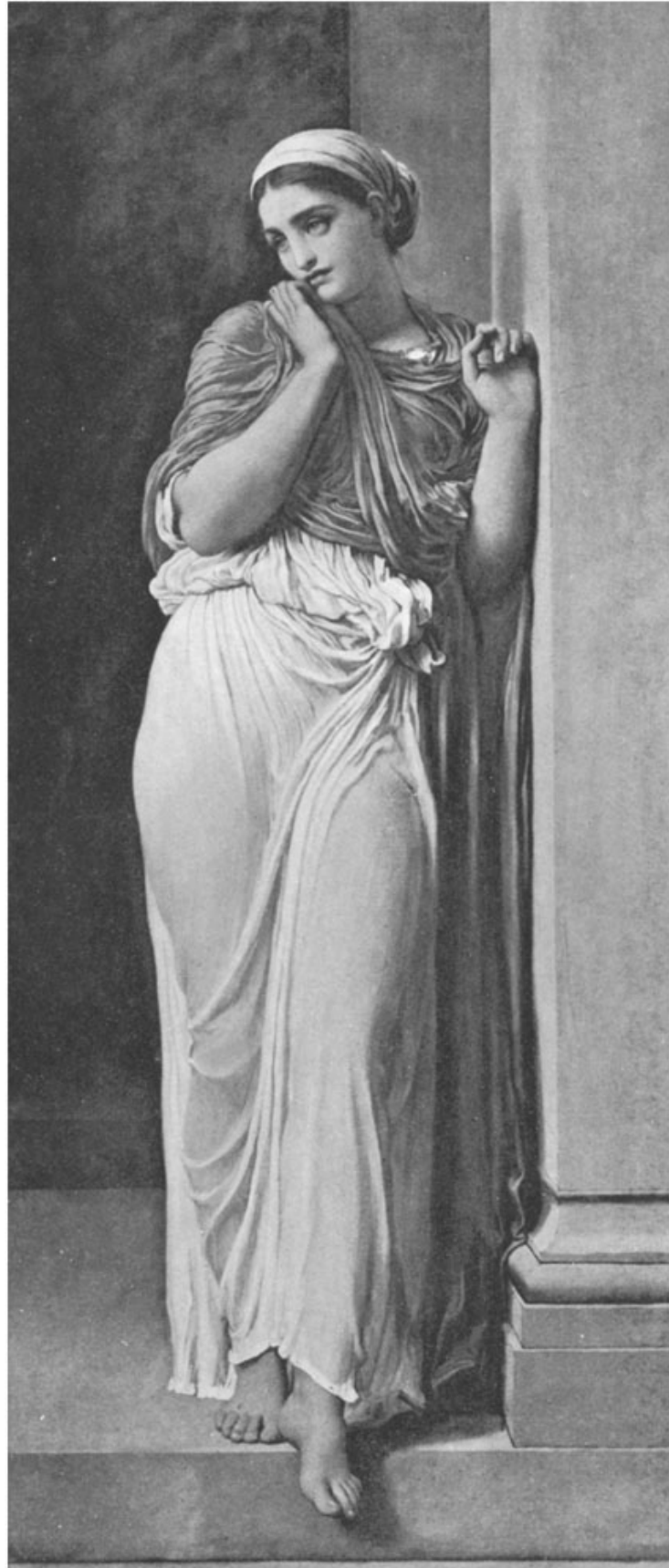
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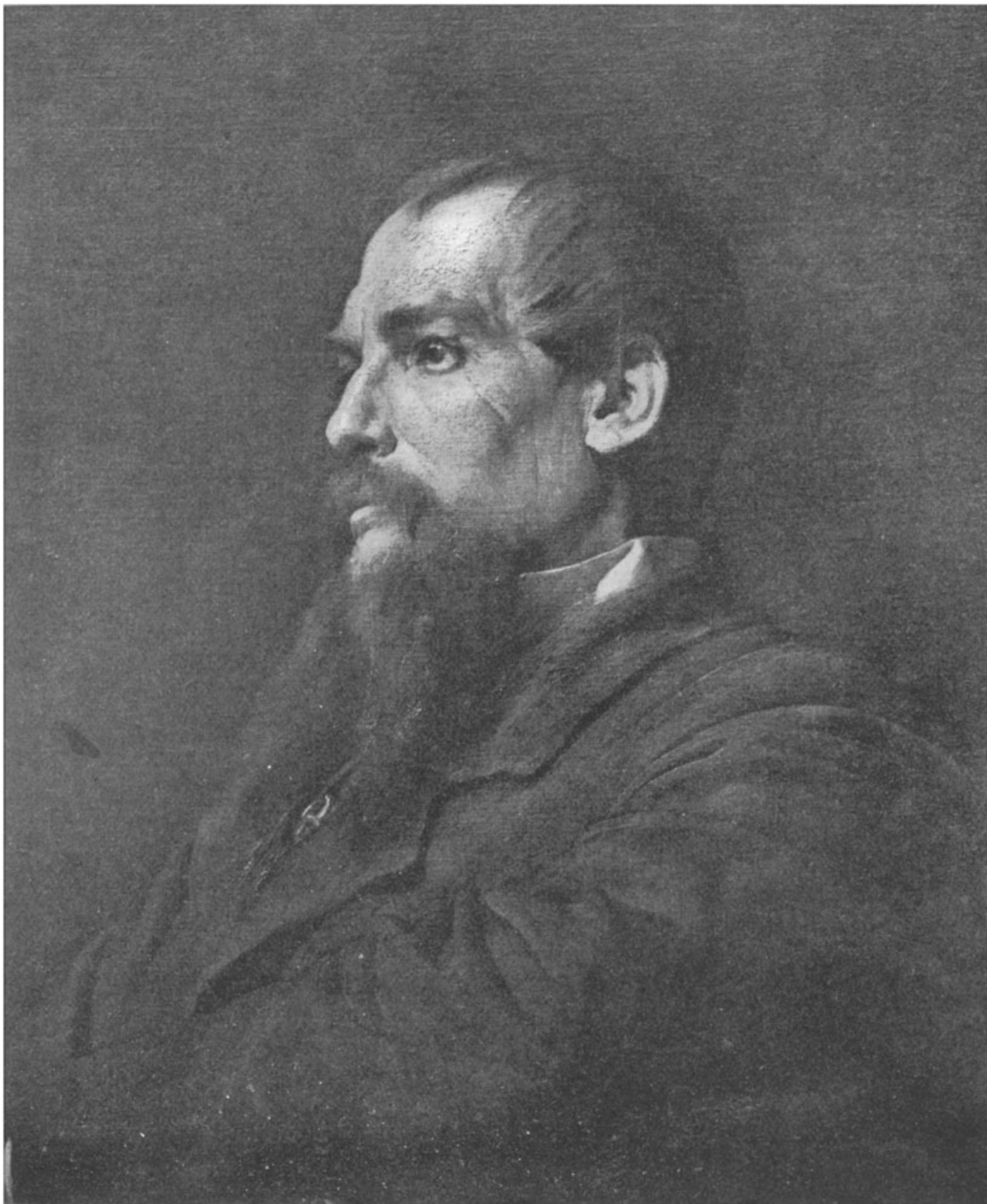
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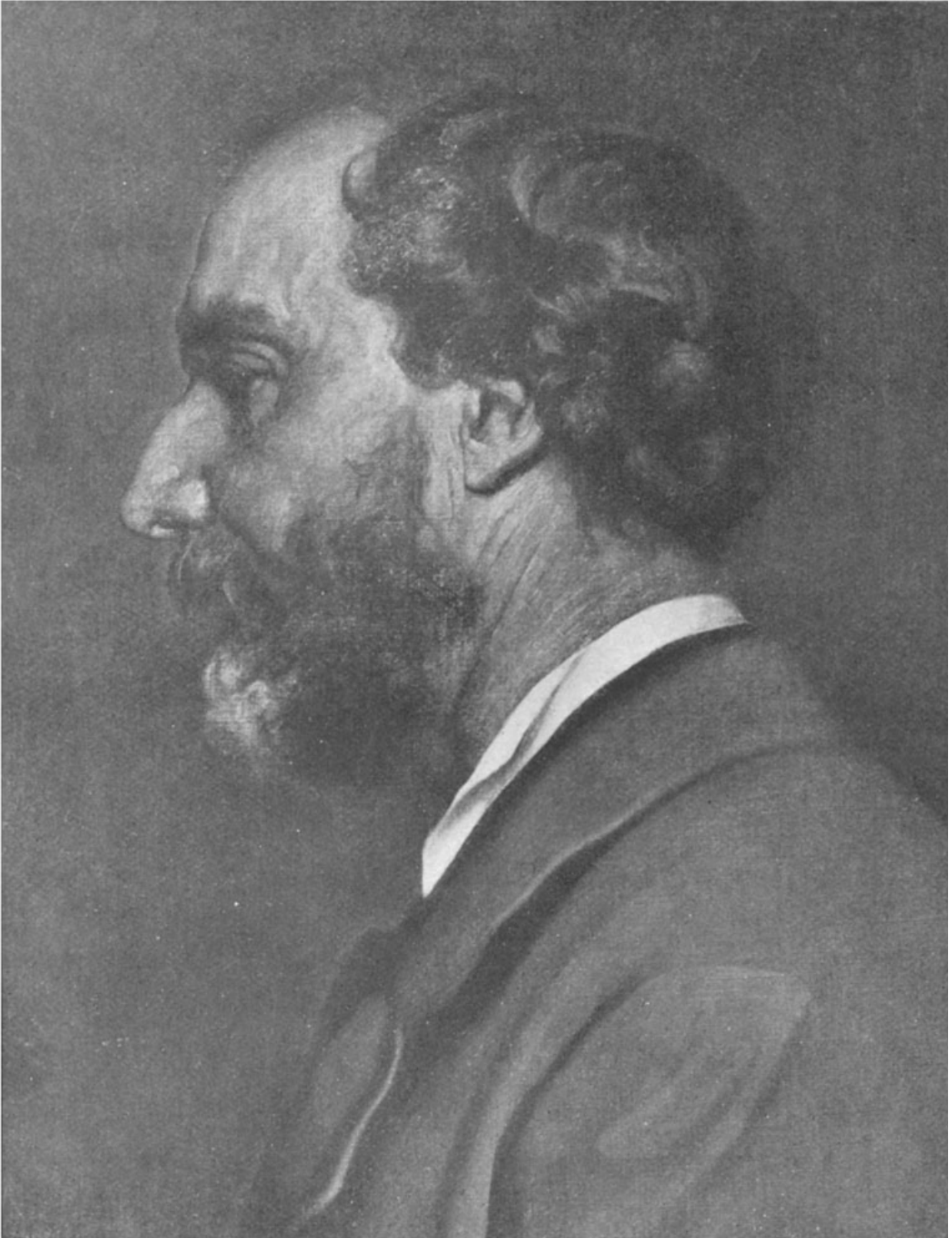
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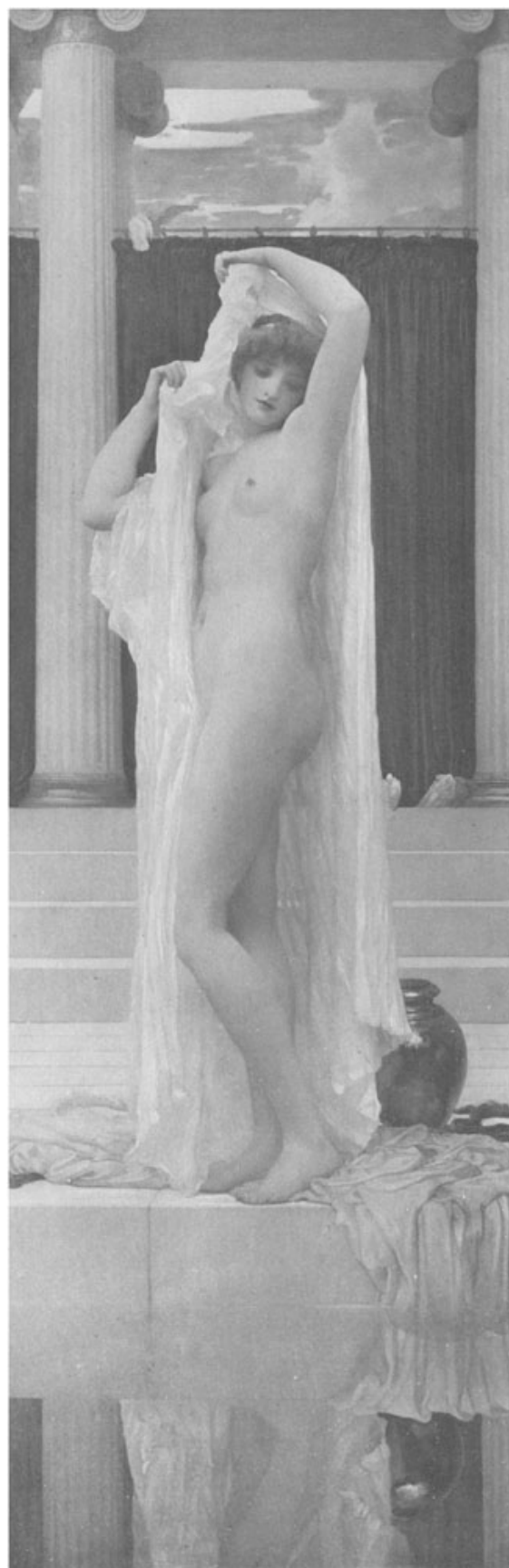
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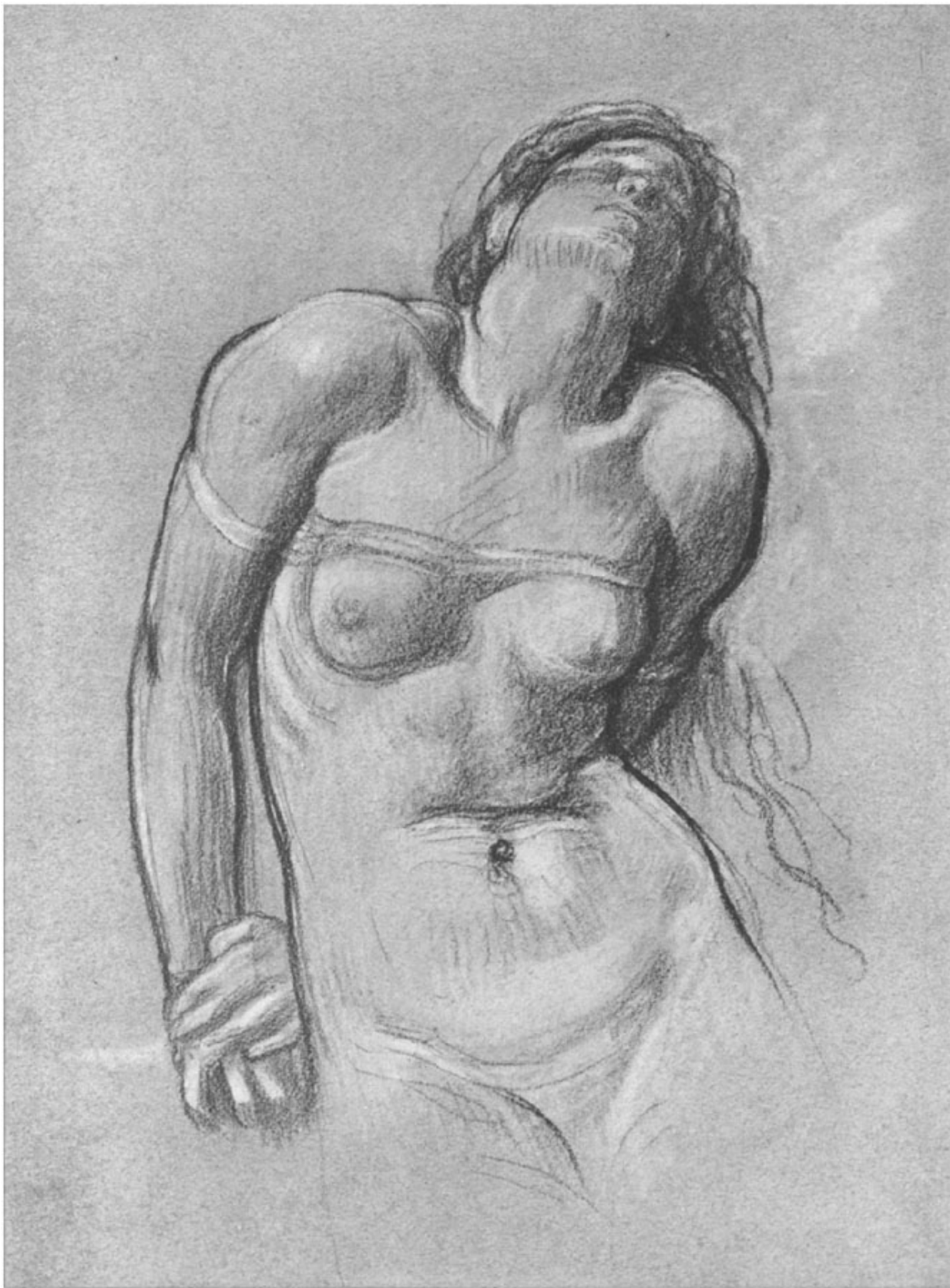
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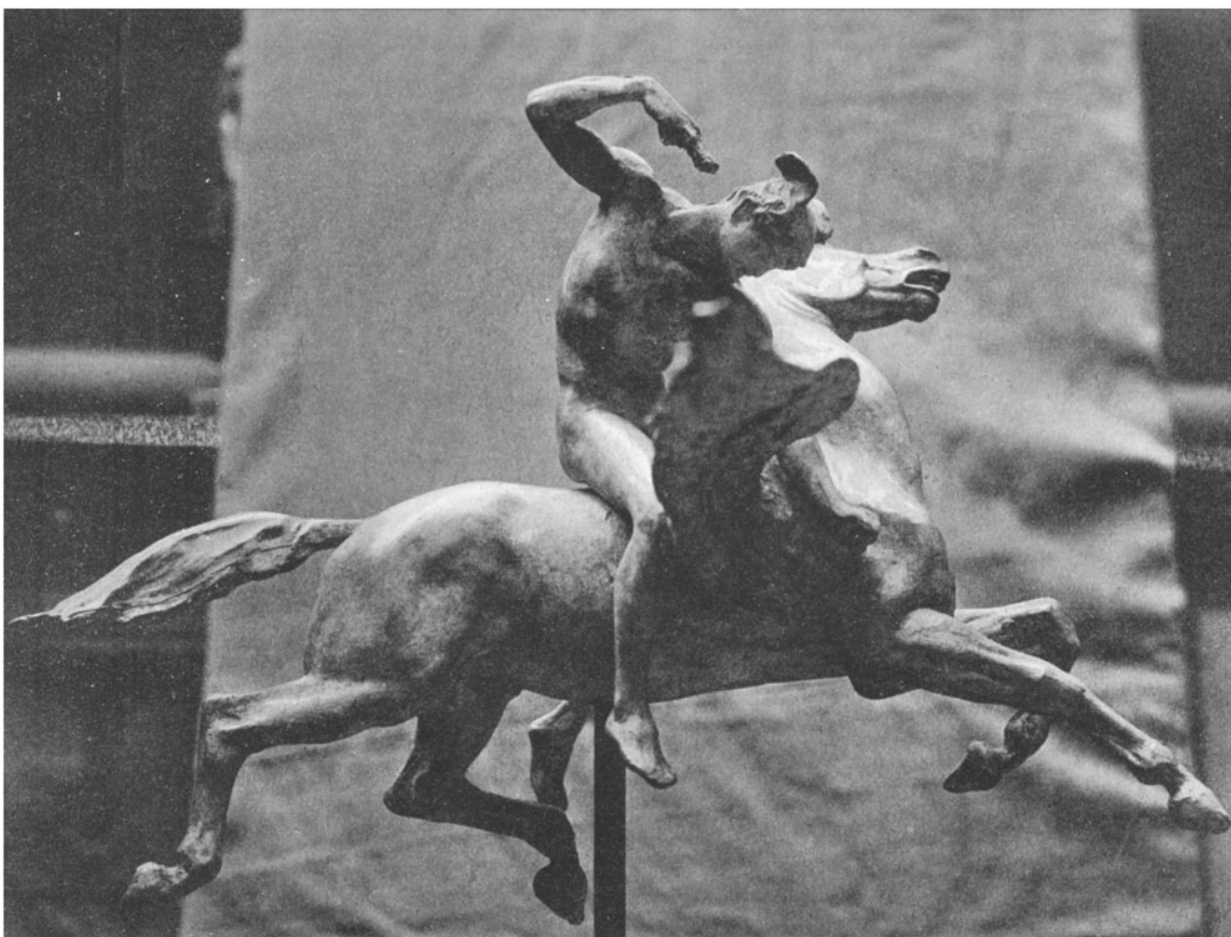
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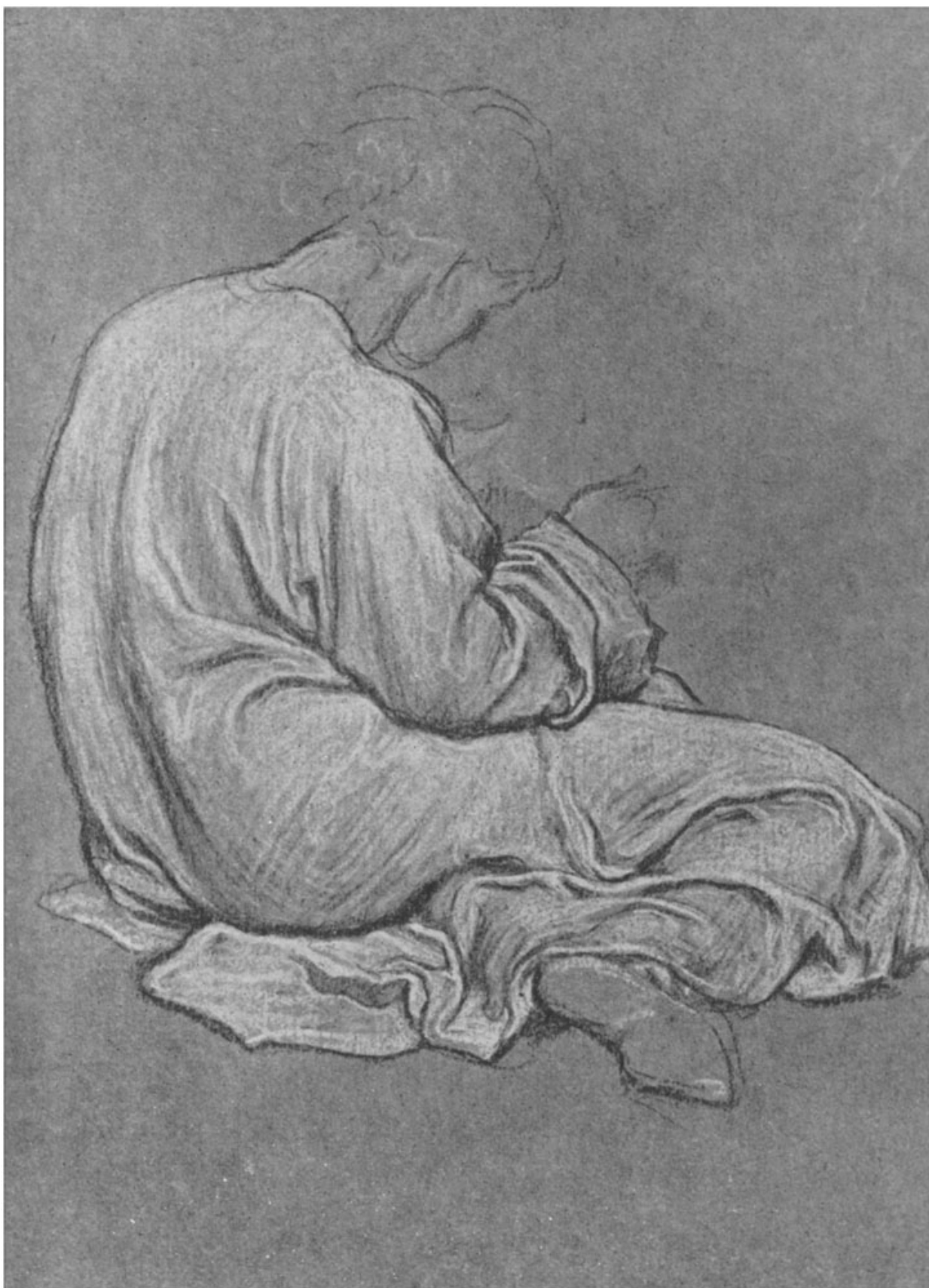
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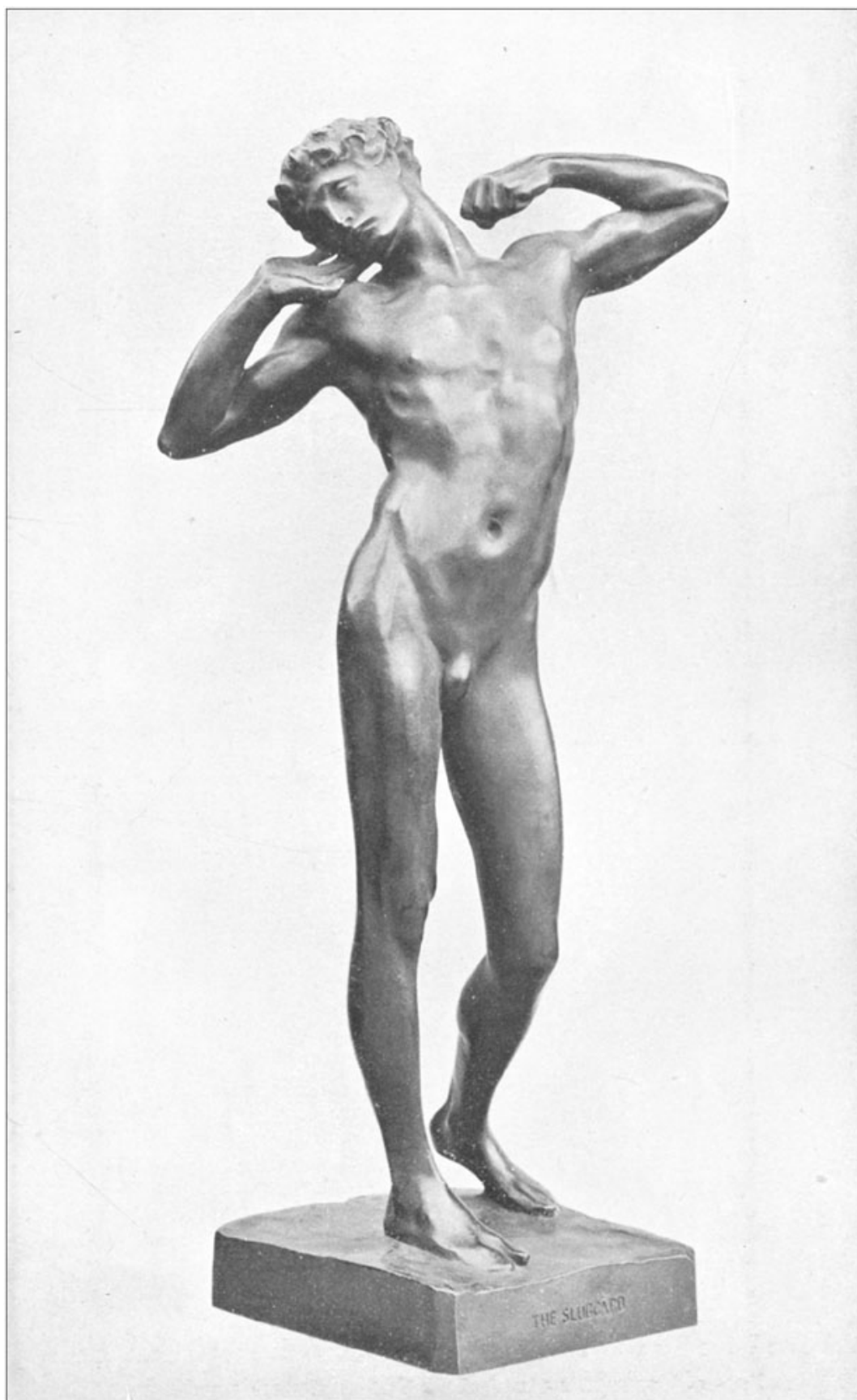
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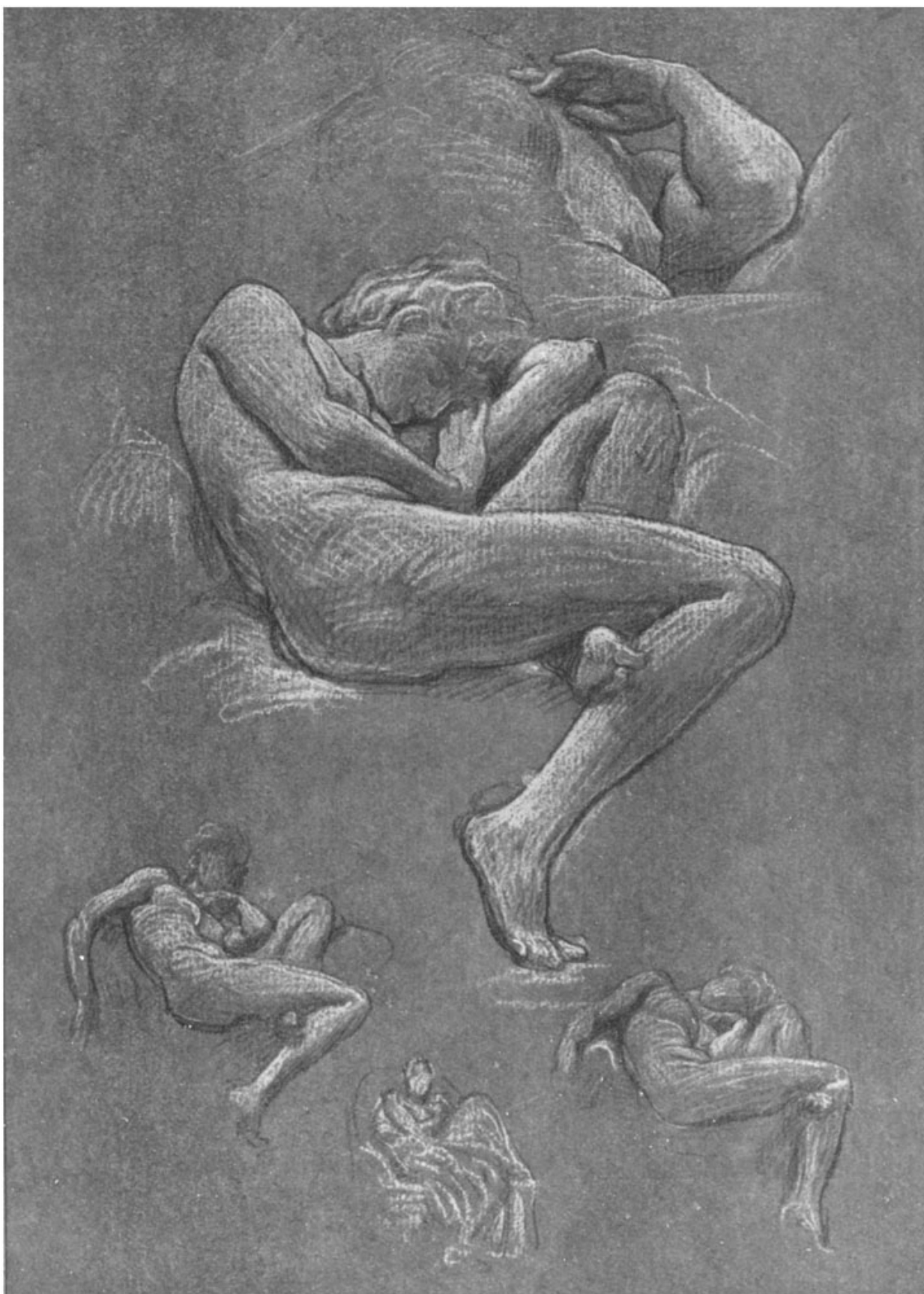
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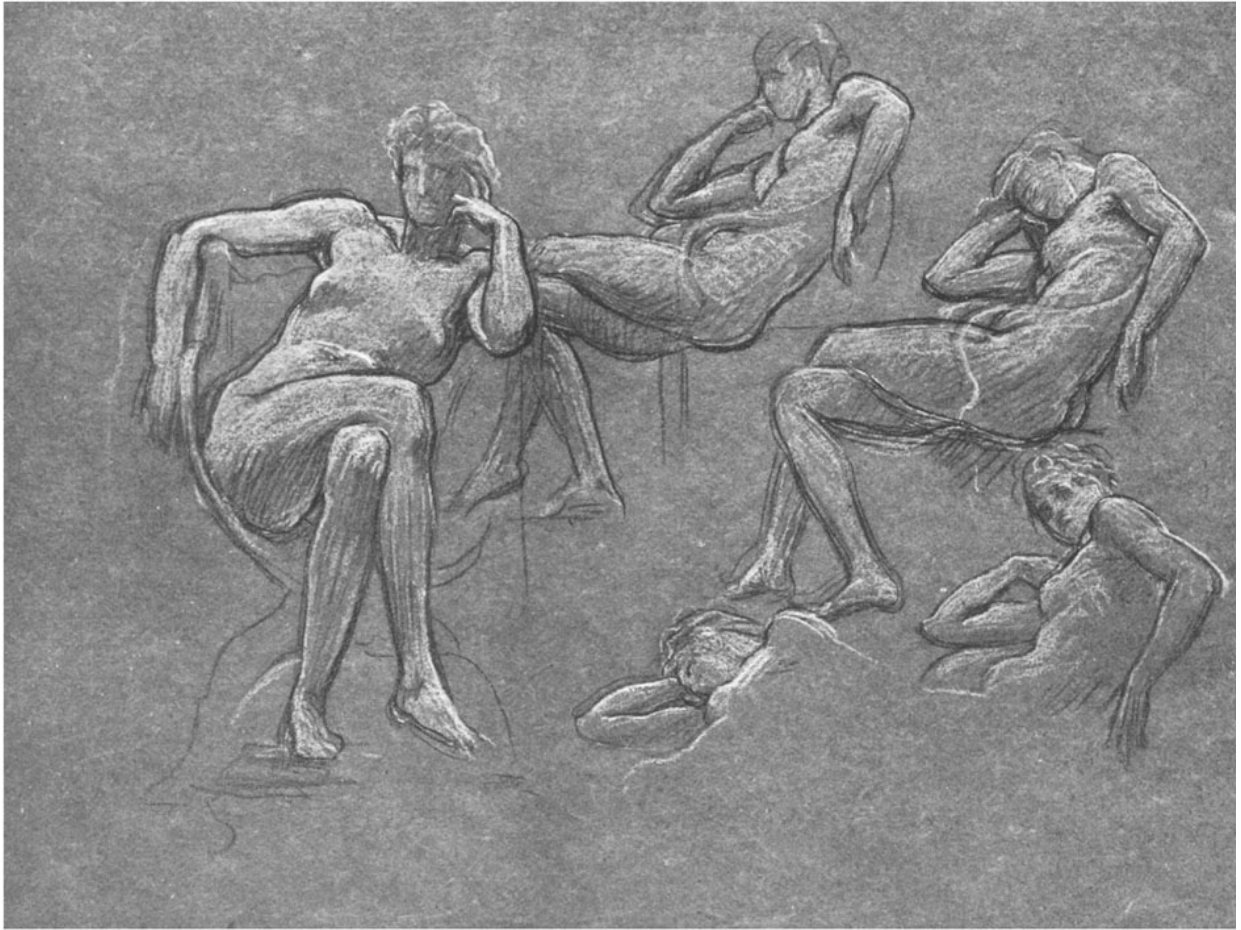
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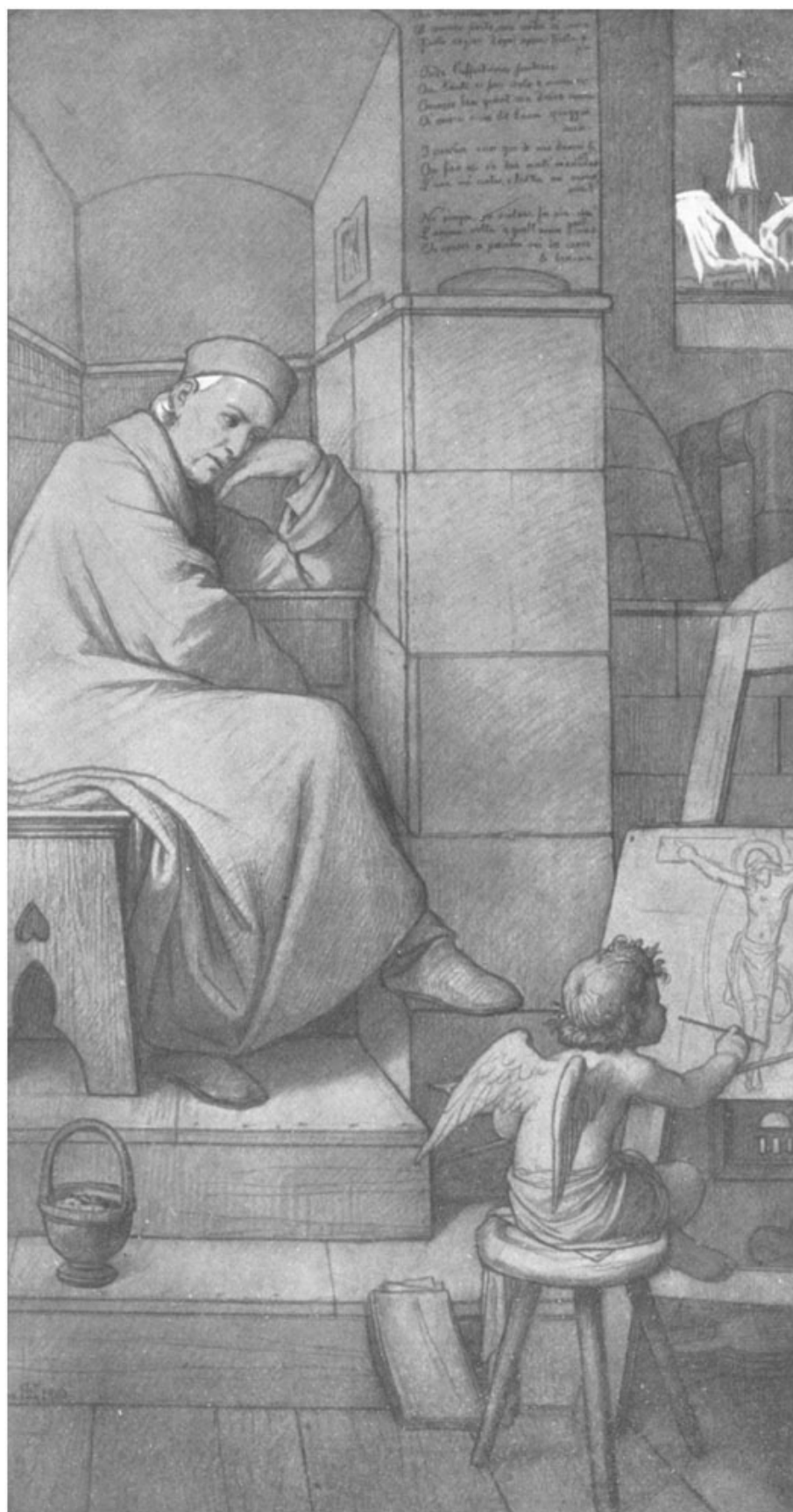
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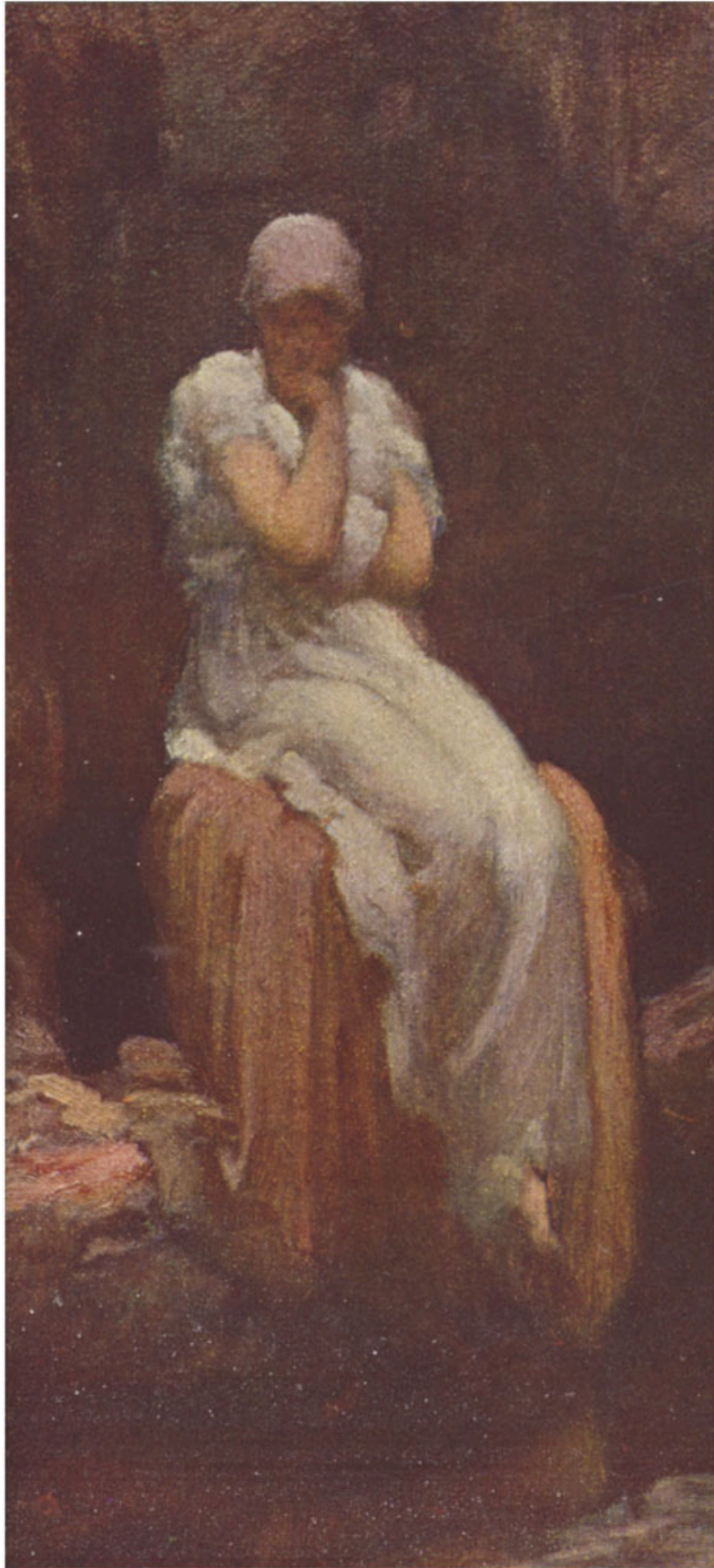
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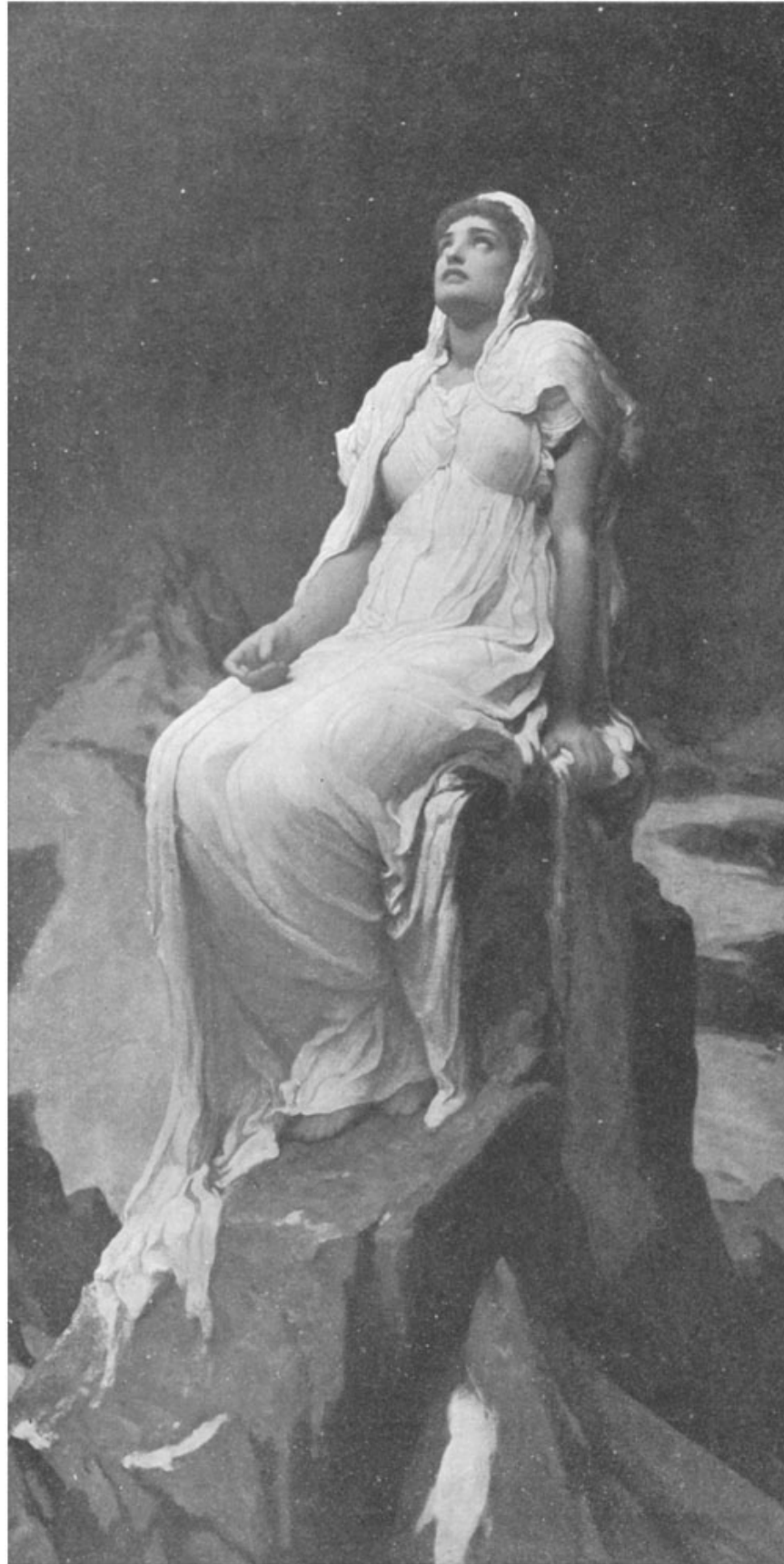
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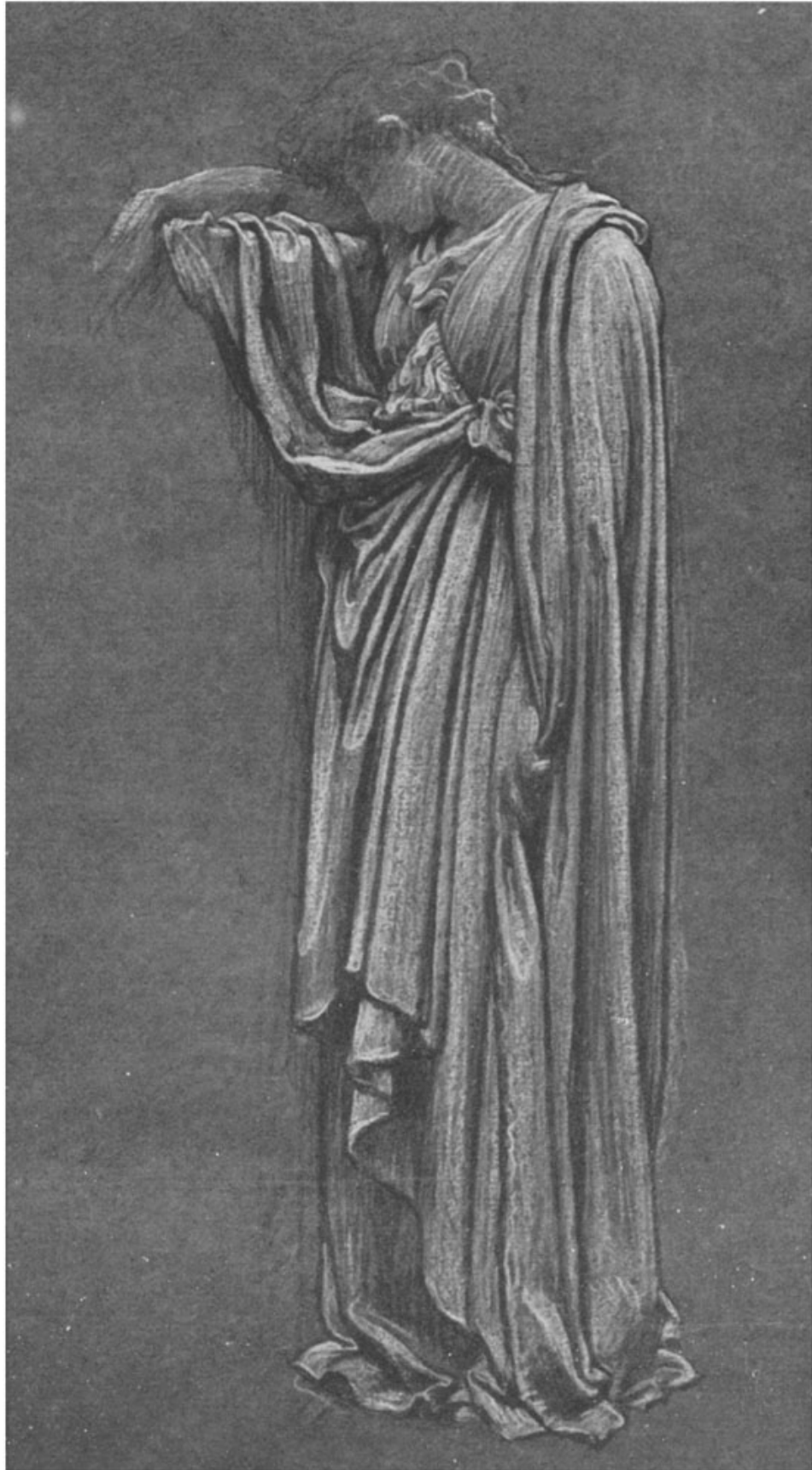
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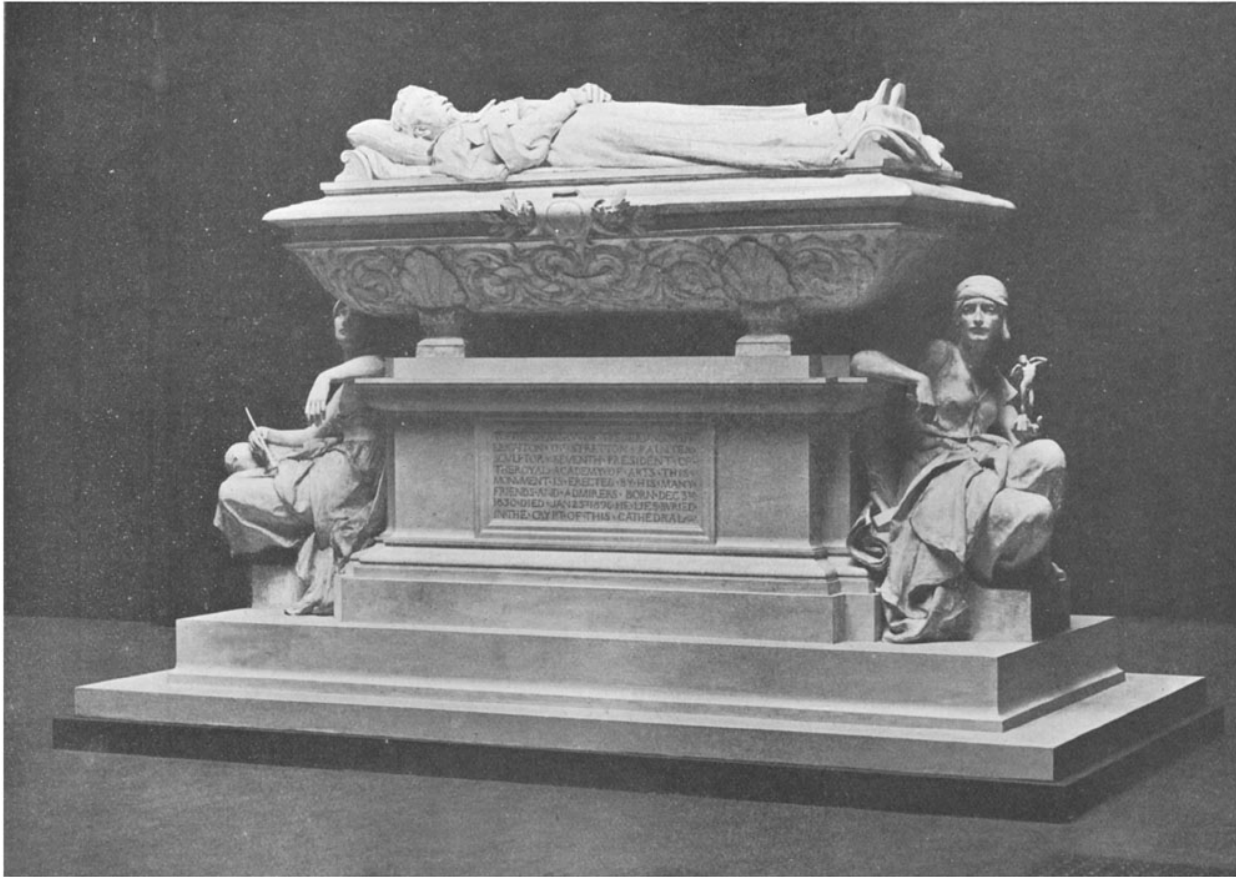
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